Spread Love & Acceptance

FOR ONE PERSON · SHORT VERSION

Spread Love & Acceptance

Understanding yourself and the people you share a life with

FOR ONE PERSON · SHORT VERSION



by Christian

Spread Love & Acceptance
spreadloveandacceptance.com

Spread Love & Acceptance: For one person, the short version.
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Free to read and share. You may print, copy and share this book for personal use and for non-commercial teaching, as long as you credit "Spread Love & Acceptance, spreadloveandacceptance.com" and don't change it or sell it.

Not therapy. This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

The examples are made up. The people in the scenes and examples are invented, built from common patterns. None of them is a real person or a testimonial.

Research mentioned in the chapters is listed, with links, in the research notes at the back and at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

How to use this book

This is a book about seeing what is really going on, in yourself and between people, without blaming anyone, and then changing one small thing. This copy holds 20 chapters in two parts, in the short version. There is no wrong way in.

THE PARTS

Part One: Self-discovery. Where you came from, who you are now and who you are becoming. You can read all of it on your own.

Part Three: Understanding people. How feelings, stress, trust, change, grief, groups and love work, for anyone, in any kind of relationship.

TWO SIZES OF EVERY CHAPTER

Every chapter comes in a short version (about 10 to 15 minutes) and a full version with the research, more examples and more to try. This is the short version. The full version is free at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book.

READ IN ORDER, OR BY NEED

Read it front to back like any book, or start with the chapter that fits what is going on. Each chapter ends with *What to remember*, *This connects to* (the chapters that explain it or put it to use, with page numbers) and *Put it to use*, with codes you can scan for the matching tool.

IN EVERY CHAPTER

- A short scene: a made-up moment from everyday life.
- **Words you could use**: sentences to say out loud.
- **Try this**: one small thing to do this week.
- **Common mix-ups**: easy mistakes, and what is closer to true.

THE SITE, THE PROGRAM AND PROFESSOR PUDDLES

The book has a free website with the workpapers (pages you fill in) and tools (helpers you use) that the chapters mention; the next page explains both. Nothing you type there leaves your device, and there is no account. The **six-week program** (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01) puts Part Two to work a week at a time, and the **self path** does the same for Part One. **Professor Puddles**, the site's friendly guide, answers questions about the book's ideas.

GO GENTLY

Some chapters touch hard things: grief, shame, anger, worry, trauma. Skip anything that isn't right for today. Nothing here is a test, and nothing needs to be done all at once.

Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-03 **Workpapers: pages you fill in**

A workpaper is a page you fill in, on your own or together: a one-week log, a list of who owns which job, a short check. Each one has a number, like **WP-03**, and it is always called a workpaper, for example “Workpaper WP-03: One owner per job”. The blank workpapers are also at the back of this book, one page each, to copy.

TOOL **Tools: helpers you use on the site**

A tool is an interactive helper on the website: a quiz, a calm-down timer, a card maker, or the Chat analyzer that reads a message with you. You use it and it gives you something back. It is always called a tool, for example “Tool: Chat analyzer”.

The book keeps the two apart: a workpaper and a tool never share a list. Both are free, need no account, and what you type stays on your device.

Three friends who give hints



Professor Puddles, the site’s cheerful raindrop professor, gives most of the hints: a thought to take with you, and the workpaper or tool that fits.



Tidbit, the quick, curious pup with the big smile and the collar, bounds in now and then with a playful tip.



Sugarfoot, the steady, gentle pup with the long soft ears and the best hugs, turns up with a calm, slow tip.

They keep to the lighter pages. Where a chapter talks about crisis, deep grief or being hurt, the pages stay quiet and plain.

Find it fast

Start with what is going on, not with chapter one. Each line points to the place in the book that helps most, and one tool to try. You can read that part on its own and stop.

SHARING THE LOAD

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
We each think we do more than our share.	Part Three · Chapter 3 · Everyone feels like the one who sees clearly	87	WORKPAPER WP-01 Who did what
We've just had a baby and we're both exhausted.	Part Three · Chapter 2 · Rest isn't one thing	72	WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying?
I'm caring for a parent or partner, and it's wearing me down.	Part Three · Chapter 12 · Your limits make your help last	210	WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying?

TALKING IT THROUGH

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
Small things turn into big rows.	Part Three · Chapter 2 · When you're flooded	72	WORKPAPER WP-11 The Calm-Down Kit
One of us goes quiet and the other pushes for an answer.	Part Three · Chapter 5 · Feeling safe with someone	114	WORKPAPER WP-11 The Calm-Down Kit: our pause plan
Texts and messages keep landing wrong.	Part Three · Chapter 4 · Messages lose their tone	99	TOOL Chat analyzer
We need to say sorry and mend things.	Part Three · Chapter 11 · A real apology	197	WORKPAPER WP-09 Say it so it lands
Conflict at work, with a colleague or in a team.	Part Three · Chapter 4 · Saying hard things kindly	110	WORKPAPER WP-09 Say it so it lands

KNOWING YOURSELF

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
I can't tell what I'm feeling.	Part One · Now · When feelings are hard to name	35	TOOL My weather today
I'm wiped out and everything feels like too much.	Part One · Now · Check your weather; one state, many words	33	WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying?

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
ADHD: I'm overwhelmed and keep forgetting things.	Part Three · Chapter 9 · ADHD, time and motivation	**165**	TOOL "How to talk to me" card
I'm autistic, and people keep misreading me (or I misread them).	Part One · Now · A mix-up runs both ways	**38**	TOOL "How to talk to me" card
Old rules from childhood still run my reactions.	Part One · Then · Write down the rulebook from home	**21**	The self path: where your lens came from
My inner critic is loud.	Part Three · Chapter 7 · The critic and the soothing system	**140**	WORKPAPER WP-11 The Calm-Down Kit
I want to change a habit, but it keeps slipping.	Part One · Next · Tiny, repeatable steps	**47**	The self path, step by step

HARD SEASONS

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
Someone I love has died.	Part Three · Chapter 8 · Grief comes in waves	**160**	When you've lost someone
I feel lonely, or I live on my own.	Part Three · Chapter 5 · Building connection from where you are	**123**	Living on your own, living well
A teenager's anger, or I'm a teenager and I'm angry.	Part Three · Chapter 13 · The hot minutes	**233**	WORKPAPER WP-11 The Calm-Down Kit
Left out of a group, a friend group or a group chat.	Part Three · Chapter 17 · Groups online, and their pull	**286**	TOOL Chat analyzer
Worry keeps me awake, or my mood is low.	Part Three · Chapter 16 · Worry time; low mood	**268**	WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying?

This copy holds only part of the book, so this map lists the problems it covers. The whole book's map has 14 more, and every chapter is free to read at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book. Each thing to try is marked as a workpaper (a page you fill in) or a tool (a helper you use on the site). All are free on the website, with nothing to sign up for; each chapter's end has a code you can scan for them. Looking for a word rather than a problem? The index at the back lists the main ideas.

The book in two pictures

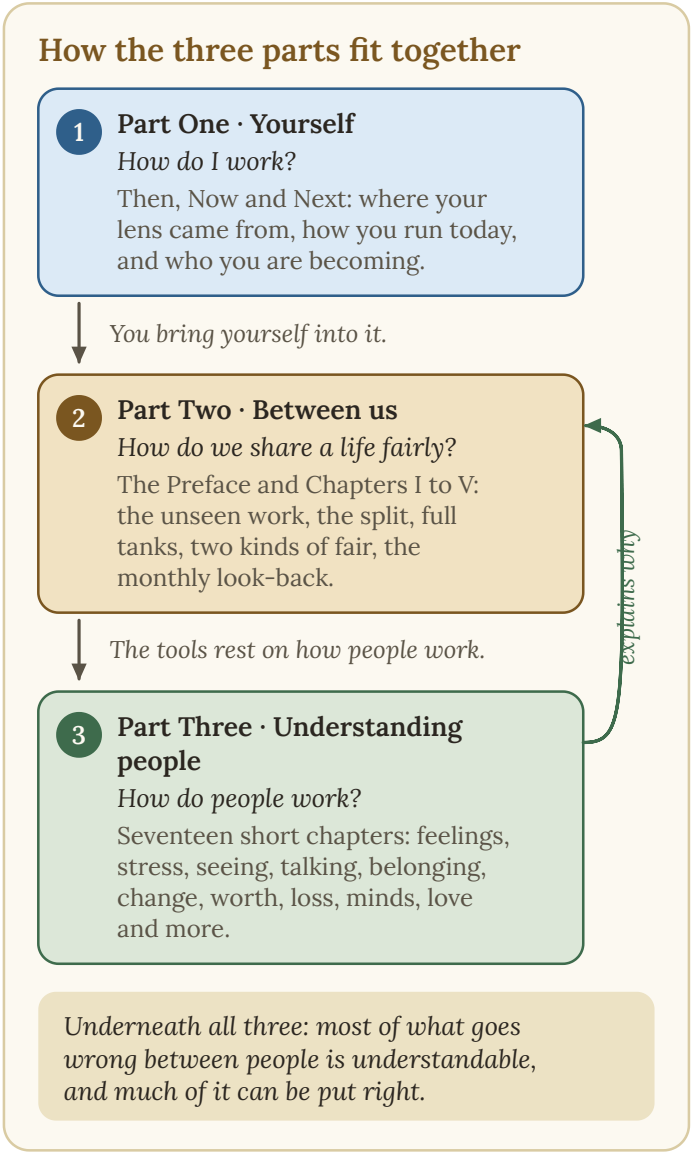


FIGURE 1 How the three parts fit together: you bring yourself into every shared life, and Part Three explains why the Part Two tools work.

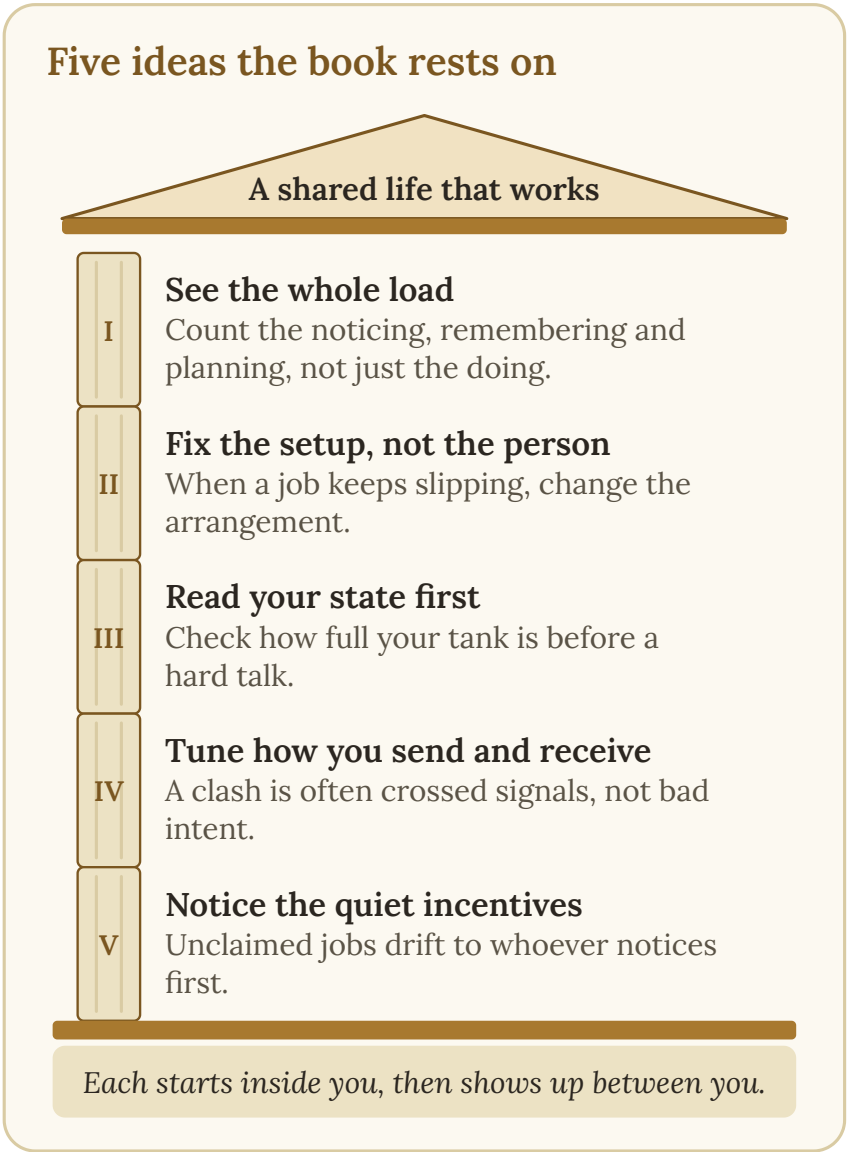


FIGURE 2 Five ideas the whole book rests on. Each one starts inside you, then shows up between you and the people you share a life with.

Contents

How to use this book 5

Workpapers, tools and three friends 6

Find it fast 7

The book in two pictures 9

Part One **Self-discovery** 13

Then Know yourself: then, where your lens came from 14

Now Know yourself: now, your wiring, your weather and your words 29

Next Know yourself: next, shaping who you are becoming 44

Part Three **Understanding people** 57

1 How feelings work: signals, the body, and naming what you feel 58

2 Stress and the nervous system: the ladder, flooding, rest and recovery 72

3 How we see each other: perception, bias, and the stories we tell 87

4 How communication works: meaning, listening, repair and messages 99

5 Attachment, trust and belonging 114

6 Habits and change: why change is hard and how small steps work 127

7 Self-worth, shame and self-compassion 140

8 Loss, grief and big life changes 152

9 Minds that work differently 165

10 Values, meaning and a good life: what philosophy offers everyday life 184

11 Healing after hurt: repair, forgiveness, and when to get help 197

12 Helping others well: support without fixing, boundaries, and not burning out 210

13 Anger: what it's for and what to do with it 223

14 Personality, temperament and change across life 238

15 Closeness and love: being known, at every age 252

16 Worry, low mood and trauma 264

17 Fitting in: groups, influence and culture 279

Workpapers and tools in this book 292

How the numbers work 296

Blank worksheets 299

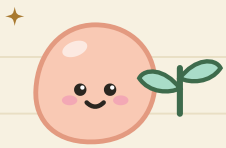
Words used in this book 303

List of figures 307

List of filled-in examples 309

Research notes 311

Index 351



PART ONE

Self-discovery

Where you came from, who you are now and who you are becoming. You can read all of it on your own.

IN THIS PART

Then	Where your lens came from	14
Now	Your wiring, weather and words	29
Next	Who you are becoming	44



SUGARFOOT

Go slowly in this part. It's all about you, and you're worth the time. A one-minute check on how you are today is an easy way in.

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

Then

PART ONE · THEN

Know yourself: then, where your lens came from

Why you expect what you expect, and how the rules you picked up growing up still make small decisions for you today.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. You're not one thing
2. Your lens came from somewhere
3. Each stage of growing up asks its own question
4. When something happened matters
5. Some old answers were learned without all the facts
6. An old rule can read other people for you
7. Write down the rulebook from home
8. You get to choose which rules to keep
9. What you carry forward is yours
10. You, in all your relationships
11. Common mix-ups

This is where the book begins. Part One (Then, Now and Next) is about you. Part Two (a Preface and Chapters I to V) is about the people you share a life with. Part Three (Chapters 1 to 17) is about how people work. Some printed copies hold only one or two of the parts; every chapter is free to read at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, and the book at a glance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-start-here) there gives a one-minute tour of the whole thing.

SUNDAY, 10:15AM

Last night's pan is soaking on the hob, there's a tin of tomatoes open by the kettle, and one of the three mugs has grown something. Your partner is asleep. You haven't had a single thought yet, not one, and already there's a voice going of course it's you, it's always you.

Nobody said that, and nobody else is even awake yet.

Across town Ray is drying a plate that nobody will ever see. His wife died two years ago, and he still can't sit down with the paper until the last fork is back in the drawer. His mother couldn't either.

01

You're not one thing.

Dot is seventy-one and her son is forty minutes late for Sunday lunch. When he finally comes in, cold air and apologies and a bunch of garage-forecourt carnations, she says, "Well, the beef's ruined," in a voice she will regret by pudding.

Three things went into that sentence. She has liked things on time since she was a girl; that's wiring, and it isn't going anywhere. Her father treated lateness as a kind of insult, and she picked that up without ever deciding to. And she was awake at four listening to the wind rattle the side gate. A strong reaction is usually all three at once, and it helps to know which one is shouting loudest. This chapter is about the middle one, what life taught you, and Now (page 29) deals with the other two.

Dot doesn't say any of this. She says, "Sit down, then," and gives him the end bit, which he likes, and the rest of lunch is all right.

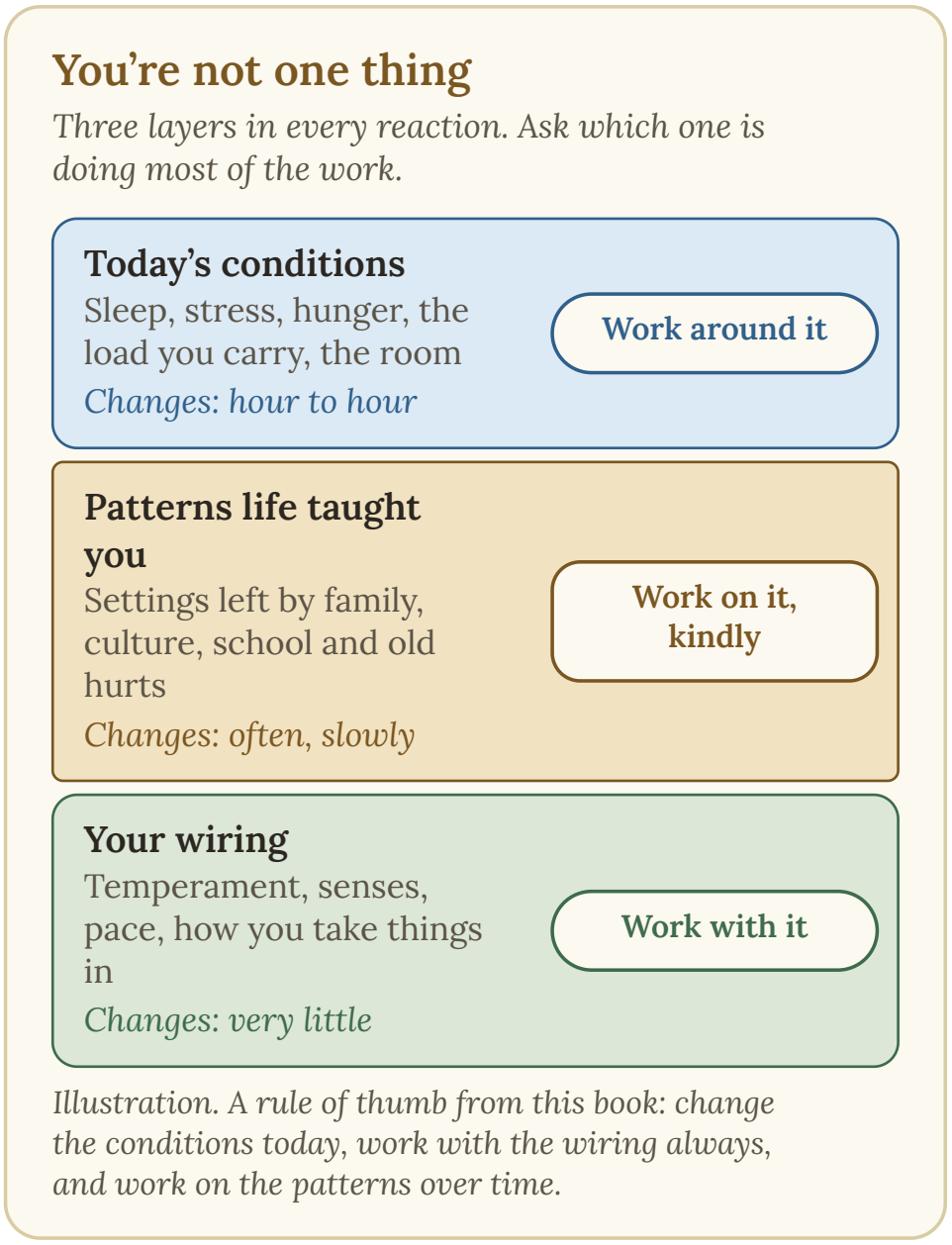


FIGURE 3 Three layers in every reaction. Each one changes at a different speed and needs a different move.

02

Your lens came from somewhere.

You learned what to expect from people long before you had words for it, at home mostly, but also at school and from whatever was on the telly at teatime. By the time you're grown up the lens doesn't feel like a lens any more, it feels like simply seeing what's there.

Birthdays give it away. Imogen grew up with a party every year, a sheet cake, and cousins driving down from Glasgow with a balloon tied to the wing mirror. Stuart got a card propped against the cornflakes and a slightly better tea. So when Stuart books a quiet table for two on her thirtieth, he thinks he has nailed it. She spends the starter trying not to look at the door.

It took them two more birthdays to say it out loud. "In my family this was a big deal," she said in the end. "What was it like in yours?" He thought about it. "Mum did a trifle." Where your lens came from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up) walks through the idea slowly, and you can read one section and stop.



TIDBIT

The rules from home aren't good or bad. They're just yours, and worth a proper look. How you like to talk is a good first one to look at.

TOOL **How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

03

Each stage of growing up asks its own question.

A small child is working out whether the world is safe. A bit older and the questions change to whether you're any good at things, where you fit, and whether you can be close to someone without disappearing into them. Later still, grown-ups start to wonder whether any of it has meant anything. What sticks is the answer you landed on at each stop, because you can go on using it for decades without noticing you're using it.

Jago moved schools four times between eleven and sixteen. He's forty-four now, a site manager, and on the first morning of every new contract he still stands by the portakabin feeling like the new kid with the wrong shoes. He

only clocked why last year. I suspect most of us have one of those questions still running somewhere.

Eight questions in a life

The idea that each stage of life asks its own question goes back to Erik Erikson, who described eight of them, from trust against mistrust in a baby to identity against confusion in a teenager. Think of it as a way of looking back, not a timetable anyone has measured.

Erikson (1950) · *Theory: very influential; a framework for reflection, not a measured sequence*

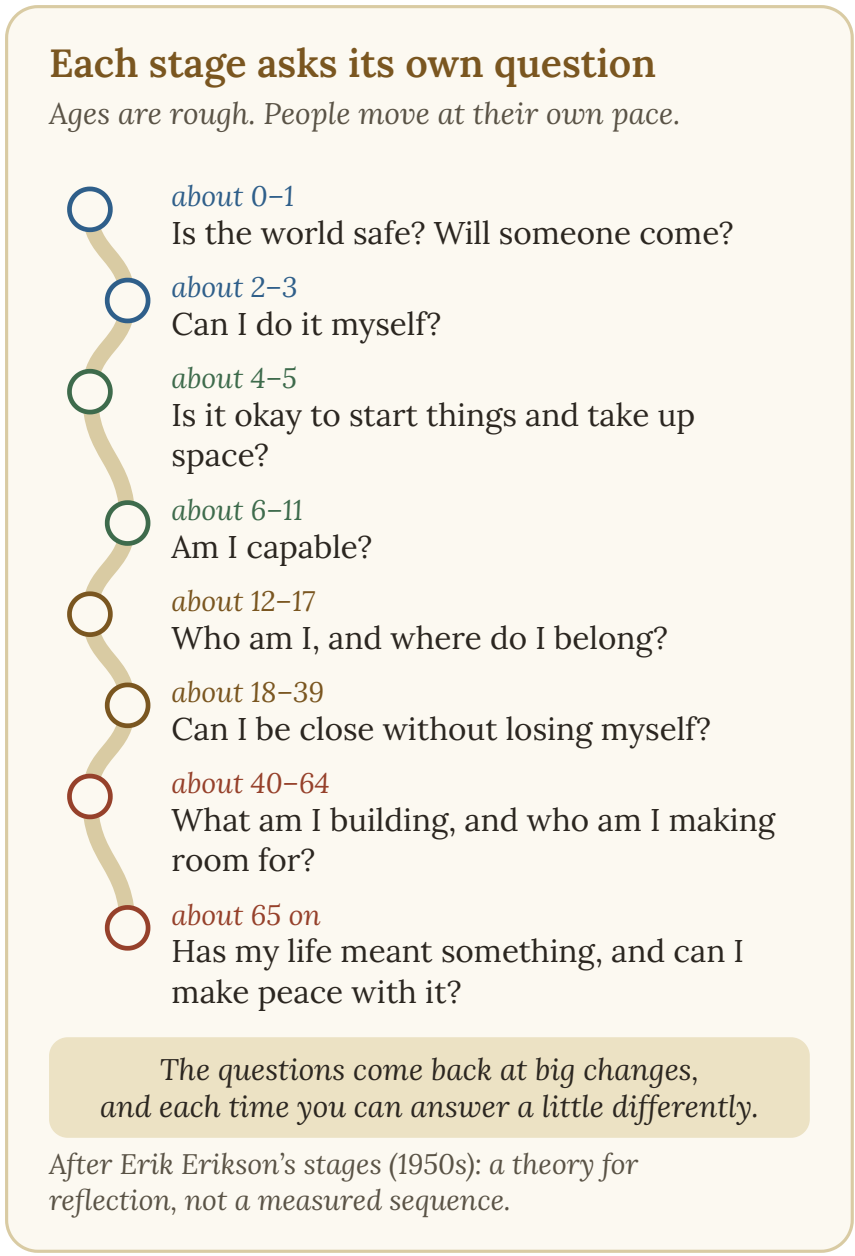


FIGURE 4 Each stage of life asks its own question. The ages are rough, and the questions come back at big changes (after Erik Erikson).

04

When something happened matters.

An experience goes deeper when it lands on the question you were busy with at the time. Moving house at four is mostly about a new bedroom. Moving at fourteen, in the thick of working out where you belong, can leave you feeling on the outside for years.

Two sisters were six and fifteen when their parents split up. The younger one remembers glow-in-the-dark stars on her new ceiling and a different bus to school,, and remembers it fondly, which drives her sister up the wall. The older one remembers every other Friday, standing in the hall with a holdall, being torn in two. They are both right, which is why that year still comes up at Christmas (see Family rifts, spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts). Deeper doesn't mean permanent, mind. People go on learning all their lives.

05

Some old answers were learned without all the facts.

Plenty of adults carry a sentence about themselves that they picked up before they were old enough to check it. *I'm only all right when I'm useful. My needs are a nuisance. If I get it wrong, I'm bad.* A child can't see what is going on for the grown-ups, so they go by how the room felt, and they draw the only conclusion a child can draw, which is usually about themselves.

Sheila has fostered for eleven years and she's very good at it. She also can't ask for respite, the planned weekend when someone else has the children, not even in the week she put the cereal in the fridge and the milk in the cupboard. "They've got enough on," she told her link worker, who had rung specifically to offer it.

Looking again as an adult doesn't mean deciding it was all fine back then. It means you're allowed the full picture now. Try writing down one old belief about yourself, then underneath it what you'd say to a friend who believed the same thing about themselves.

06

An old rule can read other people for you.

If silence at home meant someone was angry, then a partner's quiet evening can feel like weather coming in. And a rule nobody has ever said out loud can't be agreed to, so the other person can only break it. *If you loved me you'd just know. Whoever notices, does it.* Each is somebody's family rule, enforced on someone from a different family.

Gemma's housemate goes out at ten past seven without saying goodbye. Gemma, who grew up in a house where the door going without a word meant a row was coming, spends the whole morning at work going over what she might have done. The housemate was on the 7.14 to a shift she'd nearly slept through.

If you catch yourself reading a silence, you can just ask. "You went off quick this morning. Everything all right?" Nine times out of ten it's a train.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When an old rule jumps in before you've had a chance to think, you don't have to argue with it. Write it down, and look at it again on a calm day.

TOOL **Old rules, new choices** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

07

Write down the rulebook from home.

If you only do one exercise in this book, I'd make it this one. Finish these six lines the way the home you grew up in would have finished them.

"In my family, love looked like…" "When someone was upset, we…" "The jobs were split like this…" "Resting was okay when…" "Asking for help meant…" "The unforgivable thing was…"

The last one is usually the interesting one. The rulebook page (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up#home) has room to write them, and nothing is saved anywhere except on your own device.

Amira and Daniel did it one December, after Daniel's mum had asked about Christmas again and Amira had gone very quiet. Somewhere on each of their pages, in different words, was the same rule. Holidays belong to my family. It explained four years of tug of war in one go, and they laughed, a bit, before

the actual negotiating started (see Two faiths, one family, spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths). One line today is plenty. If you show it to someone, you might say, "This is a rule I grew up with. I'm not saying it's right. I just want you to know it's there."

Rules handed down

Family therapists in the Bowen tradition look at a family as one emotional unit, with roles passed from one generation to the next, which is more or less what your rulebook lines catch. It's influential in practice and lightly tested in research, so I'd hold it loosely.

Kerr and Bowen (1988) · *Debated: influential in family therapy, limited testing*

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

The rulebook from home

Nadia, on her own

Your rulebook from home

Write a few words on each line, the way the home you grew up in would have finished it. Skip any line you like. Then, for each one, ask: do I still want this rule?

1. In my family, love looked like…

Doing things. Dad fixed your bike; nobody said it.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep (Soften) Drop

2. When someone was upset, we…

Went quiet and waited for it to pass.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep (Soften) Drop

3. The jobs were split like this…

Mum noticed, planned and remembered. Dad did the big jobs.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften (Drop)

4. Resting was okay when…

Everything else was done.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften (Drop)

5. Asking for help meant…
You hadn't planned well enough.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften (Drop)

6. The unforgivable thing was…
Breaking a promise.

Do I still want this rule?

(Keep) Soften Drop

Made-up example.

Fill in your own: The rulebook from home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up)

08

You get to choose which rules to keep.

Go back over your lines and ask of each one whether you still want it. Some you'll keep. Some you'll look at and think, well, that one can go.

When a reaction feels too big for the moment, wait till you've settled and give it a minute's questioning. Where did I learn this? How old does it feel? Is it true here, with this person, today?

Bev runs a team at a building society and realised, eventually, that she hid problems from her manager until they're too big to hide, because at home a mistake meant a mood that lasted days. She wrote a new rule on a yellow sticky note and stuck it to the bottom of her monitor. *Mistakes are information. We fix them together.* Three years on it has gone curly, and she won't take it down.

Pick one of your rules and write the version you'd rather live by. "I used to think ___. Now I'm choosing ___." Later, if you like, swap rulebooks with someone you trust and pick some shared rules on purpose.

09

What you carry forward is yours.

You didn't choose the home you grew up in, or what anyone else did, or what you concluded at seven about how things work. What's in your hands now is smaller than that and a good deal sturdier. You decide which rules you keep. You decide how you talk to yourself about them, and where your energy goes, and that includes people. Give your care where it's met with care. Where it's all one way, let it shrink back to something that feels fair, so you have some left.

Marcia has organised every meet-up with an old school friend for nine years, and the friend always comes, always seems pleased, and has never once in all that time suggested a date. Last spring Marcia stopped chasing. She sent one message ("I'd love to see you, let me know when works") and then nothing, which was harder than it sounds. The friend didn't reply for five weeks, and in those five weeks Marcia went to a quiz, twice, with people who did reply (see Always the one reaching out? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)).

Is there somewhere you give far more than comes back? You could give a little less there this month and see what happens.

Then, Now, Next

The three chapters of Part One, about you.



Then

Where your lens came from

the rules you learned growing up

Now

Your wiring and today's weather

how you run, and what you need

Next

Who you are becoming

small steps towards what matters

The past isn't yours to change.
What you carry forward is.

FIGURE 5 Where your lens came from, how you run today and who you are becoming, in one picture. You choose what you carry forward.

TUESDAY, HALF PAST ELEVEN

Two people get the same text from the same friend. Can we talk tonight? Fern is pleased, because she likes a plan. Callum feels his stomach go, because in his house "we need to talk" never once meant anything good, and he spends his lunch hour sitting in the car rehearsing answers to accusations nobody has made.

The friend wanted to know if they were still up for splitting a cottage in Pembrokeshire in August. Callum said yes too quickly and then had to ring back about the dates.

You, in all your relationships

Your old rules come with you everywhere, starting with the voice you use on yourself after a mistake. At home they decide who notices, who plans and what a quiet evening means. Two housemates can share a fridge for a year before finding out they've been living by different rulebooks about mess. In families, the old roles switch back on before you've got your coat off (the helper, the peacemaker, the one who makes it funny). At work, someone praised mainly for being useful says yes to everything and then quietly seethes, and seeing the rule is often enough to buy them a pause before the next yes. After a breakup old rules can get louder, which makes it a good time to look at them kindly (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). How you connect (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength) is a two-minute quiz on the talking rules you brought with you. Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) lists pages for many more situations.

Common mix-ups

The worry people bring to this chapter most often is that looking back means blaming their family. It doesn't have to. Many of the adults who raised us had lenses of their own, and if that doesn't fit your story, you don't have to make it fit. Then there's the fear that anything which started in childhood is fixed for good. Many old patterns soften once you can see them and feel safe enough to try something else, and some leave a lasting sensitivity that you learn to carry and explain. Not every big reaction is an old wound, either. Quite often it's just a full tank (Chapter III, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3, helps you tell leftover stress from this-moment stress). And some people decide there's no point looking at their own rules if the other person won't look at theirs. I don't agree with that one at all. Knowing your own rules changes how you react whether or not anyone else reads a word of this.

A note on care: This part looks back at growing up. It is general education, not a diagnosis or therapy, and it can't tell you what anyone has. Not every home felt calm or kind, so take only what is useful. If looking back feels heavy, you can stop and come back another day, or explore it with a qualified professional, if and when you want that. Nothing here is required, and nothing you write needs to be shared.

If you want to go on, notice one "always" or "never" that went through your head this week. Whose voice was it in? How old did you feel? Where your lens came from, Roots & Wings (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up#roots) and Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself) go further.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ You're not one thing.
- ✓ Each stage of growing up asks its own question.
- ✓ Some old answers were learned without all the facts.
- ✓ Write down the rulebook from home.
- ✓ What you carry forward is yours.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part Three · Chapter 3 · How we see each other
How a lens shapes what you notice in other people page 87

Part Three · Chapter 5 · Attachment, trust and belonging
How early trust and attachment carry into adult life page 114

Part Three · Chapter 14 · Personality, temperament and change
Which parts are temperament, and which can change page 238

Part Three · Chapter 11 · Healing after hurt
Making peace with what happened, and when to get help page 197

PUT IT TO USE

The self path: see where your lens came from
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

Now

PART ONE · NOW

Know yourself: now, your wiring, your weather and your words

Why the same words can land differently on different days and in different people, and how to understand today's you well enough to say what helps.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Today is made of two layers you can work with
2. Know how you like to be spoken to
3. Check your weather before you speak
4. Ask where this feeling is coming from
5. Plan what settles you on a calm day
6. Your needs and limits are information, not demands
7. Being wired differently is not being wrong
8. Explain yourself without over-sharing
9. Do your part, and only your part
10. You, in all your relationships
11. Common mix-ups

SUNDAY, 7:50PM

Your friend pauses the film. "You all right? You've been quiet all day."

"Fine."

Which isn't a lie, exactly. You genuinely don't know if you're fine, or tired, or still chewing on something somebody said on Thursday. You couldn't explain it to yourself, never mind to her. You reach for the remote and she lets you.

01

Today is made of two layers you can work with.

Your wiring is the lasting part, your temperament and pace and senses and the way words go in, and you work *with* that, by building a life that suits it. Today's conditions are the passing part (sleep, hunger, the hour) and you work *around* those, usually by eating something or sleeping on it. Most of the frustration here comes from mixing the two up. (Then, page 14, covers the third layer, the patterns life taught you.)

Dean works nights at a distribution centre. For months the school-run chatter at ten past eight was unbearable to him, all of it, the who-sat-next-to-who and the who-said-what in PE, and he started quietly wondering whether he was any good at being a dad. Then his partner swapped with him, so he does the half-three pick-up now, after he's slept, and the same chatter is funny again (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours). His daughter told her teacher that her dad has "got nicer", which he found out about at parents' evening.

Write down one thing that always bothers you, which is probably wiring, and then one that only bothers you when you're tired.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Your wiring stays the same from day to day. Your weather doesn't. A one-minute check in the morning helps you tell the two apart.

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

02

Know how you like to be spoken to.

Pace, tone, how much needs spelling out and what a silence means all change how words land. How you connect (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength) gives you words for it, and a four-letter Wave Code that's meant to be light-hearted, so please don't put it on your CV. The "How to talk to me" card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card) fits the same thing onto one page you can hand over before a hard talk.

Agnes is seventy-two and loves a phone call. Her grandson Liam loves a text and regards the phone ringing as a kind of emergency. For about a year each of them privately decided the other had gone a bit cool. It took a cousin, over

the trifle at Christmas, to say, “Nan, he’s not ignoring you, he just doesn’t answer the phone. To anyone. Ever.” There’s a Sunday call at six now, with texts in between, and Liam mostly picks up.

If you want somewhere to start, finish this. “I take things in best when…”

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

“How to talk to me” card

Ife, made on her own to give to a friend

Your card

Pick what is usually true for you. Add a few words where the buttons are not enough. Leave a line blank if it does not apply.

Who it’s for

A partner Family *A friend* Work (a manager or coworker)

Name on the card, optional

Ife

WIRING CARD · NOT A DIAGNOSIS

How I receive things best
In writing. One thing at a time.

I take words
Literally when it matters, tone when it is light.

Give me time to answer
A few minutes.

If I go quiet, it means
I'm thinking.

Please avoid
Long texts or many topics at once.

A request lands best as
The ask in the first sentence.

Applies more strictly when I am running low. Not a contract, and not a label. Change it when it stops being true.

Made-up example.

Fill in your own: "How to talk to me" card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card)

03

Check your weather before you speak.

Everything you hear goes through your own state on the way in. Part Two, Chapter III (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3) looks closely at the stress tank in a shared home. This chapter only adds the self side, a one-minute reading on your own before you decide what a hard moment means, and for that My weather today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks) is the quick check and How much are you carrying? the fuller one, on a short worksheet.

A couple living five hours apart worked out, eventually, that every bad call they'd had came at the end of her late shift, around midnight her time. Every single one. They moved anything serious to Saturday mornings, with coffee,

and found they mostly agreed with each other (see Long distance, spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance).

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I'm running on empty tonight. Can we pick this up tomorrow morning?"

ONE STATE, MANY WORDS. The chapters and tools use a few everyday pictures for one thing, how much room you have today.

- **The three states** (Chapter 2, page 72, calls them the ladder) are calm and connected, revved up, and running on empty.
- **My weather today** uses sky words for the same three. *Clear* is calm and connected, *gusty* is revved up, and *fogged in* is running on empty. Its *pressure* is how much you were already carrying.
- **The stress tank** is the score from How much are you carrying?, from 0 to 1, where higher means fuller.
- **The battery** is the other side of the tank, the energy you have left, so a full tank means a low battery.

"Gusty", "revved up", "a fairly full tank" and "a low battery" can all describe the same Tuesday afternoon. I'd pick one set and stick with it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

My weather today

Joel, on his own, after a short night

Check today's weather

The sky

Clear: Calm and connected | *Gusty: Revved up* | Fogged in: Running on empty

Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner | Family | A co-parent | Roommates | Coworkers | Someone I care for | Friends | *Mostly on my own*

The pressure

Light | *Building* | Heavy

Ground conditions

Haven't eaten in a while · Thirsty · In pain or unwell · Been still all day · Too much noise or light · Running on caffeine · Screens since I woke up

Last night's sleep

Barely slept · *Short night* · About enough · Properly rested

People load

Barely any · A normal amount · *A lot* · Nonstop, no gaps

What's blowing in

Work · Money · Kids or caring · Health · Family · The house · One conversation · Something I can't name

What would actually help in the next hour?

Space · *Food or water* · Rest · *To move* · To be heard · A plan · Company · Quiet · Someone to take something off me

YOUR FORECAST

Gusty today
Revved up · Some room today

Pace
go gently, settle first

It's gusty. You're revved up. That energy is useful for doing something physical, but it is poor weather for big decisions.

You said what would help is food or water and to move. Arrange that before anything else.

Overall: some room today. There is less room than usual, so spend it carefully.

If you want to send someone a line: "I'm a bit wound up today, so I'll keep replies short. It isn't about you."

Fill in your own: My weather today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks)

04

Ask where this feeling is coming from.

It's 4.45 on a Friday and a colleague leans over the partition. "Quick question?"

Your heart goes. Why? If you stop and look, there's a fair bit in there. A jumpiness that belongs to a manager you had six years ago, who never once had a quick question. A long week. And nothing to eat since a biscuit at eleven. What it needs is five minutes and a sandwich, and then you can answer him like a normal person.

That's the whole check, really: name the feeling, roughly, then ask whether it fits the size of the moment or feels older, and what it needs. The answer is usually more ordinary than you'd think, and it works best once the first wave has gone past.

When feelings are hard to name. For some people "What are you feeling?" is a hard question most days and nearly impossible on bad ones. They notice a racing heart or a heavy stomach and can't tell if it's worry or hunger or something else. Psychologists call this *alexithymia*, which means "no words for feelings". It's a trait that runs from a little to a lot. It's common, especially among autistic people, and it isn't an illness. The feelings are there. The words come slowly. Start with the body ("tight chest, skipped lunch"). Pick between two words instead of hunting for one ("more tired or more annoyed?"). Use the sky words if feeling words won't come. "I'll tell you tomorrow" is a real answer.

Where is this feeling coming from?

Four small questions, once the first wave has passed.

1. **Name it**
   A word or two is enough. Or start with the body: where do you feel it?
2. **Now, or older?**
   Is the feeling the size of the moment, or is something left over?
3. **Which layer?**
   Wiring, an old pattern, or today's conditions. Pick the biggest part.
4. **What does it need?**
   Food, rest or space. A heads-up. A fact check. A talk later, once settled.

This book's own four steps. Finding words for feelings is hard for many people; the body is a good place to start.

FIGURE 6 A four-step self-check for a feeling that is bigger than you expected. Do it once the first wave has passed.

05

Plan what settles you on a calm day.

Halfway through being wound up is a terrible time to work out what calms you down, so the Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11) is a plan you make beforehand, with what tends to set you off, two things that help, and one sentence for stepping away that says when you'll be back. It's for you. It is never a list of instructions for anyone else.

Elsie is fourteen and she and her mum have the same row about her phone roughly twice a week. She made a kit, grudgingly, mostly to get her mum off her back. The next time it kicked off she said, "I need ten minutes, I'll come back," and went upstairs and lay on her bed with her headphones in, furious. Twelve minutes later she came down to find her mum had put the kettle on. Neither of them mentioned the phone, which wasn't exactly a resolution, and was a great deal better than the usual.

YOU COULD SAY

"I need ten minutes. I'll be back at quarter past."



SUGARFOOT

Make your calm-down plan on a slow, quiet day, feet up, cup of tea. Making one in the middle of a storm is like reading the instructions on the fire extinguisher while the pan's still burning.

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11

06

Your needs and limits are information, not demands.

What helps you and what you've got left are facts about you. Said kindly, they let other people plan around you. "A heads-up helps me." "I can do this one. Not that one." "I'm low today, can it wait till tomorrow?" You don't have to justify a need. A reason is a kindness you can add if you want to.

For years I was told I was too sensitive and too particular about plans, and what was actually true is that I need less coming at me at once, and I need to know what's coming. Heard as complaints, needs like that sound like things to fix in you. Understood as needs, they're simply things to arrange.

Quinn lives with his two partners in a terrace with one bathroom and an alarming number of shoes in the hall. He needs an hour on his own after work, and before he said so, that hour looked to everyone else like sulking. Once he'd said it, plainly, it turned into part of the week, like bin day, and one of the others now does his tea on Thursdays.

Needs as plain facts
Marshall Rosenberg's Nonviolent Communication teaches people to say what they saw, what they feel, what they need and what they'd like. It's very widely used and has had few rigorous studies. The piece borrowed here is small: a need, said as a fact about you.

Rosenberg (1999) · *Early: a widely used practice with few rigorous studies*

Two workpapers from other chapters help with the words. Who did what, from the Preface (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/preface), has ready-made kind ways to say no. Say it so it lands, from Part Two, Chapter IV (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4), turns a raw reaction into a plain request. Or try this. Write one need you've never said out loud, and say it to the bathroom mirror without the apology on the front.

07

Being wired differently is not being wrong.

Some people take in words, noise, change and feelings differently from the way most social customs were built, and that's wiring, which you can understand, plan round and get support for if you want. Shona has ADHD and spent years calling herself hopeless because she kept missing plans with friends. Now she just tells people the one thing that works, a text the day before, and she turns up, usually on time and always with an apology ready in case (see Neurodivergent relationships, spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships).

A mix-up runs both ways. When an autistic and a non-autistic person misread each other, the autistic person usually gets the blame. The *double empathy problem*, named by the autistic researcher Damian Milton, is the idea that the gap runs both ways. Each person reads the other through their own way of communicating, and each finds the other hard to read. In one study, a story passed along a chain of autistic people kept as much detail as one passed along non-autistic people, while mixed chains lost detail faster. I find that study quietly cheering. Wired Differently (spreadloveandacceptance.

com/wired-differently) shows how two differently wired people can each misread the other, and "Where did we lose each other?" lets both of you adjust a little.

"Putting on my best normal"
That's the title of a study in which 92 autistic adults described camouflaging their differences, mostly out of a wish to fit in and connect, and often paying for it afterwards in exhaustion. If a perfectly nice day leaves you flattened, it may be worth asking how much of it you spent performing.

Hull and colleagues (2017) · *Moderate: an interview study that shaped later research*

08

Explain yourself without over-sharing.

Most moments need one short sentence, and there are really only three. "This is how I'm wired, it won't change, but this helps." "This is an old alarm going off, I'm working on it." "Low-battery day, sorry." You never owe anyone your history, only the bit that helps them help you.

Rob has a long-term illness and a new friend from the climbing wall who keeps suggesting things. "Some days I've got less in the tank," he told him, on the bench, unlacing his shoes. "If I cancel, it isn't you." The friend said "Fair enough" and asked if he wanted a lift on Thursday, and that was the end of it, with no medical notes required (see When one of you is ill, spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill).

09

Do your part, and only your part.

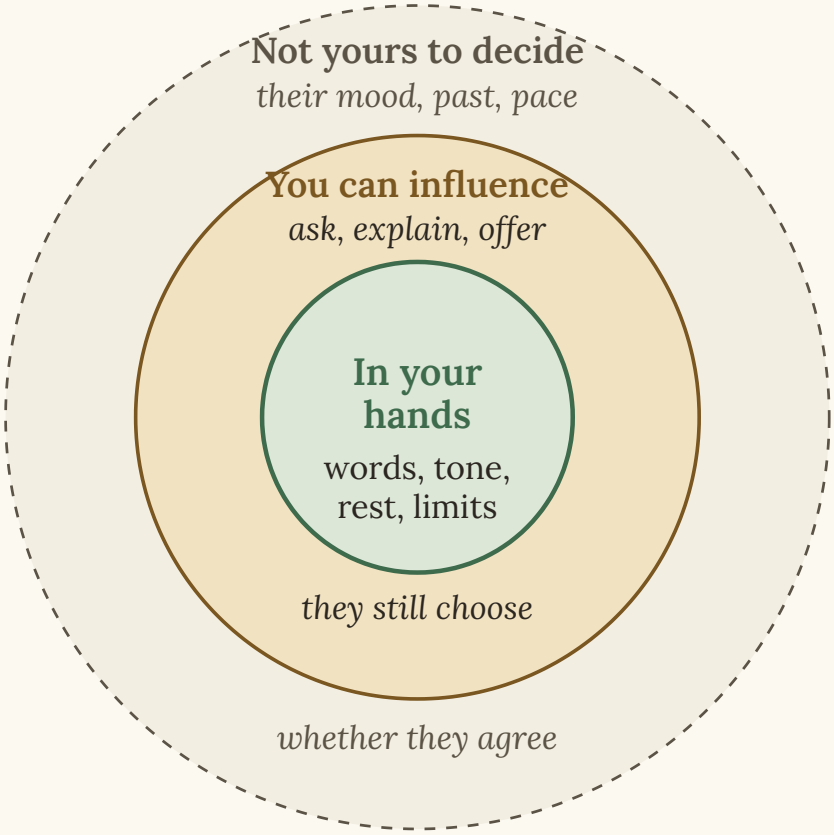
Today you control your own words, your effort, your rest, your limits and what you ask for. You don't control anyone else's mood or pace, and trying to will flatten you quicker than almost anything. It helps, too, to match energy with energy. Meet warmth with warmth, and give a little less where you keep giving far more than comes back.

Lorna is thirty-eight and her dad still worries about her driving. She has tried reassurance, statistics and once, unwisely, sarcasm, and none of it worked. What she does now is text "Home safe x" after any long run up the M6, and then she lets his worry be his (see For grown-up children,

spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children). He still worries, and she has stopped trying to talk him out of it.

Your circle of control

Spend your energy from the middle out.



Most exhaustion comes from pouring energy into the outer ring.

Illustration.

FIGURE 7 Your circle of control. Spend your energy from the middle out; most exhaustion comes from pouring it into the outer ring.

FRIDAY, 6:40PM

"Surprise! I've booked us dinner with my cousins tonight. Half seven, the Turkish place."

They meant it as a present. Your chest went tight and you heard yourself say "Great" in a voice so flat you could have ironed on it. Later, at the sink, you try to work out which bit that was, the plan changing or something older or just the end of the week, and decide it was probably some of each. You still haven't said anything, and the taxi's booked for ten past.

You, in all your relationships

Your wiring and your weather come with you everywhere, starting with how you treat yourself on a bad day. Noticing that you're low ought to come before deciding that you're failing. Partners can give each other a heads-up or a quiet hour, and every partner has wiring of their own. With friends and family, the question is usually how you like to keep in touch and how much you can give this month. At work it might be an agenda the day before, or a minute before you answer. Housemates mostly negotiate noise, and the bathroom. If you live on your own, you get to build a week that fits how you're built (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

Common mix-ups

Knowing yourself is mostly about what helps. A label can come later, or never, and the three layers and a Wave Code are everyday words with no diagnosis in them. "That's just how I am" may well be true, especially about wiring, but it works much better as the start of a conversation than the end of one. Telling people how you're wired doesn't make them your managers either, though it does help your words land. You still do your part, and they still have needs of their own.

And "I'm fine" does sometimes mean fine. Sometimes it means you've been tired for so long you've stopped noticing. A quick reading once a week shows you the baseline you've got used to, which can be a bit of a shock.

A note on care: This part is general education. It isn't a diagnosis, a test or treatment, and it can't tell you whether you're autistic, have ADHD or anything else, or what anyone else has. If you'd like to understand yourself more deeply, a qualified professional can help, if and when you want that. Nothing here is required, and nothing you try needs to be shared. If talking about any of this with someone ever feels unsafe, or you feel you can't say no, stop and talk with a trained counselor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counseling together isn't advised.

To put this to use, take one reaction you had this week and give it a line for each layer (the wiring bit, the older bit, today's bit). Then take a one-minute reading of your weather. Then write one sentence about what helps you, and keep it to yourself for a few days before trying it on someone. Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself), the "How to talk to me" card and How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying) are free on the site.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Today is made of two layers you can work with.
- ✓ Check your weather before you speak.
- ✓ Plan what settles you on a calm day.
- ✓ Being wired differently is not being wrong.
- ✓ Do your part, and only your part.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part Three · Chapter 9 · Minds that work differently
Wiring differences: autism, ADHD and the senses
page 165

Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system
Why your weather changes how you hear things
page 72

Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles
The stress tank, used between two people
read online

Part Two · Chapter IV · Two kinds of fair
What fair means when you share the work
read online

PUT IT TO USE

The self path: get to know your wiring
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

How much are you carrying? A quick stress check
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying

Next

PART ONE · NEXT

Know yourself: next, shaping who you are becoming

You aren't finished, and some of who you become is up to you. This chapter is about choosing a direction and building small steps that still work on a tired day.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Start with what matters to you
2. Pick one small goal, in plain words
3. Name what gets in the way
4. Make the step tiny, and repeatable
5. Decide ahead with a simple if-then
6. Ask for support, as information
7. Look back kindly once a month
8. Kindness to yourself is part of the plan
9. Set goals inside your circle, and spend energy where it comes back
10. You, in all your relationships
11. Common mix-ups

WEDNESDAY, 9:10PM

The trainers have been by the front door since Sunday, laces tucked in, pointing outwards like a promise. You were going to walk after dinner, and dinner was two hours ago. Monday, you think. Monday has a nice clean feel to it.

01

Start with what matters to you.

A goal built on somebody else's idea of a good life is very hard to keep going with. So before you pick one, ask what you want your days to feel like, and write two or three plain words. Calm, say, or close to family, or steady, or making things, and whatever they are, they give you a direction to face instead of a score to hit. If you're not sure what fills you up and what drains

you, How you connect (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength) can help you notice.

The week their youngest went off to Sheffield, Marion and Keith each wrote two words on the back of a gas bill, hers saying “useful, outdoors” and his “calm, curious”, and Keith looked at hers for a long while before he said, “That’s why you keep going on about the bird hut.” She had been eyeing the volunteers’ hut at the nature reserve since February. He had been spending a suspicious amount of time staring at the vegetable patch (see Kids grown and gone, spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest). Write yours in pencil, since they may well change.

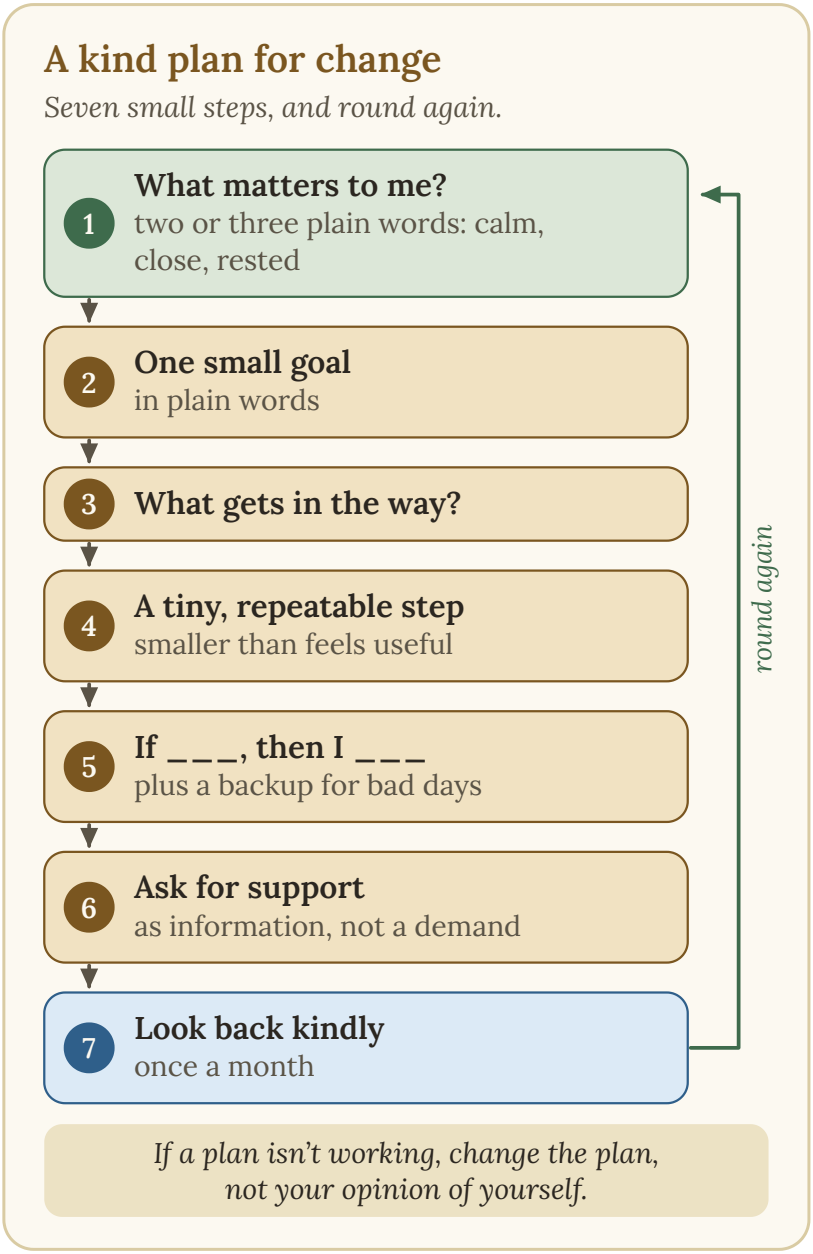


FIGURE 8 A kind plan for change in seven small steps. If the plan isn't working, change the plan, not your opinion of yourself.

02

Pick one small goal, in plain words.

Just one, and say it as something you'll do. "Walk for ten minutes after dinner" can go in a diary. "Get healthier" is a hope, and hopes are lovely, but you can't do anything with one on a Tuesday. Your own actions are up to you, while how people respond, and how it all turns out, aren't.

A student in a shared room in halls wanted to be "less messy", which her roommate had heard before. As an action it became "clothes in the basket before bed". She managed it about four nights in seven, and her roommate said that was four more than last term (see Sharing a room, spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room). Try rewriting one wish so it starts "I will…"

03

Name what gets in the way.

This is where Then (page 14) and Now (page 29) earn their keep. The obstacle might be your wiring, and a plan that ignores how you're built was made for somebody else. It might be an old rule ("rest has to be earned" is a popular one), or it might simply be a tired Tuesday. Whichever it is, change the arrangement and leave yourself alone.

Kofi kept missing his evening run and had more or less concluded he was lazy, when the truth was that he works in a warehouse on a rota that changes every single week, so "evenings" meant something different every Monday and his plan never stood a chance. Once he tied the run to his first day off, whenever it fell, he stopped missing it. He's still slightly annoyed it took him a year to see (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours).

04

Make the step tiny, and repeatable.

It needs to be small enough to survive your worst week, which means "Put my shoes on" counts, and I do mean that. Tie it to something you already do, and do it often. The 90-second daily check-in in Part Two, Chapter I (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-1-in-depth) runs on the same idea, that small and often outlasts big and rare, and Ten-minute start

(spreadloveandacceptance.com/start-in-10-minutes) shows how small a whole path can be.

Six months after the breakup, Ade wanted to "get back out there", which is far too big a thing to start on a Sunday night. What he actually did was send one message to one friend every Sunday, usually from the sofa during the weather forecast and usually something feeble like "you watching this?", and after a few weeks two of the friends started replying with whole paragraphs (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). If you like a game for this sort of thing, the Re-check Drive (spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive) turns small steps into calm football. If your step takes more than two minutes, shrink it again.



TIDBIT

Tiny steps count, wobbly ones included. If you like a game, there's one where each small kind act moves the ball up the field.

TOOL **Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

05

Decide ahead with a simple if-then.

"If it's after dinner, I put my shoes on." Deciding ahead means one decision fewer on a tired day. It's the same thinking as the Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11), made while you're calm.

Handovers with her ex had been going badly for a year, so Kerry made a rule for the car. When she pulls up outside his house she turns the engine off and takes three slow breaths before she opens the door. It doesn't make him any less irritating, but it does mean she gets out of the car as herself (see Co-parenting, spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting).

If-then plans hold up

This is one of the better-supported ideas in the book. Across 94 tests, Gollwitzer and Sheeran found that plans in the form "when X happens, I'll do Y" had a medium-to-large effect on people reaching their goals, though the size varied with the task.

Gollwitzer and Sheeran (2006) · *Strong: one of the more robust findings in behaviour change*

Pick a cue that happens every day anyway, like the kettle or brushing your teeth. If the if-then doesn't work, change it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

The Calm-Down Kit, just for me

Nell, on her own

The Calm-Down Kit

Your name
Nell

Date
11 October 2026

Part A: What tends to start it

What tends to start it	How it shows up in my body first
A long message from my sister late at night	*Tight chest, typing fast*
Plans changed with no warning	*Jaw, hot face*

Part A: My two defaults

First default
Walking it out

Second, if the first isn't available
Asymmetric breathing (4 in, 6 out)

Part A: My pause line

In my words
I'm at capacity. I'm going to step away for twenty minutes, and I'll answer properly after that.

My pause plan (yours to share, if you like)

My pause word or signal
"Back in a bit"

The shortest break I take
20 minutes

How I set the time to come back
I text a time, the same day

The first sentence when I come back
"Thanks for waiting. I can think straight now."

Part B: In the moment

Say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step. Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

Part C: Coming back

Time	What I did	How I feel now
9:40 pm	*Walking it out*	*Still hot*
10:05 pm	*Asymmetric breathing (4 in, 6 out)*	*Settled enough*

WHERE THAT LEAVES YOU

Next
Settled enough: pick things back up, at the time you named. When you come back, start with one small, simple task, like putting the dishes away.

Next small action
Reply to my sister's message, one line

If you put it off: when you'll pick it back up
Tomorrow after lunch

☑ I'm going with this

Made-up example.

Fill in your own: The Calm-Down Kit (Just me) (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11)

06

Ask for support, as information.

Tell one person what you're trying and what would help. "I'm trying to walk after dinner. Would you ask me how it's going on Sunday?" They can say no, and you don't need anybody's permission to start anyway.

Since her husband's stroke, Glenys has done nearly all of his care, and for months she said "I'm fine" whenever her brother asked, until in the end she asked him something so specific that it would have been very hard to refuse. "Could you sit with him Thursdays, two till four, so I can swim?" He said yes before she'd finished, and he brings Bourbons. She's swum eleven Thursdays out of fourteen, which she thinks is pretty good.

Some goals are better shared with a qualified professional, and asking for one is a sensible step whenever you want it.

07

Look back kindly once a month.

This is the monthly look-back from Part Two, Chapter V (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-5), pointed at yourself instead of a household. Ten minutes, once a month, asking what went well and what kept slipping. Was the gap in the plan, in what you had to give that month, or in one strange week? You don't add up old misses, because the only question is what to try next month. Its workpaper, What keeps coming back? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-04-what-keeps-coming-back), is written for a shared home, but the two questions work fine on your own.

Pauline is raising her two grandchildren. On the first of March she sat down with a pot of tea and a biro and saw, fairly quickly, that bedtime was working and homework very much wasn't, so in March homework moved to the kitchen table straight after a snack, before the telly went on. It worked for one child, and the other one, she says, is "a work in progress, like me".



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Your monthly look is the solo version of the monthly look-back for people who share a home. Borrow its two questions if you like: what kept slipping, and what would have made it easier?

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-04

08

Kindness to yourself is part of the plan.

There's an old image of the second arrow that I find useful here. The first arrow is the slip itself. The second is the telling-off you give yourself afterwards, which hurts more and helps less. A plan that needs you to be harsh with yourself is mostly second arrows. Rest belongs inside the plan, and you can shrink a goal or drop it whenever you like.

Harvey is sixteen, and he planned to revise every night, missed three in a row, and announced at breakfast that he was useless and might as well not bother. His nan went on buttering toast. "What would you tell Kian?" she

said. Harvey rolled his eyes so hard it looked painful. That evening he did twenty minutes before tea, and said nothing about it to anyone.

Three parts of being kind to yourself
Kristin Neff, who defined self-compassion for researchers, splits it into kindness instead of harsh judgement, remembering that everyone struggles instead of feeling alone with it, and noticing a painful feeling without being swallowed by it.

Neff (2003) · *Moderate: widely studied and promising; much of the research is correlational*

09

Set goals inside your circle, and spend energy where it comes back.

A goal that needs someone else to change is really a wish. You might wish your sister rang more, but that's outside your circle. Ringing her on the first Sunday of the month, and telling her you'd love her to ring too, is inside it. Then treat your energy like the limited thing it is. Put more into the people and plans that give something back, and less into the ones that only take, so you've still got some left when you get near the goal.

THE FIRST OF THE MONTH

You open your notes app. Of the four small things you tried, two have stuck and two quietly stopped somewhere in the second week. You still don't know why the Saturday swim fell away. You liked the Saturday swim, as far as you can remember, so you put a question mark next to it and close the app.

You, in all your relationships

A goal for yourself nearly always brushes against other people, and small steps work everywhere. With a partner, offer one small habit instead of demanding one. With friends, one message a week can keep a friendship warm for years. In a family it might be a regular call, a visit you can actually keep up, or a first step after a long silence (see Reaching out,

spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts). At work it could be one comment per meeting, and with money, one small saving habit that's yours alone.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

The self path, step by step

Sam, on their own, two weeks in

The path, step by step

Step	Where it's at
Check your battery	*Done ✓*
Get to know your wiring	*Done ✓*
See where your lens came from	*Done ✓*
Plan what settles you	Not yet
Find words for what you feel	Not yet
Practise kind ways to say no	Not yet

Come back gently, once a week

Pick a day and a time, and add a ten-minute reminder to your own calendar. It repeats every week and just says "10 minutes for me".

Day	Time
Sunday	*7:30 pm*

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

The next step is Plan what settles you: the Calm-Down Kit. Three steps done is three steps done; the rest will still be here next week.

Fill in your own: The self path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path)

Common mix-ups

The commonest, and the least true, is that a goal has to be big to count. Small and repeatable is what survives a bad week, and most big goals turn out to be a lot of small ones in a trench coat. Some people think that once they understand themselves they should be able to change anything. Wiring stays, though, so the aim is a goal that fits how you're built. Asking for support doesn't mean you couldn't manage, it just gives people what they need to help, and "I'll start on Monday" isn't always a dodge either. A fresh start can genuinely help, though the tiny version you could do today counts just as much.

> **A note on care:** This part is general education. It isn't therapy, coaching or medical advice, and it can't promise any result. Goals about your health, money, work or a hard stretch in life may deserve a qualified professional, and there's no shame in asking for one. Nothing here is required, and nothing you write needs to be shared. If a goal ever starts to feel like a weight, you can shrink it or put it down.

If you want to start tonight, write your two words, one goal as something you'll do, the smallest first step you can think of and one if-then. Then put ten minutes in the calendar for a month from now. Your self-discovery path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) and Ten-minute start are free on the site.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Start with what matters to you.
- ✓ Name what gets in the way.
- ✓ Decide ahead with a simple if-then.
- ✓ Look back kindly once a month.
- ✓ Set goals inside your circle, and spend energy where it comes back.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part Three · Chapter 10 · Values, meaning and a good life
Finding out what matters to you page 184

Part Three · Chapter 6 · Habits and change
Why tiny steps and if-then plans work page 127

Part Two · Chapter V · The monthly look-back
The same monthly look, done together read online

Part Three · Chapter 7 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion
A kinder inner voice when a step slips page 140

PUT IT TO USE



The self path, step by step
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path



The Calm-Down Kit: a plan for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11



PART THREE

Understanding people

How feelings, stress, trust, change, grief, groups and love work, for anyone, in any kind of relationship.

IN THIS PART

Chapter 1	How feelings work	58
Chapter 2	Stress and the nervous system	72
Chapter 3	How we see each other	87
Chapter 4	How communication works	99
Chapter 5	Attachment, trust and belonging	114
Chapter 6	Habits and change	127
Chapter 7	Self-worth, shame and self-compassion	140
Chapter 8	Loss, grief and big life changes	152
Chapter 9	Minds that work differently	165
Chapter 10	Values, meaning and a good life	184
Chapter 11	Healing after hurt	197
Chapter 12	Helping others well	210
Chapter 13	Anger	223
Chapter 14	Personality, temperament and change	238
Chapter 15	Closeness and love	252
Chapter 16	Worry, low mood and trauma	264
Chapter 17	Groups, influence and culture	279



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

If a question pops up while you read, ask me. Nothing you type leaves your device.

TOOL **Ask Professor Puddles** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

1

PART THREE · CHAPTER 1

How feelings work: signals, the body, and naming what you feel

What feelings are for, where they start, and why putting a name to one can make it easier to carry, whether you're on your own, at home, with friends or at work.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. A feeling is a signal, not a verdict
2. Feelings start in the body
3. Naming a feeling helps you hold it
4. More words, better tools
5. Feelings come in layers
6. Feelings rise and pass like waves
7. Feelings spread between people
8. If you weren't brought up to talk about feelings
9. Feeling it isn't the same as doing it
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **A feeling is a signal** that something matters to you. It doesn't tell you what to do about it.
- **Feelings start in the body.** A tight chest or a hot face often arrives before the word for it.
- **Naming helps.** "I feel let down" is easier to hold than a big, nameless rush.
- **You can let a feeling be there** and still choose what you do next.

THURSDAY, 4:50PM

A message from your manager. Have you got a minute tomorrow? No full stop, no smiley, nothing else at all.

By the time you get in you've snapped at the cat, decided you're not hungry, and gone back over every mistake of the past month, plus one from March that nobody else remembers. Nobody has said anything bad. You check the message again anyway, in case it's grown a full stop.

Feelings sit underneath nearly everything else in this book, so they get looked at first. Two tools elsewhere lean on this chapter. My weather today and the daily check-in (Part One, Now, page 29; Part Two, Chapter I, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-1) ask for one word about how you are, because naming a feeling turns its volume down a little and a daily word catches feelings while they're still small. And Say it so it lands (Part Two, Chapter IV, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4) asks you to describe a feeling, because "I felt let down" is a good deal easier to hear than "you never care."

01

A feeling is a signal, not a verdict.

Feelings are fast messages about what matters to you. Fear says watch out. Anger says this seems unfair, or this is in my way. Sadness says something that mattered has gone. A signal is worth listening to. It can also be badly wrong about the details, the way a smoke alarm goes off for burnt toast with exactly the same urgency it would give a house fire.

Hayley's best friend has a new best friend, or that's how it feels, and Hayley is jealous and a bit ashamed of being jealous at thirty-four. The jealousy proves nothing about her, and nothing about whether the friend is drifting off either; it just shows how much the friendship matters, which is worth knowing, and possibly worth saying. "I'm being daft," she texts eventually, "but I miss you." The friend rings within the minute.

Sunny days and big questions

In a classic study, people phoned on sunny days rated their whole lives as more satisfying, and the bad-weather dip vanished once the interviewer mentioned the weather. Much bigger studies later found the weather effect itself is tiny. The useful part survives: spotting where a feeling comes from stops it colouring everything else.

Schwarz and Clore (1983) · *Moderate: a classic study of feelings as information; the weather effect proved very small*

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"This feeling is telling me something matters. What is it?" "Is this the fire, or the toast?"

02

Feelings start in the body.

Often the body goes first. Racing heart, hot face, a weight on the chest, a knot in the stomach. Then the brain tries to work out what the signal means. It guesses, and it isn't always a good guesser. Which is why being hungry, or cold, or in pain, can feel so much like being upset.

Reece is fifteen and has come home in a fury about a towel. Specifically, about his mum asking where his PE towel was. There is a good deal of door involved. After a cheese toastie and twenty minutes on the sofa with the dog's head on his knee, most of it has drained away, and he admits, through a mouthful, that he didn't have any lunch. "I wasn't hungry," he says. Then, "I was a bit hungry."

A few times today, stop and ask what your body feels like right now, and whether any of it is simply hunger, or cold, or a sore back.

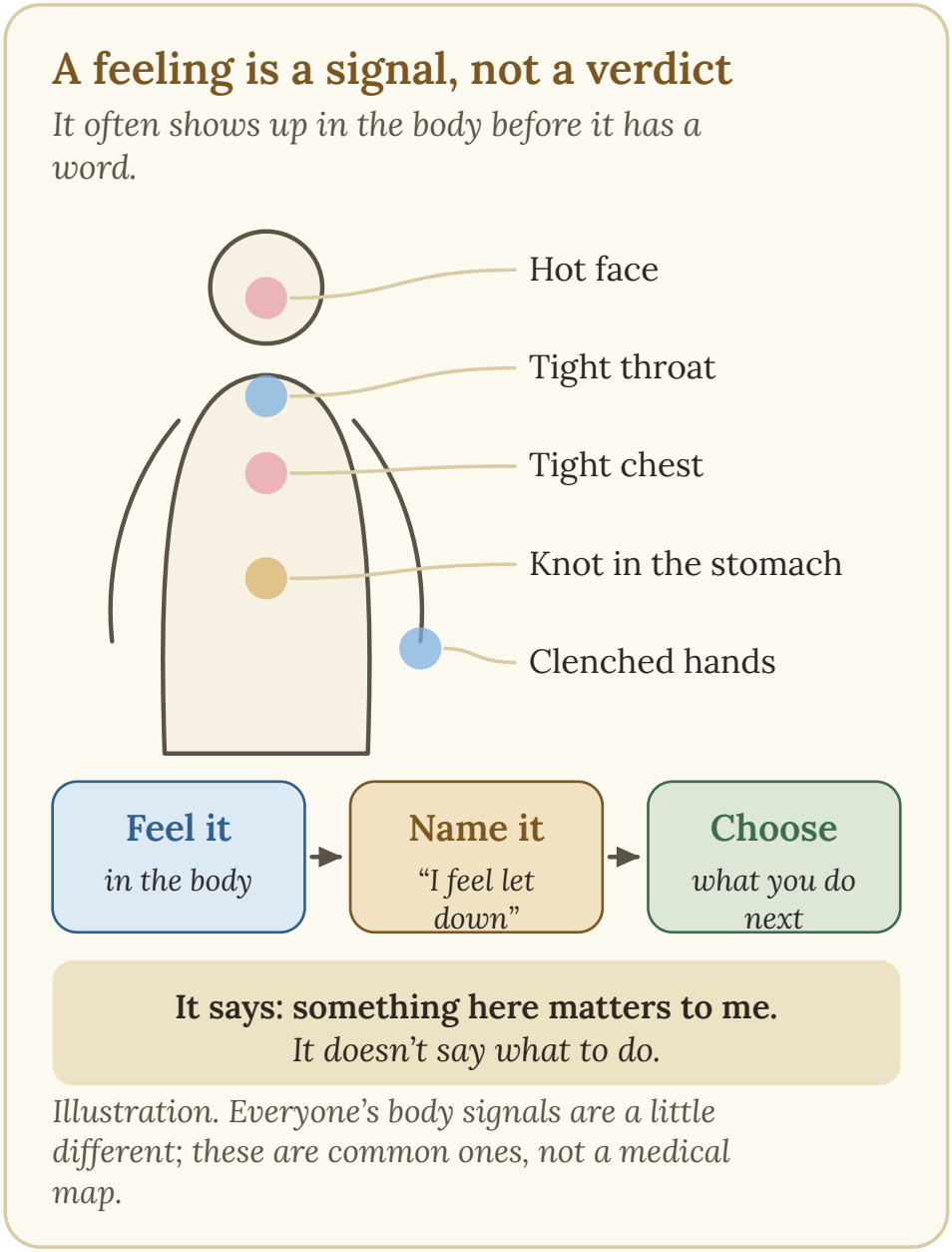


FIGURE 9 A feeling is a signal, not a verdict. It often shows up in the body first; naming it helps you choose what to do next.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

My weather today

Esme, 29, at 4:50pm, after "Got a minute tomorrow?" from her manager

Check today's weather

The sky

Clear: Calm and connected · *Gusty: Revved up* · Fogged in: Running on empty

Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner · Family · A co-parent · Roommates · *Coworkers* · Someone I care for · Friends · Mostly on my own

The pressure

Light · *Building* · Heavy

Ground conditions

Haven't eaten in a while · Thirsty · In pain or unwell · Been still all day · Too much noise or light · *Running on caffeine* · Screens since I woke up

Last night's sleep

Barely slept · Short night · *About enough* · Properly rested

People load

Barely any · *A normal amount* · A lot · Nonstop, no gaps

What's blowing in

Work · Money · Kids or caring · Health · Family · The house · *One conversation* · Something I can't name

What would actually help in the next hour?

Space · Food or water · Rest · To move · *To be heard* · *A plan* · Company · Quiet · Someone to take something off me

YOUR FORECAST

Gusty today
Revved up · Some room today

Talk window
wait about 20 minutes

It's gusty. You're revved up. That energy is useful for doing something physical, but it is poor weather for deciding anything about another person.

The ground underneath: you haven't eaten in a while and you're running on caffeine. That isn't a side note. It's likely a big part of why today feels the way it does, and it's easier to change than character is.

Blowing in: one conversation. Weather from one front tends to land on whoever is nearest, often someone who had nothing to do with it. Worth saying out loud before it does.

You said what would help is a plan and to be heard. Arrange that before anything else.

If you want to send someone a line: "I don't need it solved. I just need you to hear this for a few minutes first."

Made-up example. Esme ate something, then rang her sister to be heard. She didn't reply to the message until the morning.

Fill in your own: My weather today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks)

03

Naming a feeling helps you hold it.

Putting a feeling into words can turn its volume down. In brain-scan research by Lieberman and colleagues (2007), simply putting a name to a feeling ("I feel scared") turned down the brain's alarm response. A name gives a big, cloudy rush some edges, so you can see it and talk about it and decide what to do.

Two housemates spent a whole evening passing each other in the hall without a word. Nobody had done anything, as far as either of them knew. At about ten, one of them stopped on the stairs. “I think I’m embarrassed about the noise complaint,” she said, “and I’ve been taking it out on you by being weird.” The other one, who had spent two hours going back over everything she’d said that week, laughed so hard she had to sit down. Then she put the kettle on.

It works even when it doesn’t feel like it

A review by Torre and Lieberman found that naming a feeling can turn down its intensity even though, in the moment, it doesn’t feel as if you’re doing anything at all. So carry on with “something like sad” even when it seems pointless.

Torre and Lieberman (2018) · *Moderate: consistent lab evidence; how it works is still being worked out*

Once a day, name one feeling, out loud or on paper. A guess like “something like sad” counts.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

If the words won’t come, weather words often will. “Foggy” or “stormy” is a perfectly good place to start.

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

04

More words, better tools.

“Bad” is a blunt instrument. Disappointed is different from left out, and both are different from overwhelmed or ashamed. Each one needs something different. A review by Kashdan, Barrett and McKnight (2015) found that people who can tell their feelings apart more finely tend to cope with them in healthier ways. You don’t need a fancy vocabulary. A number does the job. So does a colour.

Stephen told his partner he felt bad about his mum and they went round the houses for half an hour. Bad how? Bad about what? Then, out of nowhere, staring at the fridge: “I feel guilty I haven’t been up since Easter. And I’m scared she’s getting worse.” Within ten minutes they were looking at trains to Carlisle, and the cheapest one turned out to leave at 6.12 in the morning, which led to a whole different conversation about who was going to drive them to the station.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"On a scale of one to ten, I'm about a six." "It's less angry and more… let down." "It feels heavy, like a grey day."

05

Feelings come in layers.

The feeling you show first isn't always the one you felt first. Anger very often sits on top of hurt or fear, because anger is a stronger place to stand. And we have feelings about our feelings (ashamed of being sad, cross about being scared) and that second layer can sting more than the first.

Half-term has been cancelled again, for the second time. Brenda's daughter rings to say so, with a lot of reasons, all of them good ones, and Brenda says, "Fine. Well. Another time," in a voice like a closing door. Under that is hurt, and under the hurt, if she let herself look, there is a quieter worry that she isn't needed much any more by anyone, which is the one she has spent the last two years carefully not looking at. She doesn't look. She puts the phone down and sits next to it for a while with her coat still on.

Next time you're angry, you might ask whether there's hurt or worry underneath. You don't have to tell anyone what you find.

06

Feelings rise and pass like waves.

Most feelings, even big ones, rise and peak and settle, as long as you don't keep feeding them. Moods are something else. A mood is more like weather, a background feeling that hangs about for hours or days and colours everything without announcing itself.

By eleven o'clock on a Saturday morning Rachel had decided her whole life was going nowhere. In fairness it had been a morning. The boiler, a letter from the council, and a dream about her ex in which he was, for some reason, a dentist. By seven that evening, after a walk along the

Not every wave is the same length

Of 27 emotions in one study, sadness lasted longest, and shame, fear and disgust were among the shortest. The long ones tended to follow events that mattered, and to be chewed over.

Verduyn and Lavrijsen (2015) · *Moderate: a single self-report study, in line with other research on how long feelings last*

canal and an hour on the phone to her sister, the same life looked fairly ordinary and mostly all right, with an actual dentist on Tuesday and a library book she wanted to finish. Nothing in her life changed between eleven and seven.

So if you can, leave big decisions until the wave has gone past. Write it down. Look at it tomorrow.

07

Feelings spread between people.

We catch each other's feelings from a tight voice, a sigh, a door shut slightly too hard, usually without noticing we've caught anything. It's part of how people bond. It also means stress can go round a house or a team like a cold in February.

Bryony came into the Monday meeting late and rattled, and within ten minutes six people who had been perfectly fine at nine o'clock felt behind on everything. The following Monday she stood outside the door for two slow breaths before going in. The meeting finished on time. In that office this was regarded as a minor miracle and nobody could work out why.

You can care about someone's feeling without catching the whole of it. Good moods are catching too, and Stay close (spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding) has small ideas for passing one on. Notice who you tend to catch things from, and give yourself a minute before you next talk to them.



TIDBIT

Good moods are catching too. If you'd like a small way to share one, there's a tool for it.

TOOL **Stay close: one small idea** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

08

If you weren't brought up to talk about feelings.

Lots of people grew up in homes, generations or cultures where feelings were kept private. "Don't make a fuss." "Big boys don't cry." "We don't talk about that." It's especially common among men and older people, and in some cultures keeping your feelings to yourself is a sign of respect and strength.

It isn't a flaw, and it doesn't mean you don't feel. Many people who rarely put a feeling into words show it every day by doing things, fixing the tap or driving someone to A&E at two in the morning and waiting in the car park till it's over. They turn up. Caring by doing is real caring. Words can be added slowly, a few at a time, if you want them.

Len was a builder for forty years and his wife died in the spring. He has never in his life said how he feels about anything, apart from Newcastle United. On the touchline at his grandson's match, during a long dull bit of the first half, he says to his son, "I wasn't brought up to say this. But I miss her. Every morning." His son puts a hand on his shoulder and leaves it there. Neither of them says anything else for the rest of the match. They watch the second half, which is also dull, and it's one of the better afternoons either of them has had all year.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> "I wasn't brought up to say this, but I miss her." "I'm not good with words for this. It's been a hard week." "I don't know what to call it. I just feel heavy." "I'm not one for talking, but I wanted you to know I'm proud of you."

If one of those fits, you could say it once this week, to one person, or just out loud in the car. A text counts.

09

Feeling it isn't the same as doing it.

A feeling usually arrives with an urge attached, to shout or leave or hide or send the text you'll regret by teatime. You don't choose the feeling, but you get rather more say over the urge. Pushing a feeling down tends to bring it back bigger, and acting on every urge hurts people, so the middle way is to let the feeling be there and choose the action.

A crash from the garden. Through the kitchen window, Imran's son is standing very still beside the greenhouse with a football, and there is a lot less greenhouse than there was. Imran feels the heat go up his neck. He opens the back door, says, "I'm too cross to talk about this. Ten minutes," shuts it again, and goes to find the dustpan. By the time he comes out his son

has picked up most of the big bits, very carefully, in gardening gloves two sizes too large.

> FRIDAY, 9:05AM
>
> *The knot's back. This time you give it a name, which is scared, and then you do the thing you'd been avoiding and just ask. Your manager looks honestly baffled. "Oh God, no. It's the summer rota." You go back to your desk and eat the breakfast you skipped, a banana that's been in your bag since Wednesday.*

In everyday life

If you live on your own, nobody is going to notice how you are, so a one-word check-in with yourself each day matters more (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). With a partner, "What are you feeling?" can sound like an exam. "Do you want to tell me, or shall I just sit with you?" is much easier to answer. Children learn feeling words from the grown-ups near them, and hearing you say "I'm frustrated, so I'm going to take a breath" teaches more than any lesson. At work, "I'm a bit flat today and I'm not upset with anyone" can stop a whole team guessing. And if someone close to you shows care by doing, like clearing the drive on your bad day, you can thank them for it in words. They may not know what to do with it the first time.

Common mix-ups

Some feelings hurt and some actions do harm, but a feeling on its own isn't bad. It's information. Feeling stupid doesn't make you stupid, either, so treat a feeling as something to check before you obey it. People also expect to know straight away what they feel, and plenty can't, some of them most days, which is why body words and numbers count as answers here. The most stubborn mix-up is the idea that a face tells you what someone feels. Faces are a poor guide. People show the same feeling in very different ways, and asking is kinder than guessing and a lot more accurate.

If you want to help someone else with this

Ask before you name it for them. “You’re angry” can land like a label. “You seem upset, am I reading that right?” leaves them room to put you straight. Then help the feeling make sense (“Of course you’re upset, that was a lot”), which does more than advice and doesn’t mean you agree with everything they did. Ask whether they want ideas or just company. A lot of people only want the second and are relieved to be asked. Take other ways of saying it, a number or a text or “I’m at a seven”. And settle yourself first. If their sadness makes you anxious, calm down before you go in, or they’ll end up looking after you.

> YOU COULD SAY
> “That sounds really hard.” “Do you want to talk, or would company help more?” “You don’t have to find the right word. A number is fine.”

When to get more help

Everyone has hard days and big feelings. It may be time to talk to a doctor, a counsellor or another trained professional if:

- a low, numb, anxious or angry feeling stays most days for two weeks or more;
- feelings are stopping you from sleeping, eating, working or seeing people;
- you are using alcohol, drugs or other things to stop feeling;
- you feel you can’t cope, or have thoughts of harming yourself. You deserve help today.

If you feel afraid of someone you live with or are close to, that fear is an important signal. It is not something to “manage” on your own.

This chapter is general education, not a diagnosis or therapy. It can’t know your situation.

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Workpapers **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11): a plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments.

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- My weather today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks): a short, private daily check of your mood and state.
- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now): steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.

Reading **pages to read on the website**

- Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself): how you tend to feel and react, and why.
- The library: what emotions are (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), naming feelings (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#affect-labeling), emotional granularity (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#emotional-granularity), when feelings are hard to name (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#alexithymia), emotional contagion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#emotional-contagion) and sensing your body (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress).

More for your situation

- Next in Part Three: Stress and the nervous system (page 72)
- Part One, Now: your wiring, your weather and your words (page 29)
- Wired differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently) and Neurodivergent relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- For teens: when feelings get loud (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- For caregivers: resentment and guilt (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers)
- Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)

- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words
Reading your own weather day to day — page 29

Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles
Feelings when a stress tank is full — read online

Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system
What the body does under pressure — page 72

Part Three · Chapter 13 · Anger
One feeling up close — page 223

PUT IT TO USE

The Calm-Down Kit
A plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11

My weather today
A short, private daily check of your mood and state
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

2

PART THREE · CHAPTER 2

Stress and the nervous system: the ladder, flooding, rest and recovery

What stress does to your body and your mind, why kind people say things they don't mean when they're flooded, and which kinds of rest actually put something back.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Stress is your body getting ready
2. Stress depends on what you have to meet it
3. The ladder: three everyday states
4. When you're flooded, thinking goes offline
5. Stress adds up, like a tank filling
6. Settle the body first
7. Rest isn't one thing
8. Sleep and stress feed each other
9. Stress is easier to carry when it's shared
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation

MONDAY, 7:52AM

The bus is late. One school shoe is missing, last seen under the sofa on Saturday. Your phone buzzes with a message from work that begins "Quick one", which it never is. From the hall your partner calls, "Have you seen my keys?" and you hear yourself shout, "I'm not your secretary!"

A second later you're standing there wondering where that came from. It wasn't the keys. You were behind before anyone had said a word, before the shoe went missing, probably before you were even out of bed.

Feelings got their own chapter (Chapter 1, page 58). This one goes a layer down, to the nervous system underneath them, and what it does when the pressure's on. Knowing how stress works won't make Monday any quieter. It does make your own reactions, and other people's, a lot less mysterious.

It also explains why some of the tools elsewhere work at all. The stress tank in Part Two, Chapter III (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3) asks how full you are before you judge the moment, because stress piles up from small loads. The Calm-Down Kit in Part One, Now (page 29) settles the body before any words, and it asks you to name a time to come back, so a pause doesn't look like walking out. And the setup score in Part Two, Chapter II (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2) counts stress as well as hours, since a split can look fair on paper and still leave one person running on empty.

01

Stress is your body getting ready.

Something needs dealing with, and your body gears up before you've decided anything. Heart faster, breath quicker, muscles tight, stress hormones up. Which is exactly what you want when a glass is sliding off the table. The trouble starts when the body stays geared up for hours and never gets the message to stand down.

Morag is a nurse. She handles a cardiac arrest on the ward calmly and well. She gets home at nine, eats half a sandwich standing up at the counter, and at half past ten finds herself sobbing at an advert for car insurance. Car insurance has never moved her to anything before. Her body is still running the emergency it thinks she's in.

So after something stressful, give your body a clear sign that it's over, whether that's a walk round the block or a hot shower or one song played much too loud in the car on the way home. The body takes its cue from what you do far more than from what you tell it.

02

Stress depends on what you have to meet it.

The same deadline lands on two colleagues on a Thursday afternoon, and one of them has a quiet evening ahead and a takeaway menu. The other has a seven-year-old at home with a temperature and a partner away in Leeds till Saturday. On paper it's one task. Guess which of them is awake at 3am.

Stress grows when a demand looks bigger than what you've got to meet it with, whether that's time or energy or money or help or sleep. That's why a small thing tips you over on a bad day. It's also why giving someone more support can shrink their stress without changing the job at all. When something feels huge, I'd write two lists side by side, one for what it asks of you and one for what you've got. Then ignore the first list for a minute and ask what would make the second one a line longer.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "It's less the task than how little I've got left today." "What would make this feel more doable?"

03

The ladder: three everyday states.

The ladder is a picture of the states your body moves between in a day. Near the bottom you're **calm and connected**, breathing easily, able to hear something difficult without bristling. Higher up you're **revved up**, tense, and small things start to feel urgent or personal. Then there's **running on empty**, which is flat and slow, with the words just out of reach.

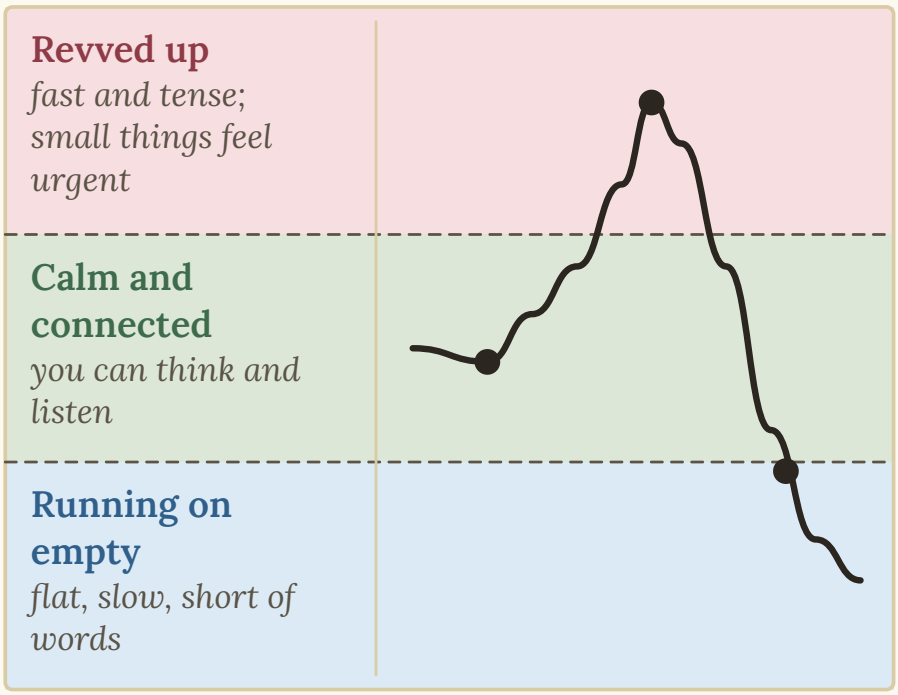
Most people go up and down it many times a day. Derek minds his granddaughter on Wednesdays, and at two o'clock he's calm and connected and they're doing a jigsaw. By four she has found the felt-tips and the wall, and he's revved up. By six, when her mum comes, he is sitting on the kitchen floor eating a fish finger off her plate and can't remember the word for colander. Neither of them had changed, only the hour, and how much afternoon was left in him.

The Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks) is a thirty-second check that gives you a best guess at where you are. If you'd rather not use a screen, set three reminders on your phone for today, and

each time one goes off, notice which rung you're on. Don't do anything about it, just notice.

The ladder: three everyday states

You move up and down it all day.



Same grandfather, same toddler. The state changed.

Hard talks go best from the middle band.

Everyday words, not a medical model. A related map is the "window of tolerance" (Siegel, 1999): inside it, you can feel strongly and still think.

FIGURE 10 The ladder: three everyday states. You move up and down it all day; hard talks go best from the middle band.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

The ladder (the sky, in My weather today)

Mike, who cares for his wife, Ann

The sky

Pick the one closest to true right now. This is a reading of you, never of anyone else.

The sky

Clear: Calm and connected Gusty: Revved up *Fogged in: Running on empty*

Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner Family A co-parent Roommates Coworkers *Someone I care for* Friends Mostly on my own

The pressure

Light Building *Heavy*

Last night's sleep

Barely slept Short night About enough Properly rested

What's blowing in

Work Money *Kids or caring* *Health* Family The house One conversation Something I can't name

What would actually help in the next hour?

Space Food or water *Rest* To move To be heard A plan Company Quiet *Someone to take something off me*

YOUR FORECAST

Fogged in today
Running on empty · Very little room today

Talk window
another day is kinder

You were already carrying a heavy day before this. Treat the size of your reaction as a reading on the day, not on whoever is in front of you.

Between you and the person you care for today: do the essentials kindly and let the rest go. If anyone can cover one thing today, ask them.

If you need to say something now: "I'm at the end of what I can carry today. Could you take [one thing] off me?"

Made-up example. A heavy reading is information about a day, not a failing in a person.

Fill in your own: My weather today: the sky (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks)

04

When you're flooded, thinking goes offline.

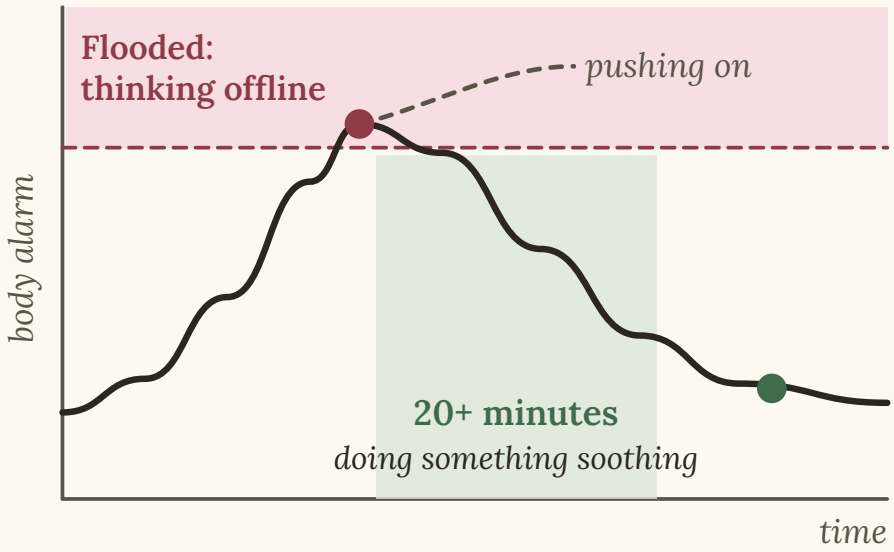
At the top of the stress curve your body is in full alarm, and the things a hard conversation needs most (careful thinking, listening, seeing the other side) get much harder to reach. Lots of people call this being **flooded**. You might say something you don't mean, or freeze, or want nothing in the world except to be out of the room.

Two brothers start clearing their dad's house one wet Saturday in March. Within twenty minutes they are shouting at each other about a standard lamp. Neither of them likes the lamp. Neither of them wants it. One of them says "Fine, take it then!" and the other says "I don't *want* it!" and they stand there either side of it, breathing hard, while the actual subject sits in the boxes all round them and nobody says it.

A flooded person is still a decent person whose body has to come down before the talk can go anywhere. Know your own flood signs in advance. Heat in the face is a common one. So is a racing heart, or the room going narrow, or a voice in your head that has gone very loud and very certain. Two at once is your cue to stop. Then say so in plain words, something like “I’m too flooded to listen well. Can we stop for twenty minutes and come back at four?”

Flooded means offline

Pause, settle, then come back.



- Pause, and name a time to come back.
- Settle the body. Don't rehearse the argument.
- Come back and talk, once you can listen.

Illustrative curve. John Gottman's work on couples suggests a real break of at least about twenty minutes when flooded.

FIGURE 11 Flooded means offline. Pause and name a time to come back, settle the body for at least twenty minutes, then talk. Illustrative curve.

05

Stress adds up, like a tank filling.

Picture a tank holding everything you're already carrying today. The traffic goes in. So does the meeting that overran, and the noisy shop, and the text from your mum that just says "Call me when you can." It's all one tank, and by

the evening something tiny makes it overflow and gets the blame for the whole lot.

Asked to empty the dishwasher, Kyle, who is fifteen, explodes. Really explodes, a whole speech about how he does everything in this house. It's days later, from a friend's mum at the school gate, that his own mum finds out his closest friendship fell apart at lunchtime that Monday, over something said in a group chat. The dishwasher was just the next thing anyone asked of him.

Hassles beat headlines

In a classic study, everyday hassles predicted how people were doing better than major life events did, even once the big events were taken into account. Which is why a missing shoe can be the thing that tips you over.

Kanner and colleagues (1981) · *Moderate: a classic study; many later studies agree*

Small daily hassles count as much as big events here, which surprises people. Before you react to a small thing in the evening, ask how full you were before it happened. How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying) is five quick questions, and Part Two, Chapter III uses it to tell old stress from new.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Stress fills up a little at a time, like a puddle in a long spell of rain. Five quick questions tell you how full yours is today.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02

06

Settle the body first.

You can't think your way out of a body in alarm. You can help the body come down, though, and the thinking usually follows. Slow breathing with long out-breaths works for a lot of people. So does moving, or humming something you know by heart, or steady pressure like a heavy blanket, or simply leaving the noisy room. What works is personal, which is why it's worth finding your own short list on a calm day and not in the middle of a row.

Before she has to give some difficult feedback, Bridie feels her heart going. She walks once round the staff car park, breathing out slowly past the bins

and the smokers' shelter, and goes in a little steadier, if not exactly calm. Put your list on your phone. The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11) helps you build it. If you only keep one line from this section, keep "body first, words second".

07

Rest isn't one thing.

An hour on the sofa scrolling can leave you more tired than when you sat down. That's because recovery comes in different kinds, and sleep is only one of them, alongside switching off from work in your head, real relaxation, doing something absorbing that you enjoy, and the plain feeling of being in charge of your own time for once. None of them stands in for the others.

Two housemates have friends round on a Saturday for a curry and the quiz on the telly. One wakes up on Sunday buzzing. The other spends the whole of Sunday in her room with a library book and the door shut, and comes out at teatime feeling human again. Company fills some people up and drains others, and neither of them is doing rest wrong.

Four kinds of recovery

Researchers who study unwinding after work separate four things: switching off in your head, relaxing, doing something absorbing that stretches you a little, and being in charge of your own time. An evening that gives you none of the four isn't much of a rest, however long you sit down.

Sonnentag and Fritz (2007) · *Strong: a widely used measure; recovery research is large and consistent*

Ask yourself which kind of tired you are, whether it's your body or your brain, or people, or feelings, then pick a rest that matches rather than the one you always go for. Calm sounds and music (spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes) is one kind, if you like that sort of thing.



SUGARFOOT

Rest can be a nap, a walk or ten minutes of quiet music. Find the kind that suits you, and keep it somewhere you can reach it.

TOOL **Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes`

08

Sleep and stress feed each other.

Stress makes sleep harder, and poor sleep makes stress land harder. After a short or broken night small things feel bigger, tempers are shorter, and people pull away from each other. This one is well studied. In a brain-scan study by Yoo and colleagues (2007), one night without sleep made the brain's alarm centre react more strongly to upsetting pictures.

In a daily study by Gordon and Chen (2014), couples reported more conflict after nights of poor sleep. In experiments by Ben Simon and Walker (2018), people who had missed a night's sleep kept others at a greater distance and felt lonelier.

Saoirse comes off her third night shift at the care home and bursts into tears in the car park over a parking ticket. Her sister, on speakerphone, says, "You've had no sleep, leave it, we'll sort it Thursday." By Thursday it is a parking ticket again, annoying and payable, and she pays it online in her lunch break between a sausage roll and a yoghurt.

You can't always fix sleep, but you can notice when it's part of the story. Before a hard conversation, ask whether you've both slept, and if not, pick another time. At night, do the same few calm things before bed in the same order, so your body learns the signal. If poor sleep goes on for weeks, talk to a doctor, because sleep problems are common and often treatable.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "I slept badly, so if I'm short with you today, that's why." "Can we talk about this after we've both slept?"

09

Stress is easier to carry when it's shared.

People calm each other down. A steady voice, a hand on the shoulder, or just a quiet person in the same room can help a nervous system settle. Saying your state out loud helps too, because "I'm stressed about work" stops your partner wondering if it's about them.

Fish fingers again, Tuesday. Kwasi says to his ten-year-old, without quite looking at him, "I'm a bit stressed about money this month. Sorting it is my

grown-up job, and you're not in trouble." His son nods and carries on eating. Nothing else is said. Over the next few days the boy stops tiptoeing round him, and on Friday he brings his maths homework to the table again and asks for help with it, which he hasn't done since half-term.

> MONDAY, 7:58AM
>
> *Six minutes later your partner is by the front door, still patting their pockets. "Sorry," you say. "I was full up before you opened your mouth." And then, after a moment, "Bathroom shelf, next to the toothpaste." They laugh, and ask if it's been a bad start. The bus is still late and the shoe is still missing.*

In everyday life

Living on your own means nobody's there to notice when you're running on empty, so build rest into the week before you need it. With a partner, agree a pause word on a calm day, plus the rule that whoever pauses names a time to come back (One of you wants to talk now, the other needs space, spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw, has more on this). A child can't settle until the nearest grown-up does. Your calm is something they borrow for years before they can make their own. At work, a flooded colleague can't take in feedback, and waiting an hour usually beats pushing on.

Some people run on empty for reasons built into their lives, like shift work, a long-term illness or caring for someone. What that needs is a different setup. More effort won't do it (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours, and Caregivers, spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers). If you have ADHD, just keeping track of everything can fill the tank before breakfast. Get the remembering out of your head and into the world, with labelled alarms and one hook for the keys, and plan hard talks for your better time of day. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-2-stress-in-depth).

Common mix-ups

People often think all stress is bad, and it isn't. Short bursts help you rise to something, and the harm comes from stress that never gets a recovery. Being calm doesn't mean not being upset, either. You can be calm and sad, or calm and extremely firm. Pausing gets mistaken for avoiding, but a pause with a time to come back is how you finish a talk well. Avoiding is the pause that never comes back. Rest gets called lazy, though bodies and minds that never recover tend to break. And short replies with a flat face get read as not caring, when far more often they mean someone is worn out.

If you want to help someone else with this

Nobody in the history of the world has calmed down because they were told to. A lower voice, slower words and a steady presence do far more. Taking one job off someone's list beats any pep talk. Ask what kind of help they'd like (practical help, company, distraction, some space) instead of guessing. Don't argue with someone who's flooded. Offer a break and a time to come back, because the facts will still be there in twenty minutes. And if someone has been running on empty for weeks, say so kindly and help them find support.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "You seem really stretched. Is there one thing I could take off your plate?" "We don't have to sort this now. Shall we pick it up after dinner?"

When to get more help

Stress is normal. Constant stress that never lets up is a warning sign. It may be time to see a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional if:

- you've felt exhausted, dread-filled or numb most days for several weeks, even after rest;
- you can't sleep, or sleep but never feel rested;
- you have physical signs that worry you, such as chest pain, constant headaches or stomach trouble (always get chest pain checked straight away);

- you're relying on alcohol, drugs or other habits to get through the day;
- you feel you can't cope, or have thoughts of harming yourself.

If the stress comes from being afraid of someone, such as how they will react, what they will do or whether you are allowed to leave, that is not ordinary stress. Your body may be warning you.

This chapter is general education, not medical advice or diagnosis.

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Workpapers **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit: your plan for heated moments.

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- The Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks#ladder): a thirty-second self-check.
- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now): steps to calm down, alone or together.
- Drift (spreadloveandacceptance.com/calm-visualizer), Brain Breakers and calm games (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pause-and-play): gentle ways to come down.

Reading **pages to read on the website**

- The library: the stress response (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress), appraisal (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress#appraisal), the window of tolerance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress#window-of-tolerance), flooding (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships), burnout (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress#burnout) and slow breathing (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/calm).

More for your situation

- Back: How feelings work (page 58) · Next: How we see each other (page 87) · All chapters in the contents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/contents)
- Part Two, Chapter III: full tanks and different angles

- How to stop fighting: calm steps (spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-to-stop-fighting-with-your-partner)
- New baby, sharing the load (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent) and Coming home after time apart (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home)
- For teens: big feelings and stress (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- Sensory overload at home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Stress is your body getting ready.
- ✓ The ladder: three everyday states.
- ✓ Stress adds up, like a tank filling.
- ✓ Rest isn't one thing.
- ✓ Stress is easier to carry when it's shared.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles — read online
The stress tank in a shared home

Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words — page 29
Your weather before you speak

Part Two · Chapter I · Why we get out of tune — read online
How stress knocks two people out of tune

Part Three · Chapter 16 · Worry, low mood and trauma — page 264
When stress turns into worry or low mood

PUT IT TO USE



The Calm-Down Kit
Your plan for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11



The Nervous System Ladder
A thirty-second self-check
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

3

PART THREE · CHAPTER 3

How we see each other: perception, bias, and the stories we tell

Why two people can watch the same moment and come away with two different stories, and how to see others, and yourself, a little more fairly.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Seeing is a best guess
2. You see what you're looking for
3. We fill the gaps with stories
4. We judge ourselves by our reasons, and others by their actions
5. Quick shortcuts can lead us astray
6. Everyone feels like the one who sees clearly
7. "Us" and "them" changes what we see
8. Ask, don't guess
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Seeing is a best guess.** Your brain fills in a lot of what you think you see and hear.
- **We fill gaps with stories**, and the story often feels like a fact.
- **We judge ourselves by our reasons and others by their actions**, and that gap causes a lot of hurt.
- **Asking is kinder and more accurate** than trying to read someone's mind.

WEDNESDAY, 12:15PM

You wave at a colleague across the canteen, tray in one hand, soup slopping. She looks straight through you and walks out.

All afternoon. All afternoon you go back through Monday's meeting, that thing you said about the budget, the email you didn't reply to. At four o'clock she messages. Sorry I didn't stop earlier, I'd just had a call about my dad. She hadn't seen you at all.

How feelings work (page 58) and Stress and the nervous system (page 72) look inward. This chapter looks outward, at how we see other people, and why misunderstandings are so common even between kind and clever people. Before I built any of this I spent my career as a government auditor, walking into situations where nobody could tell me straight what had happened. Almost everyone, it turned out, was doing their best with the piece of the picture they could actually see. This chapter is more or less about that.

Some of the tools elsewhere depend on it. Who did what (the Preface to Part Two, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/preface) exists because everyone sees their own effort more clearly than other people's, so two honest guesses of "I do about 60%" can add up to well over 100%, and one shared page settles it. Rewind the talk (Part Two, Chapter III, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3) slows down the habit of judging ourselves by our reasons and others by their actions. And the Chat analyzer follows this chapter's last idea, that asking beats guessing.

01

Seeing is a best guess.

Your eyes and ears take in far less than you think, and your brain fills in the rest from what it expects. Most of the time this works well, and fast. It also means what you see is partly what you expected, so two people can watch the same moment and honestly see different things.

Under-12s, a freezing Sunday morning, a pitch that is mostly mud. Archie's mum sees him giving up, and says so, quietly, into her scarf. His dad, beside her with the flask, sees him being careful with the ankle he went over on last

week. They argue about it all the way home and Archie, in the back, says nothing, because he was actually thinking about his tea.

They saw a game

Students from two rival universities, Princeton and Dartmouth, watched the same rough American football game and saw it very differently, right down to how many fouls each side committed. Same match, two games.

Hastorf and Cantril (1954) · *Moderate: a classic single case study, widely cited*

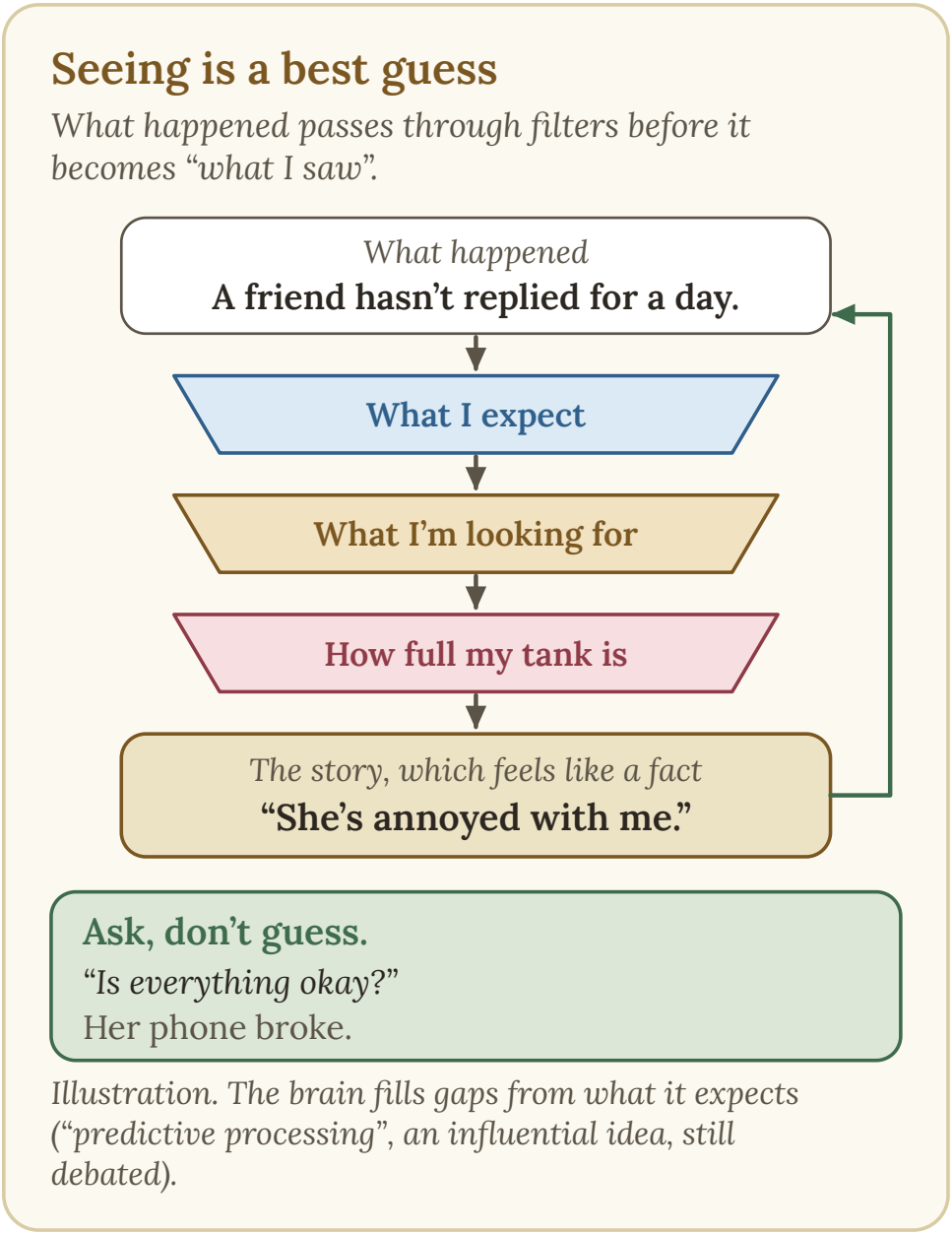


FIGURE 12 Seeing is a best guess. The story that comes out feels like a fact; asking is kinder and more accurate than reading minds.

02

You see what you're looking for.

Attention is like a torch in a dark room. You see what it lights up and can miss what it doesn't, even when it's right in front of you. If you're looking for proof that someone doesn't care, you will notice every missed call and none of the little kindnesses.

In her first week Rosie decided her new manager didn't like her. For a month she clocked every short email he sent, and there were a lot. He sends short emails to everyone, including, as it turned out, his wife. What Rosie somehow didn't clock was that he'd given her the best project on the team. A colleague pointed it out in the pub after somebody's leaving do, and Rosie said, "Oh." Then, "Oh no."

If there's someone you're struggling with, try writing down one kind thing they do each day for a week. It's an odd exercise, and it tends to move the torch.

03

We fill the gaps with stories.

When we don't know why someone did something, the mind makes up a reason, fast. A late reply becomes anger, and a closed door becomes rejection. And the story arrives feeling like a fact. Memory works the same way, because every time we remember something we rebuild it a little, so two people can honestly remember the same evening differently.

Two days without a reply. By Sunday evening you have decided she's fed up with you, and you've drafted, then deleted, a message saying you're sorry for whatever it was. On Monday morning she sends seventeen photographs from a campsite in Snowdonia with no signal, most of them of the same sheep. One message, "The story I'm telling myself is that you're upset with me. Is that right?", would have saved two days of it.

04

We judge ourselves by our reasons, and others by their actions.

When you're late, you know why, because it was the traffic or a phone call or a child who lost a shoe. When someone else is late you only see the lateness, and it's very easy to decide they're careless. We all tend to blame other people's character for things that are really about their situation.

A driver cuts in front of you on the ring road and you call him an idiot, not quite under your breath. The next week your mum has a fall and you're racing to the hospital, and you cut someone up yourself, badly, at the roundabout. You know exactly why you did it. You'd quite like them to know too. They don't, and in their car, right now, you are an idiot.

The fundamental attribution error

Lee Ross gave this habit its name: when we explain what someone else did, we tend to underrate the situation and overrate their character. It's well replicated, though weaker in some cultures than in others.

Ross (1977) · *Strong: foundational and widely replicated*

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY

"What might be going on for them that I can't see?" "If I did this, what would my reason be?"



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

We know our own reasons and only see other people's actions. Try writing out their side, in their words. It's irritatingly effective.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder`

05

Quick shortcuts can lead us astray.

The brain uses shortcuts to save time, and plenty are useful. Some lead to unfair judgements, like a first impression that colours everything after it, or one bad moment that outweighs ten good ones, or a quick guess about someone from their age or accent or looks or group. Everyone has these, and the trouble only starts when nobody notices them.

On day one, the new tenant left a box in the hall, just the one, for an afternoon. Tash decided there and then that he was messy, and every bit of mess after that was proof. Her own mug collection on the landing, eleven mugs at the last count, went entirely unseen, by her, though he saw it. He didn't say anything for months, which, when it finally came out, was its own small row.

Bad is stronger than good

That's the real title of a wide review, which found that bad events, feedback and behaviour usually hit harder and last longer than equally good ones. There are exceptions, but it explains how one box in the hall can outweigh months of tidiness.

Baumeister and colleagues (2001) · *Strong: a widely cited review; the pattern is accepted, with known exceptions*

06

Everyone feels like the one who sees clearly.

Most of us feel we see things as they really are, and anyone who disagrees must be missing something. The other person feels exactly the same about you. Each of you can see the other's lens much more easily than your own.

Two brothers in their fifties argued, at their mum's eightieth, about how they'd been brought up. "I'm just being realistic," said one. "So am I," said the other. They were both right. Each was being entirely realistic about the childhood he had lived through, which turned out, when they finally compared notes in the car park, to have been quite a different childhood, in the same house, four years apart.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I think we're both seeing this from where we stand. Can you tell me how it looks from yours?"

07

"Us" and "them" changes what we see.

People split into groups quickly, even over tiny things. We tend to see our own group as varied and full of individuals and other groups as all the same, and we give our own side the benefit of the doubt. Spending real time with people from the other group, as equals, is one of the best ways to soften this.

At one depot the night shift calls the day shift lazy and the day shift calls the night shift sloppy, and has done since before anyone can remember. Then there was a joint training day, with a bad buffet and a fire drill in the rain. By the afternoon people were using each other's names. It didn't fix everything, though the notes on the kettle stopped.

Have one real conversation this month with someone from a group you tend to see as "other", and ask about their day before you ask about their views.

08

Ask, don't guess.

Imagining yourself in someone's shoes is a kind start, though research suggests it doesn't make us much more accurate about what they think, while asking does. A plain, curious question like "What was that like for you?" beats the cleverest guess.

Every Sunday Moira's grandson sat at her kitchen table glued to his phone, and every Sunday she decided a bit more firmly that he hated coming. One week she just asked. "Do you not like coming here, love?" He looked up, horrified, with his thumb still on the screen. He'd been messaging a friend who was having a terrible time. He liked her house because it was calm, he said, and for the crumble. He wouldn't have mentioned the crumble if she hadn't asked. She makes two now, and sends one home with him in a tin she never gets back.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 8

Chat analyzer

Zoe, texting her oldest friend, who moved abroad

Chat analyzer

Mode

I'm about to send this Someone sent me this

Type your sentence

You always cancel on me last minute. Can we pick a time for a call on Sunday?

Relationship

Friends

Channel

Text / chat

THE READ

How it may land for most listeners
Some words may hurt. How it may sound: sharp in places.

What stands out
The word “always” (words like “always” and “never” leave no room for the times it went fine).

A clearer way to say it
Lately it’s felt like you cancel on me last minute. Can we pick a time for a call on Sunday?

What changed, and why
always → lately it’s felt like. “Always” and “never” erase every exception, so the listener argues the exception.

Made-up example. The ask stayed; only the word that would start an argument changed.

Fill in your own: Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator)

THURSDAY, 12:20PM

She’s in the canteen again. This time you go over and ask how her dad is. She tells you about the hospital and the waiting and the car park charges, which seem to be the thing she’s angriest about. You end up sharing a table until the end of the break. Your soup goes cold. You don’t mind.

In everyday life

We tell stories about ourselves too, and “I always mess things up” is usually built from a few bright memories that leave a lot out. After years together, partners stop checking and start assuming. And “I know what you meant” can do a lot of quiet damage in a long relationship. Children get labelled early, the difficult one, the easy one, and the label becomes a lens that only sees what fits. With ADHD, attention gets pulled by whatever is new or urgent and can lock on hard, so someone may genuinely not have seen or heard. Get their

attention first and put requests in writing. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-3-seeing-in-depth).

Common mix-ups

Nobody sees things exactly as they are. Everyone sees through a lens, and knowing that is where fairness starts. Memory isn't a recording, either, since it gets rebuilt each time, so two honest people can remember the same evening differently and both be telling the truth. Giving someone the benefit of the doubt doesn't mean ignoring what happened. It means checking the story before you decide, and if something hurtful keeps happening, that matters. And a face or a tone is a clue to what someone meant. Faces and tones vary a lot between people and between cultures, so a face is a weaker clue than it feels.

If you want to help someone else with this

Start with how they feel, and make sense of the feeling first, and only then wonder aloud whether there might be another way to see it. Offer information instead of verdicts. "I know she had a hard week" helps more than "You're being unfair to her." Check your own guesses out loud ("I assumed he was annoyed, I'll ask"), which shows how it's done. Be careful with labels for children and colleagues, because they stick and then shape what everyone sees. And believe people about their own experience. Seeing other angles never means telling someone that what happened to them didn't happen.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "That sounds really hurtful. Do you know what was going on for them?"
> "It might be worth asking. Want to plan what to say?"

When to get more help

Seeing other people's side is a strength. It should never mean doubting yourself when you know something is wrong. If someone often tells you that

what you saw, heard or remember didn't happen, that you're "too sensitive" or "imagining it," and you find yourself unsure of your own mind, take that seriously. It can be part of controlling behaviour.

It may also help to talk to a counsellor or other trained professional if you notice you often feel others are against you, find it hard to trust anyone, or keep getting stuck in the same painful stories about yourself. Those patterns are common and understandable, and they often change with support.

This chapter is general education, not diagnosis or therapy.

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Rewind the talk: see their side (spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder): a free perspective-taking tool.
- Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator): how a sentence might land before you say it.

Reading pages to read on the website

- Wired differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently): how different minds hear the same words.
- Philosophy stories on seeing the other person (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth): the cave, the elephant, the fish and the empty boat.
- The library: the fundamental attribution error (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking), confirmation bias (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking#confirmation-bias), negativity bias (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking#negativity-bias), naive realism (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking#naive-realism), mind-reading (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking#mind-reading) and how memory is rebuilt (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking#memory-reconstruction).

More for your situation

- Back: Stress and the nervous system (page 72) · Next: How communication works (page 99)

- Part One, Then: where your lens came from (page 14)
- Part Two, Chapter III: full tanks and different angles
- Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts), Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting) and For grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children)
- Communication between different minds (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) and For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents)
- Everything on the site (spreadloveandacceptance.com/contents) · Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part One · Then · Where your lens came from
Where your lens came from — page 14

Preface to Part Two · The work nobody sees
Why the other person doesn't see the work — read online

Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles
Seven angles on the same moment — read online

Part Three · Chapter 17 · Groups, influence and culture
Us and them, and the stories groups tell — page 279

PUT IT TO USE

Rewind the talk: see their side
A free perspective-taking tool
spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

Chat analyzer
How a sentence might land before you say it
spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

4

PART THREE · CHAPTER 4

How communication works: meaning, listening, repair and messages

Talking feels simple because we do it all day, yet every message has to travel from one mind to another, and a lot can change on the way. This chapter follows that journey and looks at what helps a message arrive the way you meant it.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Meaning is made between two people
2. Every message says two things
3. Listening is something you do
4. Check, don't guess
5. Hard things land better when they start soft
6. Mix-ups are normal. Repair is the skill
7. Messages lose their tone on the way
8. Different styles aren't wrong styles
9. Small talk has a job, and it can be short
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Meaning is made between two people.** What you say and what they hear can differ without either of you being wrong.
- **Every message says two things**, the words themselves and what they seem to say about the two of you.
- **A short question saves a long misunderstanding**, so check before you guess.
- **Mix-ups are normal, and repairing them is the skill.** Small talk is allowed to be short.

THURSDAY, 8:15AM

Ana texts her brother. Can you call me when you're free?

She means no rush, small question about the weekend. He reads it on the top deck of the 8.10, and for eleven stops, past the hospital, which doesn't help, he works out who is ill.

Small habits help a message arrive. Listening, checking, starting softly, mending quickly. A few ready-made lines make small talk easier for anyone who dreads it. And three tools elsewhere lean on this chapter. Say it so it lands (Part Two, Chapter IV, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4) asks for what happened, how you feel and one clear request, because every message carries a second message about the relationship. The 90-second daily check-in (Part Two, Chapter I, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-1) keeps repairs small and frequent. And the Chat analyzer's whole-conversation view shows where a written conversation lost its tone.

01

Meaning is made between two people.

Words don't carry meaning on their own. The speaker has a meaning in mind, and the listener builds their own from the words, the tone, the timing and everything they already expect. Most of the time the two match well enough. Sometimes they don't, and neither person can see the gap from where they're standing.

"Let's chat tomorrow," the manager wrote to the new starter at ten to five, meaning a friendly catch-up and possibly a biscuit. The new starter went home and reread his last three emails looking for the mistake. He found two, neither of which existed. In the morning there was a biscuit, which he couldn't face. The sentence that would have saved him an evening is a dull one, "I think what you meant and what I heard might be two different things. Can we check?"

02

Every message says two things.

There is *what* you say, and there is what it says about the two of you. "You're late" is a fact about time, though it can also mean "I was worried" or "I don't matter to you." People argue about the fact when the hurt is in the second layer.

I take one eight-word sentence apart on the website's About page: "don't worry about it, I'll sort it out." Said kindly, in passing, it's reassurance. Said for the third time that month about the same job, it also says a job has no owner and a decision has been put off again, and both of those are in the same eight words.

Or take Tomasz, who wants to know whether his housemate used his good pan. On the surface it's a question about a pan. Underneath, it's a question about whether his things are respected in this house, and no amount of talk about the pan is going to settle that. "Honestly," he said in the end, "I don't care about the pan." His housemate, who had in fact used the pan, washed it and put it back in the wrong cupboard, looked baffled. "Then why have we been talking about it for ten minutes?"

Content and relationship

Watzlawick and colleagues made this one of their axioms of communication: every message has a content level and a relationship level, and the relationship level often decides how the content is heard. It's a framework rather than an experiment, and a remarkably durable one.

Watzlawick, Beavin and Jackson (1967) · *Theory: influential in communication and family therapy*

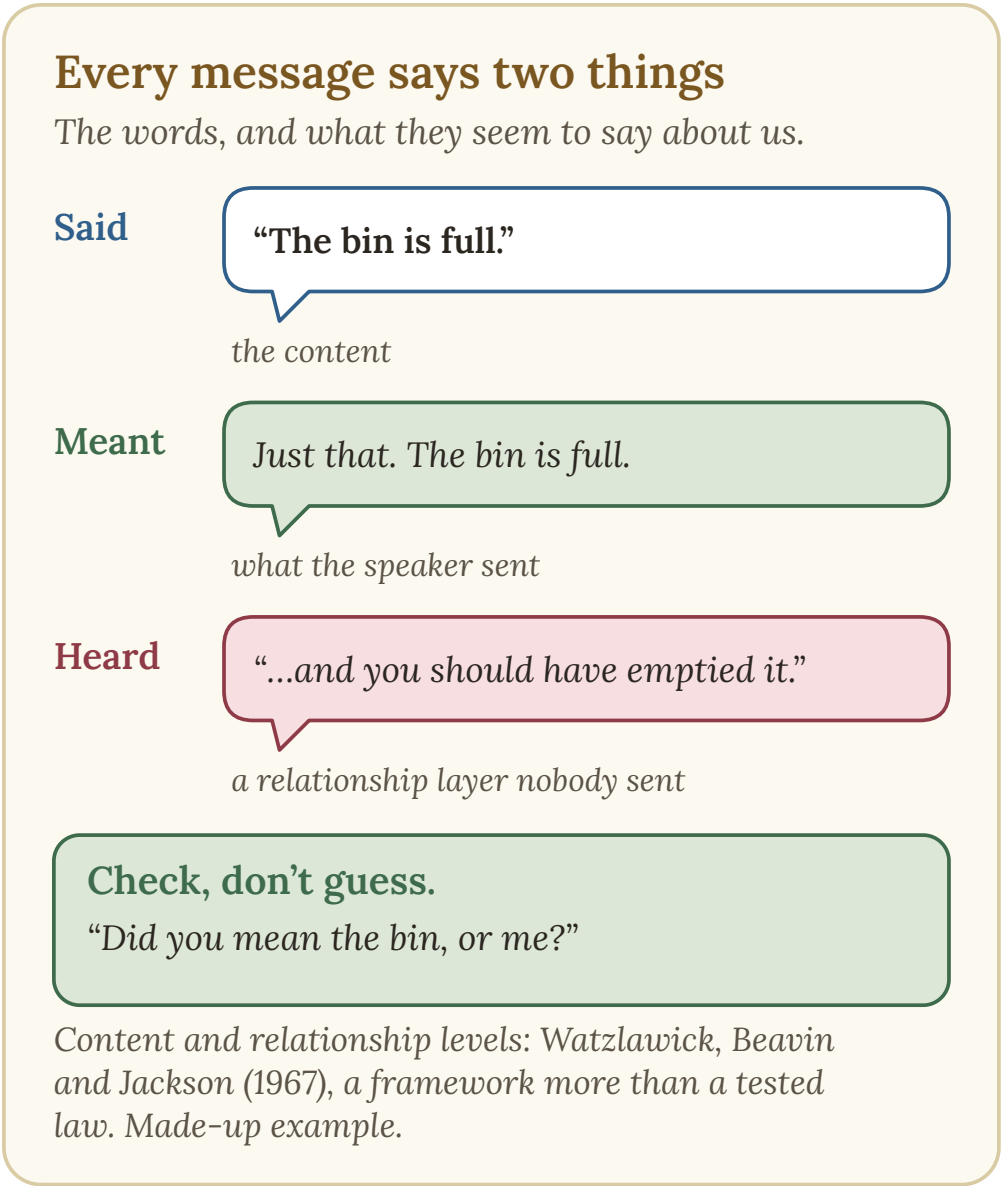


FIGURE 13 Every message says two things: the words, and what they seem to say about the two of you. Check, don’t guess.

03

Listening is something you do.

Hearing happens by itself. Listening is a choice, and most of us do a lot of it partly in order to reply. To fix, or defend, or advise, or tell our own story. Real listening means following what the other person is trying to say, and letting them know you got it, before you add anything of yours.

"School is pointless," Mollie announced, thirteen, coat still on. Her dad started explaining, at some length and with examples, why it wasn't. She stopped talking and went upstairs, and the door shut harder than it strictly needed to. The next time she said it, a week later, he bit his tongue, hard. "Pointless how?" he said. "Tell me about today." She talked for twenty minutes, mostly about a supply teacher and a seating plan, and he said almost nothing, which nearly killed him.

04

Check, don't guess.

Once we know something it's very hard to imagine not knowing it, so we leave out steps, assume the other person can tell what we mean, and guess what they meant instead of asking. We do it most with the people we know best, which is unfortunate, because they're the ones we most want to get it right with. A short check costs you a sentence, whereas a wrong guess can cost a whole evening.

"Something low-key," they agreed, for Fliss's fortieth. Fliss pictured a Chinese takeaway on the sofa, in pyjamas, with the good crackers. Her best friend booked a quiet table at the Italian, ironed a shirt, and turned up at seven with flowers. Fliss opened the door in her pyjamas, and for a second they just looked at each other, both disappointed, both having thought it was obvious. They ate the takeaway in the end, the friend in her ironed shirt, and it was a good night, eventually.

Closeness makes us lazy listeners

In three small experiments, people overestimated how well they got through to friends and spouses even more than to strangers. Closeness seemed to switch off the checking we do without thinking with people we don't know.

Savitsky and colleagues (2011) · *Moderate: three small experiments, extended in later work*



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Checking what someone meant takes ten seconds and can save a whole evening. When you're ready to reply, this workpaper helps.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09

05

Hard things land better when they start soft.

How a hard conversation starts often decides how it ends. A complaint about one thing ("The bins weren't taken out") is easier to hear than a criticism of the person ("You never help"). A simple shape works for most hard things, which is to say what happened, how you feel and what you would like.

A woman wants her eighty-one-year-old father to stop driving at night. She has "You're not safe any more" on the tip of her tongue. She leaves it there and says, "You had two near-misses last month and I lie awake worrying. Could I drive us in the evenings?" He says he'll think about it, which in his language is nearly a yes.

Say it so it lands

A simple shape for most hard things.

What happened
One specific fact, not a verdict.
"The bins didn't go out on Tuesday."

How I feel
Your feeling, in a word or two.
"I felt let down, because I'd asked."

What I'd like
A small, doable ask.
"Could you set a reminder for next week?"

✕ **Not: "You never help."**
That's about the person, so it starts a defence.

This book's plain-language shape, a cousin of I-messages and Nonviolent Communication; research on such scripts is mixed, and tone matters most.

FIGURE 14 Say it so it lands: what happened, how I feel, what I'd like. A complaint about an action can be heard; a criticism of the person starts a defence.

06

Mix-ups are normal. Repair is the skill.

Even close, kind people misunderstand each other constantly, several times a day if you're counting, and what keeps a relationship steady is noticing it and fixing it rather than never doing it. "That came out wrong." "Can we start again?" Small repairs made often build trust much faster than big apologies made rarely.

"Excuse *me*!" a woman snaps in the supermarket, because your trolley is blocking the tins. "I'm *moving*," you snap back. A second later you hear yourself add, "Sorry. Long day." And she sags a bit and says hers has been too, and somehow you end up talking about the price of coffee for five minutes by the chopped tomatoes.



SUGARFOOT

A mix-up isn't the end of anything. Come back, sit close, and go through it a step at a time.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

07

Messages lose their tone on the way.

A text or email carries the words without your face or your voice, so the reader fills in the tone with however *they* feel right now. A tired reader hears a tired, cross message. Short replies, missing greetings and late-night timing all get read as meaning something.

In the group chat for the school summer fair, somebody proposes the tombola goes by the gate. One parent replies, "Fine." Full stop and everything. Within four minutes two other parents have privately decided she's furious and started composing careful messages. She was stirring a pan of soup, typing with one thumb, and genuinely thought it was fine.

The full stop problem

In one study with students, short text replies ending in a full stop were rated less sincere than the same replies without one, while handwritten notes showed no such effect. Later work suggests it fades with longer messages, so this one is early days.

Gunraj and colleagues (2016) · *Early: one study with students*

Before you send your next tricky message, read it out loud in the grumpiest voice you can manage. If it sounds harsh, add a warm word. This is my favourite test in the whole book, and it takes four seconds.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 9

Chat analyzer: a whole conversation

Dana and Raj, coworkers on the same project

Chat analyzer: paste a conversation

01 Paste the conversation

Dana: Did the slides go to the client?
Raj: Not yet, still waiting on the numbers from finance
Dana: I needed them by 10. This always happens.
Raj: I can't make finance go faster.
Dana: Forget it. I'll do it myself.

02 Which one is you?

Dana (3 messages) Raj (2 messages)

03 THE READ

What happened

Ends shut down. 5 messages: 3 from you, 2 from Raj. The words don't make it clear what it's mostly about, so the Reader won't guess. It starts calm. There's no one big turn, but some tension creeps in. By the end someone has pulled back. That isn't the same as calm: it can mean they're overwhelmed, or hurt.

Your part · always / never

I said "This always happens", and that isn't fair: it isn't every time. What I meant was: [one recent time, and how it felt].

04 Check your reply before you send it

Your reply

Sorry, that last line wasn't fair. When the numbers weren't in by 10, I felt worried about the client. Could you ask finance for them by 9 next time? I'll chase them with you.

THE CHECK

✓ Says what you need or how it landed · ✓ Makes one clear ask · ✓ No verdicts, always/never, dismissals, sarcasm, jabs, comparisons or shutting the door · ✓ Stays on one topic

Nothing in the wording is likely to add heat. Read it once more as if you were them, then send it when you're calm.

Made-up example. The Reader looks at one side's part without blaming anyone.

Fill in your own: Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator)

08

Different styles aren't wrong styles.

Some people say exactly what they mean. Others hint, and expect you to read between the lines. Some talk fast and overlap, and others need a pause to think. Families and cultures and different kinds of mind all shape this, and a clash between two styles is usually a translation problem, with nobody being difficult on purpose.

"Is the report ready?" "No. I need two more days." Her manager heard that as rude, for about a month, until they talked about it over a coffee he didn't want. She said she'd rather tell him the truth plainly than make him guess, and that where she grew up a straight answer was the polite one. After that he started finding her clarity a relief, and then, slightly to his surprise, a model.

WORDS TO TRY

"I'm quite direct, so if I sound blunt, it doesn't mean I'm cross." "It helps me if you say exactly what you need."

09

Small talk has a job, and it can be short.

Small talk ("Cold today, isn't it?" "Busy weekend?") isn't really about the weather. Its job is to say that you see the other person and that the two of you are okay. In 1923 the anthropologist Bronisław Malinowski called this "phatic communion", talk whose main purpose is bonding more than information. Small moments like this matter more than people expect. Sandstrom and Dunn (2014) found that people who had a short, friendly exchange with a coffee-shop barista felt more belonging and a better mood than people who kept it purely efficient.

Small talk is hard work for many people, though, including many autistic people, shy or anxious people and people speaking a second language. The rules are unwritten, and it uses energy that some people would rather keep. A few ready-made lines, sometimes called social scripts, take the guesswork out, and keeping it short is allowed. For what it's worth, this is the part I had to learn on purpose.

Phil dreads the school gate. He has three lines ready, a "Morning! How's your week going?", an "Oh, nice" and a "Right, I'd better get going, see you Friday." Some mornings he still sits in the car with the radio on until the bell goes. Most days he gets through it. One of the other dads now saves him a spot by the railings, and has never once asked him how his week is going, which Phil appreciates more than he can say.

YOU COULD SAY

"Morning! How's your week been?" "How do you know Nico?" "Oh, how was that?" "Lovely to see you. I'd better get on." And to opt out kindly, "I'm not great at chit-chat, but it's really nice to see you."

THURSDAY, 9:02AM

He rings the second he's off the bus. "Who's ill?"

"Nobody! I wanted to know if you're free Saturday. Wardrobe."

He laughs, a bit shakily, and says he'll bring the van. The week after, her text says, No rush and nothing's wrong!! Quick q about Sat, call when free.

In everyday life

On your own: how you talk to yourself

You send yourself messages all day, from "Typical, I always mess this up" to "That was hard and I handled it." The same things apply. Notice the tone, check whether it's fair, and mend it when it's harsh. Catch one harsh sentence you say to yourself today and rewrite it the way you'd say it to someone you like.

With other people

Between partners, "We never go out any more" sounds like a complaint about evenings, and underneath it may mean "I miss you", so answering that layer goes further than defending the calendar. "Stop that!" tells a child what not to do without saying what to do instead. "Feet on the floor, please" is easier to follow. In meetings, silence gets taken as agreement until a quieter colleague says afterwards that she never agreed, and a round of "Anyone see it differently?" catches that early. "Are you eating properly?" is care in one generation's language and checking up in another's.

- **Feedback at work.** Talk about the work rather than the person, with one recent example of what good looks like. Then ask, "What's been getting in the way?" When you're the one receiving it, "Thanks. Can I think about it and come back tomorrow?" is a fine first answer. The full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-4-communication-in-depth) walks through a whole performance conversation.

Common mix-ups

"If they loved me, they'd just know" is the big one. Closeness makes us check *less* without making us understand any more, so saying it clearly is a kindness, and no test of love. Listening isn't agreeing, either, because you can understand someone completely and still see it differently, and the understanding comes first. A repair doesn't mean you're confessing to being the bad one. It just says that didn't go the way you wanted, and either person can make one. And texts feel safer for hard things because they're easier to

send. They're also much easier to misread, so for anything tender, add warmth, or ring.

If you want to help someone else with this

Maybe a friend keeps having the same argument with their partner, or your teenager feels nobody listens. You can't talk for them. You can be the one person who really hears them, without fixing, which is often the most useful thing anyone does all week. You can help them pull the two layers apart, by asking what it was about and then what it seemed to say about the two of them. You can offer the simple shape (what happened, how they feel, what they'd like) and let them find their own words. And stay out of judging the other person's character, since you only hear one side and they may make up next week. **Notice if it's more than a mix-up.**

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "Do you want me to just listen, or help you think about what to say?"

When to get more help

Most mix-ups can be eased with the ideas here. Some situations need more.

- **When talking makes things worse every time,** a couples or family counsellor can slow conversations down and help both people be heard.
- **When you're afraid of how someone will react,** that isn't a communication problem. Clearer words are not the fix, and you don't have to keep trying.
- **When someone is always "misunderstanding" you** in ways that make you doubt your memory or your sense of what happened, talk with someone you trust outside the relationship.
- **When speaking or understanding is hard for you every day,** because of anxiety, a hearing or language difference, or how your mind works, a doctor, speech and language therapist or counsellor may help. Needing support is not a failing.
- **If you're overwhelmed right now,** start with Upset right now (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now).

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Try one of these this week with one real conversation. Say it so it lands (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-09-say-it-so-it-lands) helps you shape a hard sentence, Rewind the talk (spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder) walks you back through a talk that went wrong, and the wiring card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card) puts how you communicate on one page.

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator): calm replies after a fight.
- Communication style quiz (spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz): a playful look at your own style.

Reading pages to read on the website

- Effective communication (spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication): the site's complete, plain guide, from listening and timing to hard talks, repair and each kind of relationship.
- Check-ins (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins): how to hold a hard conversation kindly.
- Why we get out of tune looks at the same ideas at home.

More for your situation

- At work: messages and meetings (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) and for parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents)
- Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting)
- Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)
- Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance)
- Two faiths or cultures, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths)

- Neurodivergent relationships: communication (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- Find it by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part Two · Chapter I · Why we get out of tune read online
Pace, tone and getting back in tune

Part Two · Chapter IV · Two kinds of fair read online
Letting a comment land

Part Three · Chapter 11 · Healing after hurt page 197
Repair after it goes wrong

Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words page 29
How you like to be spoken to

PUT IT TO USE

Chat analyzer
Calm replies after a fight
spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

Communication style quiz
A playful look at your own style
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

5

PART THREE · CHAPTER 5

Attachment, trust and belonging

Why we need each other, how the bonds we had early on shape what we expect today, and how trust and belonging are built and lost and built again, one small moment at a time.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Belonging is a basic need
2. Early bonds teach us what to expect
3. Patterns, not boxes
4. Trust is built in small moments
5. Feeling safe with someone calms the body
6. Fitting in isn't the same as belonging
7. When trust breaks, rebuilding takes time
8. You can start building connection from wherever you are
9. If you're a teenager
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Reading on this site
15. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Belonging is a basic need.** Feeling lonely or left out is a signal, like hunger.
- **Early bonds set expectations that can change.** What we learned about being cared for can soften over time.
- **Trust grows in small moments.** Doing what you said, again and again, matters more than big gestures.
- **You can start small**, with one friendly exchange or one kept promise.

SUNDAY, 9:30PM

Kai sent his friend a long message at lunchtime. Four paragraphs about the new job, and a question at the end. It says Read 12:47, and there's nothing after that.

By teatime he's gone from "she's busy" to "she's annoyed". By half nine he's wondering whether anybody really likes him at all. The friend, meanwhile, is at her nephew's sixth birthday at a soft-play centre in Stockport, and her phone is in her coat pocket under nineteen other coats.

Two tools elsewhere rest on this chapter. One owner per job (Part Two, Chapter II, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2) works because trust is built from small promises kept, and a named owner turns "someone will probably do it" into a promise people can rely on. The monthly look-back (Part Two, Chapter V, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-5) looks at the month and keeps both people out of the dock, because feeling safe is what lets anyone say what went wrong.

01

Belonging is a basic need.

People need to feel connected, the way we need food and sleep. When we feel left out it can hurt in a way that feels almost physical (Naomi Eisenberger and colleagues, 2003). That hurt works like hunger, pushing you to reach for someone.

Rhea moved to Manchester for work. She's busy and doing well and likes the job. And by the third month she's flat and teary every Sunday afternoon, when the office is shut and nobody in the whole city knows her well enough to ring. She found this embarrassing for a while, and told her mum on the phone that she was "just tired". Then she joined a running club, which she hated, and a pub quiz team, which she loved.

Friendship takes hours

Studies of adults who had recently moved found that more time together, especially relaxed time, went with moving from acquaintance to friend. The hour counts are rough. The message isn't: friendship is mostly built out of time spent.

Hall (2019) · *Moderate: survey studies; the hour estimates are rough*

02

Early bonds teach us what to expect.

As children we learn, from the people who looked after us, whether others will come when we need them. If help usually came, we tend to expect it. If it came sometimes, or rarely, we may learn to cling harder, or stop asking. These lessons are a starting point that later relationships can change. This is the idea of attachment, first described by John Bowlby (1969) and studied by Mary Ainsworth and colleagues (1978).

Watch a toddler at the park. He runs off towards the ducks, then runs back to check his nan is still on the bench, then off again, a bit further, and back, and further still, right to the edge of the pond, where he stands and shouts at a goose. He gets braver every time, because he knows exactly where she is. If you're the one on the bench, "I'm right here, go and look, come back whenever you want" is more or less the whole job.

03

Patterns, not boxes.

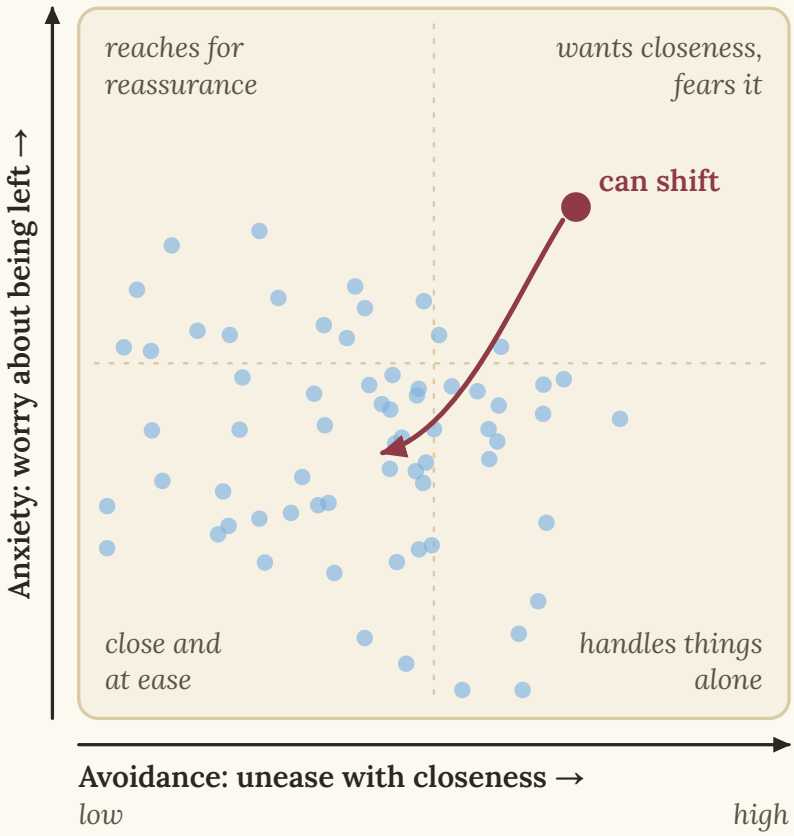
As adults, some of us worry a lot about being left, and reach out more when we feel unsure. Some of us pull back when things get close and need more room. Many of us feel mostly secure. Most of us mix all three, depending on the day and the person.

These are patterns that can soften and change, especially in steady, kind relationships. Cindy Hazan and Phillip Shaver (1987) first described them in adults, and later work, such as R. Chris Fraley and colleagues (2015), suggests they work as sliding scales.

When things get tense, Ronan wants to talk it through, now, immediately. His wife Clara needs to go quiet first, usually in the garden, usually with the secateurs. He reads her quiet as her leaving, and she reads his questions through the back door as pressure. It took them nine years to see it. Now she says "I need an hour, and I'm coming back," and he waits, which for about the first month he found almost unbearable.

Patterns, not boxes

Two scales. Everyone sits somewhere, and can move.



After Brennan, Clark and Shaver (1998) and Fraley and colleagues (2015): adult attachment is best measured as two scales, not types. Dots are illustrative, not data.

FIGURE 15 Attachment as two scales, not four boxes: worry about being left, and unease with closeness. Everyone sits somewhere, and can move. Dots are illustrative.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 10

Our pause plan

Imani and Kwame, married ten years

Our pause plan

Fill this in together on a calm day, or fill it in yourself and send it to your partner to change.

Our pause word or sentence

"Pause. I'll be back at …", with a hand on the heart

Shortest break, so our bodies can settle

30 minutes

Whoever pauses names a clock time to come back, no later than

the same evening

If one of us can't come back on time

Send one text with a new time. No silence.

The first sentence when we come back

"I'm back. You first: what do you most want me to hear?"

YOUR PLAN, READY TO SEND

Our pause plan

Pause word: “Pause. I’ll be back at …”, with a hand on the heart

Shortest break: 30 minutes

Return time: whoever pauses names a clock time, no later than the same evening

If one of us can’t come back on time: Send one text with a new time. No silence.

When we come back, we start with: “I’m back. You first: what do you most want me to hear?”

Made-up example. For relationships where everyone feels safe.

Fill in your own: Our pause plan (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw)

04

Trust is built in small moments.

Trust rarely comes from big gestures. It grows from small, ordinary things done again and again, like doing what you said, and being the same person on a hard day as on a good one. Honestly, it’s a bit boring, which is probably why it works.

The new starter said she’d send the figures by Thursday, and she did. The following week she warned on Monday that something would be late on Friday. By the third month her manager trusted her completely, and if you’d asked him when that happened he couldn’t have told you. It hadn’t happened at any one moment, more like in forty small ones.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Trust grows in small moments that repeat. This workpaper helps you notice the little rituals you already have, and keep them going.

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-15

05

Feeling safe with someone calms the body.

Being with someone we trust can settle the nervous system. In one study, holding a trusted partner's hand calmed the brain's response to threat (James Coan and colleagues, 2006). A calm voice, a hand to hold, or just someone nearby can make a hard moment easier to bear. It works both ways, so we can be that for other people, often without saying much.

After his panic attack, Kieran's friend didn't try to fix anything. He sat down next to him on the cold step outside the flats. "Take your time. I'm here." Then nothing else, for about twenty minutes, while a man walked past twice with a very small dog. Eventually Kieran's breathing slowed, and he noticed how cold the step was. "Cheers," he said. "Any time," said his friend, and meant it.

Notice who helps you feel calmer, and tell them. "I always feel better after seeing you" is a lovely thing to hear, and almost nobody says it.

06

Fitting in isn't the same as belonging.

Fitting in means changing yourself to be accepted. Belonging means being accepted as you are. Teams, families, clubs and communities can offer either. Being left out of a group hurts even when the group doesn't matter much to us, and real belonging grows where people feel safe to be themselves and to speak up.

At her new job Ola laughs at jokes she doesn't find funny. She orders a lime and soda "for the drive", every Friday, so nobody asks why she doesn't drink. She goes home shattered. At her book club, in the back room of the library on alternate Tuesdays, she says exactly what she thought of the book, which last month was "I hated every single character", and someone said, "Oh, thank God," and they talked till the caretaker turned the lights off.

> YOU COULD SAY
> (in a group) "I see it a bit differently. Is it okay if I say why?" "Has everyone had a chance to say something?"

07

When trust breaks, rebuilding takes time.

When someone lets us down badly, trust doesn't come back with one apology. It comes back slowly, as words are matched by actions over time. The person who broke trust can own what happened and be patient. The person who was hurt can decide, at their own pace, whether and how much to trust again.

At Sunday dinner, for a laugh, Jen told the whole table a story her sister had told her in confidence. Nobody else at the table thought it was a big deal, but her sister left before pudding. The apology, two days later, was a start. What actually rebuilt things was the months after, when the story never came up again, and Jen started checking before she told anyone anything. "Can I mention the thing about work?" "No." "Okay."

08

You can start building connection from wherever you are.

If you feel alone right now, big friendships can seem a long way off. Belonging can start far smaller than that. A chat with a neighbour. A regular class. An online group about something you love. Even small, light contact with people we barely know can lift our mood (Gillian Sandstrom and Elizabeth Dunn, 2014).

After his divorce, Martin started saying more than "thanks" to the man at the coffee stall outside the station. It was the weather, at first. A few weeks later they were talking football every morning, mostly about Stoke's defence, which they agree about entirely. It's a small friendship, and it makes Mondays bearable. Small rituals like that are worth keeping going on purpose, and Keep your little rituals alive (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-15-keep-your-little-rituals-alive) helps you notice the ones you already have.

We underestimate strangers

Commuters asked to talk to a stranger on their train or bus had a better journey than those told to keep to themselves, even though most people predicted the opposite. Misjudging how pleasant it will be is part of what keeps people apart.

Epley and Schroeder (2014) · *Moderate: field and lab experiments, replicated since*



TIDBIT

One small hello is a fine start. If you can't think of one, there's a tool that picks one for you.

TOOL **Stay close: one small idea** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

MONDAY, 8:10AM

SO sorry, phone was in my coat all day, soft play hell. LOVED your message. Coffee Thursday?

Kai reads it twice. He thinks about how far last night's story got, all on its own, with no help from anybody. Next time a reply is slow, he decides, he'll send something light, no rush, just thinking of you, and leave it at that.

If you're a teenager

Ezra is sixteen when he sees a photo of his three closest friends at the cinema and finds out there's a group chat he isn't in. It hurts like being punched, because being left out really does register a bit like pain. He drafts something sharp, deletes it, and messages one friend instead, saying he's a bit gutted not to be asked and was it something he did. It turns out they thought he'd be at football. One of the friendships really is drifting, though, and that's allowed to hurt too.

WORDS TO TRY

"Bit gutted not to be asked. Did something happen?" "I'd like to come next time, even if I can't always make it." "I miss how we used to be. Are we okay?"

In everyday life

When one partner texts a lot while apart and the other forgets, agreeing on one goodnight message can keep both feeling connected. A child who acts up at pick-up may simply be letting go of a long day with the safest person they know. A friend who keeps cancelling may be overwhelmed, and "Is it easier if we do something short?" keeps the door open. At work, a team where

mistakes can be owned without blame builds trust faster than one where everyone hides them. And in a shared house, one simple weekly meal can turn people who share a kitchen into people who look out for each other. Stay close (spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding) has small ideas if you're stuck for one.

On your own: belonging with yourself

Belonging includes how you treat yourself. If you're kind to yourself on a bad day, you carry a small safe base wherever you go, and people who can comfort themselves often find it easier to let others in, because they're less afraid of being let down. You're allowed to need people. A lonely day is hard. It isn't a forecast. On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own) has more for people living alone.

Common mix-ups

"Needing people means I'm needy" is the one people say most quietly. Everyone needs connection, including the people who hide it well. Attachment style isn't fixed for life, either, and patterns can change, especially through steady, kind relationships and a bit of reflection. And forgiving isn't the same as trusting again straight away. Trust can return slowly, or not at all, and that's your call.

- **"Jealousy and checking up show how much they love me."** Reaching for reassurance is human, and so is asking for something out of care for the relationship. Controlling who someone sees, or checking their phone without agreement, is not love and is not an attachment style.

If you want to help someone else with this

Be steady, and turn up when you said you would, which matters more than any big gesture. If someone says they feel alone, listen before you remind them how many friends they have. Invite, and keep inviting. People who feel left out may say no a few times, and a warm invitation with no pressure still counts every time. In groups, notice who's on the edge and ask what they think. And leave the labels out. Telling someone they're "so avoidant" or "so

clingy" has never helped anyone, as far as I can tell. "What would help?" often does.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I'm here, and I'm not going anywhere." "We're having a few people over on Friday. No pressure, but I'd love you to come."

When to get more help

- **If loneliness has lasted a long time,** or comes with low mood, hopelessness or thoughts of not wanting to be here, please talk to a doctor or a mental health service. Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) has a few things to try in a hard moment.
- **If fear of being left, or of getting close, keeps hurting your relationships,** a counsellor or therapist can help you understand where it comes from and how to change it.
- **If someone uses your need for them against you,** by cutting you off from friends, checking where you are, or threatening to leave to get their way, that is not about attachment.
- **If trust was broken in a way that frightened you,** you don't owe anyone a second chance. Your safety comes first.

Reading on the website

Pick one small way to turn towards someone this week. Turning towards (spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward), When one talks and one goes quiet (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw) and How to apologise so it counts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages) have more ideas.

Reading pages to read on the website

- Bonding: how closeness grows: what research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family, coworkers and you.
- Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends): when a friendship drifts, and how to reach out.

- The languages of connection (spreadloveandacceptance.com/languages-of-connection): the different ways people show care.
- Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency): why good things fade, and how to keep them alive.

More for your situation

- On my own after a breakup
- Friends
- Parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) and foster, adoptive and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship)
- Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance)
- Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- Coming out as an adult (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out)
- At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- Find it by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part One · Then · Where your lens came from
Early trust and the rules from home page 14

Part Three · Chapter 15 · Closeness and love
Being known, at every age page 252

Part Three · Chapter 17 · Groups, influence and culture
Belonging to groups, and their pull page 279

Part Three · Chapter 8 · Loss, grief and big life changes
When a bond is lost page 152

PUT IT TO USE

Bonding: how closeness grows
What research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family, coworkers and you
spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

Friends
When a friendship drifts, and how to reach out
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends

6

PART THREE · CHAPTER 6

Habits and change: why change is hard and how small steps work

Why it's so hard to change, even when we really want to, and what actually helps: small steps, a kinder setup, patience with slips, and remembering that other people's change belongs to them.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Change is hard for good reasons
2. Habits run on cues
3. Start smaller than feels useful
4. Change the setup, not just your willpower
5. Being in two minds is normal
6. Slips are part of change
7. Change sticks when it fits who you want to be
8. You can support change, but not force it
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Change is hard for good reasons.** Habits save effort, so the old way is always the easy way.
- **A small step and a kind setup outlast willpower.** Make the first step tiny and change what is around you.
- **Slips are part of change.** A missed day tells you something about the plan and nothing about your character.
- **Other people's change is theirs.** You can support it, though you can't force it.

MONDAY, 7:05AM

The plan was a walk before work. The trainers are by the door. Somehow the phone is in your hand instead, and at 7.40 you are watching a man in Finland restore a rusty axe, next to a coffee that went cold twenty minutes ago. You don't even like axes.

By the evening a quiet voice is telling you that you never stick to anything. What you actually ran into this morning was a habit with about six years of practice behind it. It won, as it usually does for the first few rounds.

This chapter is why several tools in these books are so small. One small step a week (Part One, Next, page 44) starts smaller than feels useful and decides ahead of time. The setup score and One owner per job (Part Two, Chapter II, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2) change the setup instead of asking anyone for more willpower. And What keeps coming back? (Part Two, Chapter V, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-5) treats a repeat as information about the plan, because slips are an ordinary part of changing anything.

01

Change is hard for good reasons.

A lot of what we do each day runs on autopilot. That saves energy, and it's the whole point of a habit. The catch is that the old way is always quicker and easier than the new one, so changing asks your brain to do something effortful again and again, for weeks, until the new way becomes the easy one.

Every night Jodie decides she will not snap at the children in the morning, and she means it. Every morning, somewhere between the lost reading book and the toast going cold and Lily's hair, she snaps. The morning has worn a groove deeper than her good intentions, which says something about mornings and not much about her as a mother.

Pick one thing you'd like to change, and write down when it usually happens, where, and what's going on just before.

02

Habits run on cues.

Most habits have a trigger, which might be a time or a place or a feeling or a person, or simply the thing you've just done. The cue starts the routine, and some kind of reward (relief, comfort, a small buzz) keeps it going. Once you know the cue, you can plan for it.

Nigel noticed, eventually, that he reached for the biscuit tin the moment he opened his laptop after dinner, hungry or not, every night, and the laptop was the cue. So now he puts the kettle on before he opens it and makes a pot. By the time the tea's brewed the urge has mostly wandered off. On Fridays it doesn't wander anywhere and he has a custard cream, and that seems fair.

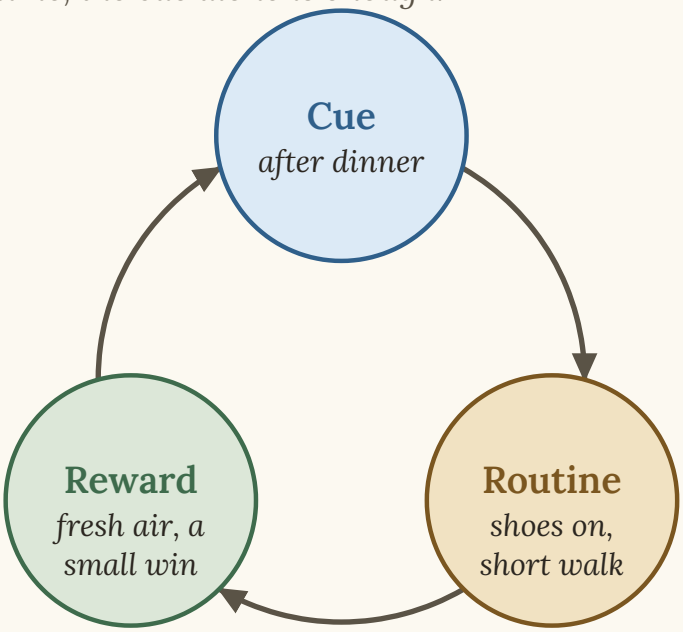
Stale popcorn

In one field experiment, people with a strong cinema-popcorn habit ate stale popcorn about as much as fresh, but only in a cinema. Somewhere else, they didn't. The setting drove the habit more than taste or good intentions did, rather like Nigel's laptop.

Neal and colleagues (2011) · *Moderate: two field experiments, in line with wider habit research*

Habits run on cues

Over time, the cue alone is enough.



Change the setup, not just your willpower: *move the cue, make the step tiny.*

The cue, routine and reward loop is a popular simplification; the core idea, that context triggers habits, is well supported (for example Neal, Wood and colleagues, 2011).

FIGURE 16 Habits run on cues. Over time the cue alone is enough, so change the setup, not just your willpower.

03

Start smaller than feels useful.

Big goals are inspiring and easy to drop. Tiny steps feel almost silly, and they work precisely because they're easy enough to manage on a bad day. Tie the new step to something you already do ("After I put the kettle on, I'll…"), and only grow it once it's stuck.

Two housemates had been promising each other a big Sunday clean of the kitchen since March. It had happened once, so they agreed something smaller. After dinner, each of them wipes one surface, which takes two minutes. By the second week the hob had stopped being a source of tension. By the fourth, someone had descaled the kettle without being asked, which caused a small sensation.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "Let's start with something tiny, and see if it sticks." "After I ..., I will ..."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 11

Your done list

Bernie, 71, living on his own

Your done list

Write down one small thing that went right, however small.

A small win
Went to the Thursday quiz with Rita and Joe

Who it was with
With a friend

THIS WEEK: 4 SMALL WINS

Went to the Thursday quiz with Rita and Joe · Thu, Oct 8 · With a friend

Cleared one shelf in the spare room · Wed, Oct 7

Rang my brother back · Tue, Oct 6 · With family

Walked to the post office instead of driving · Mon, Oct 5

Made-up example. A done list is for encouragement, not proving who does more.

Fill in your own: Your done list (spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins)

04

Change the setup, not just your willpower.

Willpower runs low when you're tired or hungry. Your surroundings stay the same all day. So make the new habit easier, by putting it in sight or getting things ready the night before, and make the old one a little harder, by moving it out of reach. I'd back a small change to the setup over a big push of effort almost every time. At home that can be as simple as one owner for each job (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job).

Callan is seventeen and wants to sleep better, and for weeks he tried to stop scrolling in bed by sheer force of will. It didn't work once. Then his mum suggested charging his phone in the kitchen overnight, next to the bread bin. He said this was ridiculous, and did it anyway, mainly to prove her wrong, and within a week he was asleep before midnight most nights. Every few weeks he tells her it's ridiculous, without much conviction.

Willpower isn't a fuel tank, probably

A popular idea says self-control runs out like fuel. When 23 labs tried to repeat the classic experiment together, they found an effect close to zero. The argument isn't over, but it's one more reason to change the setup rather than lean harder on yourself.

Hagger and colleagues (2016) · *Strong: a large pre-registered replication; the debate continues*



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Changing the setup is often easier than changing a person. At home, that can be as simple as one owner for each job.

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03

05

Being in two minds is normal.

Part of you wants to change and part of you doesn't, and the reluctant part usually has its reasons. The old habit may give comfort, or protect you from something. Pushing harder against it rarely works, and listening to it often does.

Asif wanted to drink less, and he also loved Friday nights in the pub with his team. When he finally asked himself what Friday actually gave him, the answer wasn't really the beer. It was the people, the laughing, the end of the week. So he kept the Friday and switched to alcohol-free after the first pint. If anyone at the table noticed, they didn't say, which is its own sort of kindness.

Try two lists, one of what you like about how things are, one of what you'd like about changing. You're allowed both, and I suspect the first one will be the more honest of the two.

06

Slips are part of change.

Nearly everyone who changes something slips back sometimes, and one slip doesn't undo the progress. What does the damage is usually the thought that follows. "I've blown it, so why bother?" Being kind to yourself after a slip makes it a good deal more likely you'll start again.

Three calm weeks, and then Lewis shouted at his son over spellings. Really shouted, the old way. That night he sat on the end of the bed in the dark. "I shouted, and I'm sorry. I'm working on it." A small voice from under the duvet said "Okay." The next evening they did the spellings at the kitchen table with the radio on. Nobody raised their voice. The word was "necessary", which neither of them could spell.

There's a name for "why bother?"
Relapse-prevention research calls it the abstinence violation effect: after one slip, guilt and a sense of total failure make a full slide back more likely. It comes from addiction treatment, but the shape is the same for biscuits and evening runs.

Marlatt and Gordon (1985) · *Moderate: a foundational clinical model, widely used in addiction treatment*

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"A slip is one moment out of many." "What made today harder, and what can I plan for next time?"

Decide now, while things are going well, what you'll do after a slip. Have one kind sentence to say to yourself and one small step to start again. A game can help some people practise, and the Re-check Drive (spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive) turns small kind steps into calm football.



TIDBIT

A slip is a stumble, not a fall. Try the tiny step again tomorrow. A game for small kind acts can make the practising easier.

TOOL **Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

07

Change sticks when it fits who you want to be.

Change made only to please someone, or out of shame, is hard to keep up. Change that connects to what you care about has deeper roots, and each small action becomes a vote for the person you're turning into.

Rania kept meaning to be better at keeping in touch, and kept not being. What shifted it was a different sentence in her head. She stopped telling herself she must message people and started thinking of herself as someone who shows up for her friends. A voice note on Sunday evenings became part of that. Some weeks it's thirty seconds of nonsense and some weeks it turns into an hour on the phone.

08

You can support change, but not force it.

It's natural to want the people we love to change, to drink less, or look after themselves better. Their change belongs to them, though, and pressure tends to make people dig in. It helps more to say clearly what you need, ask what would help, and notice their small steps out loud.

Grant kept missing deadlines, and his teammate had the lecture about being organised all ready, she'd been polishing it for a fortnight, and at the last minute she didn't give it. She asked what would make the handover easier, and he looked surprised. Between them they set up a shared checklist, and he fills it in every Friday before lunch, mostly. She has kept the lecture, though, in a note on her phone.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"I can't change this for you, but I'd love to help if you want me to." "I noticed you did that this week. That really helped."

TWO WEEKS LATER, 7:05AM

The trainers are still by the door. The phone sleeps in the kitchen now, and the plan has shrunk to shoes on, out to the end of the road. Some mornings that's it. Most mornings it turns into a loop past the allotments and back. On the Thursday you miss, the voice starts up again, and you tell it you'll get to the end of the road tomorrow. It says you won't. You do.

In everyday life

Take a couple who want to spend less of the evening on their phones. Earlier attempts failed because each of them watched the other. This time they put a basket by the door, both phones go in at nine, and there's one exception for whoever's on call for an elderly parent. The first week is awkward. On the Wednesday one of them sneaks a look at the football. By the third week the basket is part of the furniture and the evenings have a shape again, a film or a crossword or an early night.

Big life changes, a move or a new baby, break old routines, which is disruptive and also a good moment to start new habits. If you have ADHD, make the cue impossible to miss, do the step the moment it appears, and make the reward come straight away. Expect the novelty to wear off, and swap the method when it does instead of blaming yourself. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-6-change-in-depth).

On your own: a kind plan for change

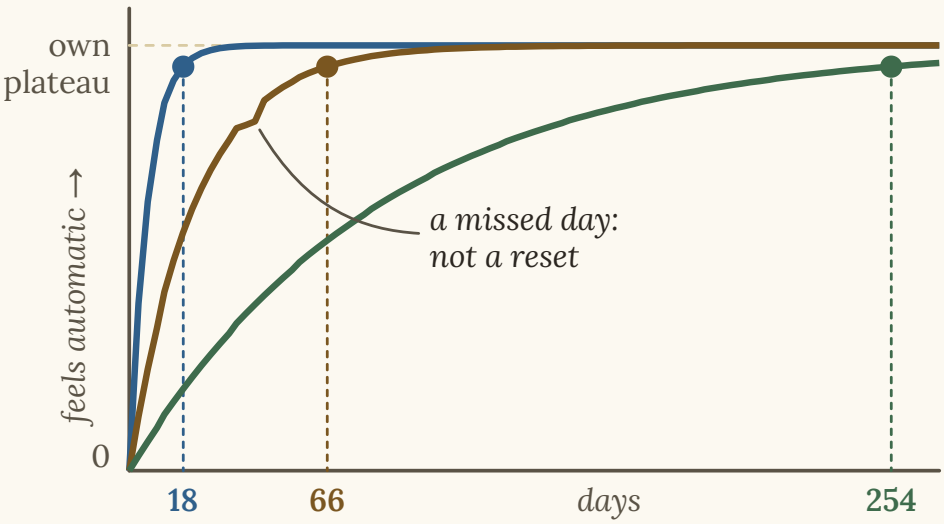
If you're working on something alone, the whole chapter fits into one small plan. Choose one change, the one that would make the most difference or the one that feels most doable. Give it a cue, written as "After I ___, I will ___." Make one tweak to your surroundings so it's easier to start. Decide on the smallest version you could still manage on a tired day. And write down one kind sentence to use after a slip. The self path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) and Know yourself, next (page 44) walk through it step by step.

Common mix-ups

"If I really wanted it, I'd just do it" is the cruellest of these, and it's wrong. Wanting is only the start. Habits, setup, tiredness and stress all get a vote. Then there's the famous 21 days. There's no magic number. In one study, led by Phillippa Lally (2010), it took about two months on average, with a very wide range. Being hard on yourself doesn't keep you on track, either. Harshness makes people give up, and kindness makes it easier to try again. And routines don't have to mean being rigid. For a lot of people, autistic people especially, routines are what make life manageable, and change can respect that.

About two months, give or take a lot

How automatic a new daily habit feels, over time.



— Fastest in the study: about 18 days
— Middle (median): about 66 days
— Slowest: about 254 days

Illustrative shapes, not the raw data. Lally and colleagues (2010) followed 96 volunteers; reaching 95% of each person's own plateau took 18 to 254 days, median 66. Simpler habits formed faster.

FIGURE 17 How long a new habit takes to feel automatic: about two months on average, with a very wide range. Illustrative shapes based on Lally and colleagues (2010).

If you want to help someone else with this

Ask before you advise ("Would ideas help, or would you rather just talk it through?"), and help them find their own reasons by asking what would be

different for them if this changed. Practical help with the setup, like a lift to the gym, often does more than encouragement. Notice small steps out loud and be kind about slips. Look after yourself too. You can care a great deal and still have limits on what you'll put up with.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I'm on your side with this. What would help?" "You've done this three days running. That's not nothing."

When to get more help

- **If a habit is harming your health or life,** such as drinking, drugs, gambling, eating or self-harm, please talk to a doctor or a specialist service. Needing help with this is common and nothing to be ashamed of.
- **If you can't stop even though you've tried many times,** professional support can make a real difference. It isn't a sign of weakness.
- **If change feels impossible because you're exhausted or low most days,** that may be burnout or depression. A doctor or counsellor can help.
- **If someone is demanding you change in ways that frighten you,** or punishing you when you don't, that isn't support.
- **If you're overwhelmed right now,** start with Upset right now (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now).

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Pick one tiny change and try it for a week. The 90-second daily check-in (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-13-daily-check-in), the quick checks (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks) and the self path can help you keep track.

Reading pages to read on the website

- Know yourself, next (page 44): values, one small goal, tiny steps and if-then plans.
- Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency): why good habits fade, and how to keep them alive.

More for your situation

- On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own)
- New parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent)
- When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids)
- Neurodivergent relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- Gaming, phones and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together)
- At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Coming home after time apart (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home)
- Find it by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part One · Next · Who you are becoming
One small goal and tiny steps page 44

Part Two · Chapter V · The monthly look-back
The monthly look-back read online

Part Two · Chapter II · Is the split working?
Changing the setup, not the person read online

Part Three · Chapter 14 · Personality, temperament and change
How much people really change page 238

PUT IT TO USE

Know yourself, next
Values, one small goal, tiny steps and if-then plans
spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next

Complacency
Why good habits fade, and how to keep them alive
spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency

7

PART THREE · CHAPTER 7

Self-worth, shame and self-compassion

Why your worth isn't a score you keep earning, how shame differs from guilt, and why being kind to yourself makes it easier to grow.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Your worth isn't a score
2. Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad."
3. Shame makes you want to hide
4. The inner critic is trying to protect you
5. Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off
6. Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you
7. You can own a mistake without drowning in it
8. Worth is learned between people, and we can give it
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

THURSDAY, 11:20PM

You sent the wrong spreadsheet to the whole team. Last quarter's, not this one's. Priyanka spotted it in four minutes, sent the right one round and added "no worries!!" with two exclamation marks, which somehow made it worse.

It's nearly midnight. The file stopped being the point some time around ten. The voice has moved on to bigger things now, like how you've always been a bit useless, really, and now they all know.

This chapter is about how self-worth and shame work, and then about what you can actually do with them. None of it is a diagnosis. Take what helps.

01

Your worth isn't a score.

A lot of us carry a quiet scoreboard, on which we're worth something when we're useful, or liked, or slim, or busy, or top of the class, or never any bother to anybody. Psychologists call these "conditions of worth", and the trouble with a score is that it can drop. If your worth goes up and down with each day's results, then every bad day is a verdict.

Pam taught Year 4 for forty years. In the September after she retired she found herself in the supermarket at ten on a Tuesday morning, holding a basket with nothing in it, feeling lost in a way she couldn't have explained to anyone. Nothing was wrong. But for four decades being needed was how she knew she mattered, and the bell had stopped ringing.

Try finishing "I feel okay about myself when I…" three times, then look at what you wrote. Those are your scores. Just noticing them is enough for now.

02

Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad."

Guilt is about something you did, so it points somewhere useful. Say sorry. Put it right. Shame is about who you are, which feels impossible to fix, and so it makes people hide, or freeze, or blame someone else, or lash out. Research on the two feelings, such as June Tangney and Ronda Dearing's (2002), suggests guilt is the one more likely to lead to repair.

Rhys is twelve and he has just knocked his mum's favourite mug off the side, the one with the hare on it that she bought on the seafront in Whitby years ago and drinks her first tea of the day from, and there are two ways this can go. Guilt says go and tell her, and maybe offer some birthday money. Shame says you ruin everything, and this time shame wins. He wraps the pieces in yesterday's paper and pushes them right down to the bottom of the bin, under the potato peelings, where his mum finds them on Sunday.

It was the hiding that upset her. She told him so. It took him a while to see what she meant.

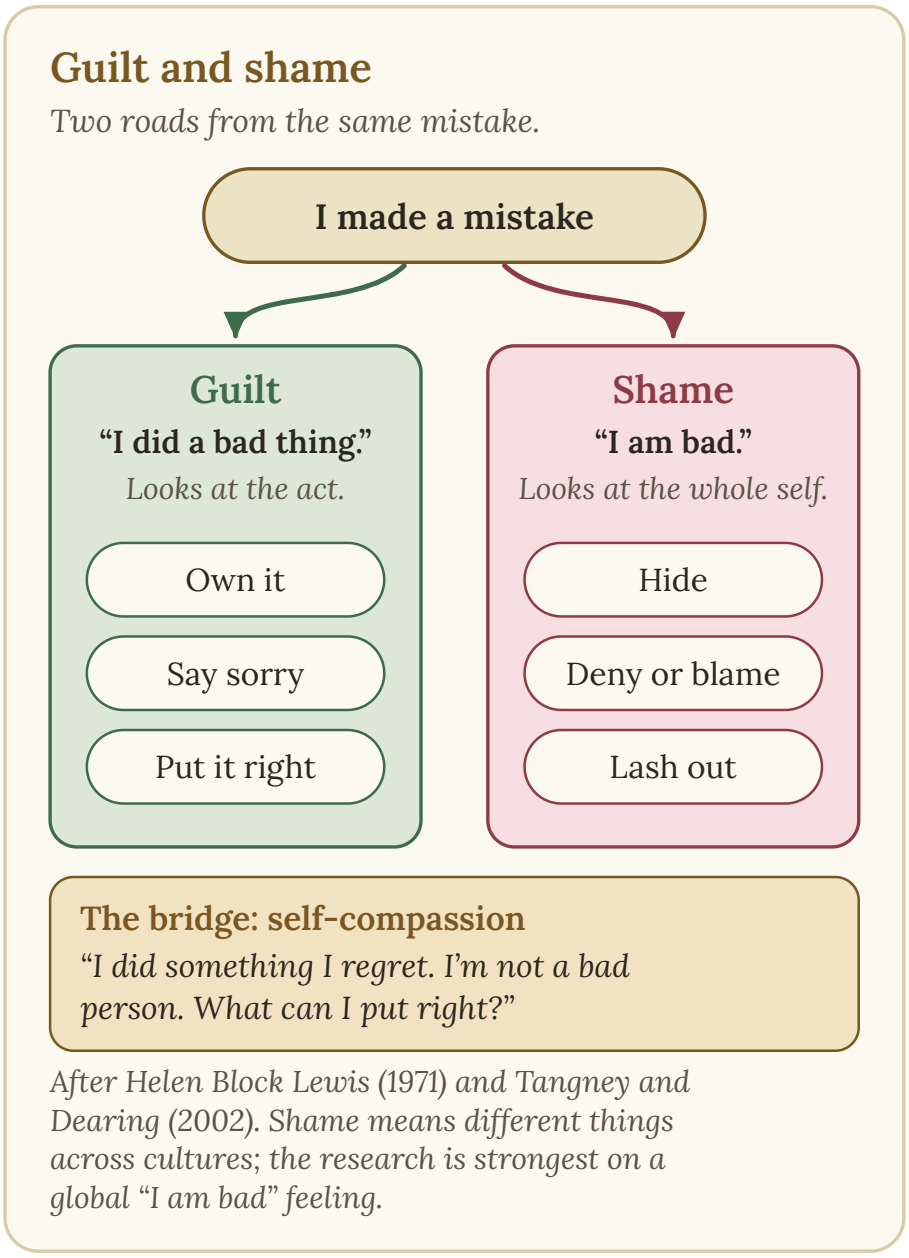


FIGURE 18 Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad." Guilt is easier to put right, and self-compassion helps you cross over.

03

Shame makes you want to hide.

You feel shame in the body before you think it. Hot face, eyes down, stomach dropping, a strong wish for the floor to open. It also comes out sideways, as sudden anger or a closed, cold face, which is how a small comment turns into a big row.

"Didn't we already cover this?" It was a mild question, asked in a Tuesday meeting by a man who genuinely couldn't remember. Becky snapped at him, properly, in front of nine people. That evening, scraping a plate into the bin, she worked out that it had nothing to do with him. She'd felt stupid in front of everyone, and stupid had come out as sharp.

Learn your own signs, if you can. Next time you suddenly want to vanish, or bite, you can name it quietly to yourself, and now and then out loud. "Sorry, I think I felt embarrassed and it came out sharp. Can I try that again?"

04

The inner critic is trying to protect you.

That harsh inner voice usually started as protection. If you criticise yourself first, perhaps nobody else gets the chance. If you're hard enough on yourself, perhaps you'll never fail again. It meant well, in its way. But a voice that only threatens keeps your body on alert, and it's exhausting to share a head with.

Every time Craig forgets something for the baby he calls himself an idiot. Out loud, sometimes. The wipes. The rabbit she won't sleep without. It's the word his own dad used about him, all through his childhood. Patting his pockets in the nursery car park for a rabbit that's on the kitchen table, he hears it in his dad's voice, exactly, and it strikes him as odd that he's still using it.

Perfectionism has been creeping up

Students' perfectionism scores rose between 1989 and 2016, according to a meta-analysis by Curran and Hill, with the sharpest rise in the feeling that other people expect you to be perfect. It's questionnaire data from Western countries and it can't say why, but if that feeling is loud for you, you have company.

Curran and Hill (2019) · *Moderate: questionnaire data from Western countries; does not explain the cause*

Write down one thing your critic says a lot. Would you say it to a friend you loved? Some people find it helps to answer the critic directly. "Thanks. I

know you're trying to protect me. I can take it from here."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 12

Flip it

Hamish, 44, after a mistake at work

Flip it

What's on your mind?

I got the figures wrong in the client report and my manager had to fix it. I'm hopeless at this job.

What kind is it?

A complaint about someone · A worry · *Being hard on myself* · Anger

THE FLIP

What a good friend might say

"That sounds like a hard moment. One mistake is not the whole of you. You're not hopeless. You're a person having a hard day."

Kinder words for yourself

"I had a hard moment. I'm human. Next time I'll [one thing]."

One next step

[one small thing, like a short sorry, a reminder on your phone, or some rest]

Talking to yourself the way you'd talk to a friend is a simple form of self-compassion. Being harsh rarely makes the next try easier. This is a starting point. Change any words you like.

Hamish's own words, after changing the flip

I got two figures wrong and it was caught before the client saw it. I'm human. Next time I'll ask a colleague to check the numbers before it goes out.

His next step

Send my manager a two-line sorry and the checking plan, today, then go home on time.

Made-up example. The flip is a starting point: Hamish changed the words until they were true and sounded like him.

Fill in your own: Flip it (spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins)

05

Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off.

Self-compassion means treating yourself the way you'd treat a good friend who's having a rotten time. One well-known model has three parts. Kindness instead of attack. Remembering that everyone struggles. Noticing the pain without drowning in it. Studies, such as one by Juliana Breines and Serena Chen (2012), suggest that people who are kind to themselves after a failure are often *more* likely to try to improve.

Lindy failed her driving test for the third time, on the reverse round a corner again, clipping the same kerb she had clipped in March, and afterwards she sat in the test centre car park for a while with the engine off. Then she told herself what she'd have told her sister, more or less. This is hard. Loads of people need more goes. You're fine everywhere except that one corner. On Sunday morning she was on the empty industrial estate by the ring road with her dad in the passenger seat, reversing round the same lamp post eleven times.

If it feels all right, try putting a hand on your arm once today and saying, slowly, "This is a hard moment. Other people feel this too. What do I need?" It will feel daft the first time, and probably the second.



SUGARFOOT

Speak to yourself the way you'd speak to a friend having a hard day, slowly and kindly. Writing it down first helps.

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

06

Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you.

Everyone measures themselves against other people. It's how we work out where we stand. But a feed full of other people's best moments makes the measuring wildly unfair, and self-esteem that depends on being better than others swings about all over the place.

Two old friends met for a curry, one of them having just bought a house. The other rents a room in a shared flat in Leyton where the shower only works if you hold it. The renter spent the whole evening quietly ranking herself, and she missed what was right in front of her. Her friend was lonely in the new house, and had wanted to say so all evening, and kept waiting for a gap in the conversation that never came because the renter was so busy ranking herself. You're comparing your inside with somebody's outside. When you catch yourself at it, try a question instead. "How are you, really?"

Why we compare at all

Leon Festinger proposed in 1954 that people judge their opinions and abilities by comparing themselves with others, especially when there's no objective standard to go by. Worth has no objective standard, which may be exactly why comparing goes so badly there.

Festinger (1954) · *Strong: a foundational theory with a large body of later research*

07

You can own a mistake without drowning in it.

Owning a mistake gets a lot easier once it doesn't mean you're worthless. Say what you did. Say what it did to the other person. Say what you'll do now. Then stop. Beating yourself up afterwards proves nothing about how sorry you are, it just pulls everyone's attention back onto you.

Jess forgot to pay her share of the broadband and it got cut off for the whole of the bank holiday weekend. On the Tuesday, after a weekend of the others tethering their laptops to their phones and one of them going to the library to finish an essay, she put her head round the living-room door. "I forgot to pay, and it left you all without internet for three days. I've paid it and set a reminder for the 28th." Someone said "Cheers," and that was more or less the end of it.

If it went wrong in a conversation, Rewind the talk (spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder) helps you find the words. Then decide whether to

send them or let it rest.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Owning a mistake can be short and plain: what happened, that it was yours, what you'll do. If it went wrong in a talk, Rewind the talk helps you find the words.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

08

Worth is learned between people, and we can give it.

Children learn their worth from how they're treated, and adults never entirely stop. The words matter, because "You did a careless thing" leaves room to change, while "You're so careless" shuts the door. Notice effort, and who someone is, as well as results, and people feel they matter on bad days too.

Gill took over a team that hid its problems until week ten, and from her first month she started every project review with the same question, "What did we learn?", and refused, politely and repeatedly, to discuss who had got what wrong. Within six months people were bringing problems to her in week two, which saved everyone a great many Friday evenings, and the soppy question stayed.

Today you could say one thing to someone that has nothing to do with how well they've done. Even just "I'm glad I know you."

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't control how other people judge you, or what you were taught about your worth growing up. You can control how you speak to yourself now, whether you repair what you can, and where you spend your time. Give your energy to people who treat you as someone who matters. More in Part One: who you are today (page 29)

FRIDAY, 9:15AM

You send one line. Sorry about the mix-up with yesterday's file, right one attached. When the voice starts up again you try answering it the way you would a friend. You got it wrong and you fixed it, which is what a decent colleague does. The voice is not convinced. Priyanka sends a thumbs-up, and by lunch you've mostly stopped thinking about it.

In everyday life

Shame turns up in very ordinary places. Between partners, "You forgot to call" can land as "You're a terrible partner", so what comes back is a defence instead of a sorry. A child who hears "You're so naughty" learns something about who they are, while "That was a naughty thing to do" leaves a way back. A friend who says yes to everything may be quietly burning out, because no feels like risking being dropped. At work, someone may sit on a small error for weeks because owning it feels like proof they never belonged there.

On your own: a kinder voice to keep

You don't need anyone else for this. Notice how you talk to yourself and practise one gentler sentence. Catch the critic's favourite words ("always", "useless", "pathetic", "should") and swap one for a plain fact. "I'm hopeless" becomes "I was late twice this week." On bad days, keep a short list of what you did, and let getting up count. You're allowed to be disappointed in what you did and still be on your own side.

Common mix-ups

People worry that self-compassion is just self-pity. They feel quite different from the inside. Self-pity says "only me, poor me". Self-compassion says "this is hard, and other people go through it too", which joins you to other people instead of shutting you away from them. Others fear that being kind to themselves will make them lazy. The research leans the other way, because it's fear of your own attack that makes people stop trying and hide their

mistakes. And self-worth doesn't mean thinking you're great, only that you go on mattering on the days when you plainly aren't.

If you want to help someone else with this

Talk about what happened, never about what sort of person they are. Arguing with someone's shame ("You're not useless!") can feel like being told they're wrong to feel it, so you might try "It sounds like you feel really low about it. I don't see you that way." Helping them find one small thing they can do gives the feeling somewhere to go. And kindness on ordinary days, when nothing has gone wrong, teaches worth far better than anything said in a crisis.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "That sounds like it's weighing on you. Want to work out one thing that would help?" "You don't have to earn being cared about."

When to get more help

Everyone feels shame and self-doubt sometimes. It's worth talking to a doctor, counsellor or therapist if harsh thoughts about yourself are there most days, if they stop you working, eating, sleeping or seeing people, or if you feel you deserve to be hurt. Therapies such as compassion-focused therapy and cognitive behavioural therapy are built to help with exactly this.

If you are having thoughts of hurting yourself or not wanting to be here, please tell someone today.

If someone close to you keeps telling you you're worthless, stupid or lucky to have them, that isn't a self-esteem problem. It can be a way of controlling someone.

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) for a feeling that is too big to think through

- Ask Professor Puddles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask), the site's chat host, to help you find a kinder sentence

Reading pages to read on the website

- Shame and guilt (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), in the site's library of research notes
- Self-compassion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection) and self-esteem (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/motivation)
- Perfectionism (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/motivation#perfectionism) and social comparison (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life)
- Masking (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring), for anyone who has spent years trying to seem "normal"
- Where your lens came from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up), for where an old inner voice might have started

More for your situation

- **On your own:** Part One: where you came from (page 14) · Your self-discovery path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · On my own after a breakup (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own)
- **Teens:** For teens: feelings (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- **Neurodivergent:** Wired differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently) · Neurodivergent relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- **At work:** At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- **Coming out:** Coming out as an adult (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out)
- **Carers and parents:** Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers) · When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids)
- **Related chapters:** Loss, grief and big life changes (page 152) · Minds that work differently (page 165)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Your worth isn't a score.
- ✓ Shame makes you want to hide.
- ✓ Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off.
- ✓ Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you.
- ✓ Worth is learned between people, and we can give it.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part One · Then · Where your lens came from
Old rules that taught you your worth page 14

Part One · Next · Who you are becoming
Kindness when a goal slips page 44

Part Three · Chapter 11 · Healing after hurt
Guilt, apology and forgiveness page 197

Part Three · Chapter 16 · Worry, low mood and trauma
When the inner critic gets loud page 264

PUT IT TO USE

Upset right now?
For a feeling that is too big to think through
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Ask Professor Puddles
The site's chat host, to help you find a kinder sentence
spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

8

PART THREE · CHAPTER 8

Loss, grief and big life changes

What grief is, why it comes in waves, how it shows up in the body, and how to carry a loss, or a big change, without having to "get over it."

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Grief is love with nowhere to go
2. Grief comes in waves, not neat stages
3. Grief lives in the body, too
4. Some losses nobody sees
5. People grieve in different ways
6. You don't have to let go
7. Big changes are losses too, even the good ones
8. Most people find a way through, and support helps
9. Losing a partner in later life
10. In everyday life
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Grief is love with nowhere to go.** It hurts because the person, place or life mattered.
- **It comes in waves.** A good week followed by a bad day is part of grieving, and it doesn't send you back to the start.
- **You don't have to let go.** Many people keep a bond with the person they lost, and that is healthy.
- **Most people find a way through.** Support helps, and some losses need more help than friends can give.

SATURDAY, 9:05AM

Six months on, you're doing fine, or that's what you tell people, and on most days it's even true.

Then, in aisle seven, there's the cereal, his cereal, the faded blue box he always said tasted of cardboard and ate every single morning for thirty years. You leave the trolley where it is, next to the porridge, and walk out to the car and sit in it with the engine off. A woman loading her boot two spaces down glances over and then, kindly, doesn't.

This chapter is for anyone who has lost someone or something. It might be a person, or a pet, or a marriage or a friendship, their health or a home or a job, a country they had to leave or a future they'd pictured. It looks at how grief works and then at what can help. There's no right way to grieve. Nothing here is a timetable, and if any of it doesn't fit you, leave it.

01

Grief is love with nowhere to go.

Grief is what we feel when something we were attached to is gone, and it isn't only for deaths. A divorce, a miscarriage, a diagnosis, a move, a friend who drifted off, children leaving home. Its size usually matches the size of the bond, whatever anyone else thinks the loss ought to mean.

When Bramble died, his owner was shaken by how hard he took it, and his friends at the pub told him, kindly enough, that it was only a dog. That dog walked beside him along the same stretch of river every morning for twelve years, through two jobs and a divorce. The lead is still on its hook by the back door, and he can't move it yet.

It can help to say a loss out loud to yourself, especially one you've never called grief. "I'm grieving the friendship." "I'm grieving the life we planned." They're small sentences, and they can bring a surprising amount of relief.

02

Grief comes in waves, not neat stages.

You may have heard of five stages of grief, running from denial through anger, bargaining and depression to acceptance. They came from listening to people who were dying, and they were never meant as steps that everyone goes through in order. Most people swing back and forth, some hours deep in the loss and some hours getting on with life, and researchers who study grief see that swing as healthy.

Three months after Gerald died, Val laughed properly at lunch. Her sister had told a story about a man at the bowls club and a wasp, and Val laughed till she had to put her fork down. On the bus home she felt terrible about it. That evening she cried for two hours. The lunch was grief too, and so was the bus.

Back and forth is normal

The dual process model describes healthy grief as moving back and forth between facing the loss and getting on with life, with breaks from grief included. In this model Val's laugh at lunch isn't a lapse. It's part of the grieving.

Stroebe and Schut (1999) · *Moderate: a widely used framework with partial support*

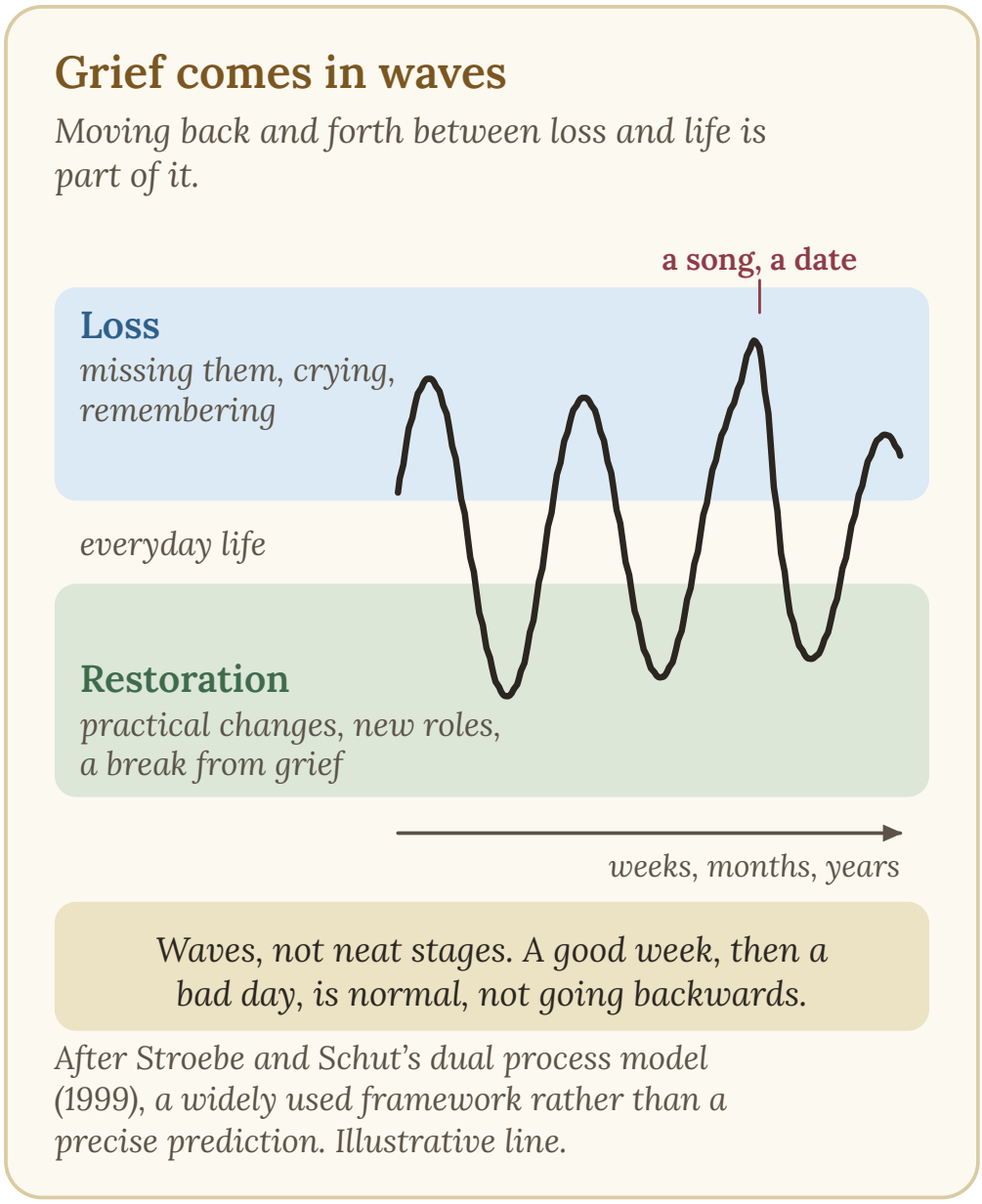


FIGURE 19 Grief comes in waves, not neat stages. Moving back and forth between loss and everyday life is part of healthy grieving.

03

Grief lives in the body, too.

Grief can bring tiredness, bad sleep, no appetite or too much, aches, a tight chest, forgetfulness and a foggy head. Your brain is slowly learning that someone or something it expected to be there has gone, and the learning takes time and uses a lot of energy.

A deputy head whose mother has just died loses her car keys three times in one week. She drives to school on a Saturday, and walks into a governors' meeting that is happening on Thursday when it is in fact Tuesday. She starts to wonder, quietly, if something is wrong with her memory. It's grief fog. It lifts as the months go on, though nobody can tell her when, and she'd really like somebody to.

While it lasts, look after a few basics, like one proper meal a day and a regular bedtime and a short walk outside, and it's fine to tell people, "I'm grieving, so I'm slower than usual. Could you send me a reminder?"

04

Some losses nobody sees.

Some losses are hard to explain to anyone else. Someone may still be alive but changed by dementia or illness, or gone without having died, like an estranged parent or a missing relative. Other losses go unrecognised, such as the death of an ex-partner, a pregnancy loss or a friend you only ever knew online.

Every Sunday at two, Teresa visits her dad at the care home. He's always pleased to see her. He thinks she's his sister, Connie, and asks after their mother, who died in 1987. Teresa has stopped correcting him, and they talk about Connie's life, which Teresa now knows a surprising amount about. She is grieving someone who hasn't died. There's no funeral for that, no cards, and at work nobody thinks to ask.

A loss without an ending

Pauline Boss named this ambiguous loss: someone gone but still present in the mind, or present but changed, as with dementia. Part of what makes it so hard is that there's no clear ending to grieve.

Boss (1999) · *Moderate: a widely used framework, backed by clinical and interview research*

If a loss of yours had no ceremony, you can make a small one, a candle or a letter or a bulb in the garden, or just going to stand for a while somewhere that mattered.

05

People grieve in different ways.

Some people grieve by talking and crying. Others grieve by doing, fixing things, organising, working, building. Neither is more loving. Families often clash because one person thinks another isn't grieving, when they're grieving differently, and culture and faith and age and how your mind works all shape how it comes out.

After their son died, Janet wanted to talk about him every evening. Steve went into the garage every weekend and worked on the old Raleigh that Ryan had never got round to fixing. She thought he was hiding. He thought she was making it worse. It took a bereavement counsellor about forty minutes to point out, gently, that they were both doing exactly the same thing. In March Steve brought the bike out, finished. Janet cried and he let her. Then she asked him what was wrong with the gears, and he told her, for some time.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 13

Write it through

Edith, 74, seven months after her husband died, writing to her son and daughter

Write it, wait, then send

Who is it to?

Partner · Co-parent or ex · *Family* · Friend · Housemate · Coworker · More than one person · Someone else

Their name (optional)
Malcolm and Fiona

Your name (optional)
Mum

What kind of message?

Raise something · Reply to something · *Make a plan* · Say sorry · I need a pause

What we need to plan (one thing)

How often we ring and visit. Since your dad died in March, I've had a call every evening at seven and a visit every Sunday.

How I feel about it

tired · rushed · frustrated · unseen · taken for granted · overwhelmed · stretched thin · worried · hurt · disappointed · left out · alone with it · confused · embarrassed · annoyed · sad · on edge · hopeful · *grateful*

What I suggest (one clear suggestion)

Could we change to a call on Wednesdays and Sundays, and I'll ring you if I need you in between?

What I'm NOT saying (optional, but it helps)

I'm not pushing you away. I love hearing from you, and I miss your dad too.

When I'd like a reply

Today · Tomorrow · *By the weekend* · No rush

A GENTLE CHECK

House rules: ✓ One topic · ✓ Facts, not verdicts · ✓ No always or never · ✓ No sarcasm or ALL CAPS · ✓ No "you" accusations · ✓ Says what you're asking for · ✓ A reply-by time

No sharp words found. It reads as calm and clear.

Made-up example. Fiona rang the same evening: "Of course. Will you still tell us on a bad day?" Edith said she would.

Fill in your own: Write it through (spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through)

06

You don't have to let go.

An older idea said healthy grief meant moving on and cutting ties. Many grief researchers now see it differently. People often keep a bond with the person they lost, in memories, rituals, conversations in their head and the values they carry on, so the relationship changes shape without having to end.

Ama wears her grandad's watch to every exam. It's far too big. She has to push it up her arm to write. She doesn't believe in luck, and if you asked her

why she does it she would probably shrug and say “dunno”, but the honest answer is that it feels as if he’s in the room.

You could pick one way of keeping a bond, cooking their recipe, or telling one of their stories at Christmas, or keeping one of their habits going. Some people find it helps, in a hard moment, to ask what the person would have said. Often it’s something rude.

Continuing bonds

This is the book that challenged the cut-the-ties view of mourning, showing that inner bonds with someone who has died are common across many groups and often healthy. Later research adds a fair caveat: for some people the bond comforts, and for others it hurts.

Klass, Silverman and Nickman (1996) · *Moderate: influential; effects differ from person to person*

07

Big changes are losses too, even the good ones.

A new baby, a promotion, retiring, moving country, a child starting school, coming out, getting well after a long illness. All of them can bring grief for the old life. Change often has three parts, an ending, a confusing middle bit, and a new beginning. The middle is the hardest part and also the easiest to rush.

Ifeoma and Olu moved to Bristol for a job they both wanted. They toasted it with fizz in the empty flat. Six months in, Olu felt low, and then guilty for feeling low, since this was the plan. What nobody had toasted was what they’d left behind, a circle of friends, a café where nobody had to ask what they wanted, and a whole Saturday that used to run itself. You can be glad about a change and still miss what came before.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When a loss is hard to talk about, writing can come first. Put the words down at your own pace. You never have to send them.

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

08

Most people find a way through, and support helps.

Research suggests that over time many people find they can live with a loss and still feel joy, though they never forget. Being around people who let you talk, or let you stay quiet, helps. For some people, though, grief stays at full

strength for a long time and makes daily life very hard.

Doctors call this **prolonged grief**. It means a strong longing for the person, or being taken over by the loss, most days, still going many months after the death (6 to 12 months or more, depending on the guideline) and getting in the way of life. It has nothing to do with weakness, and there is specific help for it.

A year after his wife died, Dennis still couldn't go into their bedroom. He slept on the settee and had stopped answering the phone to his friends. His doctor referred him to a grief counsellor and he went, mainly so his daughter would stop asking. Things moved, slowly, starting with one evening a week at his brother's, watching the snooker and not saying much. He's back in the bedroom now, on his own side of the bed.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't control the loss, how long grief lasts, or how other people react to it. You can control small things: eating something, resting, telling one person how you are, and saying no to what you can't manage right now. That is enough for a hard season. More in Part One: who you are today (page 29)

SATURDAY, 9:40AM

You let it come, for ten minutes maybe, and then you blow your nose on a napkin from the glove box and go back in. The trolley is still there by the porridge, and you put the cereal in it, without knowing why.

At home you text your sister. Saw Dad's cereal. Cried in the car park. She's typing straight away. Same thing happened to me with his aftershave in the chemist's. Call tonight?

Losing a partner in later life

After a long marriage the loss is in everything, in the empty chair and the jobs that were always theirs and the paperwork, done alone, and in the first birthday and the first anniversary without them. Do one small thing at a time,

and let one drawer count as a day's work. It's fine to ask someone to sit with you while you fill in the forms.

Your grown-up children have lost a parent while you've lost a partner, and you may grieve on different clocks. If they start ringing every day, that comes from love and worry. It isn't control, and you can still say what helps. "I love that you ring. Could we make it two evenings a week, and I'll ring you if I need you?"

In everyday life

After a miscarriage one partner may want to talk while the other goes quiet, and each can end up worrying the other doesn't care. A child may laugh and play the day after a funeral and cry at bedtime, and both are grief. A friend who stops calling after your diagnosis is usually stuck for words more than cold. Colleagues who avoid the subject when someone comes back after a death can leave that person feeling as if the loss has been rubbed out. And a whole town can grieve together, when it loses its library or its factory.

On your own: carrying it gently

Grief can be lonely even with people round you. When you're carrying it on your own, give the day a small shape, with a meal and a walk in it and one person you message. Expect harder days around birthdays and anniversaries, and plan something gentle for them. Writing to the person you lost, or about what you lost, can help, and nobody ever needs to read it. Some days the only goal is to get to tonight, and that is enough of a goal.

IF SOMEONE CLOSE TO YOU HAS DIED. Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief) goes further, with family after a loss, coming back to people, and a new chapter on your own. On a heavy night, the page called For a hard evening (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief#hard-evening) may help.

If you want to help someone else with this

Show up, and then keep showing up. Support floods in for about a fortnight and then stops, so a text at three months, or on a birthday, can mean a great deal. Offer something specific, because "Can I drop dinner round on Thursday?" is far easier to say yes to than "Let me know if you need anything." Say the name, too. Many grieving people find it a comfort to hear it, and a memory with it, and if you're not sure, ask. Leave out the explanations, since "Everything happens for a reason" and "At least…" tend to hurt. "I'm so sorry. I'm here" rarely does. And if you're upset too, lean on people further from the loss, not the ones closest to it. Comfort goes in towards the middle and venting goes out.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I don't know what to say, but I'm here." "I was thinking about your mum today. I remember her laugh." "I'm going to the shop. What can I bring you?"

When to get more help

Grief is not an illness. But it's worth talking to a doctor or a grief counsellor if, after many months, the pain isn't easing at all, you can't manage daily life, you feel life has no meaning without the person, or you are drinking or using other things to get through. Many hospices, faith communities and charities offer free bereavement support, including for children.

If you are having thoughts of not wanting to be here, please tell someone today.

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) for a wave that feels too big

Reading pages to read on the website

- Calm sounds (spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes) for a quiet few minutes
- Grief and later life: loss, family and a new chapter, with a page for a hard evening
- Grief and change (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions) and ambiguous loss (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life), in the site's library of research notes
- Moving and life transitions (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life#moving-and-transitions) and writing about hard things (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#expressive-writing)
- After a loss (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path), in your self-discovery path

More for your situation

- **After a breakup or divorce:** On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own)
- **Families after a loss:** Grief and family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief#family) · Family rifts after a loss or a will (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- **Children and teens:** Helping children grieve (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief#children) · For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- **Big changes:** Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest) · Retired together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/retired-together) · Coming home after time apart (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · New parent (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent)
- **Illness and caring:** When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers)
- **Friendships:** When a friendship drifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- **Related chapters:** Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 140) · Minds that work differently (page 165)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part Three · Chapter 5 · Attachment, trust and belonging page 114
Why losing a bond hurts so much

Part Three · Chapter 12 · Helping others well page 210
Supporting someone who is grieving

Part Three · Chapter 16 · Worry, low mood and trauma page 264
When grief turns into low mood

Part One · Then · Where your lens came from page 14
Losses that shaped your lens

PUT IT TO USE



Upset right now?
For a wave that feels too big
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now



Calm sounds
For a quiet few minutes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

9

PART THREE · CHAPTER 9

Minds that work differently

How autistic, ADHD, sensory and learning differences work, why none of them is a character flaw, and how people with different minds can meet in the middle.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Brains vary, like bodies do
2. Autism is a different way of sensing and connecting
3. ADHD is about steering attention, not lacking it
4. Everyone has a sensory profile
5. Learning differences aren't about intelligence
6. Masking costs energy
7. Autistic burnout is more than being tired
8. Meltdowns and shutdowns aren't choices
9. Stimming helps, so let it be
10. Deep focus makes switching hard
11. Deep interests are a source of joy and rest
12. Meet in the middle, out loud
13. Labels are tools, and they belong to the person
14. Finding out later in life
15. Getting things started and finished is a skill of its own
16. When demands feel like a threat
17. Not recognising faces isn't rudeness
18. Not speaking isn't the same as having nothing to say
19. Telling friends and dates is your choice
20. Finding your people
21. In everyday life
22. Common mix-ups
23. If you want to help someone else with this
24. When to get more help
25. Tools and reading on this site
26. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Brains vary, like bodies do.** A different mind is not a broken one, though differences can still be disabling in a world built for one kind of mind.
- **Nobody chooses overload.** Meltdowns, shutdowns and burnout are what happens when a nervous system has had too much.

- **Less masking, room to stim, time for deep interests and real rest** help a great deal.
- **Meet in the middle, out loud.** Ask what helps, say what helps you, and use the words each person chooses.

MONDAY, 8:15AM

"Shoes, please, just put them on," you say, for the third time.

Your son is lying on the hall floor with his hands over his ears. The new socks are wrong. From where you're standing, they are socks. From where he is, the seam across his toes is sandpaper, and the alarm clock upstairs that nobody has switched off is going straight through the middle of his head. You are already late. So is he, in a way you can't see.

This chapter is for neurodivergent people, diagnosed or not, and for the people who live and work with them. It can't diagnose anyone, and only you get to choose the words you use for yourself. I should say that some of it is personal. I'm autistic, with ADHD in the mix too, and I've tried to write this the way I'd want it written about me.

Two tools elsewhere rest on it. The "How to talk to me" card (Part One, Now, page 29) works because different minds need different input, and saying things plainly helps almost everyone. One owner per job and the written job list (Part Two, Chapter II, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2) move memory out of anyone's head and onto paper, which helps ADHD and autistic minds most and everybody a bit.

01

Brains vary, like bodies do.

Brains differ in how they take in the world, focus, move, read, remember and connect with people. "Neurodiversity" is the idea that this variety is natural. "Neurodivergent" describes people whose minds work differently from what gets treated as typical. A different mind isn't a broken one. Differences can still be disabling, though, especially in a world built for one kind of mind, and that is just as true.

Gary found out he was dyslexic at forty, and he sat in the car outside the assessment centre for twenty minutes afterwards with the report on the passenger seat, not reading it, obviously. What he mostly felt was relief. For thirty years he had half believed the teachers who wrote “lazy” in red pen.

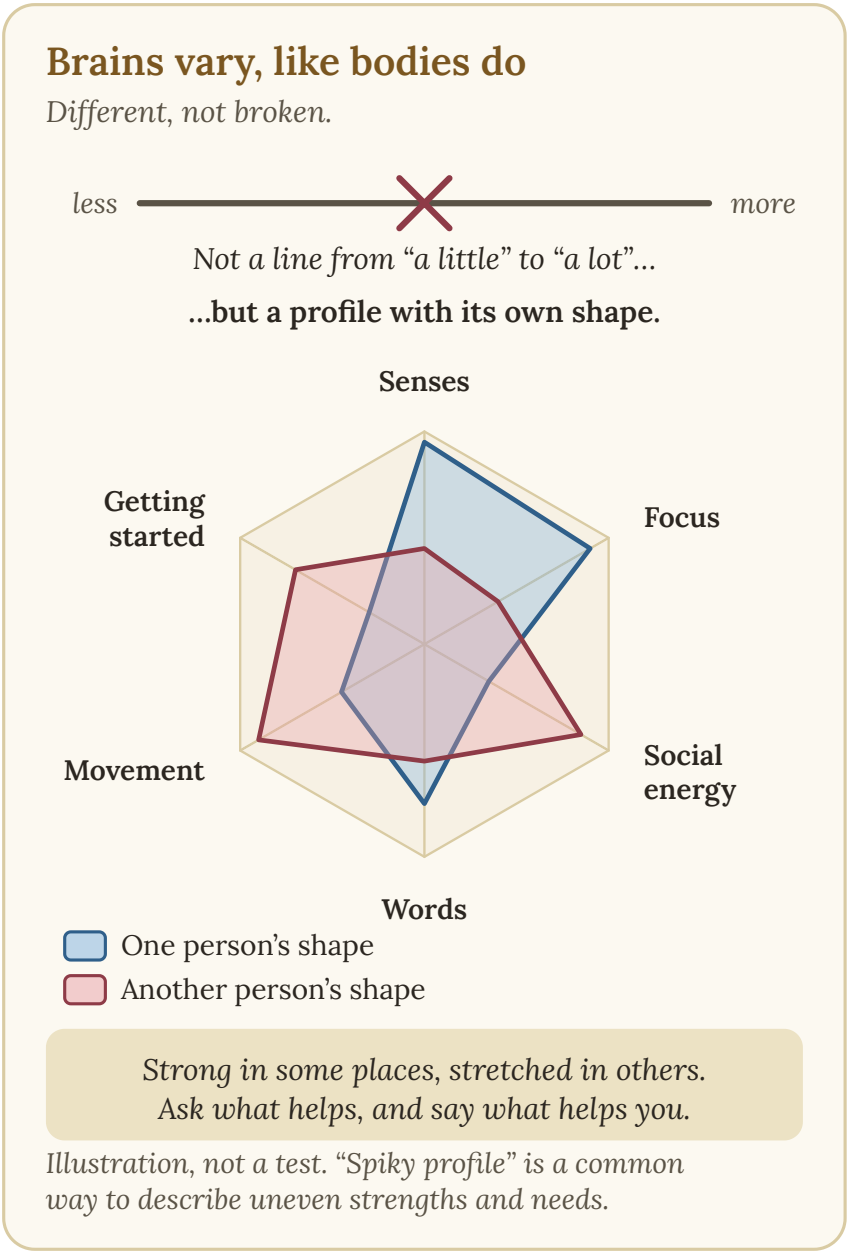


FIGURE 20 Brains vary, like bodies do. A mind has a profile with its own shape, not a place on a line from "a little" to "a lot". Different, not broken.

02

Autism is a different way of sensing and connecting.

Autistic people often communicate more directly and literally. Many have deep, focused interests, feel senses more (or less) intensely than others do, and find predictability calming. Autism doesn't run along one line from "mild" to "severe". Each autistic person has their own mix of strengths and needs, which can change from day to day, and the misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people usually run both ways.

"Your slides have three typos," Kate told her colleague, kindly. "One on slide four and two on the summary." It was exactly what she would have wanted to be told. He went quiet for the rest of the afternoon and she had no idea why until a mutual friend explained it to her in the pub, They were using two different sets of rules for what kindness sounds like, and neither set is wrong, though it would help if they came with subtitles. If you're the direct one, it can help to say so up front, something like "I like it when people say exactly what they mean, so you can be direct with me."

The story that got lost in the middle

In an experiment, a story was passed along chains of eight people. All-autistic chains kept as much detail as all-non-autistic ones, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported less rapport, which supports the idea that the difficulty sits between two styles rather than inside one of them.

Crompton and colleagues (2020) · *Moderate: a careful experiment; modest sample, one task*

03

ADHD is about steering attention, not lacking it.

People with ADHD usually have plenty of attention, and the hard bit is pointing it. Boring tasks feel like pushing a car uphill, interesting ones swallow whole evenings, and time is slippery (there's "now" and there's "not now" and not much in between). Feelings arrive fast and big. It's a real difference in how the brain manages itself. Effort and caring don't come into it.

Saffy forgot her best friend's birthday. Completely. Not a text. Then she spent six hours making a card with pressed flowers from the garden, glued on one at a time with tweezers, and posted it four days late with a note that said "I KNOW". The forgetting and the six hours came out of the same brain. If

something keeps falling out of yours, move it into the world. A labelled alarm. A note on the door. A basket by the front door for the keys.

04

Everyone has a sensory profile.

We all take in sound, light, touch, smell, taste, movement and signals from inside the body. Some people feel these strongly and get overloaded by noise, or a label in a jumper. Others need more input, like movement or strong flavours or firm pressure. Overload is a body at its limit, which is a very different thing from being fussy.

Two housemates fell out over the kitchen radio, because one found silence creepy and the other found Radio 2 at breakfast physically painful. They settled on the radio until nine and headphones after, which has lasted two years.

Notice one sound, light or texture that drains you and one that calms you, and change one small thing today.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Knowing your own sensory profile is information, not a complaint. Write it down once and hand it over, and you don't have to explain it every time.

TOOL **How you connect: how I like to be spoken to** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

05

Learning differences aren't about intelligence.

Dyslexia (reading and spelling), dyscalculia (numbers), dyspraxia (coordination and planning movement) and language disorders are specific differences, and none of them measures how clever someone is. Plenty of people have a "spiky" profile, very strong in some areas and struggling in others. The right tools, audiobooks or extra time in exams or a reader for the long letters, can level things a good deal.

Every Wednesday afternoon on the football pitch, fourteen-year-old Ewan is called clumsy, usually by a PE teacher who should know better. The same term he wrote and directed the school play, which had a revolving set made

out of a bike wheel. Ask the people you live or work with how they find it easiest to take things in, and then actually use it.

06

Masking costs energy.

Many neurodivergent people learn to hide their differences. They copy other people, force eye contact, hold back movements, rehearse small talk in the car. This is called masking. It can get someone through a day. It also uses a great deal of energy, and over years it can wear a person down into exhaustion and burnout. For a long time the cost can be invisible even to the person paying it, which is rather the point of a mask.

Mia seems completely fine at college, chatty in the canteen and helpful in class and laughing in all the right places. She gets home at quarter past four, goes straight up to her room, and can't say a word to anyone for an hour. Her dad used to knock and ask what was wrong, and now he leaves a cup of tea outside the door and goes away.

Style, not substance

Across three studies, non-autistic people formed poorer first impressions of autistic people from a few seconds of video and were less keen to talk to them. Given only a transcript of what was said, the bias disappeared. That goes a long way to explaining why people mask.

Sasson and colleagues (2017) · *Moderate: three studies with consistent results*

Notice one place where you could drop the mask a little, and one person you can be fully yourself with. Spend a bit more time there.

07

Autistic burnout is more than being tired.

Autistic burnout is a deep, long-lasting exhaustion. Working with autistic adults, Raymaker and colleagues (2020) described it as long-term exhaustion, loss of skills (like speech, planning or self-care) and lower tolerance of noise, light and other input. It comes from long stress without enough support, and it often lasts months. Rest helps, and so do fewer demands and less masking. Pushing harder usually makes it worse. If you think you might be there, list three demands you could drop or hand to someone else for a month. If it goes on, or you feel hopeless, talk to a doctor.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I'm in burnout. What I need for a while is fewer demands." "I can't do phone calls at the moment. Can we message instead?"

08

Meltdowns and shutdowns aren't choices.

A **meltdown** is an involuntary loss of control when overwhelm gets too much, and it can look like crying, shouting, running off or lashing out. A **shutdown** is the quiet version: going still, losing speech, not being able to respond. Neither is a tantrum. In interviews by Phung and colleagues (2021), autistic young people described meltdowns and shutdowns as separate experiences, both linked to overload.

For a lot of people words go first. What helps is less of everything. Less noise, fewer words, no questions, more space. Talking can wait, sometimes until the next day. On a calm day, agree a simple signal for "I'm overloaded" and a quiet place to go.

WAYS TO SAY IT

(to someone else) "You're safe. I'm right here. No need to talk." (for yourself) "I'm overloaded. I need quiet for twenty minutes."

09

Stimming helps, so let it be.

Stimming means repeated movements or sounds. Rocking, flapping, tapping, humming, pacing, fiddling with something. Most people stim a little. (Watch any meeting and count the jiggling feet.) For many autistic people it matters a lot. In interviews by Kapp and colleagues (2019), autistic adults described stimming as a way to cope with overwhelming emotions and sensations, and objected to efforts to stop harmless stimming. If it isn't hurting anyone, it doesn't need stopping. It's worth noticing what your own hands do when you're stressed or focused or happy, because that's yours, and nobody needs to train it out of you.

10

Deep focus makes switching hard.

Some minds go deep into one thing at a time, often autistic and ADHD ones. That focus can be a real gift, because it builds expertise and brings a great deal of joy, and it also makes switching hard. Being interrupted can feel like being yanked out of water.

"Dinner!" Nothing. "Tilly, dinner!" Still nothing. Third time, louder. The fish fingers are going cold and Dominic is getting properly cross. His daughter is upstairs building a castle and has reached a delicate stage with the drawbridge. The next night he tries a ten-minute warning, then a five. She comes down on time, still talking about the drawbridge, and tells him at length what the problem with it is. He doesn't entirely follow, but he eats his fish fingers while they're still warm, which is the main thing. The warning, for the record, goes "Dinner in ten minutes, I'll come and get you at five to," shouted up the stairs, and it works about four nights out of five.

11

Deep interests are a source of joy and rest.

Many autistic people have deep, intense interests, often called special interests. The theory of monotropism (Murray, Lesser and Lawson, 2005) describes autistic attention as pulled strongly into a few things at a time. In a survey of autistic adults by Grove and colleagues (2018), people who were more motivated by and engaged with their special interests reported higher wellbeing, though very intense engagement went with lower wellbeing.

Ask someone about their favourite subject and let them talk for five minutes without steering. It costs you five minutes. It's one of the warmest things you can do for anyone.

Interests and wellbeing

In a large Dutch survey of autistic adults, about two in three had a special interest, and being more motivated by it went with higher wellbeing. Very intense engagement went the other way. The joy is real, and so, some weeks, is the need for an off switch.

Grove and colleagues (2018) · *Moderate: a large survey, self-report, at one point in time*



TIDBIT

The website can change to fit your mind too, with bigger text, calmer pages and fewer surprises. The settings are worth a look.

TOOL **Read your way** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in

12

Meet in the middle, out loud.

When two kinds of mind live or work together, neither should have to do all the adjusting. Clear, plain words help everyone. Say what you mean, give times, write things down, ask what helps. And changes made for one person (a quiet space, an agenda, flexible hours) usually help plenty of other people too.

A team started sending meeting agendas a day early, for one autistic colleague. Within a month most of them said meetings had got shorter. Two people who had never said a word in a meeting started saying things.

Today, swap one "how I work best" fact with someone. Tell them one thing that helps you and ask for one that helps them. The website can bend a bit to your mind too, with Read your way (spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in) (bigger text, calmer pages, fewer surprises).

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 14

"How to talk to me" card, for work

Tom, autistic, for his new manager

Your card

Who it's for

A partner Family A friend *Work (a manager or coworker)*

Name on the card, optional

Tom

WIRING CARD · NOT A DIAGNOSIS

How I receive things best
A written list.

I take words
Literally.

Give me time to answer
Write it down so I can answer later.

Please avoid
A hard topic with no warning. Correcting me in public.

A request lands best as
"Could you ___ by ___?"

Also good to know about me
If I go quiet, I'm processing, not upset. Tell me the plan, and tell me if it changes. Noise, light or touch can wear me out.

Sensory needs
Short breaks in long talks.

Sent with one line: "Here's a short card about how I work best. It's not a request for anything big; it just helps us avoid crossed wires."

Made-up example. Sharing a card is always the person's own choice.

Fill in your own: "How to talk to me" card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card)

13

Labels are tools, and they belong to the person.

A diagnosis can bring understanding, and sometimes support and a community too. Some people find their way to a label through self-discovery first. Many autistic adults prefer "autistic person" and others prefer "person with autism". The kindest rule is to ask, use the words the person chooses, and never try to diagnose somebody else, least of all in an argument.

The row was about the washing-up. It was going badly. "You're so autistic," Danny said, and the conversation ended right there, as it deserved to. In the morning, over toast that neither of them was eating, he said sorry, properly,

and then asked what his partner actually needed from him when the kitchen was a mess. It was the conversation they should have had the night before.

If you've wondered about yourself, write down what you've noticed and pick one small next step, like talking to someone or asking a doctor.

14

Finding out later in life.

More and more adults are finding out they're autistic, or have ADHD, in their thirties or fifties or seventies. Many were missed as children, especially women. In interviews by Leedham and colleagues (2020), women diagnosed at forty or older described how exhausting it had been to go so long without an explanation, and how much the diagnosis changed the way they understood their own lives. Relief and grief and something like joy can all turn up together, on the same afternoon. If that's you, look for one autistic-led group or online space, and give yourself time.

15

Getting things started and finished is a skill of its own.

Planning, starting, switching, remembering what you were doing and keeping track of time are called **executive function**. Many autistic and ADHD people find some of these harder, and harder on some days than others. A review of 235 studies by Demetriou and colleagues (2018) found differences in executive function in autism on average, with a lot of variation between people. The brain's self-management system is working differently. Laziness doesn't come into it.

Siân wrote a forty-page report for her board in a week, and it was brilliant. The same three weeks, she could not post one parcel. It sat on the hall table while she walked past it forty times. Then she put it on the doormat with a yellow sticky note on top ("POST ME") and set an alarm for Tuesday at 8.10, and on Tuesday at 8.11 it went. See routines that help (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids) and Wired differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently).

16

When demands feel like a threat.

Some people, often autistic, feel strong anxiety when asked or expected to do things, even things they want to do. Avoiding the demand can look like refusing, joking, changing the subject or a meltdown. The profile was first described as "pathological demand avoidance," or PDA, by Newson and colleagues (2003).

It isn't in the main diagnostic manuals, and researchers disagree about it. A review by Kildahl and colleagues (2021) found the evidence limited and mostly based on parent reports. Many people who identify with it prefer the phrase "persistent drive for autonomy." Honestly, I'd hold this one loosely until the research settles. What helps tends to be the same whatever it's called. Less pressure. Requests that feel like invitations. "Put your coat on now" gets a flat no from Reuben every morning. "It's cold out. Coat or jumper, your choice?" gets the coat, usually.

17

Not recognising faces isn't rudeness.

Prosopagnosia, or face blindness, means finding it hard to recognise faces, sometimes even close friends seen out of context. It can be something you're born with, and it often runs in families (NHS). Many autistic people also find remembering faces harder, as a review by Weigelt and colleagues (2012) found. People who don't recognise you may be relying on your voice, your hair, your coat or where they usually see you.

Clive walked straight past his neighbour in the supermarket without a flicker, and she went home feeling snubbed and told her sister about it on the phone. When he explained, a week later and very embarrassed, that he hadn't known her without her spaniel, she laughed. Now she says "Hi Clive, it's Jo from number twelve" every time, even when the spaniel is right there.

> WORDS TO TRY
>
> "I'm bad with faces, so please say who you are when you say hi." (to someone else) "Hi, it's Jo from next door."

18

Not speaking isn't the same as having nothing to say.

Some autistic people speak rarely, sometimes or not at all, and some lose speech when stressed. Many communicate through **AAC** (augmentative and alternative communication), which can mean typing, letter boards, picture cards, apps or sign. Using AAC doesn't stop speech developing: a review by Millar, Light and Schlosser (2006) found it did not hold speech back, and may help it. The safest place to start is to presume competence, which means assuming the person understands and has something to say, and giving them the time and the tools to say it.

At Sunday lunch at her nan's, fifteen-year-old Ruby types on her tablet. Her uncle used to talk about her across the table as if she wasn't there ("Does she want gravy?"). Now he asks her, and waits, a bit longer than he'd like, while she types. Her answer was "Yes. Obviously." Wait longer than feels natural, which will feel very long and isn't.

19

Telling friends and dates is your choice.

Whether to tell someone you're autistic or ADHD, and when, is up to you. Telling can bring understanding. In a study by Sasson and Morrison (2019), people formed better first impressions of autistic adults when they knew they were autistic, especially if they knew more about autism.

People don't always respond well, though, and interviews by Au-Yeung and colleagues (2025) describe autistic adults weighing hope for support against fear of not being believed. Many share a little at a time, starting with what helps and leaving the label for later. Second date, outside a bar with a queue. "I'm autistic," Nina said, "so I'm quite direct, and I'd rather walk than sit in there." Her date looked at the bar, then the queue, then back at her. "Oh, thank God," he said. They walked along the canal as far as the lock and back.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
>
> "I'm autistic. For me that means…" "I won't always pick up hints, so please just tell me." (if someone shares with you) "Thanks for telling me. What helps?"

20

Finding your people.

Lots of autistic people describe meeting other autistic people as a turning point, because at last they don't have to translate or explain or mask. The research backs this up. Cooper, Smith and Russell (2017) found that autistic people who felt more connected to other autistic people had higher self-esteem, and through that, less anxiety and depression. Being autistic can be an identity and a community as well as a diagnosis.

After his diagnosis at fifty-three, Bernard joined an online group of autistic adults who love old maps, specifically the Ordnance Survey kind with hand-drawn hachures. The first evening he talked to them for three hours about contour lines. When he logged off he had more energy than when he'd started, which hadn't happened after a conversation in years,

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't change how your brain, or anyone else's, is wired. You can learn how yours works and say what helps, and ask others what helps them. Meeting in the middle means both people move a little. If you're always the one adjusting, it's fair to say so. More in Part One: who you are today (page 29)

MONDAY, 8:30AM

You stop asking. You sit down on the hall floor next to him, which is cold, and say, "Socks feel wrong?" He nods without opening his eyes. You go upstairs, switch the alarm clock off, dig the old seamless pair out of the wash basket Two minutes later his shoes are on. You're ten minutes late and nobody has shouted, which on a Monday is about as good as it gets. That night you order three more pairs and let him pick the colours.

In everyday life

On your own

Knowing how your mind works helps you build a life that fits it, and spot burnout before it's on top of you (see Get to know your wiring,

spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path). Partners can swap "how I work best" notes about plans, messages, touch and time alone. With children, behaviour very often has a sensory or overload reason, so "What's too much right now?" is worth asking before "Why are you doing this?" A friend who cancels at the last minute may just be out of energy, and offering something easier, like a walk, keeps the door open. At work, written agendas, clear deadlines and quiet spaces help far more people than the ones they were made for.

If you have ADHD and share a home, make the chore tools lighter. Log three days instead of seven, with a tally on the fridge. Own a few jobs completely, each with a labelled alarm, instead of helping a bit with everything. Forgetting is a setup problem to fix together. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-9-minds-in-depth).

Common mix-ups

"Everyone's a bit autistic" is probably the commonest, and it makes real needs sound small. Everyone shares some traits, but autism is a whole pattern, present across life. ADHD doesn't just mean not sitting still. Many people with it, girls and women especially, are mostly inattentive or restless on the inside. "They seem fine to me" overlooks how much masking can hide, and seeming fine can cost someone their whole evening. Adjustments aren't special treatment; they remove a barrier, the way glasses do. And the idea that autistic people lack empathy is simply out of date. Many feel other people's feelings very strongly, and the differences in how empathy is shown run both ways.

If you want to help someone else with this

Believe them about what's hard and what helps, even when it's different for you. Be clear, which means saying what you mean, giving times and writing down anything important. Ask what helps, because every neurodivergent person is different and their answer will beat any list, this one included. Protect their energy. Quiet time, warnings before changes and a way out of loud places matter more than they look. And enjoy their interests with them, if you can.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"Is there anything about this place, or this plan, that would make it hard for you?" "You don't have to explain. Just tell me what you need."

When to get more help

If you wonder whether a difference is part of ongoing difficulties at school, work or home, for you or someone you care for, a doctor, school support staff or a psychologist can talk you through an assessment. Waiting lists can be long, so start early and write down what you notice.

Burnout, depression and anxiety are more common among neurodivergent people, often because of the stress of living in a world that doesn't fit. If you're exhausted most days, losing skills you used to have, or feeling hopeless, please talk to a doctor. **If you are having thoughts of hurting yourself,** please tell someone today.

A difference never excuses harm, and it never makes someone deserve harm.

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Communication style quiz (spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz) for a friendly look at how you send and receive words

Reading pages to read on the website

- The wiring card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card): a one-page "how I communicate" card to share
- Wired differently: neurodiversity and communication, including the double empathy problem (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently#double-empathy)
- Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself)
- Research notes: autism (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring), ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#adhd-basics), monotropism

(spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#monotropism), masking (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#masking), sensory profiles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#sensory-profiles) and sensory load (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress)

More for your situation

- **Couples:** Neurodivergent relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- **Parents and grandparents:** When a child has ADHD · Neurodivergent families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships#families)
- **At work:** Neurodiversity at work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work) · Autistic at work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work#autistic-at-work)
- **Teens:** For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- **Sharing a home:** Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)
- **On your own:** Get to know your wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path#wiring) · Part One: who you are today (page 29)
- **More in Part Three:** Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 140) · Loss, grief and big life changes (page 152)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

FOR AUTISTIC READERS. If you are autistic, or wondering, several pieces were written with you in mind. Masking and autistic burnout are covered earlier in this chapter, and When feelings are hard to name (page 35) looks at alexithymia. The double empathy problem explains why misunderstandings run both ways, the wiring card gives you a one-page "how I work best" card to share, and Autistic at work has words for asking for what you need.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words
Getting to know your own wiring page 29

Part Two · Chapter I · Why we get out of tune
Pace, tone and meeting in the middle read online

Part Three · Chapter 14 · Personality, temperament and change
Dials, not boxes page 238

Part Three · Chapter 4 · How communication works
Saying it so it lands for different minds page 99

PUT IT TO USE

Communication style quiz
For a friendly look at how you send and receive words
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

The wiring card
A one-page "how I communicate" card to share
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

10

PART THREE · CHAPTER 10

Values, meaning and a good life: what philosophy offers everyday life

What matters to you, how to find it, what to do when two good things pull against each other, and what a few very old ideas can offer an ordinary, busy week.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Values are directions you keep walking in
2. Your strong feelings point to what you value
3. Two good things can pull in different directions
4. Put your effort where it can land
5. A good life is more than a good mood
6. Meaning comes from ordinary places
7. Different values aren't wrong values
8. Values live in small, everyday acts
9. In everyday life
10. If you want to help someone else with this
11. When to get more help
12. Tools and reading on this site
13. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Values are directions you keep turning towards.** You never finish being kind, and that is why values still work on days when goals fall apart.
- **Strong feelings point to what you value.** Anger often guards fairness, and hurt often guards closeness.
- **Meaning comes from ordinary places.** People, care and everyday work give most of us most of our meaning.
- **Values live in small acts.** One small thing this week, done because it matters, counts.

SUNDAY, 9PM

The week ahead has the MOT on Tuesday, a dentist, two late meetings and your turn for the school run, twice, and none of it feels like yours, somehow. You're not sad, exactly. You just can't remember the last time you did something because it mattered to you, and not because it was next on the list.

This chapter is about values, the things you care about and the direction you want your life to face, and about what makes a life feel worth living. It borrows from psychology, and from philosophy, which has been asking how we ought to live for more than two thousand years. You don't need to have read any of it. I've tried to keep the old names to a minimum and the words plain. If you enjoy that sort of thing, connect two fields of study (spreadloveandacceptance.com/polymath) puts philosophy next to psychology to see what they share, which is my idea of a good rainy afternoon.

01

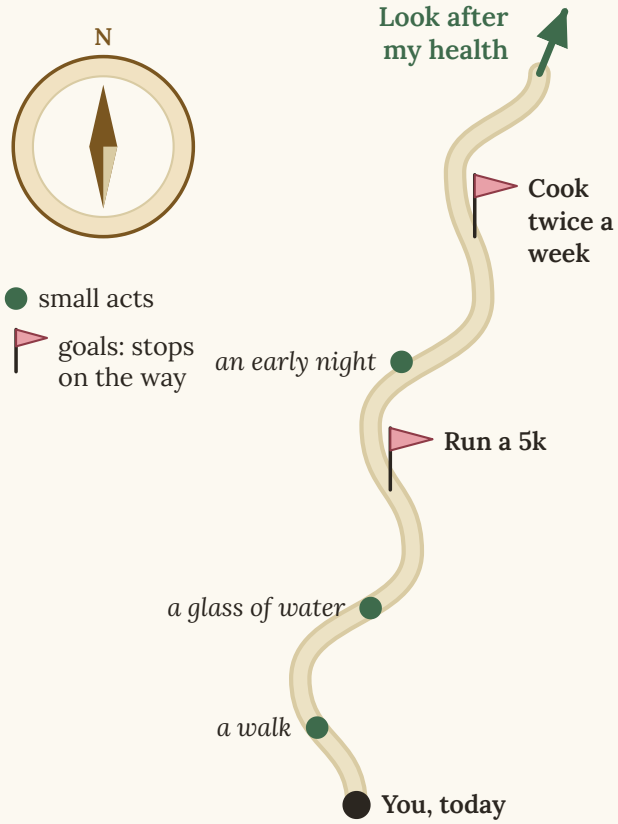
Values are directions you keep walking in.

A goal is something you can tick off, like painting the hall or passing the test. A value is a direction you keep walking in, like looking after your health, or making home feel cared for, or being a fair friend. Nobody ever finishes being kind. That's exactly why a value still works on a day when a goal falls apart.

Bethan was going to go to the gym three times this week. She went once, on the Monday. On Thursday evening she was on the sofa in her gym kit eating a family bag of crisps and feeling like a failure. So she asked herself what the gym was for. Looking after her body, was the answer, and when she asked what that was for, it was so she'd have energy for the kids. On Friday she walked twenty minutes at lunchtime, round the little park behind the office, past the man who feeds the pigeons, and as far as she was concerned it counted.

Values are directions

A goal can be finished. A value is a direction you keep facing.



Missing a goal is a missed stop.
The direction is still there.

Illustration. Acceptance and commitment therapy treats values as "chosen life directions", with goals as milestones.

FIGURE 21 Values are directions, not finish lines. Goals are stops on the way; missing one doesn't change the direction.

02

Your strong feelings point to what you value.

You don't have to invent your values from scratch. They show up in your strongest reactions. Anger often means something you care about has been stepped on. Envy can point to something you want for yourself. Sadness tends to show what you love.

A colleague stood up in the quarterly review and took credit for a whole team's work, and Sacha was so angry he couldn't eat his lunch. He spent the afternoon drafting emails he didn't send. On the train home it dawned on him that it wasn't really about the colleague. It was fairness. Seeing people's effort. That was what had been stepped on. At the next team meeting he raised it as a fairness thing ("Can we agree how we credit joint work?") instead of seething at one person for a month, and it went better than any of the emails would have.

03

Two good things can pull in different directions.

Most hard choices aren't between something good and something bad. They're between two good things, honesty and kindness, say, or family and rest. Feeling torn just means you care about more than one thing. Even when you choose well, it's normal to feel a bit sad about the side you didn't pick.

Biscuit, the family Labrador, was very ill, and Megan's eight-year-old kept asking. Megan cares about being honest, and she also cares about protecting her son. She sat on the kitchen floor next to the dog's bed with him and tried to do both. "Biscuit is very poorly. The vet is helping. We'll look after him together." Her son thought about it for a long time, picking at the edge of the dog blanket. "Is he going to die?" "He might," she said. "We don't know yet." He put his hand on Biscuit's side, very carefully, and left it there.

If you're stuck on a choice, write down the good thing on each side. You may be able to honour some of both, even if you can't have all of either.

04

Put your effort where it can land.

About two thousand years ago a teacher called Epictetus, who had been born into slavery, taught that some things are up to us and some aren't. It's one of the oldest ideas in this book and still one of the most useful. Your own choices and how you treat people are up to you. Other people's choices, and the weather, and the past, are not. Worry tends to pile up in the second heap. Values do their work in the first.

Ingrid wants her partner to enjoy Christmas at her mum's, and she can't make him. She has tried, for six years, mainly by telling him it'll be fun. What she can do is plan a shorter visit, put a long muddy walk on Boxing Day into it, which he'll like, and be warm herself. That's her part, and it turns out to be quite a lot.

05

A good life is more than a good mood.

Feeling good matters. But many thinkers, from the Greek philosopher Aristotle to psychologists now, also describe a second kind of wellbeing. It comes from growing, using your strengths, being a decent friend, and doing things that matter even when they're hard. Aristotle called it flourishing, and he thought you build it the way you build any skill, by practice, a little at a time.

Jade spent a whole month of evenings helping a friend move out of a damp, miserable flat. She scrubbed black mould off a bathroom ceiling with a toothbrush. She carried boxes down three flights of stairs while the friend cried on the landing. It was tiring and not much fun, and at the end of the year, when she thinks back over it, she counts it as one of the best months she had.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

If you enjoy big questions, put philosophy next to psychology and see what they share. It's one of my favourite rainy-day pastimes.

TOOL **Learn by doing: connect two fields of study** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/polymath

06

Meaning comes from ordinary places.

Researchers who study meaning often describe three parts to it: your life makes some sense to you, you're heading somewhere, and your life matters to someone. Most meaning comes from people, from work done with care and from small roles other people count on, far more than from big moments.

Walter has lived alone since his wife died, and for a long time his days went very quiet. Now he reads to the under-fives at the library on Wednesday mornings. He irons a shirt for it on Tuesday nights. He does the voices, badly. When he had a cold in February and missed two weeks, a four-year-old called Albie asked the librarian every single day where the man was.

Three meanings of meaning

The three parts above come from Martela and Steger, who split meaning into coherence (life makes sense), purpose (a direction) and significance (your life matters). It's a way of thinking that has shaped later research rather than a finding in itself.

Martela and Steger (2016) · *Theory: a conceptual paper that has shaped later measurement*

Try listing the roles you play, big or small (neighbour, sister, the one who waters the office plants), and next to each one write who it matters to.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 15

Keep your little rituals alive

Lachlan and Sunita, who lead a hybrid team of nine together

Keep your little rituals alive

Person A
Lachlan

Person B
Sunita

Date
2 October 2026

Part A: Our rituals, big and small

Ritual or habit	How often	How it's doing	What it gives us, or what got in the way
Monday coffee call, cameras optional	*Weekly*	*Fading*	*Half the team stopped coming when it moved to 8:30*
Friday "one good thing" round in the team chat	*Weekly*	*Alive*	*Five minutes; people notice each other's work*
A card and lunch when someone leaves	*Now and then*	*Alive*	*People leave feeling thanked*
Office day with lunch together	*Monthly*	*Stopped*	*Stopped when the office moved; the three who work from home felt like guests*
Hello and goodbye in the chat, start and end of day	*Daily*	*New idea*	*So nobody wonders who's around*

PART B: WHERE YOUR RITUALS STAND

Your rituals
5 rituals listed. Alive: 2 · Fading: 1 · Stopped: 1 · New idea: 1.

Fading or stopped
Monday coffee call, cameras optional, Office day with lunch together.

New ideas
Hello and goodbye in the chat, start and end of day.

Rituals lapse for ordinary reasons: a new job, a baby, a move, an illness, a hard year. A stopped one isn't a failure. Pick one to restart below, or let it go on purpose.

Part C: One to restart, or start

The ritual
Monday coffee call

The smallest version that still counts
Ten minutes at 9:15, no work talk, cameras optional

The first time: when, and who will suggest it
Next Monday; Sunita sends the invite

What would make it easy to skip, and how we'll protect it (optional)
A busy week. We keep it then too, just shorter.

Part D (optional): One to let go, with thanks

The ritual
Office day with lunch together

What it gave us
A day all together, back when we all lived near the office

Made-up example. The sheet is written for couples and families, and it works for a team: the rituals are what make a group feel like one.

Fill in your own: Keep your little rituals alive (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-15)

07

Different values aren't wrong values.

Two people can share a home, a family or a team and still put the same good things in a different order, one putting safety first and another adventure. The philosopher Isaiah Berlin argued that there are many real goods in life and they can't all be ranked on one scale, which leaves room to disagree without either person being bad.

Jasper likes a calm, tidy house. His housemate Darnell likes an open door and people dropping in. For months each of them privately thought the other was a bit much, uptight in one direction, messy in the other. It came out one night over a takeaway. "I just like knowing who's going to be in the kitchen," Jasper said. Darnell said, "I just like it when *anyone* is." Fridays are open house now, and Sundays are quiet, or as quiet as Darnell can manage.

In your next disagreement, you might ask, "What matters to you about this?", and listen for the value under the position.

08

Values live in small, everyday acts.

A good life is built mostly from small things done again and again. How you say hello. Whether you keep small promises. How you talk about someone who isn't in the room. The Chinese teacher Confucius taught that small, everyday courtesies shape who we become, and later thinkers who wrote about care said that being good starts with paying attention to the person in front of you.

An older man at the self-checkout can't get the card machine to take his card. The queue behind him is growing and somebody near the back tuts, loudly. You're next, and you don't sigh. You say, "No rush." He says, "It's always this one, isn't it," and you agree that it is. The whole thing costs you about forty seconds.

Kindness does something for the giver

A meta-analysis of 27 experiments found that acts of kindness gave the person doing them a small-to-medium lift in wellbeing. The authors flagged worries about study quality, so take the size with a pinch of salt and the direction with rather less.

Curry and colleagues (2018) · *Moderate: the authors noted concerns about study quality and possible publication bias*

Pick one value, choose one tiny act that shows it, and do it every day this week. You'll drift, as everyone does, and turning back is the practice.



SUGARFOOT

A value can be as small as a cup of tea made just the way someone likes it. A "What feels like care" card helps you learn what that is for each of you.

TOOL **How you connect: what feels like care** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can choose your direction. When you notice you've drifted, you can turn back without shame. You can't choose other people's values for them, and you don't have to adopt theirs to love them. You can share what matters to you, listen to what matters to them, and look for the places where your directions overlap.

SUNDAY, 9:20PM

On the back of an envelope you write people, health and making things, and under each one, a small thing for this week. Ring Gran, walk on Wednesday, finish the shelf in the spare room, the one that has been "nearly done" since Easter. The week is just as full as it was. You prop the envelope against the kettle, where it'll be the first thing you see.

In everyday life

Partners may rank the same values differently, security and adventure, say, and it helps to say what each of you is protecting before you argue about the plan. Two generations of a family can both value family and mean very different things by it, from living round the corner to being free to go, so it's worth asking what the word means to each of you. When a job keeps asking you to act against a value, the strain often shows up as tiredness or cynicism, and naming the clash is a first step. A club, a faith group or some volunteering can give you a place to act on a value alongside other people.

If you want to help someone else with this

"What matters most to you about this?" helps more than telling someone what they ought to care about. People often see their values for the first time in someone else's words, so it can help to notice them out loud. "You stayed late to help your friend. Loyalty really matters to you, doesn't it?" With children, naming the value when you see it teaches more than any lecture. Try not to use values as a weapon, because "I thought you valued family" lands as a guilt trip. You can disagree with someone's choice and still see the good thing they were reaching for.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "What would a good outcome look like to you?" "What do you want to be able to say about how you handled this, a year from now?"

When to get more help

Feeling a bit lost or flat for a while is part of being human. But some signs mean it's worth talking to someone trained:

- Life has felt empty or pointless for more than two weeks, and things you used to enjoy don't reach you. That can be depression, which is common and treatable. A doctor or counsellor is a good first step.
- You have thoughts of not wanting to be alive. Please talk to someone today.
- Someone in your life is pushing you to give up what matters to you, cutting you off from friends, or making you afraid to disagree. That's about control. It has nothing to do with values.

Some therapies, such as acceptance and commitment therapy (ACT), work directly with values. A counsellor can help you find yours when everything feels foggy.

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Your self-discovery path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path), step by step, and Professor Puddles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask), the site's chat host, if you want to think out loud.

Reading pages to read on the website

- Part One, Next: start with what matters (page 44), a short values step from the self-discovery part of the book.
- Library: values, what matters most (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/motivation) and self-determination theory (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/motivation#self-determination-theory).
- Library: why new things stop feeling new (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life) and comparing yourself to others (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life#social-comparison).
- Stories from philosophy: What is up to us (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth), Three kinds of friendship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth#friendship) and The circles of Hierocles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth#circles).

A limit to keep in mind: This chapter shares ideas to think with, not answers to follow. Your values are yours to find, and it's fine if they change as your life does.

More for your situation

- **On your own after a big change:** On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own) · Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest) · A new chapter after loss (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- **Couples with different priorities**: Money together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together)
- **Families with different beliefs:** Two faiths, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths) · Coming out as an adult (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out)

- **Friends and work:** Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- **Teens working out who they are:** For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) · Growing up (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up)
- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part One · Next · Who you are becoming
Turning values into one small goal — page 44

Part Two · Chapter IV · Two kinds of fair
Two kinds of fair — read online

Part Three · Chapter 17 · Groups, influence and culture
Whose values a group rewards — page 279

Part Three · Chapter 7 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion
Worth that is not a score — page 140

PUT IT TO USE

Your self-discovery path
Step by step, and Professor Puddles, the site's chat host, if you want to think out loud
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

Part One, Next: start with what matters
A short values step from the self-discovery part of the book
spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next

11

PART THREE · CHAPTER 11

Healing after hurt: repair, forgiveness, and when to get help

How hurt heals, why it lingers, how small breaks get mended, what a real apology sounds like, what forgiveness is and isn't, and when it's time to get more help.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Hurt is real, and healing takes time
2. Every close relationship has breaks. Repair is what counts
3. Telling someone they hurt you
4. A real apology names it, owns it, and mends it
5. Forgiveness isn't forgetting, excusing or going back
6. You can heal even if they never say sorry
7. Trust comes back in small, kept promises
8. Going back is a choice. Safety comes first
9. Look after the hurt part of you
10. In everyday life
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Hurt is real, and healing takes time.** Replaying a hurt says more about how much it mattered than about any weakness in you.
- **Repair is what counts.** Every close relationship has breaks, and a real apology names what happened, owns it and offers to mend it.
- **Forgiving and going back are separate choices.** You can forgive without forgetting, excusing or letting someone back in.
- **Safety comes first.** You can heal even if they never say sorry, and you never owe anyone a risk to your safety.

THURSDAY, 2AM

It was one sentence, three weeks ago, said over your shoulder in somebody's kitchen at a party on the way to the fridge, and they have almost certainly forgotten it.

You haven't. It plays again, word for word, tone and all, followed by every clever thing you could have said back and didn't. You're very tired of carrying it about, and you honestly don't know where you'd put it down if you could.

Everyone gets hurt, and everyone hurts other people, mostly without meaning to. This chapter looks at how hurt works and how relationships mend, and at how you can heal with or without the other person, for small hurts and bigger ones.

01

Hurt is real, and healing takes time.

Being hurt by someone shows that something mattered, whether it was the person, or your trust in them, or your sense of being respected. The mind replays hurts because it's trying to understand them and keep you safe from the next one. Healing rarely goes in a straight line. The hurt can come back on an anniversary, or out of nowhere, which doesn't mean you've failed.

Months after a friend said something cruel to him at a party, Kwesi still feels a jolt whenever the song that was playing comes on the radio. It happened again on Sunday, chopping onions. He said, out loud, to nobody, "Oh, that," turned the radio down, and carried on with the onions.

What a hurt is about

When Leary and colleagues asked people about times their feelings were hurt, the common thread was feeling less valued by someone, usually someone they knew well. A stranger's remark stings for an afternoon. A friend's can stay for months.

Leary and colleagues (1998) · *Moderate: based on people's recollections; the idea is widely supported*

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY

"This hurts because it mattered." "A feeling coming back doesn't mean I'm back at the start."

02

Every close relationship has breaks. Repair is what counts.

No relationship is smooth all the time, because people snap, forget, misread each other and let each other down. Research on parents and babies, on couples and on therapy all points the same way. Breaks are normal, and what matters most is whether they get mended. A small repair, made soon, often leaves a relationship feeling safer than before the break.

Orange juice, a full glass, right across the breakfast table and into the toast rack. Toby's dad shouted, not a huge shout, but enough. Twenty minutes later he sat down next to him on the sofa. "I was grumpy and I shouted. That wasn't fair, spills happen. Want to help me make a new one?" They went and did it together. Toby poured, very slowly, with his tongue out, and slopped some, and they both pretended he hadn't.

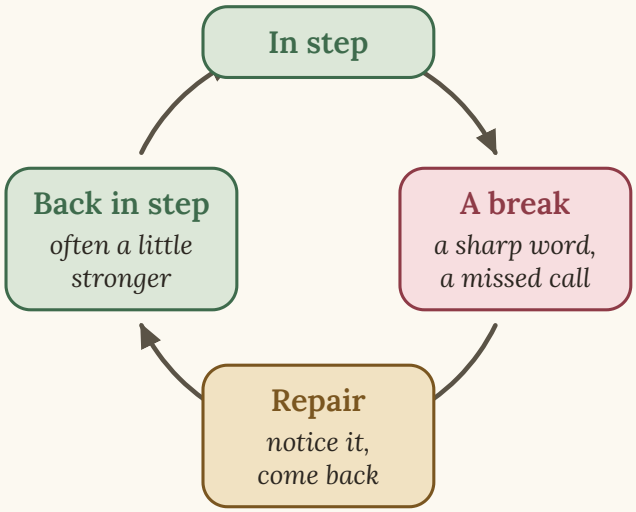
Even therapy has ruptures

Across 11 studies, repairing breaks in the relationship between therapist and client went with better results. Training therapists in repair didn't show a clear effect on outcomes in the six studies that tested it, which is a useful bit of honesty.

Eubanks, Muran and Safran (2018) · *Strong: a meta-analysis, though the main finding is correlational*

Every close relationship has breaks

What counts is coming back.



A real apology

Name it	Own it	Mend it
say what you did	*no "but"*	*now and next time*

Trust comes back in small, kept promises.

Everyday breaks and repairs show up in parent and baby play (Tronick), in couples (Gottman's "repair attempts") and in therapy (Eubanks and colleagues, 2018).

FIGURE 22 Every close relationship has breaks; what counts is the repair. A real apology names it, owns it and mends it.

03

Telling someone they hurt you.

People can't mend what they don't know about. Saying "that hurt" is a risk, but it gives the relationship a chance. It works best when you describe what happened and how it felt, and leave out what kind of person they are. Pick a calm moment, well away from the middle of a row.

Amara had a stronger word ready, one she'd been working on for days. On a walk with her friend, not over the phone, she said this instead. "When you told the group about my breakup before I was ready, I felt exposed. I'd like to be the one who shares my news." Her friend, who had honestly thought she was helping, went bright red. There was a long, awful pause next to a bench with a brass plaque on it for somebody called Maud. Then the friend said, "God. Yes. Sorry," and they walked on. It was a bit stiff for the rest of the walk and fine by the following week.

Before you say it, try writing it down in three short lines, one for what happened, one for how you felt and one for what you'd like.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 16

Write it through

Carys, writing to her brother Owen

Write it, wait, then send

Who is it to?

Partner · Co-parent or ex · *Family* · Friend · Housemate · Coworker · More than one person · Someone else

Their name (optional)

Owen

Your name (optional)

Carys

What kind of message?

Raise something · Reply to something · Make a plan · Say sorry · I need a pause

What happened (facts only, one thing)

At Dad's 70th on Saturday, you said to everyone at the table that I don't visit. I visited three times in September.

How it landed for me

tired · rushed · frustrated · unseen · taken for granted · overwhelmed · stretched thin · worried · *hurt* · disappointed · left out · alone with it · confused · *embarrassed* · annoyed · sad · on edge · hopeful · grateful

What I'm asking for (one clear ask)

Could we talk on the phone this week about how we share the visits?

What I'm NOT saying (optional, but it helps)

I'm not angry with you as a person.

When I'd like a reply

Today · Tomorrow · *By the weekend* · No rush

A GENTLE CHECK

House rules: ✓ One topic · ✓ Facts, not verdicts · ✓ No always or never · ✓ No sarcasm or ALL CAPS · ✓ No "you" accusations · ✓ Says what you're asking for · ✓ A reply-by time

No sharp words found. It reads as calm and clear.

Made-up example. Then the tool asks her to wait before she sends it.

Fill in your own: Write it through (spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through)

04

A real apology names it, owns it, and mends it.

"Sorry if you were upset" doesn't heal much. A real apology says what you did, takes responsibility without excuses, shows you understand what it did to the other person, and offers to put it right or do things differently. Research, such as a study led by Roy Lewicki (2016), suggests owning it and offering repair are the parts that matter most.

At the Tuesday meeting, Leila presented an idea she'd worked out with a colleague as if it were all hers. She saw his face. She spent the evening telling herself it didn't matter, then the next morning went and found him at the coffee machine. "I presented our idea as mine. That wasn't fair to you. I'll

email the team today and say it was joint work." He said, "Okay," and then, after a moment, "Thanks." She sent the email at 9.40 and copied him in.

Next time you say sorry, check it has all four parts. If it went wrong in a conversation, Rewind the talk (spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder) helps you find the words, and Apology languages (spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages) has more.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

An apology lands best when it's plain: what happened, that it was yours, and what you'll do now. Rewind the talk can help you find those words.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

05

Forgiveness isn't forgetting, excusing or going back.

Forgiveness is usually described as letting go of resentment and the wish to get even, and it happens inside you. Forgiving someone doesn't mean saying what happened was okay. It doesn't mean forgetting, or trusting them again, or keeping them in your life. It's a choice, often a slow one, and you never owe it on anyone else's timetable.

Danielle forgave her father for missing most of her childhood, though it took her well into her thirties. She keeps his visits to an hour and won't leave the children with him if he's been drinking. He knows why. They don't discuss it. For her the forgiving and the protecting sit side by side without much strain.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"I can let go of wanting to get even, and still keep my limits." "I don't have to forgive today. I can just stop feeding the anger today."

06

You can heal even if they never say sorry.

Waiting for an apology that never comes can keep you stuck for years, because the person may be gone, or unwilling, or unable to understand. Your healing doesn't have to depend on them. You can make sense of what happened, tell your story to someone safe, and decide what it means for you now.

After the breakup, Martha wrote a letter she never sent. Four pages in biro, both sides, about what hurt and what she'd hoped for and what she was taking with her, which was mostly the good saucepans. She folded it into the back of a notebook and for a while she read it most nights, then less, and then one day in April she realised she hadn't looked at it for a month.

Writing helps, a bit

Pooling 146 randomised studies, Frattaroli found that writing about something painful had a small but real benefit on average. Small is the honest word, and it varies a good deal from person to person.

Frattaroli (2006) · *Moderate: a real but small effect that varies by person*

Writing works for a lot of people. Write about the hurt for fifteen minutes on three or four days in a row, the facts and the feelings both. If it ever makes you feel much worse, stop and talk to someone instead.

07

Trust comes back in small, kept promises.

After trust is broken, one big apology rarely rebuilds it. Trust grows back slowly, in lots of small moments where someone does what they said they'd do. If you broke trust, being patient and consistent matters more than a grand gesture. If you were let down, it's fair to watch what someone does as well as what they say.

Declan hid a credit card debt from his partner for most of a year. When it came out it was very bad for a while. After that, on the first of every month, he left his bank statement on the kitchen table without being asked, with no speech, just the statement left by the fruit bowl. About a year in, one ordinary evening, his partner said she could breathe again. He went into the garden so she wouldn't see his face.

08

Going back is a choice. Safety comes first.

After a hurt, you can mend the relationship or change its shape. You can also step away. All three can be healthy. If someone keeps hurting you after you've told them, if you feel afraid of them, or if they control, threaten or put you down, the work is to protect yourself, not to repair. Counselling together isn't advised when someone is afraid of their partner.

Ellie's housemate borrowed money twice and didn't pay it back. Ellie let the first time go, because it was only a tenner and she'd been skint herself. The second time it was forty pounds for a train ticket to Leeds, and she said, "I won't lend money again. I still want us to get on in the house." The housemate sulked for two days and left a slightly pointed note about the recycling. They still do Sunday roast together most weeks, and nobody mentions Leeds.

Three questions can guide what comes next: is it safe, has the hurt stopped, and do you want this relationship in your life?

09

Look after the hurt part of you.

Hurt lives in the body as well as the mind, as poor sleep or a jumpy feeling that won't settle. Healing goes better with basic care, which means rest and food and moving about, people who are kind to you, and talking to yourself the way you'd talk to a hurting friend. Some people find they grow after something painful and some don't, and neither is a test you can fail.

A man on the top deck of the 38 shouted at Idris and called him names, the whole way from Angel to Dalston, and nobody else said a word. For days afterwards Idris felt shaky. He told a friend. He went for long walks after work. He kept reminding himself it was about the man, and that he was safe now. Over a couple of weeks the shakiness faded, though he sat downstairs on the 38 until well into the spring.

Pick one small act of care for today, an early night or a call to someone kind. Calm tools are in Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can say what hurt, apologise for what you did, and look after your own healing. You can't make someone apologise or change, and you don't have to wait for them to start feeling better. Forgiveness, trust and going back are all yours to choose, in your own time.

SATURDAY, 11AM

You wrote it all down last night, every word of it, two pages. This morning you wrote a much shorter version. When you said that, I felt small. I just wanted you to know.

You haven't sent it. It's sitting in your drafts between a half-finished email to the council about the bins and a shopping list that just says "eggs??". But the two o'clock replays have gone a bit quieter since it went onto paper.

In everyday life

Between partners, small breaks happen most days, and a quick "That came out wrong, can I try again?" mends most of them (see How to apologise so it counts). Old family hurts often need a different kind of talk from new ones, and sometimes more time apart. A friend may not know they hurt you, and "Can I tell you something that stung? I'd rather say it than drift" keeps the door open. You can even heal a hurt with someone who has died, by writing to them or talking it through with someone you trust.

- **After an affair.** The shock is real for both people. Couples can recover, and some decide to part; both can be done with care. Trust returns through kept promises over months, and a couples therapist can help. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-11-healing-in-depth).
- **If you decide to separate.** Part as kindly as you can. Tell children together, without blame, and never ask them to choose. Write decisions down, and consider family mediation where it's safe. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-11-healing-in-depth#separating).

If you want to help someone else with this

Listen before you advise. "That sounds really painful" helps far more than "You should just let it go." Don't rush them towards forgiveness, which can

feel like being told their hurt doesn't matter. Don't push them to cut someone off, either; it's their relationship and their choice, unless they're in danger. If you were the one who caused the hurt, give a real apology and then give them time, and don't ask them to make you feel better about it.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "Do you want to talk it through, or would it help more to take your mind off it?" "Whatever you decide about them, I'm on your side."

When to get more help

Some hurts are too heavy to carry alone, and getting help takes some strength. Think about talking to a doctor, counsellor or therapist if:

- More than a month after something frightening, you still have flashbacks, nightmares, feel constantly on edge, or avoid places and people that remind you of it. These can be signs of trauma, and there are well-tested treatments for it, such as trauma-focused talking therapies.
- The hurt is taking over: you can't sleep, work or enjoy anything, or you're drinking or using more to cope.
- The hurt came from abuse or violence, now or in the past.
- You're having thoughts of hurting yourself or someone else. Please reach out today.

If you and someone else both want to mend things, a couples or family counsellor can help, as long as nobody is afraid of the other.

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Upset right now? for calming down in the moment, and the Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks) for checking your state.

Reading pages to read on the website

- Apology languages: how to say sorry so it lands, and asking for forgiveness (spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages#forgive).
- Library: forgiveness (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/conflict), what research says about apologies (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/conflict#apology-research) and repair attempts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships).
- Library: rumination (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), expressive writing (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#expressive-writing) and self-compassion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection).
- Stories from philosophy: the Second Arrow (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth).

More for your situation

- **Families:** Adult siblings and family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · For grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children)
- **After a breakup:** On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own) · Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting)
- **Friends:** When a friendship drifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- **Children who have been hurt:** Foster, adoptive and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship)
- **After a loss:** Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

A limit to keep in mind: This chapter is for everyday hurts and for thinking about bigger ones. It isn't therapy, and it isn't a reason to stay somewhere unsafe. If you're afraid of someone, the most healing step is getting safe.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part Two · Chapter IV · Two kinds of fair
Covering kindly and saying it out loud
read online

Part Three · Chapter 4 · How communication works
Repair in everyday talk
page 99

Part Three · Chapter 13 · Anger
When anger did the damage
page 223

Part Three · Chapter 7 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion
Guilt without shame
page 140

PUT IT TO USE

Upset right now?
For calming down in the moment, and the Nervous System Ladder for checking your state
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Apology languages
How to say sorry so it lands, and asking for forgiveness
spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages

12

PART THREE · CHAPTER 12

Helping others well: support without fixing, boundaries, and not burning out

How to help someone without taking over, by asking what they need, listening first, caring without drowning and keeping kind limits, with what to do in a crisis and how to keep going without burning out.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Ask what kind of help they want
2. Listening is a kind of help
3. Fixing it for them can take away their power
4. Care without drowning in their feelings
5. Your limits make your help last
6. Notice when you're running on empty
7. In a crisis, stay with them and bring in help
8. Don't wait for someone else to step in
9. Let other people help you too
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Ask what kind of help they want.** "Ideas, or just someone to listen?" saves a lot of misfires.
- **Listening is help.** Fixing a problem for someone can take away their power.
- **Your limits make your help last**, and caring from a steady place helps more than drowning in their feelings.

- **In a crisis, stay and bring in help.** It's okay to ask directly about suicide, and to call for help.

WEDNESDAY, 7:15PM

Your friend is telling you about her awful week. Before she's finished her first sentence you have five good ideas. You give her all five, in order, with reasons.

"Yeah," she says. "Maybe."

You both hang up feeling slightly worse, and neither of you could tell you why.

Most of us want to help the people around us, and helping well is a skill, because good intentions don't always land. This chapter looks at how support works, why fixing can backfire, and how to care for people in a way you can keep up. Two tools elsewhere grew out of it. One owner per job (Part Two, Chapter II, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2), because carers burn out when everything counts as "just helping" and nobody else owns a job. And How much are you carrying? (Part Two, Chapter III, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3), which helps you notice you're running on empty before you snap or stop.

01

Ask what kind of help they want.

Help comes in kinds. Some people want ideas. Some want someone to listen. Some want a practical hand, a meal or a lift, and some just want company on the sofa, and giving the wrong kind, however kindly, can leave someone feeling unheard.

That phone call could have gone differently. "That sounds like a rotten week. Do you want ideas, or do you just want to have a rant?" It feels a bit formal the first few times you say it, like reading off a card, but people tend to love being asked.

Ask what kind of help they want

The wrong kind of help can feel like not being heard.

"Ideas, or just someone to listen?"

Listening
comfort, company

Practical
a lift, a meal

Ideas
advice, if asked

Making sense
thinking it through

- Fixing it for them can take away their power.
- Care from a steady place. Your limits make your help last.
- In a crisis, stay with them and bring in help.

Kinds of support after House (1981). Support helps most when it fits what the person needs (Cutrona and Russell, 1990), though the evidence for exact matching is mixed.

FIGURE 23 Ask what kind of help they want. Fixing it for them can take away their power, and your limits make your help last.

02

Listening is a kind of help.

Being properly heard helps people calm down and think, and quite often they find their own answer. Good listening means paying attention, letting them finish, checking you understood, and showing that their feelings make sense even if you'd feel differently.

Ravi came home furious about his boss. His partner had "Just quit" ready on her tongue and kept it there. "So he had a go at you in front of everyone," she said, "after you'd stayed late all week. No wonder you're livid." Ravi's shoulders came down about two inches. Ten minutes later he was sketching out a plan on the back of a takeaway menu. It was a better plan than "just quit", which he'd have hated being told anyway.

Matching the help to the problem

Cutrona and Russell proposed that support works best when it fits the problem: practical help for things that can be changed, comfort for things that can't. Later studies back this in part.

Cutrona and Russell (1990) · *Moderate: widely cited; later studies support it in part*

In one conversation today, listen for two whole minutes without giving advice, then sum up what you heard. Two minutes is longer than you think.



SUGARFOOT

Sometimes the best help is sitting close and listening, with no fixing. Listening takes energy too, so check your own tank now and then.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02

03

Fixing it for them can take away their power.

When we love someone we want the problem gone. But doing things for people that they could do themselves can leave them feeling less capable, so helping well often means helping someone do it themselves. It's their life, and their choice.

Rosalind's son is twenty-four and struggling with a job application for the council, and she is itching to rewrite it. She can see three things wrong with the first paragraph alone. She sits on her hands. "Would you like me to read it and say what stands out?" He makes the changes himself, some of them, not

the ones she'd have made. When he gets the interview he's quietly, enormously proud, and so is she, and she doesn't mention the paragraph.

04

Care without drowning in their feelings.

Feeling someone's pain as if it were yours can wear you out fast. Researchers separate this "empathic distress" from compassion, which is warm concern from a steadier place, still caring deeply without sinking alongside the other person. A steady helper is more use than a second person drowning.

When Abi's housemate went through a breakup, Abi cried with her every night, stopped sleeping, and was a wreck by the end of the first week. So she changed tack. Still kind, still there. But a run in the mornings, and Friday evening with her own friends, and a quiet reminder to herself, roughly hourly, that this was her housemate's pain to feel and hers to keep company with.

05

Your limits make your help last.

Saying yes to everything leads, eventually, to resentment, exhaustion and not being able to help at all. Limits tell people what you can actually give, so your yes means something. And a kind no that comes with an offer of what you can do is still help.

Kojo's sister keeps asking to borrow money, fifty here and eighty there, and none of it comes back. He loves her and he's running out, of money and of something else. On the phone one evening, with the telly on mute, he says it. "I can't lend money any more. I can help you go through your bills on Sunday, if you want." There's a silence long enough for him to hear her kettle click off. "Fine," she says, not fine. On Sunday she turns up with a carrier bag full of envelopes.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> "I can't do that, but I can do this." "I want to help, and I need to stop at nine tonight."

If you need words for a "not this time", Say no kindly (spreadloveandacceptance.com/refusals) helps you make your own, with something to offer instead.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Your limits keep your help going for longer. When you need to say "not this time", Say no kindly helps you find the words, with something to offer instead.

TOOL **Say no kindly: make your scripts** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/refusals

06

Notice when you're running on empty.

People who help a lot can burn out: carers, parents, nurses, teachers, the friend everyone rings. The signs include feeling exhausted most of the time, or numb and cynical about the people you help, or dreading the next call, and any of them means you need some help too.

Gwen has looked after her husband since his stroke two years ago. Last month she snapped at him over the remote control, properly snapped, and felt terrible for the rest of the day. She mentioned it to her doctor almost in passing, on the way out of an appointment about her knee. The doctor sat her back down. "That sounds like carer strain." There's a carers' group on Tuesday mornings now and a few hours of respite a week. She has, she says, about a third of herself back.

Rate your energy from 1 to 10 each evening for a week. If it's often 3 or lower, ask someone for one specific kind of help. See Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers).

07

In a crisis, stay with them and bring in help.

If someone tells you they're thinking of ending their life, or you're worried they might be, it's okay to ask them directly. Research, such as a review led by Dazzi and colleagues (2014), suggests asking about suicide doesn't put the idea in someone's head; it can bring relief. You don't have to be their therapist. Your job is to listen, stay with them, and help them reach trained support.

For example (a coworker): A colleague says, "Sometimes I think everyone would be better off without me." Kirsty says gently: "I'm really glad you told

me. Are you thinking about ending your life?" She says she's had thoughts. Kirsty stays with her.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "Are you thinking about suicide?" "I'm glad you told me. You don't have to go through this alone. Let's call someone together."

08

Don't wait for someone else to step in.

When lots of people see something going wrong, each one can assume someone else will deal with it. Psychologists call this the bystander effect, and knowing about it helps you break it. Small, safe actions count. "Are you okay?" Fetching a member of staff.

On a train out of Sheffield, a man was making a young woman uncomfortable, leaning in and asking where she was getting off. Yvonne didn't confront him. She sat down in the seat next to the woman and said brightly, "Hiya! Is this the train to Leeds?" The woman grabbed the conversation with both hands. They talked about Leeds, which neither of them knew much about, until the next stop, when the man got up and moved down the carriage.

It helps to decide in advance what your safe move would be, distracting or getting help or checking in afterwards. People with a plan act. People without one tend to freeze.

09

Let other people help you too.

Helping goes both ways, and people who are good at giving help are often hopeless at receiving it. Letting someone help is a gift to them as well, because most people like being useful to someone they care about. And relationships where only one person ever helps start to feel lopsided.

After the baby came, Nkechi said "We're fine, thanks" to every single offer, including several when she very much wasn't. When she finally said yes to the woman next door, who had offered a lasagne four times, the neighbour was so pleased she nearly dropped it. They walk their buggies round the park together on Thursday mornings now. Say yes to the next small offer of help you get, even if you could manage.

People say yes more than we think

In a set of experiments and field studies, people asking for help underestimated, by as much as half, how many others would agree, mainly because they forgot how awkward it is to say no. It has been repeated many times since.

Flynn and Lake (2008) · *Strong: several experiments and field studies, widely replicated*

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"Yes, thank you. That would really help." "Could you do one thing for me this week?"

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 17

One owner per job: sharing the care

Margaret and Alan, with their daughter Sue

One owner per job: sharing the care

Person A
Margaret

Person B
Alan

Person C
Sue

Date of this list
6 October 2026

Who owns each job

Job	How often	Roughly how long?	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Medicines and the pill box (as the care team directs)	*Weekly*	0.5	*Margaret*	*Sue*	*Sue checks it on Sundays*
Book and go along to medical appointments	*As needed*	3	*Sue*	*Margaret*	*Sue drives; Mum comes too*

Job	How often	Roughly how long?	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Insurance and paperwork	*Monthly*	1	*Alan*	*Sue*	*Dad can do this from his chair*
Night care and night-time calls	*Daily*	1	*Margaret*		*Ask the nurse about a night sitter*
Sunday call with the family	*Weekly*	0.5	*Alan*		
Book respite: a break for the main carer	*Monthly*	0.5	*Sue*		*Mum's Thursday afternoon off*
Groceries and meals	*Weekly*	2	*Sue*	*Margaret*	*Online shop, Sue orders*

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

Jobs with an owner
7 of 7. Every job has an owner.

Who's carrying more right now
Margaret 63% · Alan 9% · Sue 28%. Does this match what you agreed? If it doesn't match, ask which job could move first. It's a starting point for a talk, not a scorecard.

Changes to the list

Date	What changed	Who
6 Oct 2026	*Sue takes Tuesday nights from next week, so Margaret gets one full night's sleep.*	*Margaret, Alan and Sue*

Made-up example. This is about who owns each job, not medical advice.

Fill in your own: One owner per job (sharing the care)
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can offer help and listen well, and be honest about your limits. You can't make someone accept help or get better on your timetable. Their life and their choices are theirs. If someone is in danger, your part is to bring in help, not to carry it alone.

THE NEXT WEDNESDAY, 7:15PM

She rings again. This time, before she gets going, you ask. "Ideas, or just a moan?"

She laughs. "Moan."

So you listen, through her manager, and her landlord, and the cat's vet bill (£212, for a sock). At the end she says she thinks she knows what she's going to do. You realise you haven't offered a single idea, and you had at least four.

In everyday life

Helping yourself counts too, and you can ask yourself the same question, ideas or rest. Caring for a parent, or a child with extra needs, is long-haul help, so share the load early (see Caring for someone you love). The friend everyone rings needs someone to ring too. Covering for a struggling coworker is kind for a week, and after that it needs a proper conversation with the team. In an emergency, point to one person ("You in the blue coat, please call for help"), because a crowd tends to wait. If you have ADHD, helping can feel interesting and urgent, so a fast yes comes easily, and "I'd like to help. Let me check my week and come back to you tonight" buys you time. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-12-helping-in-depth).

Common mix-ups

People think helping means solving the problem. Often it means listening, or being there, or helping someone find their own answer. People think good helpers never say no, when it's knowing their limits that lets good helpers

last. Some people worry that asking about suicide might give someone the idea. Research suggests it doesn't, and asking can help someone open up. And "I'll make it worse if I step in" stops a lot of people. There are small, safe ways to help, and doing nothing often feels worse to the person in trouble.

If you want to help someone else with this

The helpers around you need looking after too. Notice them, the carer, the friend everyone rings, the coworker who always covers, and ask how they are as if you mean it. Offer something specific, because "Can I take the kids on Saturday morning?" is far easier to accept than "Let me know if you need anything." Give them permission to rest ("You're allowed a night off. I've got this"). And if a helper seems burned out, share Caring for someone you love or suggest they talk to a doctor. Sometimes it's as simple as asking them, "You look after everyone. Who looks after you?"

When to get more help

- **If you're burned out as a helper or carer,** talk to your doctor, a carers' organisation or a counsellor. Respite and support are not luxuries.
- **If helping someone is becoming unsafe for you,** step back and bring in professionals. You can still care from a safer distance.

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Check-ins (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins), for tender conversations, and Professor Puddles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask) if you want help finding words.

Reading pages to read on the website

- Library: active listening (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/communication), advice or support? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/communication#advice-vs-support) and validation (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/communication#validation-in-conversation).

- Library: empathic distress and compassion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection) and social support (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection#social-support).
- Library: burnout (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress) and caregiver strain (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress#caregiver-strain).
- Library: saying no (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/communication#saying-no) and boundaries (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/communication#boundaries).
- Stories from philosophy: the circles of Hierocles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth).

More for your situation

- **Carers**: Caring for someone you love · When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill)
- **Friends**: Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- **Parents and grandparents**: For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) · For grandparents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents) · When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids)
- **At work**: At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work) · For counsellors, coaches and group leaders (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)
- **After a loss**: Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

A limit to keep in mind: This chapter is about everyday helping. It isn't training in crisis care or therapy. When someone's safety is at risk, the most helpful thing you can do is bring in people trained to help.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Preface to Part Two · The work nobody sees
The care work nobody sees
read online

Part Two · Chapter II · Is the split working?
Sharing the load so it lasts
read online

Part Three · Chapter 8 · Loss, grief and big life changes
Helping someone through grief
page 152

Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system
Noticing your own stress first
page 72

PUT IT TO USE

Check-ins
For tender conversations, and Professor Puddles if you want help finding words
spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins

Stories from philosophy: the circles of Hierocles
spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth

13

PART THREE · CHAPTER 13

Anger: what it's for and what to do with it

What anger is for, what to do in the hot minutes, how to repair afterwards, and how to tell when anger has turned into harm. For anyone, in any kind of relationship, or on your own.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Anger is a signal about something that matters
2. Anger often guards a softer feeling
3. Anger rises in the body fast
4. In the hot minutes: slow the body first
5. Letting rip doesn't empty it
6. Step back and look from the outside
7. Say it, don't throw it
8. After anger, repair
9. When anger becomes harm
10. If you're a teenager
11. In everyday life
12. Common mix-ups
13. If you want to help someone else with this
14. When to get more help
15. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
16. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Anger is a signal** that something seems unfair, blocked or threatening. The feeling is allowed, and what you do with it is the part you choose.
- **The first minutes are about the body.** Slow down, breathe out long, and step away with a time to come back.
- **Letting rip doesn't empty anger.** Shouting tends to feed it, while calming the body, putting it into words and repairing any sharp moments help more.

- **Anger that frightens, controls or hurts someone has become harm.** That needs more help, and safety comes first.

TUESDAY, 6:10PM

Your brother. Cant do thurs after all sorry!! work thing

Thursday is Mum's hospital appointment. The one with the consultant, the one you've been going on about for three weeks, and it's the third time this month he's done this. Your jaw goes and your face goes hot. Your thumbs are already moving, TYPICAL. You never, and the message is one tap from sent.

Plenty of us were taught that anger was rude, or dangerous, or grew up around anger that was frightening. Anger itself is an ordinary human feeling, though, and it very often points at something real. It also sits under two tools elsewhere. The Calm-Down Kit (Part One, Now, page 29) works because anger rises in the body first and slowing the body is what makes words possible. And letting a comment land before you react (Part Two, Chapter IV, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4) is the stepping back described further on.

01

Anger is a signal about something that matters.

Anger usually says something is unfair, or something's in your way, or a line has been crossed. It pushes you *towards* a problem so you'll change it. It can also land on the wrong person, or come out far bigger than the thing in front of it.

Somebody keeps eating Shabnam's lunch from the office fridge. Week one, she assumes a mistake. Week two, she writes her name on the box in marker pen. Week three, the box is empty again and has been put back in the fridge, neatly, with the lid on, which is the bit that does it. Her anger has now told her very clearly that a line has been crossed, and it's the anger, frankly, that gets her to raise it at the Monday meeting. (It was the new starter. He thought the fridge was communal. He bought her a meal deal and looked like he wanted to die.)

Next time you're angry, finish this privately. "I'm angry because something I care about, which is ___, seems ___."

Anger moves you towards things

Most unpleasant feelings make us back away. A review by Carver and Harmon-Jones argued that anger usually does the opposite: like eagerness, it pushes you towards the goal or the obstacle. That's what makes it good at showing what matters, and risky to act on at full heat.

Carver and Harmon-Jones (2009) · *Moderate: an influential review; the approach view is still debated*

02

Anger often guards a softer feeling.

Anger can arrive first because it feels stronger and safer than whatever is under it, which is often hurt, or fear, or shame, or plain exhaustion. Chapter 1 (page 58) calls this layers, and the layer underneath usually tells you what you actually need.

Frankie was an hour late home. She is sixteen. Her dad was waiting in the hall when the key went in the door and what came out of him was mostly about curfews and rules and respect, at volume. She gave as good as she got. It was only later, sitting on the stairs, that he told her about the hour itself. Standing at the front window. Phone in his hand. Checking the bus app over and over. Working out which A&E. She went quiet then. "Sorry," she said, and this time she meant it.

YOU COULD SAY

"I'm angry, and I think underneath I was really scared." "I came across cross, but I think I'm actually hurt."

03

Anger rises in the body fast.

A hot face, a tight jaw, a pounding heart and a voice going up are the body getting ready for a fight, and it takes seconds. When anger is high, careful thinking gets a lot harder, and listening harder still. Chapter 2 (page 72) calls this being flooded.

Halfway through an argument about the bins (whose turn, and also, it emerged, whose turn for the last four years) Meera noticed that her hands were shaking. She also realised she hadn't heard a single thing her housemate had said for at least a minute. She'd been composing, and that was her sign. Learn your own early signs, if you can, whether it's a tight jaw or talking faster or being very, very reasonable in a slightly high voice.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Anger moves faster than words. The Calm-Down Kit is a plan you make on a calm day, for the hot minutes.

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11

04

In the hot minutes: slow the body first.

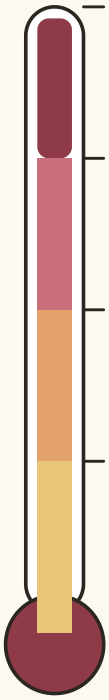
When anger is high, settle your body before you try to sort anything out. Stop talking. Stop typing. Breathe out slowly, so the out-breath is longer than the in-breath. Unclench your hands. If you can, get out of the room for a bit. A large review of 154 studies by Kjærvik and Bushman (2024) found that activities which calm the body, like slow breathing, relaxation and mindfulness, reduced anger, while ones that rev you up showed little or no benefit.

Fractions, at the kitchen table, half past seven, question four. Ben could feel his voice getting tighter with every "But *why* is it a half?" "I'm getting frustrated," he said in the end, "and that's not your fault. I'm getting a glass of water. Five minutes." He stood at the sink, looking out at the dark garden, and drank the whole glass. When he came back they did the rest of the sheet together, and both of them got number six wrong, confidently.

Make the plan on a calm day. Your early sign, the words you'll say, where you'll go for ten minutes. Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) has steps for the very worst moments.

Anger rises fast

What helps depends on how hot it is.



Hot minutes
Slow the body first: long out-breaths. Step away, with a time to come back.

Angry
Don't solve it now. Problems can wait; sharp words are hard to take back.

Annoyed
Notice the body: hot face, tight jaw, clenched hands.

Irritated
Say it early, plainly and kindly.

✕ **Letting rip doesn't empty it. It feeds it.**

Once cooler: say it, don't throw it.
Then repair any sharp moments.

In a review of 154 studies (Kjærvik and Bushman, 2024), activities that calm the body reduced anger; revving it up did not help. If anger frightens or controls someone, safety comes first.

FIGURE 24 Anger rises fast, and what helps depends on how hot it is. In the hot minutes, slow the body first; letting rip feeds it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 18

The Calm-Down Kit

Pat, a grandmother raising her grandson Jay, 13

The Calm-Down Kit

Whose kit is this? (your name)
Pat (Nan)

Date
4 October 2026

Part A: What tends to start it

What tends to start it	How it shows up in my body first
Door slammed after a call with his mum	*Shoulders up by my ears*
Being shouted at in front of the neighbours	*Hot face, can't find words*

Part A: My two defaults

First default
Gating (lower the lights, step out)

Second, if the first isn't available
Low, steady sound

Part A: My pause line

In my words
I'm too wound up to listen well. I'm putting the kettle on for twenty minutes. I'll come and find you at half past.

Our pause plan (agree it together, and share it)

Our pause word or signal
"Kettle time"

The shortest break we take
20 minutes

How we set the time to come back
Whoever pauses says a time before they go

The first sentence when we come back
"I'm back. Let's start again, slower."

Part B: In the moment

Say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step. Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

Part C: Coming back

Time	What I did	How I feel now
5:10 pm	*Gating (lower the lights, step out)*	*Settled enough*

WHERE THAT LEAVES YOU

Next
Settled enough: go back to the conversation, at the time you named. When you come back, start with one small, simple task, like putting the dishes away.

Next small action
Sit with Jay and agree one screen-time rule

If you put the conversation off: when you'll pick it back up
After tea, at 6

☑ I'm going with this

Made-up example. Jay agreed the pause plan with her on a calm Sunday. "Gating", one of the kit's calming steps, means cutting down what comes in through the senses: lower the lights, turn the sound down, or step out of the room.

Fill in your own: The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11)

05

Letting rip doesn't empty it.

A lot of people believe anger works like steam. Shout, slam a door, hit a pillow, and it's out, and you're calmer. It's a lovely tidy idea. The research doesn't support it. In a well-known study by Bushman (2002), angry people who hit a punching bag while thinking about the person who annoyed them ended up angrier than before.

Going over what happened again and again in your head has a similar effect. In studies by Bushman and colleagues (2005), people who dwelt on a provocation were later more aggressive, even towards someone who only mildly annoyed them. Anger fades faster when the body is calmed and the mind has something else to do for a while.

After a row with a colleague, Neville spent his lunch break telling three separate people how awful she was. Each telling got a bit better. By two o'clock he was angrier than he'd been at noon, and had a headache. The next time it happened he walked to the river and back instead and didn't tell anyone anything, which nearly killed him. By two he could think about the actual problem. He still thinks she was out of order, and says so, but at a normal volume and to fewer people.

06

Step back and look from the outside.

Once your body has come down a bit, try looking at the moment as if you were watching from the other side of the room. What actually happened? What might the other person have been dealing with? In experiments by Mischkowski, Kross and Bushman (2012), people who looked back on an annoying moment "like a fly on the wall", instead of reliving it, felt less angry and acted less aggressively. Rethinking what happened, which psychologists call reappraisal (Gross, 1998), helps too.

One way in is to write two lines about it in the third person, with your own name. "Wes got angry because…" It feels a bit mad. It works annoyingly well. Wes himself, cancelled on by a friend for the third time, got as far as "Wes got angry because Matt cancelled again, and Matt is…" and stopped, because Matt is looking after his dad, who has been in and out of hospital since June. The anger didn't go. It turned, slowly, into worry, which was at least pointing the right way.

07

Say it, don't throw it.

Anger is often a fair message sent in a hurtful way. Once you're calmer you can still say you were angry, and why, without going for anyone, by keeping to what happened and how you felt and what you're asking for.

"You always let me down" was what Carol wanted to say to her sister. What she actually sent, after two drafts and a cup of tea, was this. "When you cancelled Mum's appointment again I felt really angry, and on my own with it. Can we sort out who takes her for the next three months?" It's longer, and it

is also the only version that gets anyone to the hospital. Chapter 4 (page 99) has more on saying hard things.

Two versions of the same row

When people wrote about a time they angered someone and a time someone angered them, the two kinds of story differed in how serious the harm seemed, how understandable it was and whether it was over. Same sort of event, told from two different places.

Baumeister, Stillwell and Wotman (1990) · *Moderate: a classic study of people's own written memories*

YOU COULD SAY

"I was angry about what happened on Monday. Can I tell you why?"
"When ___ happened, I felt ___, and what I'm asking for is ___."



SUGARFOOT

Say it slowly, in one plain sentence. A soft start makes it far easier for the other person to hear you.

TOOL **Cool-down corner: soften a tense moment** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/soften-a-tense-moment

08

After anger, repair.

Everyone gets angry, and most of us say something sharp now and then. What happens next matters a lot, because a short, real repair rebuilds trust. Name what you did, with no "but" on the end, and say what you'll do differently.

The blue vase from the hall table is on the floor in about nine pieces and Nana Jean has just shouted, really shouted, and Jayden is crying. An hour later she finds him on the stairs. She sits down next to him, which takes her a while with her knees. "I shouted, and that was scary," she says. "You matter to me far more than any vase. I'm sorry." He leans on her shoulder for a bit, and then he asks if they can glue it, so they try. It now has a very visible crack and lives on the landing, where she says it reminds her of something. Chapter 11 (page 197) has more on apologies that land.

YOU COULD SAY

"I was sharp with you earlier. That wasn't fair, and I'm sorry." "I'm still upset about what happened, and I also shouldn't have spoken to you that way."

09

When anger becomes harm.

Feeling angry is human. But some things done in anger are harm, whatever the feeling behind them: hitting, pushing, throwing things at or near someone, breaking their things, threatening, shouting so someone is scared, or using anger to control what another person does, wears, spends or who they see. People walking on eggshells around you is a sign too. Anger is never a reason someone deserves to be hurt.

For example, a man realises his partner and children go quiet when he comes home in a bad mood. He doesn't hit anyone, but they are afraid of him. He talks to his doctor and joins an anger course.

YOU COULD SAY

"I think my anger is scaring people I love. I want help with it." (If it's happening to you) "I'm frightened of how they get when they're angry."

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can learn your early signs, settle your body, say what made you angry in words, and repair when you get it wrong. You can't make someone else calm down, and you don't have to accept being shouted at, threatened or controlled. If someone else's anger frightens you, getting safe matters more than working it out.

TUESDAY, 6:40PM

You put the phone face down on the arm of the sofa and walk round the block, breathing out long and feeling slightly silly about it, and somewhere near the postbox on the corner you notice what's underneath, which is that you're tired and you're frightened about Mum. Back home you delete the capitals and write, "I'm really frustrated. This is the third time and I feel on my own with Mum's care. Can we talk tonight and make a plan?"

He reads it at 6:52. By ten there's still no reply, and you go to bed not knowing who's driving her on Thursday.

If you're a teenager

Ten o'clock, and Maisie's dad has taken her phone. Right in the middle of a group chat about Saturday. She shouts and slams her bedroom door hard enough to rattle the picture on the landing, and then lies on her bed composing speeches. The next morning, calmer and also starving, she tells him it felt like he didn't trust her, says sorry about the door, and asks for ten minutes' warning next time. He says fine. He also says he'd much rather hear this over breakfast than through a door, which she thinks is a bit much, but lets go.

Being angry with a parent is normal, and the rows often feel most intense in the middle teens. A rule given out of care is not control, even when it feels unfair, and a calm request the next day works more often than a slammed door.

YOU COULD SAY

"I'm too angry to talk properly. Can we talk tomorrow?" "I don't mind the rule so much as how it happened." "Could we try it for two weeks and then check?"

In everyday life

Anger at yourself counts. “I’m so stupid” is anger turned inward, and it helps to talk to yourself the way you would to a friend who’d done the same thing (Chapter 7, page 140, goes further). With a partner, agree a pause word on a calm day, and a time you’ll always come back. Children copy what we do with anger far more than anything we say about it. At work anger is common and rarely spoken, and “I’m frustrated about the deadline change, can we talk about what’s realistic?” keeps it useful.

If you have ADHD, anger can come fast and big and go just as fast, so plan for the speed. A three-word pause line (“Back in ten”) and a rule to wait before you send anything. If you’re managing a clash between two other people, hear each of them on their own first and then together, always about what happened and never about each other. Quite often the fight is about the setup, two people who both believe they own the same job. The full chapter has a worked example (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-13-anger-in-depth).

Common mix-ups

Anger itself isn’t a bad feeling. It’s normal and it carries information, and it’s some of the things done in anger that cause harm. Letting it out isn’t the healthy option it sounds like, because shouting and hitting things tend to keep anger going. “They made me angry, so it’s their fault I shouted” mixes up two separate things. Someone can do something unfair, and what you do next is still yours. And holding it in isn’t as safe as it looks. Anger swallowed for years comes out sideways, as coldness or sarcasm or a sudden explosion over a teaspoon, so saying it calmly and early is the safer road.

If you want to help someone else with this

Keep yourself safe first, and if someone’s anger scares you, step away. You don’t have to stay and calm them down. Otherwise, speak lower and slower and leave the argument until they’ve come down. Then listen for the message underneath. There’s often something fair in it, and you can take that part

seriously while still saying the way it came out wasn't okay. Something like "I want to hear this, and I can't while we're both shouting. Can we try again at seven?" keeps hold of both halves.

When to get more help

Everyone gets angry. It may be time to talk to a doctor, a counsellor or an anger management course if:

- your anger feels out of control, or you often regret what you do or say when angry;
- people close to you seem nervous or walk on eggshells around you;
- you have hit, pushed, thrown things, broken things or threatened anyone;
- anger is hurting your work, your friendships or your health;
- you are using alcohol or drugs to cope with angry feelings.

Help for anger works for many people: a review of anger treatments by Del Vecchio and O'Leary (2004) found medium to large benefits. It is good for your health too: a review by Chida and Steptoe (2009) linked anger and hostility with a higher risk of heart disease. Asking for help is a responsible thing to do.

If you are afraid of someone else's anger, that fear is an important signal.

This chapter is general education, not therapy.

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Workpapers **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11): a plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments.

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now?: steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.

Reading pages to read on the website

- When we keep having the same fight (spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-to-stop-fighting-with-your-partner) and When one talks and one goes quiet (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw).
- How to apologise so it counts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages).
- The library: anger (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), going over and over things (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#rumination), rethinking versus holding it in (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions#reappraisal-suppression), time-outs (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/conflict) and managing flooding (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/conflict#managing-flooding).

More for your situation

- For parents: help with your own anger (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) · Repair after you've scared a child (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents#repair-scared)
- For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers)
- At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles
Leftover stress behind a reaction — read online

Part Three · Chapter 1 · How feelings work
Feelings as signals — page 58

Part Three · Chapter 11 · Healing after hurt
Repair after the hot minutes — page 197

Part One · Next · Who you are becoming
A Calm-Down Kit made on a calm day — page 44

PUT IT TO USE



The Calm-Down Kit
A plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11



Upset right now?
Steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

14

PART THREE · CHAPTER 14

Personality, temperament and change across life

What personality is, where temperament comes in, how people change across their lives, and how to live and work with people who are made differently from you, without putting anyone in a box.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Traits work like dials
2. Temperament is the starting point
3. Situations matter too
4. Introvert and extravert is about energy, not liking people
5. People change across life
6. You can change on purpose, a little at a time
7. Every trait has gifts and costs
8. Differences are usually about fit
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Traits work like dials.** Everyone sits somewhere along each one, and most people are near the middle.
- **Temperament is a starting point.** Babies already differ in how active, cautious or easily upset they are, and what happens next matters too.
- **People keep changing.** On average people grow steadier and more organised as they get older, and you can change on purpose, slowly.
- **Most clashes between personalities are about fit**, and nobody has to be at fault.

SATURDAY, 3:00PM

Your aunt's seventieth, in the function room above the cricket club. You're standing by the cake, minding your own business, when she tells the whole room, "Oh, she was always the shy one!"

Everybody laughs, and you laugh along with them, and something stings.

You're forty-two. Every weekday at twenty to nine you stand in front of thirty eight-year-olds and get them to sit down, which takes some doing. So are you still the shy one? Were you ever?

We describe each other by personality all the time, as laid-back, or a worrier, or the organised one, and descriptions like those have a way of setting hard. This chapter is about how personality actually works, what stays put and what moves. Two tools elsewhere build on it. The "How to talk to me" card and the style quiz (Part One, Now, page 29) describe how you lean on a few dials, which is more use than knowing which box somebody once put you in. And One owner per job (Part Two, Chapter II, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2) arranges the jobs round people's differences, so nobody has to turn into someone else to share a house.

01

Traits work like dials.

Personality is the usual pattern in how you think and feel and act. Many psychologists describe it with five broad traits, often called the "Big Five": **openness** (curious about new ideas and experiences), **conscientiousness** (organised and careful), **extraversion** (drawn to people and busy places), **agreeableness** (warm and cooperative) and **emotional stability** (how steady your moods are).

The same five turned up in work such as McCrae and Costa (1987), whether people rated themselves or were rated by people who knew them well. Each runs from low to high, and most people sit near the middle of most of them. That's the bit online quizzes leave out. Two friends did one on the train to Brighton and were told, very confidently, that one was an introvert and the other an extravert. Then they looked at the actual numbers. Four points

apart, both bang in the middle. They spent the rest of the journey arguing about which of them was more middle.

If you're curious, mark where you think you sit on each dial from one to ten, and ask a close friend where they'd put you. The gap is often the interesting bit.

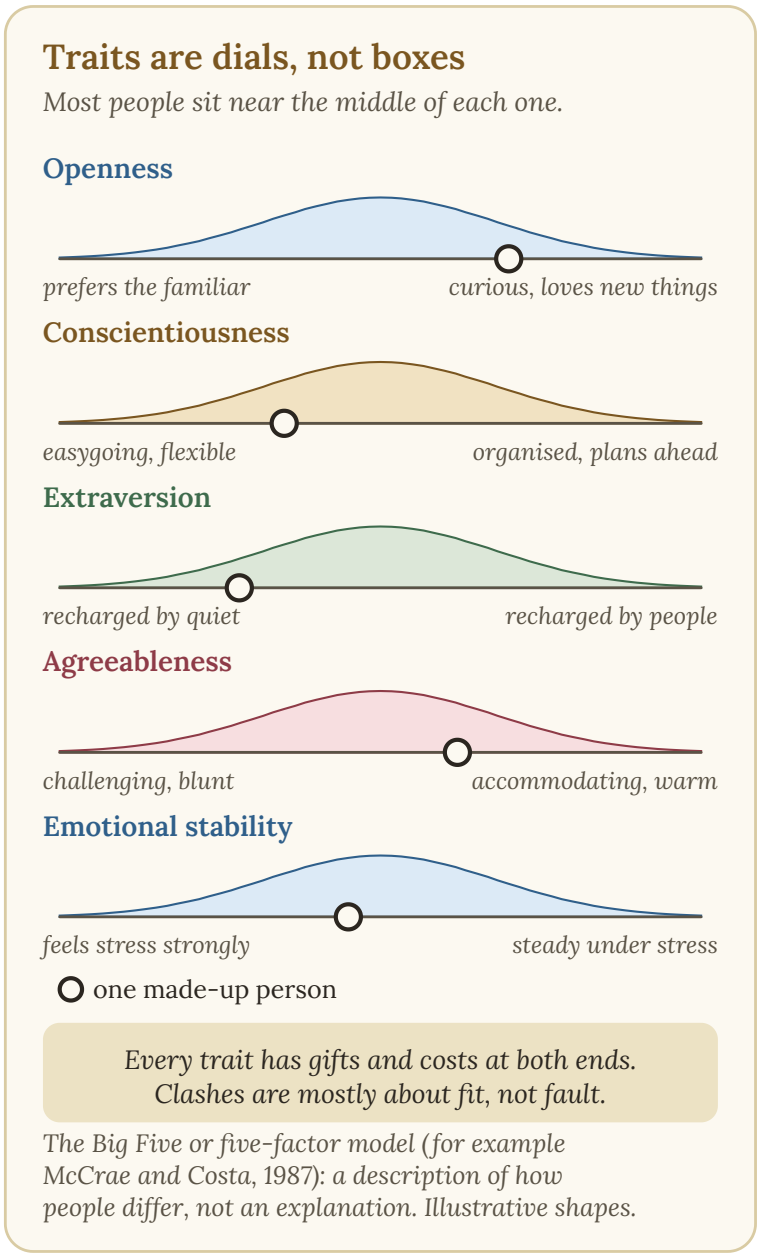


FIGURE 25 Traits work like dials, and most people sit near the middle of each. Illustrative shapes.

02

Temperament is the starting point.

Temperament is the part of personality you can see very early on. Some babies are on the go from the moment they wake. Some are calm. Some take to a new routine straight away and some need a week. Some flinch at every loud noise. In their long-running study, Thomas and Chess (1977) described these early differences and the idea of "goodness of fit", meaning how well a child's temperament suits what the people and places round them expect.

Isla is two and cried at every new playgroup. Her mum tried coaxing her into the circle, then bribing her, then (once, quietly) begging. In the end she just sat at the edge of the church hall with Isla on her lap, feeling a bit of a lemon, while everyone else did "The Wheels on the Bus". It smelled of orange squash and floor polish. Week three, Isla climbed down on her own, walked to the sand table, and didn't look back. Her mum, slightly put out, had a biscuit.

Sensitive isn't the same as shy

Elaine and Arthur Aron described a trait they called sensory-processing sensitivity, taking things in deeply, and found it was partly separate from introversion. Researchers still argue about its exact shape. Still, the child hanging back may be taking everything in rather than shrinking from it.

Aron and Aron (1997) · *Moderate: a widely used measure; the trait's structure is still debated*

YOU COULD SAY

"You like to watch first. That's fine. Join in when you're ready." (to yourself) "I need time to warm up. That's how I'm made."

03

Situations matter too.

Personality describes a pattern, and patterns have exceptions. The same person can be loud with family and quiet at work, endlessly patient with toddlers and very short with call centres. A trait tells you what someone tends to do across lots of situations and a good deal less about the one in front of you.

Anita had decided her new colleague was cold. Polite, competent, cold. Then came the charity football match, and there he was in a borrowed bib two sizes too small, shouting encouragement at a goalkeeper who was letting in

everything. On Monday Anita sat looking round the open-plan office with its grey partitions and humming lights and wondered how much of what she'd seen was the room.

04

Introvert and extravert is about energy, not liking people.

People who are more introverted often like people a lot. What they find is that busy, noisy company uses energy up, and they need quiet afterwards to get it back. People who are more extraverted tend to be topped up by company. Most of us are a mix (sometimes called an ambivert), and every point on the dial just needs different things to be at its best.

Eleven o'clock at a wedding in a barn outside Hexham. Fraser wants the after-party in the village pub. Luke wants bed and silence and possibly never to hear "Mr Brightside" again. They've had this exact standoff at four previous weddings. This time Fraser goes for an hour and Luke walks back to the hotel along the lane with his shoes in his hand, and they meet at breakfast, one of them hoarse and the other one smug, both of them happy. What Luke said, for once, was "I loved tonight, and I'm out of social energy," which he'd practised on the walk from the car.

Happy now, tired later

Forty-eight people tracked for twelve days felt better while acting outgoing and more tired about three hours later, introverts and extraverts alike. It's a small study, and the authors say so.

Leikas and Ilmarinen (2017) · *Early: a small study (48 people); the authors asked for it to be repeated*



TIDBIT

Some people recharge in a busy park and some under a quiet blanket. Both are fine. A short quiz can show you your own style.

TOOL **How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength`

05

People change across life.

Personality is fairly stable. It also moves. A large review by Roberts, Walton and Viechtbauer (2006) found that, on average, people become more organised, more emotionally steady and more confident with others as they

move through adult life, with much of the change between 20 and 40. A later review by Bleidorn and colleagues (2022) found that emotional steadiness went on growing right across the lifespan. Big life events play a part, and so do the roles people take on and who they love.

At school Tunde lost his keys about once a fortnight and once turned up to a maths exam on the wrong day. He's a charge nurse now, forty-six, the calm one people look for when it goes wrong at three in the morning. At the reunion his old friends kept staring at him across the room in the function suite, and eventually one of them came over with two pints and said, "What happened to you?" He thought about it. "Life kept asking me to cope," he said, "and eventually I learned how."

06

You can change on purpose, a little at a time.

If you want to change a trait you can, slowly, mostly by acting differently in small ways over and over. In a study by Hudson and Fraley (2015), people who set goals to change one of their traits tended to move in the direction they wanted over sixteen weeks. A review by Roberts and colleagues (2017) found that therapy was often linked to lasting change too, especially towards more emotional steadiness.

Noor wanted to be less quiet at work. She made a rule. One thing in every team meeting, even if it was only "I agree with Neil". The first fortnight her heart thudded so hard she was sure people could see it through her jumper. By the end of the second month it had become ordinary, and somewhere in the third month she forgot it had ever been a rule. Pick one small thing that fits who you'd like to be more of, and do it three times this week. Chapter 6 (page 127) has more on habits.

07

Every trait has gifts and costs.

There's no good personality. Every trait helps in some places and gets in the way in others. Very agreeable people are lovely to be around and may find "no" almost impossible to say. Very conscientious people are the ones you'd leave your keys with, and they can't always stop. People high in openness love anything new and can be bored to tears by routine.

For most of a year Alys was irritated by her housemate. His trainers in the hall. His "it'll be fine". Then the boiler died on the coldest night in January, and while Alys stood in the kitchen in her coat reading the manual, he rang round until he found a plumber who'd come out at ten o'clock, and then he filled everybody's hot water bottles from the kettle. "It'll be fine," he said, and it was, apart from the hot water bottle that leaked.

A one-page card, "How to talk to me" (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card), turns a trait people complain about into plain information about what helps.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Every trait has gifts and costs. Writing down what helps you on a one-page card turns a "flaw" into useful information.

TOOL **How you connect: how I like to be spoken to** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

08

Differences are usually about fit.

When two people with different personalities share a home or a family or a job, friction is normal. A tidy person and a relaxed one can both be right in their own way, and so can a planner and someone spontaneous, or a talker and someone who needs quiet. What helps is naming the difference and agreeing how to live with it, without either of you being the problem. Personality is also different from neurodivergence and from mental health conditions. If something feels bigger than personality, Chapter 9 (page 165) may help.

A couple argue about every single holiday, because one wants every hour planned and the other wants to wander about and see what happens. This year they plan the mornings and leave the afternoons free, and they still argue about the mornings. I'd count that as progress.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 19

How you connect: the style quiz

Mo, before moving in with his friend Callum

The style quiz: just my Wave Code

Twelve quick either/or taps, about two minutes.

Your first name (optional)

Mo

Someone asks you a big question. You…

Answer right away and figure it out as I talk — *Need a moment, or a day, to think first*

A sudden change of plans feels…

Fine, maybe even fun — Jarring. I need a heads-up or a transition

Starting something new, you want…

The why and the big vision — The first concrete step

When something bothers you, you usually…

Say it plainly so we can fix it — *Hint at it, or wait for the right moment*

Someone says "I'm fine." You…

Believe them. Fine means fine — *Check their tone to see if they really are*

…and seven more like these.

MO'S FOUR LEANINGS (HIS WAVE CODE: S F N A)

What each letter means

Pace: leans Slow Simmer (S, not Quick Spark) · Lens: leans Forest (F, not Trees) · Sending: leans Nuanced (N, not Direct) · Receiving: strongly Attuned (A, not Explicit)

The nickname the tool gives it: the Willow

Reflective and soft-spoken. Feels the undercurrents of every room.

Watch for

agreeing in the moment just to fill the silence; your real needs getting lost in the cushioning.

Mo's style-quiz statement: "About how I'm wired: I think first and talk second, I tend to hint rather than say it straight, I see the big picture first, and I like to take my time."

Made-up example. A Wave Code is shorthand for four preferences, each a lean along a dial, not a type or a box. "Leans" means near the middle. Answers can change with the day, the setting and the person you're with.

Fill in your own: How you connect (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can get to know your own mix, look after what you need, and practise one small change if you want to. You can't change someone else's personality, and you don't have to change yours to be loved. If you're always the one bending to fit, it's fair to say so. Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself)

SATURDAY, 5:30PM

People are drifting off with slices of cake in kitchen roll. You think about sitting down next to your aunt and telling her about the thirty eight-year-olds. You don't. You help stack the plates. On the drive home you're still turning it over, half cross with her and half with yourself, and somewhere round the ring road you start drafting what you'll say at Christmas if she does it again. It's quite a good line.

In everyday life

On your own

Knowing your own mix helps you build a life that suits you, with about the right amount of company and quiet. “I’m just not a people person” might be true. It might also be an old label that deserves testing at least once. With a partner, a shared plan (one does the bills, the other does holidays) usually goes better than trying to change each other. A quiet friend who hardly texts may still care a great deal, so ask what kind of contact suits them. A child’s temperament says nothing about good or bad parenting, and adjusting to fit them is a skill you pick up. And family roles like “the clever one” or “the difficult one” can hang on long after they stop fitting. You’re allowed to grow out of them, whether or not your aunt has noticed.

Common mix-ups

You aren’t simply an introvert or an extravert. Most people are somewhere in the middle, and where you sit shifts with the setting and your mood. Personality isn’t set in stone by thirty, either. It keeps moving slowly all through life. Online type quizzes are good for fun and for starting a conversation, and that includes the website’s own Wave Code, which shows four leanings on four dials, but they sort people into a handful of types when real people are spread along each dial. “They’re just difficult” often means “they’re different from me”, and it can hide stress or illness or a need nobody has asked about. And practising something new isn’t being fake. It feels odd at first, like new shoes, and then it’s yours.

If you want to help someone else with this

Drop the old labels, and notice if you still describe someone the way they were twenty years ago. Ask instead of guessing. “What helps you recharge?” or “How do you like to plan things?” will tell you more than any theory. Say it when you see someone grow, because “You handled that so calmly” can show a person a change they hadn’t spotted. And describe what happened, not who

someone is. “You’re so uptight” shuts doors that a plain description would leave open.

> WORDS TO TRY
> “I used to think of you as the shy one. I don’t think that fits any more.”
> “What do you need to be at your best this week?”

When to get more help

Personality differences are normal and don’t need fixing. It may be worth talking to a doctor, counsellor or psychologist if:

- a pattern in how you feel, think or relate to people keeps causing you or others real distress, across many parts of life;
- you feel very unsure who you are, or your moods swing so much it’s hard to cope;
- worry, low mood or fear of people is stopping you from living the life you want.

Please don’t diagnose yourself or anyone else with a “personality disorder” from what you read online. Those are clinical terms that only a qualified professional can use, after a proper assessment.

A personality trait never excuses controlling, frightening or hurtful behaviour.

This chapter is general education, not a diagnosis or therapy.

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- How you connect (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength): four quick dials for how you think, talk and listen. Its four-letter Wave Code is shorthand for four preferences, not a type.
- Communication style quiz (spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz).

Reading pages to read on the website

- Know your own wiring: how you tend to feel, react and recharge.
- The library: the Big Five (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring), introversion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#introversion), morning and evening people (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#chronotypes) and highly sensitive people (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/wiring#sensory-processing-sensitivity).

More for your situation

- Part One, Now: your wiring, your weather and your words (page 29)
- Part Three, Chapter 6: Habits and change (page 127)
- Part Three, Chapter 9: Minds that work differently (page 165)
- For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) · For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) · For grandparents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents)
- Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room) · At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words
Your wiring today page 29

Part One · Then · Where your lens came from
Temperament and how you grew up page 14

Part Three · Chapter 9 · Minds that work differently
Minds that work differently page 165

Part Three · Chapter 6 · Habits and change
How change really happens page 127

PUT IT TO USE

How you connect
Four quick dials for how you think, talk and listen. Its four-letter Wave Code is shorthand for four preferences, not a type
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

Communication style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

15

PART THREE · CHAPTER 15

Closeness and love: being known, at every age

How closeness grows, what it means to feel truly known, how love changes over the years, and how it looks in every kind of relationship, at every age, including for people on their own.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Love comes in many forms
2. Closeness grows from being known
3. Closeness is built a step at a time
4. Feeling understood matters most
5. Old maps show up in love
6. Love changes over time
7. Love at every age
8. Love is something you do
9. If you're a teenager
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Reading on this site
15. More for your situation

FRIDAY, 10:30PM

Eleven years in this house with Charlie. Tonight you're both on the sofa, both on your phones, with a cooking programme on in the background that neither of you is watching. Someone on it is crying about a soufflé.

You try to remember the last time the two of you talked about something that wasn't bills, or the boiler, or whose turn it is to cook. You can't. You love Charlie, which isn't in question. You feel oddly on your own, a foot away from them.

This chapter is about closeness in all its forms, far beyond romance. It looks at what helps people feel near to each other, and why closeness fades and

how it grows back, and it builds on Chapter 5 (page 114), on attachment and trust.

01

Love comes in many forms.

The ancient Greeks had several words for love, for friends, family, romantic partners and strangers. People love in many ways now too, through lifelong friendships, partners of any gender, more than one partner, chosen family, and among people who are asexual or aromantic and build deep closeness without romance or sex. People on their own who pour love into friends, family, pets, work and community. A life can be full of love without a partner in it.

Frances is fifty-six and has never wanted a partner. Ask her about her great love story and she'll tell you about Denise, her best friend of thirty years. Between them there have been two house moves, one cancer scare, a caravan holiday in Tenby that they still can't discuss without one of them leaving the room, and more Sunday phone calls than either of them could count. "People feel sorry for me," she says. "I feel quite sorry for them."

02

Closeness grows from being known.

Intimacy is about much more than touch or romance. At its heart is being known. The psychologists Reis and Shaver described it as a back-and-forth, in which one person shares something real about themselves and the other responds in a way that leaves them feeling understood and cared for. In a diary study by Laurenceau, Barrett and Pietromonaco (1998), feeling that the other person really responded was a big part of what made everyday conversations feel intimate.

Two brothers who mostly talk about football were driving to their dad's care home. Somewhere on the bypass, staring straight ahead, one of them said, "I find these visits really hard." There was a long pause before the other said, "Yeah. Me too. I always feel guilty on the way home." It was the longest conversation they'd had in years. It lasted all the way to the car park, where they sat with the engine off for another ten minutes. Then they went in and talked about football.

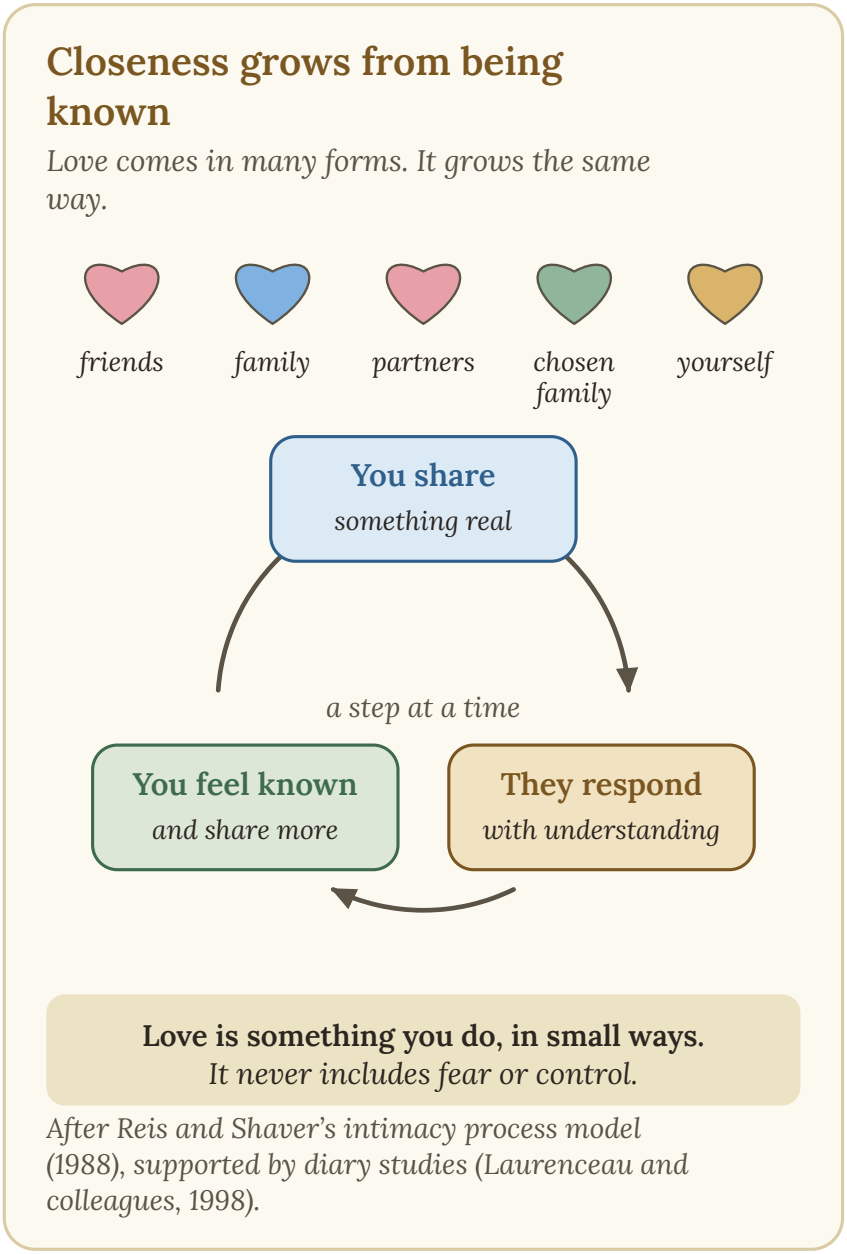


FIGURE 26 Closeness grows from being known: you share something real, the other person responds with understanding, and you share a little more.

03

Closeness is built a step at a time.

People usually get close by sharing a little more, then a little more, when it feels safe. In a well-known study by Aron and colleagues (1997), pairs of strangers who took turns asking gradually more personal questions, now known as the "36 questions", felt closer after forty-five minutes than pairs who made small talk. The same idea works in friendships and long relationships, where closeness grows when both people take small, matched steps.

Two new neighbours start with the weather, and the parking, which on their street is a serious subject. A few months later one asks how the other's mum is getting on. Some time after that, over the fence, with a hosepipe running, one of them says, "Can I tell you what's actually been going on?"



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Closeness grows when you know what feels like care to the other person, not just to you. A "What feels like care" card is a gentle way to find out.

TOOL **How you connect: what feels like care** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

04

Feeling understood matters most.

What makes someone feel loved is often less about grand gestures and more about feeling understood. Researchers call this *responsiveness*, meaning noticing, understanding and caring about what matters to the other person, and it shows in small moments such as how you react to good news. Gable and colleagues (2004) found that people whose partners usually met their good news with real interest and warmth felt closer and more satisfied together.

"I got into the band." She's fourteen, coat still on, trying to sound casual about it. Her grandad put the paper down, properly down, folded, and said, "Which instrument? When's the first concert?" She talked for twenty minutes, mostly about the trombone section and a boy called Luca who can't count. Next time someone shares good news with you, put your phone face down and ask two follow-up questions.

05

Old maps show up in love.

The patterns from Chapter 5 (page 114) often come out strongest with the people we love most. Hazan and Shaver (1987) suggested that adult love uses the same attachment system as childhood bonds. When closeness feels shaky, some people reach harder for reassurance and others pull back to feel safe. Both are ways of protecting something precious.

When his partner goes quiet, Leo texts, and once it was five times in an hour. His partner goes quiet to calm down, and five texts feels like being chased round the house. What they agreed, eventually, was that his partner would say, "I need an hour, and I'll message you at eight." Leo found, somewhat to his surprise, that he could wait quite happily for a known time, and that the waiting had never really been the problem.

06

Love changes over time.

Early love is often intense, with racing thoughts and a lot of longing, and over the years it usually settles into something calmer and deeper. A review by Acevedo and Aron (2009) found that some people in long relationships still report strong romantic love, without the anxious, obsessive edge of early love, and that this was linked to being happier together.

In experiments by Aron and colleagues (2000), couples who tried a new, mildly challenging activity together felt better about their relationship afterwards than couples given a dull task. After twenty-five years together, Howard and Lynne signed up for a pottery class at the community centre. They were both dreadful. Lynne's bowl collapsed twice and Howard got clay in his ear. They laughed most of the evening and brought home a bowl that won't stand up, and on the walk back Howard said, "That felt like a date." Something new matters more than something big. A new walk. A new recipe. A café in the next town.

Thank-yous as a booster

In a daily diary study of couples living together, feeling grateful for a partner's thoughtful act predicted feeling more connected and more satisfied the next day, for both of them. Correlational, but cheap to test at home.

Algoe, Gable and Maisel (2010) · *Moderate: a daily diary study; correlational*



SUGARFOOT

Little rituals, a Sunday walk, a goodnight text, keep love warm through the years. Most couples have more of them than they think.

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-15

07

Love at every age.

Love looks different across a life. Teenagers' first loves can be huge and real. Adults juggle love with work and children and, often, ageing parents. Many older people choose to spend their time with fewer, closer people, which Carstensen and colleagues (1999) linked to feeling that time is more limited, so that the most meaningful relationships matter more. People find new love at seventy and eighty, and people lose great loves and carry them always.

Arthur is seventy-eight, and he met Irene at his walking group, in the drizzle, arguing about a stile. When his children looked surprised, and then worried, and then started asking careful questions about wills, he said, "I loved your mother for fifty years. I still do. And I'm allowed to be happy now." His daughter cried. His son changed the subject to the car. Irene is coming for Christmas, with a trifle.

08

Love is something you do.

Feelings of love come and go. The actions of love can be steady. Turning towards someone when they speak. Keeping small promises. Saying thank you, and sorry. Making room for who they are. Physical closeness, like a hug or holding hands, matters a lot to some people and less to others, and sex is part of closeness in some relationships and not in others. What matters is that both people feel comfortable and free to say yes or no. Love never includes fear, threats or control.

Her friend had gone quiet after his divorce. Paula has never once told him she loves him and would be mortified to. Every Thursday she texts one word, *Walk?*, and turns up at his door at six in her old wax jacket, whatever the weather. Some weeks they talk and some weeks they just walk. A "What feels

like care" card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages) is a gentle way to find out what the small thing is for someone you love.

Bids, and turning towards them

Watching 49 newlywed couples over dinner, Driver and Gottman found that partners who turned towards each other's small bids, a comment or a question or a look, showed more humour and affection later, even in a disagreement. It's a small, correlational study, so it can't say which causes which.

Driver and Gottman (2004) · *Moderate: observational, small sample; direction of cause not established*

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 20

Our time-together deal

Jamal and Tess, a couple; Jamal games most evenings

Our time-together deal

Your name
Jamal

Their name
Tess

Game nights (or long phone time)
Tuesday and Friday evenings, plus Sunday afternoon

Heads-up rule
Say before a session over an hour, and roughly when it ends.

When one of us asks for time
Finish this match, then I'm yours. No new one.

Our protected evening
Wednesday, from 7: we cook together

Phone-free times
Dinner, and the first 20 minutes in bed

Chores before the session
Dishes and our own jobs for the day are done first.

YOUR DEAL, READY TO SEND

Our time-together deal (Jamal and Tess), with each line above. A link holds the deal as it is right now: if either of you changes something, send a new link.

Made-up example.

Fill in your own: Our time-together deal (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can share a little of yourself, listen well, turn towards the people you love and keep small promises. You can't make someone love you, or love you in the way you want. If closeness keeps hurting you, or you feel afraid, that is not a failure of love on your part.

THE NEXT FRIDAY, 10:30PM

The phones go on the kitchen counter and you make two cups of tea. You ask Charlie, feeling a bit silly, what they've been thinking about lately that they haven't told you. Charlie looks at you for a moment as if you might be ill. Then they talk about their dad getting older, and how they dread the phone ringing late at night. You didn't know that, and you listen. Then you tell them about the restructure at work, which you hadn't mentioned either. The tea goes cold, and it's midnight before either of you looks at the clock.

If you're a teenager

First love can be huge and real, and so can a first breakup. Ines is sixteen when she's dumped by message on a Tuesday night, and she cries until two in the morning. Being told by adults that she'll get over it does not help, at all. Telling her cousin, who just listens, does. So does muting the chat instead of rereading it, and a rule of no checking his profile after ten, which she breaks

twice. A few weeks later she notices a whole day has gone by without her thinking about him, and is slightly offended.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I don't need advice, I just need to tell someone." "Can we reply when we can, rather than all day?" And if you are the one ending it, "I don't want to go out any more. I'm sorry. It isn't about something you did wrong."

In everyday life

On your own

Being single, widowed, divorced or happily alone doesn't mean a life without love. Friendships, family, community and the way you treat yourself are all places where love lives. If you want a partner and don't have one, that longing is real and worth being gentle with (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). Most partners drift into talking only about jobs and bills, and one real question a week can bring them back. Friendship needs tending like any other love. And families often love each other enormously and say so about once a decade, so a short "I'm glad you're my sister" can land like a brick, in a good way.

- **Different levels of desire.** This is very common in long relationships and is nobody's fault. Talk at a calm time, keep some affection that doesn't have to lead anywhere, and remember that a kind "no" is a no to the moment and never a rejection of the person. A qualified sex therapist or couples therapist can help. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-15-love-in-depth).

Common mix-ups

The spark fading doesn't mean love is over. Early intensity usually settles, and many long relationships stay warm and close and lively for decades. Nobody reads minds, either, however much they love you, so saying what helps is a gift rather than a failure of romance.

- **"Jealousy proves love."** Feeling jealous is human, and asking for something out of care for the relationship is not control. Checking up without agreement, cutting someone off or punishing them is not love.

If you want to help someone else with this

Respect their kind of love, without assuming that everyone wants a partner or children. Be a safe person to tell things to, which means listening without judging and keeping what they share to yourself. After a loss or a breakup, keep showing up, because most people get plenty of support for a fortnight and very little after that.

- **If you're worried about someone's relationship,** stay close and kind rather than criticising their partner.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "I'm always glad to hear from you." "You don't have to explain your relationship to me. I just want you to be happy and safe."

When to get more help

- If you feel very lonely or low most days for two weeks or more, talk to a doctor or counsellor.
- If closeness feels frightening, or you keep ending up in relationships that hurt you, a counsellor or therapist can help you understand why.
- Couples or family counselling can help when you feel stuck, or keep having the same fight.
- If someone you love controls you, frightens you, checks your phone, cuts you off from friends or pressures you into anything you don't want, that isn't love.
- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) has a few things to try in a hard moment.

This chapter is general education, not therapy.

Reading on the website

Reading pages to read on the website

- Bonding: how closeness grows (spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding), what research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family and you.
- Turning towards (spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward), on small daily moments of connection.
- The languages of connection (spreadloveandacceptance.com/languages-of-connection), on the different ways people show care.
- Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency), on why good things fade and how to keep them alive.
- The library: responsiveness (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships), love maps (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships#love-maps), self-expansion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships#self-expansion), adult attachment (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships#adult-attachment) and sharing good news (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection).

More for your situation

- Attachment, trust and belonging (page 114)
- Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · More than two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two) · Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance)
- Coming out as an adult (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out)
- On my own · Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- Retired together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/retired-together) · Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Love comes in many forms.
- ✓ Closeness is built a step at a time.
- ✓ Old maps show up in love.
- ✓ Love changes over time.
- ✓ Love is something you do.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part Three · Chapter 5 · Attachment, trust and belonging
Attachment and trust
page 114

Part Two · Chapter I · Why we get out of tune
Staying in tune day to day
read online

Preface to Part Two · The work nobody sees
Noticing the work love does
read online

Part One · Next · Who you are becoming
Growing as a person inside a relationship
page 44

PUT IT TO USE



Bonding: how closeness grows
What research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family and you
spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding



Turning towards
On small daily moments of connection
spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward

16

PART THREE · CHAPTER 16

Worry, low mood and trauma

How worry and anxiety work, the difference between a low patch and depression, what trauma is and isn't, what helps day to day, how to support someone, and when and where to get more help. For anyone, in any kind of relationship, or on your own.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Worry and anxiety are the body's alarm
2. Avoiding keeps fear going
3. Give worry a time and a place
4. Low mood is common. Depression is more than a bad week
5. Doing often comes before feeling better
6. Sleep, moving and people do a lot of the work
7. Trauma is about what happened, and what it left behind
8. After something frightening: safety, choice and no pressure
9. Talking therapies help many people, and medicines can too
10. If you're a teenager
11. In everyday life
12. Common mix-ups
13. If you want to help someone else with this
14. When to get more help
15. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
16. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Worry, low mood and the after-effects of trauma are common, human and treatable.** They are not weakness, and they are not your fault.
- **They all run through the stress system** from Chapter 2 (page 72). Small, steady things that settle the body and reconnect you with life help more than big pushes.
- **Avoiding and withdrawing feel safer but keep things going.** Small steps back in, a little at a time, help most.

- **Talking therapies work for many people, and so can medicines.** If it has lasted weeks, is getting in the way of life, or you feel unsafe, get help.

SUNDAY, 10:50PM

The house is quiet. You've checked the front door twice and the back door once, and you're thinking about the front door again. Tomorrow is the hospital, ten o'clock, and it goes round and round. What if it's bad. What if I can't cope. Who would I even tell.

And if you're honest, it isn't only tonight. You haven't really wanted to see anyone for a few weeks. Even replying to a text has started to feel like lifting something.

Almost everyone worries, feels low or goes through something frightening at some point. For some people it settles by itself, and for others it sticks, and grows, until it shapes every day. This chapter is about how these things work, what tends to help, and when it's time to ask for more. It can't diagnose anyone. If any of this is about you right now, you aren't alone in it, and it can get better.

Some tools elsewhere lean on this chapter. The daily check-in's "low, medium or high" (Part Two, Chapter I, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-1) lets people adjust when worry or low mood has shrunk the room you have. "A full tank means later, not never" (Part Two, Chapter III, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3) names a time to come back, because avoiding a thing keeps fear going. And picking one small goal (Part One, Next, page 44) suits low mood, since doing very often comes before feeling better.

01

Worry and anxiety are the body's alarm.

Fear is the body's alarm for danger that's here now. Anxiety is the same alarm ringing about something that might happen. Worry is the thinking part, the "What if…?" going round. All three run through the stress system from Chapter 2 (page 72), which is why they come with a racing heart and a tight chest and a churning stomach and nights of bad sleep. The alarm is trying to

protect you. The trouble is it can be set far too sensitive, and it can't tell a tiger from an email.

Before every presentation in class, Leah's heart pounds so hard her hands shake her notes. She is fifteen, and nothing bad has ever happened to her in a presentation. Her alarm still treats a room full of people she's known since Year 2, one of whom once ate a worm for 50p, as somewhere dangerous.

Fear of not knowing

One review argues that fear of the unknown, the not-knowing itself, may sit underneath a lot of anxiety. It's a proposal rather than a settled finding, but it fits the night before a hospital appointment better than most explanations do.

Carleton (2016) · *Theory: an influential review; the central claim is a proposal*

When it rises, try breathing out slowly five times, each breath out longer than the breath in. Then name three things you can see. It tells the body the danger isn't here right now, and while it won't switch the alarm off, it can usually turn it down a notch.

02

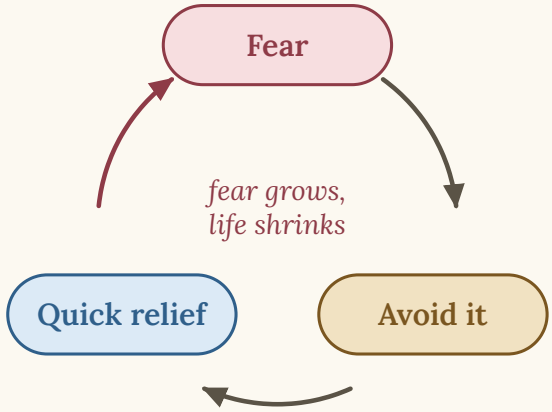
Avoiding keeps fear going.

When something makes us anxious, stepping away brings quick relief, and the relief teaches the brain that escaping was clever. So next time the fear is a little bigger and the world a little smaller. What helps is going back towards the feared thing in small, chosen steps, and staying long enough to find out you can cope. Therapists call this exposure. Craske and colleagues (2014) describe how it works best when each step tests what you expect to happen.

After a panic attack on the 42, Graham started walking everywhere, in the rain, three miles to work and three miles back. His sister didn't argue. One Saturday she just stood at the bus stop with him and they got on, and off again, after one stop. A week later, two stops. It took most of the spring before he did the whole run into town, sitting by the doors, feeling sick, reading the same advert for a solicitor over and over. But he did it, and his brain had slowly learned that buses are survivable.

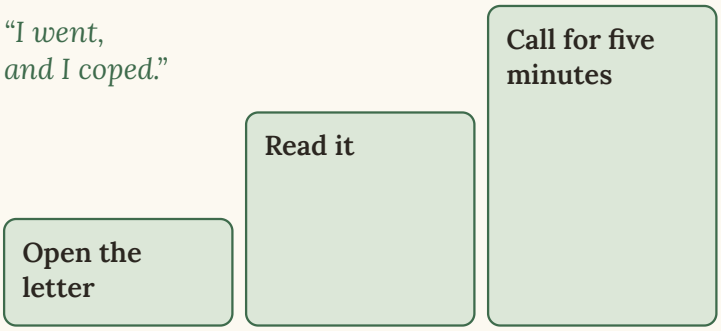
Avoiding keeps fear going

Quick relief now, a smaller life later.



The way back: small, planned steps

*"I went,
and I coped."*



Planned, gradual approach (exposure) is among the most effective treatments for anxiety; it builds new learning that competes with the old fear (Craske and colleagues, 2014). A therapist can help with strong fears.

FIGURE 27 Avoiding keeps fear going. Small, planned steps back in help most, and a therapist can help with strong fears.

03

Give worry a time and a place.

Trying hard not to worry rarely works. What helps a lot of people is postponing it. You notice a worry, write it down, and save it for a set "worry time" later in the day. In an early study by Borkovec and colleagues (1983), people who practised this for four weeks reported worrying less each day. In worry time, go through the list and ask of each one whether there's anything you can do about it. If there is, plan one step. If there isn't, practise letting it go, which is easier said than done, I know.

Desmond looks after his dad and keeps a small red notebook by the kettle. Worries go in it all day. At six, with a cup of tea, he gives the notebook fifteen minutes. By then half the morning's worries look smaller, and a couple have quietly sorted themselves out. The one about the boiler has been in there since August, and he has decided to let it stay. When one turns up at the wrong time of day, the trick is to tell it, more or less, "Noted. I'll think about that at six."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 21

Flip it

Tolu, 17, at 1am, three days before an exam

Flip it

What's on your mind?

What if I fail my chemistry exam on Friday and don't get into the course I want?

What kind is it?

A complaint about someone · A *worry* · Being hard on myself · Anger

THE FLIP

The best outcome would be
[what you hope for]

The main thing in the way
I fail my chemistry exam on Friday and don't get into the course I want

If that happens, I'll
[one small thing you could do]

One step today
[something that takes ten minutes or less]

This is WOOP, from Gabriele Oettingen's research: Wish, Outcome, Obstacle, Plan. The worry becomes the obstacle you plan for. This is a starting point. Change any words you like.

Tolu's version
Best outcome: I pass, and I feel I did my best. In the way: I freeze on the long questions. If that happens, I'll do the short questions first and come back. One step today: one long question from a past paper, then bed.

When the worry comes back at 1am
It goes on the list for tomorrow's worry time, 5pm, ten minutes.

Made-up example. If worry is stopping you sleeping or eating most days, tell someone you trust, or your doctor.

Fill in your own: Flip it (spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins)

04

Low mood is common. Depression is more than a bad week.

Everyone has low days, and sadness after a loss or a let-down is normal. Depression is different. It means low mood, or losing interest in things you used to enjoy, for most of the day, nearly every day, for two weeks or more, often with poor sleep, tiredness, appetite changes, feeling worthless or guilty, and finding it hard to think. It can look like sadness. It can also look like irritability, or just running on empty. It is a health problem, and nobody gets it by being weak.

Lionel taught geography for thirty-one years. Lately he has stopped going to the Thursday walking group. He isn't reading. He wakes at four every morning and lies there listening to the boiler come on. Getting old, he tells himself. It was his daughter, up for the weekend, who said it, carefully, while they were washing up. "Dad, I think this might be depression. And that can be treated." He was quite cross with her for about a day.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I've not been myself for a few weeks, and I don't think it's just tiredness."
> "I don't enjoy things I used to. Can I talk to you about it?"

05

Doing often comes before feeling better.

Low mood tells you to wait until you feel like it. But withdrawing makes life emptier, and that deepens the low. A well-tested approach called behavioural activation turns this round. You plan small, doable things that bring a bit of pleasure or a sense of having done something, and you do them whether you feel like it or not. A review of 26 trials by Ekers and colleagues (2014) found it helped with depression, though many of the studies were small.

After her divorce, living on her own, Lorraine planned three small things a day, a ten-minute walk to the postbox and back, one call or message, and one job she could finish, like wiping the hob. Most days, honestly, they felt pointless. She did them anyway, and over a few weeks the days started to feel less flat, though she couldn't tell you which day it changed.

06

Sleep, moving and people do a lot of the work.

These sound too simple to matter. The evidence is solid all the same. Improving sleep can lift mood: in a large trial with university students, Freeman and colleagues (2017) found that an online sleep course reduced insomnia, and with it some other mental health difficulties.

Exercise helps depression too. A review of 218 trials by Noetel and colleagues (2024) found walking or jogging, yoga and strength training all helped. Belonging to groups protects as well. Cruwys and colleagues (2013) found that people with depression who joined groups were less likely to relapse.

A new dad, exhausted and flat, sat down with his partner and a calendar and between them they blocked out one protected long sleep each at the weekend, a pram walk every morning round the park whatever the weather, and his old Wednesday five-a-side, which he'd dropped when the baby came and missed more than he'd admitted. He was terrible at five-a-side the first week, and went back anyway. Calm sounds help some people wind down at night, too, and Cool-down corner (spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes) has some.

People are not an optional extra

A meta-analysis of 148 studies, with over 300,000 people, found that people with stronger social ties had about 50% better odds of survival over the years they were followed. The studies observe rather than prove cause, but it's hard to read that and call ringing a friend a luxury.

Holt-Lunstad, Smith and Layton (2010) · *Strong: a large meta-analysis of observational studies; cause not established*

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I need help protecting my sleep for a while." "Would you come for a short walk with me? I find it hard to go on my own."



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Small, steady things help: a walk, a regular bedtime, time with someone kind. Calm sounds can be a soft way to wind down at night.

TOOL **Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

07

Trauma is about what happened, and what it left behind.

Trauma usually means going through, or seeing, something that threatened life or safety, such as violence, abuse, a serious accident, war, or the sudden death of someone close. It is very common. In surveys across 24 countries, Kessler and colleagues (2017) found about 7 in 10 adults had been through at least one.

Most people recover over time. A smaller number develop post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), with memories that come back vividly, avoiding reminders, feeling on high alert, and sleep problems. Ordinary hard times and stress hurt too, even when they aren't trauma in this sense.

Months after a crash on a wet roundabout, Shirin still jumps at the sound of brakes and won't drive after dark. Her partner has started saying "It's fine, it's fine" before she's even flinched, which she finds both sweet and maddening. Her alarm learned that cars can mean danger and hasn't unlearned it yet. That is a long way from overreacting. If something frightening happened more than a month ago and it still shapes your days, talk to a doctor. Trauma-focused talking therapies help many people.

08

After something frightening: safety, choice and no pressure.

After a frightening event, people need safety, practical help, warmth and choice. They don't need to be made to talk. A review of single-session "debriefing" after trauma by Rose and colleagues (2002) found it did not prevent PTSD, and might make things worse for some. Services that are "trauma-informed" (SAMHSA, 2014) put safety, trust, choice and working together first, and the same ideas help in families, friendships and workplaces.

Someone had been in Nan's house while she was at the shops. They took her purse from the drawer and her late husband's watch. She didn't want to talk about it, and said so, twice. Her grandson didn't push. He fixed the lock on the back door, which took him most of the afternoon and two trips to the hardware shop, and slept on her sofa. "If you ever want to talk about it, I'm here," he said in the morning, and went to work. A week later she rang him at nine at night and talked for an hour, mostly about the watch.

09

Talking therapies help many people, and medicines can too.

Cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) teaches practical ways to notice and change patterns of thinking and doing. It's one of the most studied talking therapies, and a review of over a hundred meta-analyses by Hofmann and colleagues (2012) found the strongest support for anxiety problems and stress, and support for many other problems too.

Guidelines such as NICE (2022) also recommend guided self-help, behavioural activation, exercise groups and, for some people, antidepressants. Questions about medicine, including starting, changing or

stopping it, are for a doctor or prescriber. Please don't stop a medicine suddenly without advice.

Zack was too embarrassed to ask anyone about the panic attacks. Then one stopped him getting on the 7.40 for the second week running, and he stood on the platform watching it go. His GP referred him for a short course of CBT, eight sessions. He takes the train to work again now, with a book and a bottle of water for the bad days, and there are still some bad days. Before an appointment, it helps to write three lines, on what you've noticed, how long it has gone on, and what it's stopping you doing.

WORDS TO TRY

"I'd like to talk about my mood. It's been going on for a while." "What are my options, and what do you recommend for someone like me?"

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can learn how your alarm works, keep the basics going, take small steps back towards life, and ask for help when it's more than you can carry. You can't think your way out of depression by trying harder, and you can't fix someone else's. Being kind to yourself, and getting the right help, are part of the work. If you feel unsafe, reaching out today matters more than anything in this book.

MONDAY, 7:30AM

Last night you wrote the three worries on the back of an envelope from the gas board and told them, out loud, feeling ridiculous, that they could wait till morning. You slept a bit. Now you breathe out long at the kitchen window and text your neighbour. Hospital at ten and I'm a bit scared, cuppa after?

Three hearts and "course". The appointment is still the appointment. You look at the envelope again, and the weeks of not wanting to see anyone, and add a fourth line at the bottom, smaller than the others. Ask about my mood.

If you're a teenager

Exams, friends, group chats and the future can all land at once, usually at about one in the morning. Tolu is seventeen and can't sleep the night before her chemistry exam. She writes the worry down for tomorrow's ten-minute worry time, plans one small step (ask Mr Okafor what kind of questions come up) and puts her phone out on the landing, which she hates. The next day she tells her mum, who says, "Why didn't you wake me?" and it helps more than Tolu expected.

If worry or low mood is stopping you sleeping or going to school most days for a few weeks, tell someone you trust or your doctor.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I keep worrying at night. Can I talk it through?" "I don't need you to fix it. I just need to say it."

In everyday life

Living on your own can make worry louder at night and low mood quieter and easier to miss, so one small contact a day is worth protecting, even a two-minute call (see On your own: when it's lonely, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). With a partner, low mood can look like not caring and anxiety can look like nagging, so name it plainly. "I'm low today, and I'm not cross with you." Children and teenagers get anxious and low too, and calm, routine and listening help them more than reassurance on a loop. A friend who keeps cancelling may be struggling. Keep inviting them, with no pressure to say yes.

Grief and depression overlap without being the same thing, and Chapter 8 (page 152) looks at grief on its own terms. At work, a short honest line to a manager often opens up more support than people expect. If you have ADHD, avoidance often looks like putting things off, so make the first step almost silly ("open the envelope"), set a ten-minute timer, or do it with someone else in the room. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-16-worry-in-depth).

Common mix-ups

Anxiety doesn't mean something is wrong with you. It's a normal alarm. It only becomes a problem when it rings too loud or too often, or starts shrinking your life. Depression isn't just sadness, and nobody snaps out of it. It affects sleep, energy, thinking and the body as well as mood, and many people recover with the right help. Not everything bad that happens is trauma in the clinical sense, which usually means a threat to life or safety. Other hard things still hurt and still deserve care, and the word doesn't need to fit for help to be fair. Talking about trauma straight away doesn't help everyone either. Some people want to and some don't, forcing it can make things worse, and safety and choice come first.

And asking someone about suicide does not put the idea in their head. A review by Dazzi and colleagues (2014) found no evidence that asking increases suicidal thoughts, and it may help.

If you want to help someone else with this

Notice, and ask. "You've seemed a bit low lately. How are you doing, really?" opens the door, and after that it helps to listen more than you talk. Don't argue with the feeling. "Cheer up" and "It could be worse" push people away. "That sounds really hard" keeps them close. Offer something specific, a walk or a meal or a lift to the doctor, because a small practical offer is much easier to accept than a big vague one.

Ask directly about safety if you're worried. "Are you having thoughts of ending your life?" If yes, stay with them, and get help together today. And look after yourself too, because supporting someone who is struggling is tiring (see Chapter 12, page 210).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
>
> "I'm not trying to fix it. I just want you to know I'm here." "Would it help if I came with you to the doctor?"

When to get more help

Talk to a doctor, a counsellor or a mental health service if:

- you've felt low, empty or hopeless, or lost interest in things, most days for two weeks or more;
- worry or panic is stopping you doing things, or you're avoiding more and more;
- something frightening happened over a month ago and still shapes your days and nights;
- you're using alcohol, drugs, food or anything else to cope;
- you're not sleeping, eating or looking after yourself;
- you have thoughts of harming yourself.

In England you can usually refer yourself to NHS Talking Therapies without seeing a GP first.

This chapter is general education. It isn't a diagnosis or a substitute for care from a professional.

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Workpapers **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11): a plan, made on a calm day, for hard moments.

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now): steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.
- My weather today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks): a quick daily check-in on stress, sleep and people.

Reading **pages to read on the website**

- The calm visualizer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/calm-visualizer) for slow breathing.

- The library: the stress response (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress), the window of tolerance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress#window-of-tolerance), sleep and mood (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress#sleep-and-mood), going over and over things (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), catastrophising (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking) and loneliness (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection).

More for your situation

- On your own · Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) · For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) · New parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent)
- Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers)
- At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- **More in Part Three:** Stress (page 72) · Self-worth and self-compassion (page 140) · Healing (page 197)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system
The stress ladder and rest page 72

Part Three · Chapter 7 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion
A kinder inner voice page 140

Part Three · Chapter 12 · Helping others well
Supporting someone who is struggling page 210

Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words
Checking your weather each day page 29

PUT IT TO USE



The Calm-Down Kit
A plan, made on a calm day, for hard moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11



Upset right now?
Steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

17

PART THREE · CHAPTER 17

Fitting in: groups, influence and culture

Why fitting in pulls so hard, how groups shape what we say and do, how culture and family set the unwritten rules, and how to stay yourself, and disagree kindly, without losing your place, whether the group is a family, a friendship, a team, a faith, a neighbourhood or a group chat.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. The pull to fit in is old and strong
2. We go along more than we think
3. Authority can lead people a long way
4. "Us and them" forms fast
5. Norms are the rules nobody wrote down
6. Cultures differ, and so do people inside them
7. Every family is a small culture
8. Online groups pull harder and faster
9. You can belong and still be yourself
10. Disagree kindly, and early
11. If you're a teenager
12. In everyday life
13. If you want to help someone else with this
14. When to get more help
15. Reading on this site
16. More for your situation

THURSDAY, 9:20PM

The family group chat is going. Uncle Trevor has posted a joke about your cousin's new partner, and the laughing faces are stacking up underneath it. Six, then seven, and your mum has done one.

You don't find it funny. You also don't want to be the one who can't take a joke. Your thumb is already over the little laughing face.

We all belong to groups, and we need them. Chapter 5 (page 114) looks at belonging, at why we need each other and how trust grows. This chapter

looks at the other side, at how groups pull on us, why we go along, and how to stay true to yourself while staying connected.

01

The pull to fit in is old and strong.

For most of human history, being in a group meant surviving, and being left out still feels alarming. In studies by Williams and colleagues (2000), people who were simply left out of an online ball-throwing game, by strangers they would never meet, felt worse and less as if they belonged. So we bend to stay in. We laugh at the jokes, keep quiet, go along.

At the warehouse, the new lad gets called "Prof" in his first week, because he wears glasses and once, fatally, used the word "ostensibly". He hates it. He laughs anyway, every time, because more than anything that first month he wants to be one of them. By Christmas he's down as Prof on the rota, and has mostly stopped minding.

02

We go along more than we think.

In Solomon Asch's famous experiments (Asch, 1956), people judged which of three lines matched another line. When the actors around them all gave the same wrong answer, people went along with the group on about a third of the answers, even though the right answer was obvious.

Many people never went along at all. Later research, such as a review by Bond and Smith (1996), found the effect is real but varies, smaller in more recent studies and larger in cultures that put the group first.

Everyone in the meeting loved the new rota. Bukola could see a hole the size of a bus in the Friday cover, and said nothing, because everyone loved the new rota. Afterwards, waiting for the lift, two colleagues said quietly that they'd had doubts too. All three of them went back to their desks. The rota started on the Monday and the Friday cover fell over on the first

Groupthink

Irving Janis named the moment a close group's wish to agree crowds out a realistic look at the options. His evidence was case studies of big policy decisions, so it's an idea more than a measurement, but two of his remedies travel well: the person in charge holds back their view at first, and someone is asked to argue the other side.

Janis (1972) · *Mixed: an influential idea built on case studies*

Friday. Writing your own view down before a group decides, and only then listening, makes it a good deal easier to say it.

We go along more than we think

And one other voice changes a lot.



Alone against the group



went along on about 1 in 3 answers

With one ally



going along fell sharply

One calm, kind voice saying "I see it differently" often frees others to say so too.

Asch (1956). About a quarter of people never went along. Across 133 later studies the effect held but varied by time and culture (Bond and Smith, 1996).

FIGURE 28 We go along more than we think, and one other voice changes a lot. In Asch's studies, going along fell sharply when one other person gave the right answer.

03

Authority can lead people a long way.

In Stanley Milgram's experiments (Milgram, 1963), many ordinary people kept giving what they believed were painful electric shocks to a stranger because a man in a lab coat told them to, although no shocks were real. Burger (2009) repeated part of the study safely and found similar results. The studies are also debated. Later researchers, such as Haslam and Reicher (2012), argue that people went along when they believed in the cause, and many people refused.

On a night shift, a senior doctor tells a staff nurse to give a dose that looks wrong to her. It's three in the morning, and he is very senior and very tired. She checks anyway, and then says so, and she's right. Checking was the loyal thing to do. He said thank you, eventually, and sounded as if he meant it.

Safe to speak up

In 51 teams at one manufacturing company, Amy Edmondson found that a shared sense that it was safe to take interpersonal risks went with more learning, and learning went with better performance. Most later studies are correlational, but the idea has held up widely.

Edmondson (1999) · *Strong: a highly replicated idea, though mostly correlational*

04

"Us and them" forms fast.

Part of how we see ourselves comes from our groups, whether that's a family, a town, a team, a faith or a job. Tajfel and Turner (1979) called this social identity. It brings pride and loyalty. It also makes us quick to favour "us" and to see "them" as all the same, even when the groups are formed on almost nothing.

Two branches of one family have always sat apart at weddings, and nobody can quite remember why. Something about a christening in 1994. At the most recent one a cousin quietly rearranged the seating plan, and the two sides discovered, over the cheese course, a shared and passionate weakness for terrible music. They were the last ones on the dance floor. They still sit apart at funerals, but it's a start.

05

Norms are the rules nobody wrote down.

Every group has norms about what you wear, how you speak, what you laugh at and what you never mention, and we often guess them wrong. In studies at one university, Prentice and Miller (1993) found that most students were privately less comfortable with heavy drinking than they thought everyone else was. Each person thought they were the odd one out, so everyone kept going along.

In one office everybody answered emails at midnight, because everybody thought it was expected. Then a manager said, quite casually, in a meeting about something else, that she didn't expect replies after six. You could almost hear the room breathe out. "We have always done it this way" usually means a rule nobody has checked in years, so it's worth asking when anyone last did.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 22

House rules for us

Shona and her son Dexter, 15

House rules for us

Person A
Shona

Person B
Dexter

Date of this list
3 October 2026

Our rules, and who keeps each one

Rule	Who keeps it	Why it matters to Shona	Why it matters to Dexter
Phones charge in the kitchen from 10 on school nights	*Both (decide together)*	*I sleep better knowing you're not up at 2*	*Fine if it's both our phones, not just mine*
Homework before games, Monday to Thursday	*Dexter*	*Less nagging from me*	*Weekends are mine, then*

Rule	Who keeps it	Why it matters to Shona	Why it matters to Dexter
Say where you're going and when you'll be back	*Both (decide together)*	*So I don't worry*	*Mum does it too, so it's fair*
Friday tea together, no phones at the table	*Both (decide together)*	*It's my favourite hour of the week*	*Only if I can pick the food sometimes*

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

Rules with someone who keeps them

4 of 4. Every rule has someone who keeps it.

Changes to the list

Date	What changed	Who
3 Oct 2026	*Dexter asked for weekends without phone rules. Agreed for a month, then we look again.*	*Shona and Dexter*

Made-up example. The norms nobody wrote down, written down, with room for both of them to change them.

Fill in your own: House rules for us (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

06

Cultures differ, and so do people inside them.

Cultures differ in how much they put the individual or the group first, which researchers call individualism and collectivism (Hofstede, 1980). In some, standing out is admired, and in others fitting in and keeping harmony are signs of maturity. Labels need care, though. A large review by Oyserman and colleagues (2002) found the differences were smaller and less tidy than often claimed, and individuals vary hugely within every culture.

Anjali rings her mum every day, sometimes twice. Her partner Sean, who was raised to "do his own thing" and rings his parents on birthdays, thought this was clingy. She thought he was cold, and said so, once, in the car. Each of them was following rules they'd learned before they could tie their shoes. It came out properly over a Sunday roast at her mum's, when her mum asked

Sean when he'd last rung his own mother, and he genuinely couldn't remember.

07

Every family is a small culture.

Families have their own norms about how loud people are and how feelings are shown. Some things get talked about and some never do, and there are rules about how you say sorry, if you do. Usually we only notice our family's rules when we live with someone from a different family. Where your lens came from (page 14) looks at the rules you grew up with.

Two housemates clashed over the kitchen for most of a term. In one family you wash up straight after eating. In the other you leave it to soak and do it in the morning. Each thought the other was lazy, or fussy, depending. Neither was. Each was obeying a rule from a kitchen two hundred miles away, and once they'd worked that out they made a third rule, which neither of them likes and both of them keep.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 23

Kitchen-table check-in: family plan

Amaka and Chris, new parents, with Chris's parents

Our family plan

A plan for the family, not a list of chores.

Who's in this plan (optional)
Amaka, Chris, Nana Joy and Grandad Pete

Visits
Sunday lunch every other week, 12 to 3. Text the day before.

Advice
Ask first: "Do you want ideas, or just to talk?"

The baby's or children's routines
Nap at 1. Back to sleep on her back, always. Ask us before any new food.

A regular job for a grandparent or relative
Grandad Pete does the Tuesday morning walk with the pram.

We'll look at this again on
The first Sunday of December

ON THE CARD

One topic at a time. We're on the same side.

Two family cultures, one plan written on purpose.

Fill in your own: Kitchen-table check-in: family plan
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins)

08

Online groups pull harder and faster.

Group chats, forums and social media make group pressure quicker and more public, because likes and replies show the norm instantly. In a study of over half a million posts, Brady and colleagues (2017) found that messages with more moral and emotional words spread further, mostly among people who already agreed. Outrage travels fast. Quiet doubts stay put.

A parents' group chat turned against a teacher after one angry post about a detention, forty messages in an hour. One dad, who knew her a little from the PTA, sent something calm. He said he'd want to hear her side before anyone decided anything. Two other parents agreed with him, and the thread went quiet and stayed quiet. Before you react to a heated post, wait ten minutes. The Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator) can help you read a message calmly first.



TIDBIT

Group chats move fast. Before you send a reply, a helper on the website can read the room with you.

TOOL **Chat analyzer** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

09

You can belong and still be yourself.

Belonging means being accepted as you are, whereas fitting in means changing in order to be accepted (Chapter 5, page 114, says more). Good groups have room for difference. It helps to know your own values, to have

more than one group, and to have at least one ally. In Asch's experiments, when just one other person gave the right answer, going along with the group dropped sharply.

Rory loves chess and his mates tease him about it, relentlessly. He didn't drop chess and he didn't drop his mates. He joined the club that meets in the library on Wednesdays as well, so now he has two groups and neither of them gets to decide who he is. He gets teased, and he's also county under-16 runner-up, which he mentions more often than strictly necessary.

10

Disagree kindly, and early.

You don't have to choose between going along and starting a war. A kind disagreement is short and calm, it's about the issue, and it leaves room for other people. Speaking early is easier than speaking late, and a private word often works better than speaking up in front of everyone.

Some people keep a sentence ready, for exactly this. "I see it a bit differently. Can I say why?" "I'm not comfortable with that joke." "Can we hear from people who haven't spoken yet?" Pick the one that sounds most like you and say it out loud a few times in the car, so it's there when you need it. Say it so it lands (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-09-say-it-so-it-lands) helps with the words.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Disagreeing early and kindly is easier with the words ready. This workpaper helps you say it so it lands.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can notice the pull to fit in, check what you actually think, choose your groups, and say "I see it differently" kindly.

You can't control what a group does, and you don't have to stay in a group that keeps asking you to hide who you are or go against what's right. If a group, a family or a partner uses pressure, fear or threats to control you, that's not belonging.

THURSDAY, 9:40PM

You don't press it, and you message your aunt instead, privately. I know it was meant to be funny but it might hurt if they see it. Could we leave it?

Four minutes later the joke vanishes, and then a message comes through to you. It was only a bit of fun. People are so sensitive these days. At half ten your cousin messages to say thank you, because she saw it before it went. At Sunday lunch your aunt passes you the gravy without looking at you, and you don't yet know whether that'll pass.

If you're a teenager

Group chats are where a lot of friendship happens, and a lot of hurt. Mason is fifteen when he finds a photo of himself from PE being passed round his class chat with comments under it. He doesn't answer back.

He screenshots it and mutes the chat. Then he tells his sister, and together they tell his form tutor. Then a girl in his class messages him privately to say it wasn't funny and that she's sorry she didn't say anything. Most people in a group chat don't like what's happening, and each of them thinks everyone else does.

YOU COULD SAY

"I'm not okay with this. Please delete it." To a friend, "That wasn't okay. Are you alright?" To an adult, "Something's happening online and I need help with it."

In everyday life

Having no group can be as hard as having a pushy one, and groups built round something you enjoy bring belonging along with the activity. Partners bring two families and two sets of rules, which are worth talking about openly before you make your own. Children and teenagers feel peer pressure strongly, and practising a "no" that saves face helps them. Old family roles, the peacekeeper or the black sheep, can be hard to step out of. At work,

when everyone agrees too fast, it helps if whoever leads shares their view last and asks each person to name one risk before deciding (more in the full chapter, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-17-groups-in-depth). And online, you're allowed to mute, leave, or take a break from groups that leave you feeling worse.

If you want to help someone else with this

If someone speaks up, back them up, even quietly ("I think that's a fair point"), because one ally makes a huge difference. In any group you lead, invite the quieter people and the different views by asking what nobody has thought of yet. If someone seems to be going along against their wishes, ask gently, away from the group. And keep an eye on who gets left out of the chats and the plans, so you can bring them in.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "I noticed you went quiet when they said that. Are you okay?" "I'd like to hear what you think, even if it's different."

When to get more help

Group pressure is part of life. It may be time for more help if:

- a group, family or partner controls who you see, what you wear, what you spend or what you believe, or punishes you for disagreeing;
- you feel you can't leave a group without being threatened, shamed or cut off from everyone you know;
- you're being bullied, at school, at work or online;
- being left out or pressured is leaving you very low, anxious or hopeless.

Talk to someone you trust, a counsellor or a doctor. For low mood or worry, see Chapter 16 (page 276). If you are thinking about ending your life, please tell someone today.

This chapter is general education, not therapy.

Reading on the website

Reading pages to read on the website

- The wiring card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card), to share how you work best so a group can make room for you.
- Leading a group (spreadloveandacceptance.com/groups), a six-session guide with ground rules that make room for difference.
- The library on teams (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/teams), including psychological safety.
- The library: family scripts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life), social comparison (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life#social-comparison), the false consensus effect (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking) and confirmation bias (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking#confirmation-bias).
- How communication works (page 99), on saying hard things so they land.

More for your situation

- For teens: friends and pressure (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · In-laws (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life#in-laws)
- At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- For teachers (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-teachers)
- **Related chapters:** Belonging and trust (page 114) · How we see each other (page 87) · Values (page 184)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ The pull to fit in is old and strong.
- ✓ Authority can lead people a long way.
- ✓ Norms are the rules nobody wrote down.
- ✓ Online groups pull harder and faster.
- ✓ Disagree kindly, and early.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part Three · Chapter 3 · How we see each other
Bias and the stories we tell page 87

Part Three · Chapter 5 · Attachment, trust and belonging
Why belonging matters so much page 114

Part Three · Chapter 10 · Values, meaning and a good life
Holding on to your own values page 184

Part Two · Chapter IV · Two kinds of fair
Agreeing what fair means in your group read online

PUT IT TO USE



The wiring card
To share how you work best so a group can make room for you
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card



Leading a group
A six-session guide with ground rules that make room for difference
spreadloveandacceptance.com/groups

Workpapers and tools in this book

Every workpaper and tool this book points to, in two separate lists, with the chapters and pages that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.

Workpapers mentioned in this book

Pages to fill in, on your own or together.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02
In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 29), Stress and the nervous system (page 72), Helping others well (page 210)

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03
In: Habits and change (page 127), Helping others well (page 210), Groups, influence and culture (page 279)

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-04
In: Who you are becoming (page 44)

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09
In: How communication works (page 99), Groups, influence and culture (page 279)

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11
In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 29), Who you are becoming (page 44), How feelings work (page 58), Stress and the nervous system (page 72), Anger (page 223), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 264)

WORKPAPER WP-13 **The 90-second daily check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-13
In: Habits and change (page 127)

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-15
In: Attachment, trust and belonging (page 114), Values, meaning and a good life (page 184), Closeness and love (page 252)

Tools mentioned in this book

Interactive helpers to use on the site.

TOOL **Chat analyzer** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

In: How we see each other (page 87), How communication works (page 99), Groups, influence and culture (page 279)

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

In: How we see each other (page 87), How communication works (page 99), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 140), Healing after hurt (page 197)

TOOL **Say no kindly: make your scripts** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/refusals

In: Helping others well (page 210)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: make a pause plan** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 72), Attachment, trust and belonging (page 114), Anger (page 223)

TOOL **Kitchen-table check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins

In: How communication works (page 99), Helping others well (page 210), Groups, influence and culture (page 279)

TOOL **Small wins: Flip it** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 140), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 264)

TOOL **Stay close: one small idea** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

In: How feelings work (page 58), Attachment, trust and belonging (page 114), Closeness and love (page 252)

TOOL **How you connect: what feels like care** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

In: Values, meaning and a good life (page 184), Closeness and love (page 252)

TOOL **How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

In: Where your lens came from (page 14), Your wiring, weather and words (page 29), Who you are becoming (page 44), Personality, temperament and change (page 238)

TOOL **How you connect: how I like to be spoken to** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 29), How communication works (page 99), Minds that work differently (page 165), Personality, temperament and change (page 238), Groups, influence and culture (page 279)

TOOL **Old rules, new choices** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

In: Where your lens came from (page 14), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 140), Values, meaning and a good life (page 184)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: Upset right now?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

In: How feelings work (page 58), Stress and the nervous system (page 72), How communication works (page 99), Attachment, trust and belonging (page 114), Habits and change (page 127), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 140), Loss, grief and big life changes (page 152), Healing after hurt (page 197), Anger (page 223), Closeness and love (page 252), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 264)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: soften a tense moment** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/soften-a-tense-moment

In: Anger (page 223)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 72), Loss, grief and big life changes (page 152), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 264)

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 29), How feelings work (page 58)

TOOL **My weather today: the sky (the ladder)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 72), Healing after hurt (page 197)

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 140), Loss, grief and big life changes (page 152), Healing after hurt (page 197)

TOOL **Ask Professor Puddles** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 140), Values, meaning and a good life (page 184), Helping others well (page 210)

TOOL **Read your way** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in

In: Minds that work differently (page 165)

TOOL **Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

In: Who you are becoming (page 44), Habits and change (page 127)

TOOL **Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting

In: Who you are becoming (page 44), How we see each other (page 87), How communication works (page 99), Healing after hurt (page 197)

TOOL **Plan it once: room agreement for roommates** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room`

In: Who you are becoming (page **44**), How communication works (page **99**), Minds that work differently (page **165**), Personality, temperament and change (page **238**)

TOOL **Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/work`

In: Attachment, trust and belonging (page **114**), Habits and change (page **127**), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page **140**), Values, meaning and a good life (page **184**), Helping others well (page **210**), Anger (page **223**), Personality, temperament and change (page **238**), Worry, low mood and trauma (page **264**), Groups, influence and culture (page **279**)

TOOL **Learn by doing: connect two fields of study** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/polymath`

In: Values, meaning and a good life (page **184**)

TOOL **Ten-minute start** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/start-in-10-minutes`

In: Who you are becoming (page **44**)

How the numbers work

Every number in this book is arithmetic you can do with a pencil. None of them is a test, a diagnosis or a verdict on anyone: they describe a week, a load or a way of sharing work. The weights and cut-offs are this book's own rules of thumb, not research findings, and you are free to disagree with them. The worked examples are the book's own, so you can check them against the chapters.

Two habits run through all of them. **Scores are rounded to two decimal places before their band is read,** so the number you see and the words you see always agree. And **nobody's score is ever worked out for them:** if someone's own answer is missing, the total waits.

The stress tank: How much are you carrying?

You score five things from 0 (not at all) to 4 (very true), about the last day or two: sleep debt, workload elsewhere, unresolved conflict, your physical state, and time pressure today.

```
tank = (sleep + workload + conflict + body + time) ÷ 20
```

The answer runs from 0 to 1, and **higher means fuller**. Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 up to 0.60 medium, and 0.60 or more high. (The worksheet splits each band in two for its words: very light under 0.15, light, medium on the lighter side under 0.45, medium on the heavier side, high under 0.80, and very high from 0.80.) Your **battery** is the other side of the same thing, the energy you have left, so a full tank means a low battery. The battery is a picture in words, not a second score.

> WORKED EXAMPLE Rosa, from Part Two, Chapter III (online), scores sleep 3, workload 4, conflict 1, body 2 and time 3.
>
> `3 + 4 + 1 + 2 + 3 = 13; 13 ÷ 20 = 0.65`, which is in the high band.

Two or more of you: each person scores only themselves, and the shared figure is the plain average of everyone's own scores. If any one person is at 0.60 or more, treat that as the headline, whatever the average says.

Coming back after a pause (the Calm-Down Kit): if you like numbers, take the score again after a calming round. Under 0.50, go back at the time you named. From 0.50 to 0.59, take another round. At 0.60 or more after two rounds, put it off to a named

time. The kit's line sits at 0.50 on purpose: you don't need an empty tank to come back, just one less than half full.

My weather today: the room in your day

My weather today shows words, not numbers: a sky (clear, gusty or fogged in) and how much room you have today. Behind the words sits a rough tally from 0 to 100, where **higher means a heavier day**. You only see it if you tick "Show the numbers behind this".

WHAT YOU PICKED	ADDS
The sky: clear, gusty, fogged in	0, 26, 34
The pressure: light, building, heavy (skipped: 6)	0, 10, 20
Last night's sleep: properly rested, about enough, short night, barely slept (skipped: 6)	0, 2, 10, 18
People load: barely any, a normal amount, a lot, nonstop (skipped: 4)	0, 3, 9, 14
Ground conditions (hungry, thirsty, in pain and so on)	4 each, up to 14
What's blowing in (work, money, health and so on)	3 each, up to 10

Under 45 reads as lots of room today, 45 to 64 as some room, and 65 or more as very little room.

WORKED EXAMPLE Joel, from Part One, Now, page **29**, picks gusty, building pressure, a short night, a lot of people time, one ground condition (hungry) and one thing blowing in (work).

`26 + 10 + 10 + 9 + 4 + 3 = 62`: some room today, with less than usual, so the forecast says to go gently and settle first.

On your own: is your week sustainable?

The "Who does what?" page's "just me" view adds up the hours your week is spoken for (jobs, the thinking work, care and so on) and compares them with a waking week of about 112 hours (16 waking hours, 7 days).

```
share = the hours spoken for ÷ 112
```

Under 50% reads as sustainable, 50% up to 70% as full but workable, and 70% or more as stretched. For example, 50 hours spoken for is 45%, which leaves real room; 80 hours is 71%, a lot to keep up week after week.

All of these are this book's own ways of putting things into numbers. They have not been tested in research studies, and they shouldn't be quoted as findings. The free calculators on the website do the arithmetic for you, and each one has a "How is this worked out?" note.

Blank worksheets

Photocopy or print these pages, as many times as you like, and fill them in by hand. Each one is a blank copy of a worksheet in the book. The free fillable versions on the website do the sums for you, and keep what you type on your own device.

How much are you carrying?

Fillable version: spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02.html

Fill this in on your own, about yourself only. Never fill it in for someone else.

Your name _____ Date _____

The checklist

Score each row based on how the last 24–48 hours have actually gone. Circle one: 0 = Not at all, 4 = Very true. Living with a long-term illness? Your physical row may always be high. That fills the tank; it isn't a mood.

	Not at all				Very true
Sleep debt (less rested than usual)	0	1	2	3	4
Workload elsewhere (job, school, caregiving)	0	1	2	3	4
Recent unresolved conflict (any source)	0	1	2	3	4
Physical state (hungry, sick, in pain)	0	1	2	3	4
Time pressure today specifically	0	1	2	3	4

How full is your stress tank?

Points (add the five circled numbers): _____ out of 20

Tank: points ÷ 20 = _____ out of 1.00

Higher means a fuller tank (and a lower battery). Under 0.30: light. 0.30 to 0.59: medium. 0.60 or more: high. Put off anything that doesn't need deciding in the next hour.

Optional

☐ Some of what I'm carrying is caring for someone

Anything you want to name before talking

A high score is a way to press pause, not a way out. It means "let's come back to this tomorrow," not "this doesn't need to happen."

Say it so it lands

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09.html

A self-check each of you uses on your own side of a conversation. Use it on one thing that actually stung.

Your name _____ Date _____

Before you speak or send: fact, feeling, ask

Raw reaction (optional, and just for you)

What's the fact underneath this? (One sentence, no adjectives.) For example: "The bins went out late on Tuesday."

What's the feeling underneath this? (Frustrated, tired, unseen, rushed…) A feeling about you, not a verdict about them.

What's the actual ask? (What do you want to happen next, specifically?) Something the other person can say yes to.

Before you react: four quick checks

Check	Circle one
Is this about a specific, nameable task or event?	Yes · No
Would I read this the same way if I weren't already carrying a lot?	Yes · No · Not sure
Is there a neutral interpretation that also fits what was said?	Yes · No
Am I responding to their words, or to a pattern from a past conversation?	Their words · A past pattern

A "No" or "Not sure" on the second check, a "Yes" on the third or "A past pattern" on the fourth are good reasons to pause first. A kind "not right now" and a time to come back keeps it honest.

The Calm-Down Kit

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11.html

A short plan, made ahead of time, for calming your body down enough to have the conversation, or to put it off honestly. Fill in Part A on an ordinary day, not a hard one. Your kit is yours; only the pause plan is made to share.

Whose kit is this? (your name) _____ Date _____

Part A: What tends to start it

What tends to start it	How it shows up in my body first

Part A: My two defaults

Pick two calming steps now: asymmetric breathing (breathe in for 4, out for 6) · naming the room (5 things you see, 4 you hear, 3 you can touch) · weight and pressure (feet pressed flat into the floor, or something warm held in both hands) · gating (cutting noise and light: lower the lights, step out) · walking it out · a low, steady sound.

First default _____ Second, if the first isn't available _____

Part A: My pause line

Say how you are, how long you need, and when you'll be back: "I'm at capacity. I need ten minutes. I'll be back at quarter past."

_____

Our pause plan (agree it together, and share it)

Our pause word or signal _____ The shortest break we take _____

How we set the time to come back _____ The first sentence when we come back _____

Part B, in the moment: say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step.

Part C: Coming back

Still hot? Another round. Twice? Name a new time. Settled enough to listen? Go back at the time you named. (For number fans: your stress tank score, 0 to 1. Under 0.50 go back; 0.50 to 0.59 another round; 0.60 or above after two rounds, put it off.)

Time	What I did	How I feel now (Still hot / Settled enough)	Stress tank before (0–1)	Stress tank after (0–1)

Next small action _____ If you put the conversation off: when you'll pick it back up _____

Where I've landed

☐ I'm going with this

Look at this again on (optional) _____

Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

Words used in this book

The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. More at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.

Alexithymia

Finding it hard to notice, name or describe your own feelings. It is a trait on a scale, not an illness, and it is more common in some autistic people. Naming body signals first can help.

Battery

Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, how full your stress tank is: a fuller tank means a lower battery.

For example: After a poor night and a long workday, your stress tank is nearly full and your battery is low, so a small request feels big.

A bid

A bid is any small reach for attention or connection, like "look at this," a sigh or a joke.

For example: They show you a photo of a dog. Looking and smiling back is turning towards it.

Calm-down plan

Your calm-down plan (once called the Calm-Down Kit) is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

For example: A glass of cold water, a walk to the corner, and three long breaths out.

Carrier wave

The carrier wave is the feeling that travels underneath the words: the tone that arrives before the meaning does.

For example: "Fine." can carry calm, hurt or tiredness. The carrier wave tells you which.

Check-in

A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

For example: "Load today: heavy. Thank you for the dishes. One small thing: the car. My ask: could you fill it up?"

Complacency

Complacency is what happens when something has worked for a long time and you stop checking on it. It isn't laziness or a lack of love. It's a setup nobody has looked at lately.

For example: "How was your day?" "Fine." Months go by and nobody has asked a real question.

Double empathy

The idea, from the autistic researcher Damian Milton, that misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people run both ways: each finds the other hard to read, so neither side is simply "missing" something.

Drift

Drift is how two people slowly fall out of step when nobody checks in, even when nothing is wrong.

For example: Three busy weeks, no real talk, and small things start to feel big.

Flooded

Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

For example: "I need twenty minutes. Can we talk again at eight?"

Frequency

Your frequency is your natural pace: how fast you decide, talk, reply and recover.

For example: One person answers a text in a minute; the other answers at the end of the day. Neither is wrong.

Groupthink

When a close group wants agreement so much that doubts go unsaid and a poor decision goes ahead. Irving Janis named it in 1972.

If-then plan

A small plan written as "If this happens, then I will do that", which makes a new habit easier to start (Peter Gollwitzer).

A kind no

A kind no says what you can and can't do right now, without blaming anyone.

For example: "I can't take that on this week. I could help on Saturday."

Kinship care

When a grandparent, aunt, older sibling or family friend raises a child whose parents can't.

The ladder

Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. My weather today calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

The load

The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

For example: Buying the gift is one job. Remembering the birthday, picking the gift and wrapping it are three more.

Masking

Masking is hiding the way you're wired to fit in, which can be very tiring over time.

For example: Forcing eye contact and rehearsing small talk all day, then needing the evening to recover.

Monotropism

A theory of autistic attention: attention gathers deeply on a few things at a time, rather than spreading thinly across many. Switching away can take real effort.

My weather today

My weather today is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

For example: Short night, busy day: the forecast says to keep big talks for tomorrow.

Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

For example: Sam owns the recycling: noticing it's full, taking it out and buying the bags.

Person A and Person B

Person A and Person B are simply the two people on a two-person worksheet or tool. They are labels, not a ranking.

For example: In the Chat analyzer, Person A sends the message and Person B receives it.

Pressure

Pressure, in My weather today, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

For example: A pressure of 40 leaves room in the day; 75 means go gently and leave big things for later.

Prolonged grief

Grief that stays intense and gets in the way of daily life for a long time after a death (6 to 12 months or more, depending on the guideline). It is treatable; a GP or doctor is a good first step.

Psychological safety

A shared sense in a group or team that you can speak up, ask a question or admit a mistake without being punished or embarrassed (Amy Edmondson).

Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or "Can we start over?"

For example: "I said that badly. What I meant was…"

The rulebook from home

The rulebook from home is the unwritten set of rules you grew up with, about love, upset, chores and rest, that you may still expect others to follow.

For example: "Whoever notices the mess cleans it" was the rule at home, so a messy kitchen feels like "It's always me."

Rumination

Going over the same worry or regret again and again without getting closer to an answer.

Second arrow

The extra pain we add on top of a hard moment, such as being angry at ourselves for being sad. The first arrow is the event; the second is what we tell ourselves about it (a Buddhist image).

Setup score

The one number from Is the setup working for everyone?: balance, ownership and stress added up with weights (0.40, 0.35 and 0.25), from 0 to 1. 0.70 and up is working well, 0.40 to 0.69 needs a look, under 0.40 needs a rethink, together. It judges the setup, never a person.

Static

Static is the crackle between two people when the words are fine but the tone, pace or timing doesn't match.

For example: You ask "When will you do it?" calmly. They hear pressure. Nobody meant harm, but it crackles.

Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?, scored from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 to 0.59 medium, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

Talk window

The talk window says whether now is a good time for a big conversation: open, wait a little, or closed for today.

For example: Your window says "wait," so you ask to talk after dinner instead of right now.

Wave Code

Four letters from the style quiz in How you connect, one for each of four preferences about how you take in and send words. Each letter shows where you lean on a dial today: a shorthand for preferences, not a personality type.

Window of tolerance

The range in which you can feel strong feelings and still think and talk. Above it you are flooded or revved up; below it you shut down. A phrase from the psychiatrist Dan Siegel.

Wired differently

Being wired differently means your brain works in a less common way, such as being autistic, ADHD, dyslexic or highly sensitive, which changes how words land.

For example: A hint like "the bins are full" may be heard as a plain fact, not a request.

Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

For example: Some people need a plan in writing. Others think best out loud.

Workpaper

A page you fill in, on your own or with someone, about your own week or your own side. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill in on the website.

For example: "Who did what" is a week's log of who did what.

Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

For example: "Rest is earned" can feel like plain fact, until you notice it was your family's rule.

List of figures

Figure 1 How the three parts fit together · *Front of the book* 9

Figure 2 Five ideas the whole book rests on · *Front of the book* 10

Figure 3 Three layers in every reaction · *Where your lens came from* 16

Figure 4 Each stage of life asks its own question · *Where your lens came from* 19

Figure 5 Where your lens came from, how you run today and who you are becoming, in one picture · *Where your lens came from* 25

Figure 6 A four-step self-check for a feeling that is bigger than you expected · *Your wiring, weather and words* 36

Figure 7 Your circle of control · *Your wiring, weather and words* 40

Figure 8 A kind plan for change in seven small steps · *Who you are becoming* 46

Figure 9 A feeling is a signal, not a verdict · *How feelings work* 61

Figure 10 The ladder · *Stress and the nervous system* 75

Figure 11 Flooded means offline · *Stress and the nervous system* 79

Figure 12 Seeing is a best guess · *How we see each other* 90

Figure 13 Every message says two things · *How communication works* 102

Figure 14 Say it so it lands · *How communication works* 105

Figure 15 Attachment as two scales, not four boxes · *Attachment, trust and belonging* 117

Figure 16 Habits run on cues · *Habits and change* 130

Figure 17 How long a new habit takes to feel automatic · *Habits and change* 137

Figure 18 Guilt says “I did a bad thing.” Shame says “I am bad.” Guilt is easier to put right, and self-compassion helps you cross over · *Self-worth, shame and self-compassion* 142

Figure 19 Grief comes in waves, not neat stages · *Loss, grief and big life changes* 155

Figure 20 Brains vary, like bodies do · *Minds that work differently* 168

Figure 21 Values are directions, not finish lines · *Values, meaning and a good life* 186

Figure 22 Every close relationship has breaks; what counts is the repair · *Healing after hurt* 200

Figure 23 Ask what kind of help they want · *Helping others well* 212

Figure 24 Anger rises fast, and what helps depends on how hot it is · *Anger* 227

Figure 25 Traits work like dials, and most people sit near the middle of each · *Personality, temperament and change* 241

Figure 26 Closeness grows from being known · *Closeness and love* 254

Figure 27 Avoiding keeps fear going · *Worry, low mood and trauma* 267

Figure 28 We go along more than we think, and one other voice changes a lot · *Groups, influence and culture* 281

List of filled-in examples

Example 1 — The rulebook from home · *Nadia, on her own · Where your lens came from* — 22

Example 2 — "How to talk to me" card · *Ife, made on her own to give to a friend · Your wiring, weather and words* — 31

Example 3 — My weather today · *Joel, on his own, after a short night · Your wiring, weather and words* — 33

Example 4 — The Calm-Down Kit, just for me · *Nell, on her own · Who you are becoming* — 49

Example 5 — The self path, step by step · *Sam, on their own, two weeks in · Who you are becoming* — 53

Example 6 — My weather today · *Esme, 29, after a worrying message from her manager · How feelings work* — 62

Example 7 — The ladder (the sky, in My weather today) · *Mike, who cares for his wife, Ann · Stress and the nervous system* — 76

Example 8 — Chat analyzer · *Zoe, texting her oldest friend, who moved abroad · How we see each other* — 94

Example 9 — Chat analyzer: a whole conversation · *Dana and Raj, coworkers on the same project · How communication works* — 107

Example 10 — Our pause plan · *Imani and Kwame, married ten years · Attachment, trust and belonging* — 118

Example 11 — Your done list · *Bernie, 71, living on his own · Habits and change* — 131

Example 12 — Flip it · *Hamish, 44, after a mistake at work · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion* — 144

Example 13 — Write it through · *Edith, 74, widowed, writing to her grown-up son and daughter · Loss, grief and big life changes* — 157

Example 14 — "How to talk to me" card, for work · *Tom, autistic, for his new manager · Minds that work differently* — 174

Example 15 — Keep your little rituals alive · *Lachlan and Sunita, who lead a hybrid team together · Values, meaning and a good life* — 190

Example 16 — Write it through · *Carys, writing to her brother Owen · Healing after hurt* — 201

Example 17 One owner per job: sharing the care · *Margaret and Alan, with their daughter Sue · Helping others well* 217

Example 18 The Calm-Down Kit · *Pat, a grandmother raising her grandson Jay, 13 · Anger* 228

Example 19 How you connect: the style quiz · *Mo, before moving in with his friend Callum · Personality, temperament and change* 246

Example 20 Our time-together deal · *Jamal and Tess, a couple; Jamal games most evenings · Closeness and love* 258

Example 21 Flip it · *Tolu, 17, worrying about an exam at 1am · Worry, low mood and trauma* 268

Example 22 House rules for us · *Shona and her son Dexter, 15 · Groups, influence and culture* 283

Example 23 Kitchen-table check-in: family plan · *Amaka and Chris, new parents, with Chris's parents · Groups, influence and culture* 285

Research notes

The 365 studies and books the chapters mention, chapter by chapter, each with what it found in plain words and where to read it. Each entry was looked up and checked: most against the paper itself or its abstract, some (mostly older books) against a publisher's or library's record. Unchecked works are left out. The full list, with notes on how strong each finding is, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Reading research: a few words in plain English

The chapters often say how sure the research is: "a small study", "linked with", "didn't replicate". Here is what those words mean, so every note in the book is something you can weigh for yourself.

Correlational ("linked with")
Two things tend to go together: people who sleep less tend to argue more. It doesn't show which causes which, or whether a third thing, like a new baby, causes both.

Experiment
Researchers change one thing on purpose, ideally deciding by chance who gets it, and compare. Better at showing cause, though often in a lab, for a short time, with a small group.

Meta-analysis
A study of studies: it pools many studies of the same question. Usually more trustworthy than any one study, but only as good as the studies in it.

Replication
Doing a study again to see if the result holds. When a large team re-ran 100 published psychology studies in 2015, only about a third gave a clear result again, and the effects were on average about half as big. So one study is a start, not the end.

Effect size
How big a difference is, not just whether there is one. A result can be real ("significant") and still tiny. The book says "small" or "modest" when that is the case.

Who was studied
Much of psychology studies students in Western, educated, well-off countries. A finding may not fit every age, culture or kind of family, and many studies of couples looked only at a mother and a father.

Self-report
People answered questions about themselves. That is often the only way to ask about feelings, but memory and wanting to look good both creep in.

How the book labels things: a *Research note* describes published findings in plain words and says where the evidence is thin. *This site's idea* marks the book's own ways of putting things into practice, such as the worksheets and the setup score, which have not been tested in studies. The full list at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research also says how strong each finding is: strong, moderate or early.

PART ONE · THEN

Where your lens came from

Ainsworth, M. D. S., Blehar, M. C., Waters, E., & Wall, S. (1978). *Patterns of Attachment: A Psychological Study of the Strange Situation.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ). Reported the Strange Situation studies of infants and mothers and described secure and insecure attachment patterns.
search.worldcat.org/title/4194069

Bowlby, J. (1969). *Attachment and Loss, Vol. 1: Attachment.* Hogarth Press and the Institute of Psycho-Analysis (London) / Basic Books (New York). The first volume of Bowlby's trilogy, setting out attachment theory: children's bond with caregivers is an evolved system for seeking safety and comfort.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/194760

Clark, M. S., & Mills, J. (1979). *Interpersonal attraction in exchange and communal relationships.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 37(1), 12–24. Distinguished communal relationships (benefits given in response to needs) from exchange relationships (benefits given in return for benefits). When people wanted a communal relationship, being repaid in kind reduced attraction.
clarkrelationshiplab.yale.edu

Erikson, E. H. (1950). *Childhood and Society.* New York: W. W. Norton (book). Set out eight stages of life from infancy to old age, each with its own question or tension (for example trust against mistrust in infancy, identity against confusion in adolescence).
librarything.com/work/37187

Felitti, V. J., Anda, R. F., Nordenberg, D., et al. (1998). *Relationship of childhood abuse and household dysfunction to many of the leading causes of death in adults: The Adverse Childhood Experiences (ACE) Study.* American Journal of Preventive Medicine, 14(4), 245–258. Of 13,494 adults at a large health plan sent a questionnaire, 9,508 responded; the more categories of childhood adversity people reported, the higher their risk of many adult health problems, in a graded relationship.
doi.org/10.1016/S0749-3797(98)00017-8

Gollwitzer, P. M. (1999). *Implementation intentions: Strong effects of simple plans.* American Psychologist, 54(7), 493–503. Reviewed research showing that if-then plans ("when situation X arises, I will do Y") hand control of action to the planned cue and help people act on their goals.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.54.7.493

Hazan, C., & Shaver, P. (1987). *Romantic love conceptualized as an attachment process.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 52(3), 511–524. Two questionnaire studies proposed that adult romantic love is an attachment process: the share of adults in each of three attachment styles roughly matched infant figures, and the styles differed in how people experienced love, their views of self and others, and recalled relationships with parents.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.52.3.511

Jones, E. E., & Nisbett, R. E. (1971). *The actor and the observer: Divergent perceptions of the causes of behavior.* General Learning Press (short monograph). Proposed the actor-observer hypothesis: people tend to explain their own actions by the situation and others' actions by their dispositions.
krimdok.uni-tuebingen.de/Record/1098932900

Kerr, M. E., & Bowen, M. (1988). *Family Evaluation: An Approach Based on Bowen Theory.* W. W. Norton. Explains Bowen family systems theory (differentiation, triangles, roles passed across generations) and how to evaluate a family as an emotional unit.
find.library.upenn.edu/catalog/999557963503681

Malle, B. F. (2006). *The actor-observer asymmetry in attribution: A (surprising) meta-analysis.* Psychological Bulletin, 132(6), 895–919. A meta-analysis of 173 studies found average actor-observer effects near zero; the asymmetry appeared only in some conditions (for example when actor and observer were intimates, or for negative events), with a reverse pattern for positive events.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.132.6.895

Pennebaker, J. W., & Beall, S. K. (1986). *Confronting a traumatic event: Toward an understanding of inhibition and disease.* Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 95(3), 274–281. An early expressive-writing experiment in which students wrote about traumatic experiences over several days; it launched decades of research on whether writing about difficult experiences helps health and well-being.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-843X.95.3.274

Ross, L. (1977). *The intuitive psychologist and his shortcomings: Distortions in the attribution process.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 10, 173–220. Reviewed the biases of the lay 'intuitive psychologist' and named the fundamental attribution error: underestimating situational causes and overestimating personal dispositions when explaining others' behaviour.
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(08)60357-3

Walster, E. [Hatfield, E.], Walster, G. W., & Berscheid, E. (1978). *Equity: Theory and Research.* Allyn and Bacon (Boston). Extended equity theory to close relationships: feeling under-benefited goes with anger and resentment, feeling over-benefited with guilt, and both with less satisfaction than feeling things are roughly fair.
elainehatfield.com/publications.html

PART ONE · NOW

Your wiring, weather and words

Crompton, C. J., Ropar, D., Evans-Williams, C. V. M., Flynn, E. G., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2020). *Autistic peer-to-peer information transfer is highly effective.* Autism, 24(7), 1704–1712. In "diffusion chains" where a story was passed along eight people (72 adults), all-autistic chains passed on as much detail as all-non-autistic chains, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported lower rapport.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361320919286

Gollwitzer, P. M. (1999). *Implementation intentions: Strong effects of simple plans.* American Psychologist, 54(7), 493–503. Reviewed research showing that if-then plans ("when situation X arises, I will do Y") hand control of action to the planned cue and help people act on their goals.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.54.7.493

Gollwitzer, P. M., & Sheeran, P. (2006). *Implementation intentions and goal achievement: A meta-analysis of effects and processes.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 38, 69–119. A meta-analysis of 94 independent tests found that forming if-then plans had a medium-to-large effect on reaching goals (d = .65).
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(06)38002-1

Gottman, J. M. (1994). *What predicts divorce? The relationship between marital processes and marital outcomes.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ); reissued by Routledge. Gottman's report of his long-term studies of couples, including "flooding": feeling so physically overwhelmed in a conflict that listening and thinking become very hard.
routledge.com

Hull, L., Petrides, K. V., Allison, C., Smith, P., Baron-Cohen, S., Lai, M.-C., & Mandy, W. (2017). *"Putting on my best normal": Social camouflaging in adults with autism spectrum conditions.* Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders, 47(8), 2519–2534. Interviews with 92 autistic adults described camouflaging as motivated by wanting to fit in and connect, done through masking and compensating techniques, and often followed by exhaustion and threats to self-perception.
doi.org/10.1007/s10803-017-3166-5

Kinnaird, E., Stewart, C., & Tchanturia, K. (2019). *Investigating alexithymia in autism: A systematic review and meta-analysis.* European Psychiatry, 55, 80–89. Across 15 studies, about half of autistic participants (around 50%) had high alexithymia compared with about 5% of comparison participants; alexithymia is common in autism but not universal.
doi.org/10.1016/j.eurpsy.2018.09.004

Lieberman, M. D., Eisenberger, N. I., Crockett, M. J., Tom, S. M., Pfeifer, J. H., & Way, B. M. (2007). *Putting feelings into words: Affect labeling disrupts amygdala activity in response to affective stimuli.* Psychological Science, 18(5), 421–428. In a brain-imaging study, labelling the emotion in a picture reduced amygdala and other limbic responses compared with other ways of processing the image.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2007.01916.x

Milton, D. E. M. (2012). *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

Rosenberg, M. B. (1999). *Nonviolent Communication: A Language of Compassion (later editions: A Language of Life).* PuddleDancer Press (Encinitas, CA); 2nd ed. 2003, 3rd ed. 2015. Describes Nonviolent Communication: expressing observations, feelings, needs and requests, and listening for the same in others.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/562413

Sifneos, P. E. (1973). *The prevalence of "alexithymic" characteristics in psychosomatic patients.* Psychotherapy and Psychosomatics, 22(2–6), 255–262. Introduced the term "alexithymia" for difficulty finding words for feelings, along with a limited fantasy life, and found these traits more often in psychosomatic patients than in controls.
karger.com

Walster, E. [Hatfield, E.], Walster, G. W., & Berscheid, E. (1978). *Equity: Theory and Research.* Allyn and Bacon (Boston). Extended equity theory to close relationships: feeling under-benefited goes with anger and resentment, feeling over-benefited with guilt, and both with less satisfaction than feeling things are roughly fair.
elainehatfield.com/publications.html

PART ONE · NEXT

Who you are becoming

Breines, J. G., & Chen, S. (2012). *Self-compassion increases self-improvement motivation.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 38(9), 1133–1143. In four experiments, people encouraged to be self-compassionate about a failure or moral mistake were more motivated to improve (for example, studying longer for a retest) than people encouraged to boost their self-esteem.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167212445599

Gollwitzer, P. M. (1999). *Implementation intentions: Strong effects of simple plans.* American Psychologist, 54(7), 493–503. Reviewed research showing that if-then plans ("when situation X arises, I will do Y") hand control of action to the planned cue and help people act on their goals.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.54.7.493

Gollwitzer, P. M., & Sheeran, P. (2006). *Implementation intentions and goal achievement: A meta-analysis of effects and processes.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 38, 69–119. A meta-analysis of 94 independent tests found that forming if-then plans had a medium-to-large effect on reaching goals (d = .65).
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(06)38002-1

Lally, P., van Jaarsveld, C. H. M., Potts, H. W. W., & Wardle, J. (2010). *How are habits formed: Modelling habit formation in the real world.* European Journal of Social Psychology, 40(6), 998–1009. Following 96 volunteers who repeated a daily behaviour in the same context for 12 weeks, automaticity rose along a curve that levelled off; reaching 95% of each person's plateau took between 18 and 254 days, and missing a single day did not meaningfully set progress back.
doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.674

Lazarus, R. S., & Folkman, S. (1984). *Stress, appraisal, and coping.* Springer Publishing, New York. Set out the appraisal model: stress depends on judging whether something threatens you and whether you can cope; it also distinguished problem-focused from emotion-focused coping.
wellcomecollection.org/works/b5zr7tvm

Neff, K. D. (2003). *Self-compassion: An alternative conceptualization of a healthy attitude toward oneself.* Self and Identity, 2(2), 85–101. Defined self-compassion as three parts: self-kindness instead of harsh judgement, common humanity instead of isolation, and mindfulness instead of over-identifying with painful feelings.
doi.org/10.1080/15298860309032

Nolen-Hoeksema, S. (1991). *Responses to depression and their effects on the duration of depressive episodes.* Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 100(4), 569–582. Proposed the response styles theory: people who ruminate on their low mood tend to have longer depressions than people who distract themselves.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-843X.100.4.569

Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2000). *Self-determination theory and the facilitation of intrinsic motivation, social development, and well-being.* American Psychologist, 55(1), 68–78. Summarised self-determination theory: people are most motivated and well when three basic needs are met: autonomy, competence and relatedness.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.55.1.68

PART THREE · CHAPTER 1

How feelings work

Barrett, L. F. (2017). *The theory of constructed emotion: an active inference account of interoception and categorization.* Social Cognitive and Affective Neuroscience, 12(1), 1–23. Sets out the theory that the brain constantly predicts the body's needs and constructs emotions by making sense of body sensations using learned concepts.
doi.org/10.1093/scan/nsw154

Barrett, L. F., Adolphs, R., Marsella, S., Martinez, A. M., & Pollak, S. D. (2019). *Emotional expressions reconsidered: Challenges to inferring emotion from human facial movements.* Psychological Science in the Public Interest, 20(1), 1–68. Concluded that facial movements are not reliable enough to infer a person's specific emotion across situations and cultures.
doi.org/10.1177/1529100619832930

Bird, G., & Cook, R. (2013). *Mixed emotions: The contribution of alexithymia to the emotional symptoms of autism.* Translational Psychiatry, 3(7), e285. Argued that emotional difficulties seen in some autistic people are better explained by co-occurring alexithymia than by autism itself.
doi.org/10.1038/tp.2013.61

Bushman, B. J. (2002). *Does venting anger feed or extinguish the flame? Catharsis, rumination, distraction, anger, and aggressive responding.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 28(6), 724–731. Angered people who hit a punching bag while thinking about the person who provoked them felt angrier afterwards than people who were distracted or did nothing.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167202289002

Cacioppo, J. T., & Patrick, W. (2008). *Loneliness: Human Nature and the Need for Social Connection.* W. W. Norton (New York). A book arguing that loneliness is a biological signal, like hunger, that we need connection, and that chronic loneliness can trap people in isolation and harm health.
wellcomecollection.org/works/wp45vzsp

Craig, A. D. (2002). *How do you feel? Interoception: the sense of the physiological condition of the body.* Nature Reviews Neuroscience, 3(8), 655–666. Described a pathway that carries signals about the body's internal state to the brain (including the insula), and proposed it underlies subjective feelings, emotion and self-awareness.
doi.org/10.1038/nrn894

Dutton, D. G., & Aron, A. P. (1974). *Some evidence for heightened sexual attraction under conditions of high anxiety.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 30(4), 510–517. In a field study, men approached by an attractive female interviewer on a high, swaying suspension bridge were more likely to call her afterwards than men approached on a low, sturdy bridge; the authors read this as arousal from fear being mislabelled as attraction.
doi.org/10.1037/h0037031

Ekman, P., & Friesen, W. V. (1971). *Constants across cultures in the face and emotion.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 17(2), 124–129. In the Fore people of Papua New Guinea, who had seen little Western media, adults and children mostly matched short emotion stories to the same facial expressions that Western people chose. This was taken as evidence that a few facial expressions of emotion are shared across cultures.
doi.org/10.1037/h0030377

Gross, J. J., & John, O. P. (2003). *Individual differences in two emotion regulation processes: Implications for affect, relationships, and well-being.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 85(2), 348–362. Across five studies, people who habitually reappraised had better emotional experience, relationships and well-being; habitual suppression was linked to worse outcomes.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.85.2.348

Hatfield, E., Cacioppo, J. T., & Rapson, R. L. (1994). *Emotional contagion.* Cambridge University Press (Studies in Emotion and Social Interaction). Describes emotional contagion: people tend to mimic each other's faces, voices and postures, and that mimicry can shift their own feelings.
catalogue.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/cb37435416b

James, W. (1884). *What is an emotion?* Mind, os-IX(34), 188–205. James argued that bodily changes follow directly from perceiving something exciting, and that our feeling of those bodily changes is the emotion.
doi.org/10.1093/mind/os-IX.34.188

Kashdan, T. B., Barrett, L. F., & McKnight, P. E. (2015). *Unpacking emotion differentiation: Transforming unpleasant experience by perceiving distinctions in negativity.* Current Directions in Psychological Science, 24(1), 10–16. Reviewed research on emotion differentiation (emotional granularity): people who describe negative feelings in fine-grained ways tend to rely less on unhelpful coping such as binge drinking or aggression.
doi.org/10.1177/0963721414550708

Kircanski, K., Lieberman, M. D., & Craske, M. G. (2012). *Feelings into words: Contributions of language to exposure therapy.* Psychological Science, 23(10), 1086–1091. Spider-fearful people who described their feelings in words while near a live spider showed lower skin-conductance arousal a week later than people who reappraised, distracted themselves or had exposure alone; self-reported fear did not differ between groups.
doi.org/10.1177/0956797612443830

Levant, R. F., Hall, R. J., Williams, C. M., & Hasan, N. T. (2009). *Gender differences in alexithymia.* Psychology of Men & Masculinity, 10(3), 190–203. A meta-analysis of 41 samples found that men scored slightly higher than women on alexithymia (difficulty identifying and describing feelings), but the difference was small.
doi.org/10.1037/a0015652

Lieberman, M. D., Eisenberger, N. I., Crockett, M. J., Tom, S. M., Pfeifer, J. H., & Way, B. M. (2007). *Putting feelings into words: Affect labeling disrupts amygdala activity in response to affective stimuli.* Psychological Science, 18(5), 421–428. In a brain-imaging study, labelling the emotion in a picture reduced amygdala and other limbic responses compared with other ways of processing the image.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2007.01916.x

Marlatt, G. A., & Gordon, J. R. (Eds.) (1985). *Relapse prevention: Maintenance strategies in the treatment of addictive behaviors.* Guilford Press. An edited volume setting out the cognitive-behavioural relapse prevention model, including the "abstinence violation effect": after one slip, guilt and a sense of total failure can make a full relapse more likely.
krimdok.uni-tuebingen.de/Record/27251005X

Matsumoto, D., Yoo, S. H., & Nakagawa, S. (2008). *Culture, emotion regulation, and adjustment.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 94(6), 925–937. Across 23 countries, cultures that placed more value on social order and hierarchy tended to report more suppression of emotions; cultures valuing individual autonomy and egalitarianism reported less.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.94.6.925

Milton, D. E. M. (2012). *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

Pennebaker, J. W., & Beall, S. K. (1986). *Confronting a traumatic event: Toward an understanding of inhibition and disease.* Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 95(3), 274–281. An early expressive-writing experiment in which students wrote about traumatic experiences over several days; it launched decades of research on whether writing about difficult experiences helps health and well-being.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-843X.95.3.274

Schachter, S., & Singer, J. (1962). *Cognitive, social, and physiological determinants of emotional state.* Psychological Review, 69(5), 379–399. Proposed the two-factor theory: an emotion is physical arousal plus a label we give it from the situation.
doi.org/10.1037/h0046234

Schwarz, N., & Clore, G. L. (1983). *Mood, misattribution, and judgments of well-being: Informative and directive functions of affective states.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 45(3), 513–523. People in a good mood (including people phoned on sunny days) rated their happiness and life satisfaction higher. A bad mood stopped lowering their ratings once their attention was drawn to an outside cause, such as the weather.
worlddatabaseofhappiness.eur.nl

Singer, T., & Klimecki, O. M. (2014). *Empathy and compassion.* Current Biology, 24(18), R875–R878. Distinguished empathic distress (sharing someone's pain, which can overwhelm) from compassion (warm concern), which engage different brain networks; brief compassion training increased positive feelings.
doi.org/10.1016/j.cub.2014.06.054

Torre, J. B., & Lieberman, M. D. (2018). *Putting feelings into words: Affect labeling as implicit emotion regulation.* Emotion Review, 10(2), 116–124. Reviewed evidence that naming a feeling can reduce its intensity even though it does not feel like regulating it at the time.
doi.org/10.1177/1754073917742706

Verduyn, P., & Lavrijsen, S. (2015). *Which emotions last longest and why: The role of event importance and rumination.* Motivation and Emotion, 39(1), 119–127. Of 27 emotions studied, sadness lasted longest, while shame, surprise, fear and disgust were among the shortest; long-lasting emotions tended to follow important events and involve rumination.
ppw.kuleuven.be/okp/_pdf/Verduyn2015WELLA.pdf

Wegner, D. M., Schneider, D. J., Carter, S. R., & White, T. L. (1987). *Paradoxical effects of thought suppression.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 53(1), 5–13. People asked not to think of a white bear kept thinking of it, suggesting that trying to suppress a thought can backfire.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.53.1.5

Stress and the nervous system

Arnsten, A. F. T. (2009). *Stress signalling pathways that impair prefrontal cortex structure and function.* Nature Reviews Neuroscience, 10(6), 410–422. Reviewed evidence that stress chemicals rapidly weaken the prefrontal cortex, which supports planning and flexible thinking, while strengthening more habitual responses.
doi.org/10.1038/nrn2648

Bakker, A. B., & Demerouti, E. (2007). *The job demands-resources model: State of the art.* Journal of Managerial Psychology, 22(3), 309–328. A review of the job demands-resources model: high job demands drive strain and burnout, while job resources such as support, control and feedback drive motivation and help buffer demands.
doi.org/10.1108/02683940710733115

Balban, M. Y., Neri, E., Kogon, M. M., Weed, L., Nouriani, B., Jo, B., Holl, G., Zeitzer, J. M., Spiegel, D., & Huberman, A. D. (2023). *Brief structured respiration practices enhance mood and reduce physiological arousal.* Cell Reports Medicine, 4(1), 100895. In a month-long randomised trial of five minutes a day, breathing exercises improved mood more than mindfulness meditation, with cyclic sighing (long out-breaths) showing the largest benefits.
doi.org/10.1016/j.xcrm.2022.100895

Ben Simon, E., & Walker, M. P. (2018). *Sleep loss causes social withdrawal and loneliness.* Nature Communications. After a night without sleep, young adults kept an approaching person at a greater distance and felt lonelier, with brain changes linked to social avoidance; rested people who briefly watched them felt lonelier too.
doi.org/10.1038/s41467-018-05377-0

Bolger, N., Zuckerman, A., & Kessler, R. C. (2000). *Invisible support and adjustment to stress.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 79(6), 953–961. In couples where one partner faced a stressful exam, support the recipient did not notice (reported by the giver but not the receiver) was linked with better adjustment, while noticed (visible) support was not.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.79.6.953

Coan, J. A., Schaefer, H. S., & Davidson, R. J. (2006). *Lending a hand: Social regulation of the neural response to threat.* Psychological Science, 17(12), 1032–1039. In an fMRI study, married women facing the threat of a mild shock showed less threat-related brain activity while holding their husband's hand than when alone.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2006.01832.x

Gordon, A. M., & Chen, S. (2014). *The role of sleep in interpersonal conflict: Do sleepless nights mean worse fights?* Social Psychological and Personality Science, 5(2), 168–175. In a 14-day daily study, people reported more conflict with their partner after poor nights of sleep, and conflicts were resolved best when both partners were well rested.
doi.org/10.1177/1948550613488952

Hull, L., Petrides, K. V., Allison, C., Smith, P., Baron-Cohen, S., Lai, M.-C., & Mandy, W. (2017). *"Putting on my best normal": Social camouflaging in adults with autism spectrum conditions.* Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders, 47(8), 2519–2534. Interviews with 92 autistic adults described camouflaging as motivated by wanting to fit in and connect, done through masking and compensating techniques, and often followed by exhaustion and threats to self-perception.
doi.org/10.1007/s10803-017-3166-5

Jamieson, J. P., Nock, M. K., & Mendes, W. B. (2012). *Mind over matter: Reappraising arousal improves cardiovascular and cognitive responses to stress.* Journal of Experimental Psychology: General, 141(3), 417–422. People told to see their stress arousal as helpful showed healthier cardiovascular responses and less attention to negative information than control groups.
doi.org/10.1037/a0025719

Kanner, A. D., Coyne, J. C., Schaefer, C., & Lazarus, R. S. (1981). *Comparison of two modes of stress measurement: Daily hassles and uplifts versus major life events.* Journal of Behavioral Medicine, 4(1), 1–39. Everyday hassles predicted psychological symptoms better than major life events did, and still did after life events were taken into account.
doi.org/10.1007/BF00844845

Kaplan, S. (1995). *The restorative benefits of nature: Toward an integrative framework.* Journal of Environmental Psychology, 15(3), 169–182. Set out attention restoration theory: effortful, directed attention gets fatigued, and environments such as nature, which hold attention effortlessly, help it recover; the paper links this with stress recovery.
doi.org/10.1016/0272-4944(95)90001-2

Lazarus, R. S., & Folkman, S. (1984). *Stress, appraisal, and coping.* Springer Publishing, New York. Set out the appraisal model: stress depends on judging whether something threatens you and whether you can cope; it also distinguished problem-focused from emotion-focused coping.
wellcomecollection.org/works/b5zr7tvm

Leikas, S., & Ilmarinen, V.-J. (2017). *Happy now, tired later? Extraverted and conscientious behavior are related to immediate mood gains, but to later fatigue.* Journal of Personality, 85(5), 603–615. In a 12-day experience-sampling study, acting extraverted went with better mood at the time but more fatigue about three hours later, for introverts and extraverts alike.
doi.org/10.1111/jopy.12264

McEwen, B. S., & Stellar, E. (1993). *Stress and the individual: Mechanisms leading to disease.* Archives of Internal Medicine, 153(18), 2093–2101. Introduced "allostatic load": the cumulative wear and tear on the body from repeated or chronic stress responses.
pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/8379800

Miserandino, C. (2003). *The spoon theory.* ButYouDontLookSick.com (essay). A personal essay in which Christine Miserandino, who has lupus, used a handful of spoons to show a friend that each daily task costs some of a limited supply of energy.
butyoudontlooksick.com/articles/written-by-christine/the-spoon-theory

Murray, D., Lesser, M., & Lawson, W. (2005). *Attention, monotropism and the diagnostic criteria for autism.* Autism, 9(2), 139–156. Proposed "monotropism": autistic attention tends to be pulled strongly into a few interests at a time, and the authors argued this can explain the other diagnostic features of autism.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361305051398

Raymaker, D. M., Teo, A. R., Steckler, N. A., et al. (2020). *"Having all of your internal resources exhausted beyond measure and being left with no clean-up crew": Defining autistic burnout.* Autism in Adulthood, 2(2), 132–143. From 19 interviews and 19 public online accounts, analysed with autistic co-researchers, autistic burnout was defined as long-term exhaustion, loss of function and reduced tolerance to stimulus, arising from chronic life stress and a mismatch between expectations and abilities without enough support.
doi.org/10.1089/aut.2019.0079

Repetti, R. L. (1989). *Effects of daily workload on subsequent behavior during marital interaction: The roles of social withdrawal and spouse support.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 57(4), 651–659. In a daily study of air traffic controllers, after high-workload days they were more socially withdrawn and less emotionally expressive with their spouses that evening.
psych.ucla.edu/wp-content/uploads/Repetti-JPSP-1989.pdf

Shaw, P., Stringaris, A., Nigg, J., & Leibenluft, E. (2014). *Emotion dysregulation in attention deficit hyperactivity disorder.* American Journal of Psychiatry, 171(3), 276-293. A literature review found that trouble regulating emotions (quick, strong feelings that are hard to bring back down) is common in ADHD across the lifespan, with clinic studies of young people putting it at roughly a quarter to a half, and that it adds a lot to the day-to-day difficulty ADHD brings.
doi.org/10.1176/appi.ajp.2013.13070966

Siegel, D. J. (1999). *The developing mind: Toward a neurobiology of interpersonal experience.* Guilford Press. A book linking attachment, memory and brain development; it introduced the "window of tolerance", the range of arousal in which a person can feel strong emotion and still think and respond flexibly.
catalog.library.nashville.org/Record/CARL0000114962

Sonnentag, S., & Fritz, C. (2007). *The Recovery Experience Questionnaire: Development and validation of a measure for assessing recuperation and unwinding from work.* Journal of Occupational Health Psychology, 12(3), 204–221. Identified four separate recovery experiences outside work: psychological detachment, relaxation, mastery and control.
doi.org/10.1037/1076-8998.12.3.204

Taylor, S. E., Klein, L. C., Lewis, B. P., Gruenewald, T. L., Gurung, R. A. R., & Updegraff, J. A. (2000). *Biobehavioral responses to stress in females: Tend-and-befriend, not fight-or-flight.* Psychological Review, 107(3), 411–429. Proposed that under stress people, perhaps especially women, often respond by protecting others and seeking social connection ("tend and befriend"), not only fight or flight.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-295X.107.3.411

Tronick, E., Als, H., Adamson, L., Wise, S., & Brazelton, T. B. (1978). *The infant's response to entrapment between contradictory messages in face-to-face interaction.* Journal of the American Academy of Child Psychiatry, 17(1), 1–13. The first "still face" study: when a mother kept a blank, unresponsive face, infants tried hard to re-engage her, then grew upset and withdrew; they recovered when she responded again.
doi.org/10.1016/S0002-7138(09)62273-1

Yerkes, R. M., & Dodson, J. D. (1908). *The relation of strength of stimulus to rapidity of habit-formation.* Journal of Comparative Neurology and Psychology, 18(5), 459–482. Studied how the strength of an electric shock affected how quickly dancing mice learned to avoid a black passage; later writers turned it into a general "inverted U" for arousal and performance.
doi.org/10.1002/cne.920180503

Yoo, S.-S., Gujar, N., Hu, P., Jolesz, F. A., & Walker, M. P. (2007). *The human emotional brain without sleep—a prefrontal amygdala disconnect.* Current Biology, 17(20), R877–R878. After a night without sleep, the amygdala reacted more strongly to negative pictures and was less connected to the prefrontal cortex.
doi.org/10.1016/j.cub.2007.08.007

Zaccaro, A., Piarulli, A., Laurino, M., Garbella, E., Menicucci, D., Neri, B., & Gemignani, A. (2018). *How breath-control can change your life: A systematic review on psycho-physiological correlates of slow breathing.* Frontiers in Human Neuroscience, 12, 353. Slow breathing was linked with changes in heart-rate variability and with more comfort, relaxation and alertness and less arousal and anxiety.
doi.org/10.3389/fnhum.2018.00353

PART THREE · CHAPTER 3

How we see each other

Baumeister, R. F., Bratslavsky, E., Finkenauer, C., & Vohs, K. D. (2001). *Bad is stronger than good.* Review of General Psychology, 5(4), 323–370. A wide review concluding that bad events, feedback, emotions and relationship behaviours usually have a bigger and longer-lasting effect than equally good ones.
doi.org/10.1037/1089-2680.5.4.323

Crompton, C. J., Ropar, D., Evans-Williams, C. V. M., Flynn, E. G., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2020). *Autistic peer-to-peer information transfer is highly effective.* Autism, 24(7), 1704–1712. In "diffusion chains" where a story was passed along eight people (72 adults), all-autistic chains passed on as much detail as all-non-autistic chains, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported lower rapport.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361320919286

Epley, N. (2014). *Mindwise: How We Understand What Others Think, Believe, Feel, and Want.* Alfred A. Knopf (New York). A book reviewing research on how people infer others' thoughts and feelings, and why this 'sixth sense' is more error-prone than we believe.
wellcomecollection.org/works/zh83qear

Eyal, T., Steffel, M., & Epley, N. (2018). *Perspective mistaking: Accurately understanding the mind of another requires getting perspective, not taking perspective.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 114(4), 547–571. As the title states, a series of experiments found that imagining another person's perspective did not make people more accurate about what that person thought or felt, whereas getting their perspective directly (by asking) did.
doi.org/10.1037/pspa0000115

Hastorf, A. H., & Cantril, H. (1954). *They saw a game: A case study.* Journal of Abnormal and Social Psychology, 49(1), 129–134. Students from Princeton and Dartmouth watched the same rough football game and saw it very differently, for example in how many infractions each team committed.
doi.org/10.1037/h0057880

Jones, E. E., & Harris, V. A. (1967). *The attribution of attitudes.* Journal of Experimental Social Psychology, 3(1), 1–24. In three experiments, people judged a speaker's true attitude from a speech; they tended to attribute the stated position to the speaker even when told the speaker had been assigned it.
doi.org/10.1016/0022-1031(67)90034-0

Jones, E. E., & Nisbett, R. E. (1971). *The actor and the observer: Divergent perceptions of the causes of behavior.* General Learning Press (short monograph). Proposed the actor-observer hypothesis: people tend to explain their own actions by the situation and others' actions by their dispositions.
krimdok.uni-tuebingen.de/Record/1098932900

Malle, B. F. (2006). *The actor-observer asymmetry in attribution: A (surprising) meta-analysis.* Psychological Bulletin, 132(6), 895–919. A meta-analysis of 173 studies found average actor-observer effects near zero; the asymmetry appeared only in some conditions (for example when actor and observer were intimates, or for negative events), with a reverse pattern for positive events.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.132.6.895

Milton, D. E. M. (2012). *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

Murray, D., Lesser, M., & Lawson, W. (2005). *Attention, monotropism and the diagnostic criteria for autism.* Autism, 9(2), 139–156. Proposed "monotropism": autistic attention tends to be pulled strongly into a few interests at a time, and the authors argued this can explain the other diagnostic features of autism.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361305051398

Pronin, E., Lin, D. Y., & Ross, L. (2002). *The bias blind spot: Perceptions of bias in self versus others.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 28(3), 369–381. People, from students to airport travelers, readily saw common biases in others but rated themselves as less biased than their peers (the bias blind spot).
doi.org/10.1177/0146167202286008

Ross, L. (1977). *The intuitive psychologist and his shortcomings: Distortions in the attribution process.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 10, 173–220. Reviewed the biases of the lay 'intuitive psychologist' and named the fundamental attribution error: underestimating situational causes and overestimating personal dispositions when explaining others' behaviour.
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(08)60357-3

Ross, L., & Ward, A. (1996). *Naive realism in everyday life: Implications for social conflict and misunderstanding.* In E. S. Reed, E. Turiel, & T. Brown (Eds.), Values and Knowledge (pp. 103–135). Lawrence Erlbaum / Psychology Press. Described naive realism: people assume they see the world objectively, so those who disagree must be uninformed, irrational or biased — a dynamic that fuels conflict and misunderstanding.
doi.org/10.4324/9780203773772-6

Sasson, N. J., Faso, D. J., Nugent, J., Lovell, S., Kennedy, D. P., & Grossman, R. B. (2017). *Neurotypical peers are less willing to interact with those with autism based on thin slice judgments.* Scientific Reports, 7, 40700. Across three studies, non-autistic observers formed less favourable first impressions of autistic children and adults from a few seconds of video, and were less willing to interact with them; the bias disappeared when they judged only transcripts of what was said.
doi.org/10.1038/srep40700

Tversky, A., & Kahneman, D. (1973). *Availability: A heuristic for judging frequency and probability.* Cognitive Psychology, 5(2), 207–232. People judge how common something is by how easily examples come to mind. That usually works, but vivid or recent examples make some things seem more common than they are.
apps.dtic.mil/sti/pdfs/ADA045770.pdf

How communication works

Carrère, S., & Gottman, J. M. (1999). *Predicting divorce among newlyweds from the first three minutes of a marital conflict discussion.* Family Process, 38(3), 293–301. In 124 newlywed couples, how the first three minutes of a conflict discussion went (more negative and less positive emotion) predicted which couples divorced over the next six years.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1545-5300.1999.00293.x

Crompton, C. J., Ropar, D., Evans-Williams, C. V. M., Flynn, E. G., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2020). *Autistic peer-to-peer information transfer is highly effective.* Autism, 24(7), 1704–1712. In "diffusion chains" where a story was passed along eight people (72 adults), all-autistic chains passed on as much detail as all-non-autistic chains, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported lower rapport.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361320919286

Daft, R. L., & Lengel, R. H. (1986). *Organizational information requirements, media richness and structural design.* Management Science, 32(5), 554–571. Proposed media richness theory: richer channels (face to face, then phone, then written) are better suited to ambiguous, equivocal messages.
doi.org/10.1287/mnsc.32.5.554

Epley, N., & Schroeder, J. (2014). *Mistakenly seeking solitude.* Journal of Experimental Psychology: General, 143(5), 1980–1999. Commuters asked to talk with a stranger on their train or bus reported a more positive journey than those told to sit in solitude, even though people predicted the opposite; misjudging how pleasant such talk would be keeps people apart.
doi.org/10.1037/a0037323

Gilovich, T., Savitsky, K., & Medvec, V. H. (1998). *The illusion of transparency: Biased assessments of others' ability to read one's emotional states.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 75(2), 332–346. In several sets of studies, people overestimated how well others could read their internal states (for example, liars overestimated how detectable their lies were, and people thought their disgust showed more than it did).
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.75.2.332

Gordon, T. (1970). *P.E.T.: Parent Effectiveness Training.* New York: P. H. Wyden (book; revised 2000). A parenting book and course that popularised "I-messages": describing your own feelings and the effect of a behaviour rather than blaming the other person.
search.worldcat.org/title/670595

Gottman, J. M. (1994). *What predicts divorce? The relationship between marital processes and marital outcomes.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ); reissued by Routledge. Gottman's report of his long-term studies of couples, including "flooding": feeling so physically overwhelmed in a conflict that listening and thinking become very hard.
routledge.com

Gottman, J. M., Coan, J., Carrère, S., & Swanson, C. (1998). *Predicting marital happiness and stability from newlywed interactions.* Journal of Marriage and the Family, 60(1), 5–22. In a six-year study of newlyweds, husbands who accepted influence from their wives were more likely to have stable, happy marriages, while active-listening style paraphrasing during conflict was rare and did not predict outcomes.
jstor.org/stable/353438

Gunraj, D. N., Drumm-Hewitt, A. M., Dashow, E. M., Upadhyay, S. S. N., & Klin, C. M. (2016). *Texting insincerely: The role of the period in text messaging.* Computers in Human Behavior, 55, 1067–1075. Short text-message replies ending in a period were rated as less sincere than the same replies without one; the effect did not appear for handwritten notes.
doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2015.11.003

Kruger, J., Epley, N., Parker, J., & Ng, Z.-W. (2005). *Egocentrism over e-mail: Can we communicate as well as we think?* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 89(6), 925–936. Across five experiments, people overestimated how well email recipients would detect their tone (such as sarcasm or seriousness), partly because they found it hard to step outside their own perspective.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.89.6.925

Malinowski, B. (1923). *The problem of meaning in primitive languages.* Supplement I (pp. 451–510 in later printings) in C. K. Ogden & I. A. Richards, The Meaning of Meaning. London: Kegan Paul; New York: Harcourt, Brace. Named "phatic communion": small talk whose job is not to pass on information but to create and keep up a bond ("ties of union are created by mere exchange of words").
archive.org/details/meaningofmeaning00ogde

Milton, D. E. M. (2012). *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

Rosenberg, M. B. (1999). *Nonviolent Communication: A Language of Compassion (later editions: A Language of Life).* PuddleDancer Press (Encinitas, CA); 2nd ed. 2003, 3rd ed. 2015. Describes Nonviolent Communication: expressing observations, feelings, needs and requests, and listening for the same in others.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/562413

Sandstrom, G. M., & Dunn, E. W. (2014). *Is efficiency overrated? Minimal social interactions lead to belonging and positive affect.* Social Psychological and Personality Science, 5(4), 437–442. People who had a brief, friendly social exchange with a coffee-shop barista reported more belonging and positive mood than those who kept the exchange purely efficient.
doi.org/10.1177/1948550613502990

Savitsky, K., Keysar, B., Epley, N., Carter, T., & Swanson, A. (2011). *The closeness-communication bias: Increased egocentrism among friends versus strangers.* Journal of Experimental Social Psychology, 47(1), 269–273. In three experiments, people overestimated how well they communicated with friends and spouses, more than with strangers, and made more egocentric errors following a friend's directions; closeness seemed to relax the checking people do with strangers.
sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0022103110002118

Schegloff, E. A., Jefferson, G., & Sacks, H. (1977). *The preference for self-correction in the organization of repair in conversation.* Language, 53(2), 361–382. Analyses of everyday conversation showed that 'repair' of trouble in speaking, hearing and understanding is a built-in, organised part of talk, and that people strongly prefer to correct themselves rather than be corrected.
doi.org/10.1353/lan.1977.0041

Tronick, E., Als, H., Adamson, L., Wise, S., & Brazelton, T. B. (1978). *The infant's response to entrapment between contradictory messages in face-to-face interaction.* Journal of the American Academy of Child Psychiatry, 17(1), 1–13. The first "still face" study: when a mother kept a blank, unresponsive face, infants tried hard to re-engage her, then grew upset and withdrew; they recovered when she responded again.
doi.org/10.1016/S0002-7138(09)62273-1

Watzlawick, P., Beavin [Bavelas], J. H., & Jackson, D. D. (1967). *Pragmatics of Human Communication: A Study of Interactional Patterns, Pathologies, and Paradoxes.* New York: W. W. Norton (book). Set out a few "axioms" of communication, including that every message has a content level (what is said) and a relationship level (what it says about us), and that the relationship level often decides how the content is heard.
ci.nii.ac.jp/ncid/BA01493188

Weger, H., Jr., Castle Bell, G., Minei, E. M., & Robinson, M. C. (2014). *The relative effectiveness of active listening in initial interactions.* International Journal of Listening, 28(1), 13–31. People who talked with a listener using active-listening responses felt more understood than those who received advice or simple acknowledgements; differences in satisfaction and liking were small.
doi.org/10.1080/10904018.2013.813234

Attachment, trust and belonging

Ainsworth, M. D. S., Blehar, M. C., Waters, E., & Wall, S. (1978). *Patterns of Attachment: A Psychological Study of the Strange Situation.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ). Reported the Strange Situation studies of infants and mothers and described secure and insecure attachment patterns.
search.worldcat.org/title/4194069

Baumeister, R. F., & Leary, M. R. (1995). *The need to belong: Desire for interpersonal attachments as a fundamental human motivation.* Psychological Bulletin, 117(3), 497–529. A major review arguing that the need to belong is a fundamental human motivation: people need frequent, pleasant contact within a few stable, caring relationships, and unmet belonging has wide emotional and cognitive costs.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.117.3.497

Bowlby, J. (1969). *Attachment and Loss, Vol. 1: Attachment.* Hogarth Press and the Institute of Psycho-Analysis (London) / Basic Books (New York). The first volume of Bowlby's trilogy, setting out attachment theory: children's bond with caregivers is an evolved system for seeking safety and comfort.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/194760

Brennan, K. A., Clark, C. L., & Shaver, P. R. (1998). *Self-report measurement of adult attachment: An integrative overview.* In J. A. Simpson & W. S. Rholes (Eds.), Attachment Theory and Close Relationships (pp. 46–76). Guilford. A large factor-analytic study of all known self-report adult attachment measures found that they reduce to two broad dimensions: attachment anxiety and avoidance.
labs.psychology.illinois.edu/~rcfraley/measures/brennan.html

Cacioppo, J. T., & Patrick, W. (2008). *Loneliness: Human Nature and the Need for Social Connection.* W. W. Norton (New York). A book arguing that loneliness is a biological signal, like hunger, that we need connection, and that chronic loneliness can trap people in isolation and harm health.
wellcomecollection.org/works/wp45vzsp

Coan, J. A., & Sbarra, D. A. (2015). *Social baseline theory: The social regulation of risk and effort.* Current Opinion in Psychology, 1, 87–91. Proposes that the brain expects to have supportive people around, which lowers perceived risk and effort; without them, coping takes more effort.
doi.org/10.1016/j.copsyc.2014.12.021

Coan, J. A., Schaefer, H. S., & Davidson, R. J. (2006). *Lending a hand: Social regulation of the neural response to threat.* Psychological Science, 17(12), 1032–1039. In an fMRI study, married women facing the threat of a mild shock showed less threat-related brain activity while holding their husband's hand than when alone.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2006.01832.x

Crompton, C. J., Ropar, D., Evans-Williams, C. V. M., Flynn, E. G., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2020). *Autistic peer-to-peer information transfer is highly effective.* Autism, 24(7), 1704–1712. In "diffusion chains" where a story was passed along eight people (72 adults), all-autistic chains passed on as much detail as all-non-autistic chains, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported lower rapport.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361320919286

Edmondson, A. (1999). *Psychological safety and learning behavior in work teams.* Administrative Science Quarterly, 44(2), 350–383. In 51 teams at a manufacturing company, a shared belief that it was safe to take interpersonal risks (psychological safety) was linked with more team learning behaviour, which in turn was linked with performance.
doi.org/10.2307/2666999

Eisenberger, N. I., Lieberman, M. D., & Williams, K. D. (2003). *Does rejection hurt? An fMRI study of social exclusion.* Science, 302(5643), 290–292. Being left out of a virtual ball-tossing game increased activity in the anterior cingulate cortex, a region also involved in physical pain distress, in proportion to how upset people felt.
doi.org/10.1126/science.1089134

Epley, N., & Schroeder, J. (2014). *Mistakenly seeking solitude.* Journal of Experimental Psychology: General, 143(5), 1980–1999. Commuters asked to talk with a stranger on their train or bus reported a more positive journey than those told to sit in solitude, even though people predicted the opposite; misjudging how pleasant such talk would be keeps people apart.
doi.org/10.1037/a0037323

Fraley, R. C., Hudson, N. W., Heffernan, M. E., & Segal, N. (2015). *Are adult attachment styles categorical or dimensional? A taxometric analysis of general and relationship-specific attachment orientations.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 109(2), 354–368. Taxometric analyses suggested that adult attachment differences are dimensional (degrees of anxiety and avoidance) rather than distinct types.
doi.org/10.1037/pspp0000027

Hall, J. A. (2019). *How many hours does it take to make a friend?* Journal of Social and Personal Relationships, 36(4), 1278–1296 (online first 2018). Studies of adults who had recently moved and of students found that more hours spent together, especially in leisure, went with moving from acquaintance to closer friendship.
doi.org/10.1177/0265407518761225

Hazan, C., & Shaver, P. (1987). *Romantic love conceptualized as an attachment process.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 52(3), 511–524. Two questionnaire studies proposed that adult romantic love is an attachment process: the share of adults in each of three attachment styles roughly matched infant figures, and the styles differed in how people experienced love, their views of self and others, and recalled relationships with parents.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.52.3.511

Holt-Lunstad, J., Smith, T. B., & Layton, J. B. (2010). *Social relationships and mortality risk: A meta-analytic review.* PLoS Medicine, 7(7), e1000316. A meta-analysis of 148 studies (308,849 participants) found people with stronger social relationships had about 50% greater odds of survival over the study periods, consistently across age, sex and health status.
doi.org/10.1371/journal.pmed.1000316

Hull, L., Petrides, K. V., Allison, C., Smith, P., Baron-Cohen, S., Lai, M.-C., & Mandy, W. (2017). *"Putting on my best normal": Social camouflaging in adults with autism spectrum conditions.* Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders, 47(8), 2519–2534. Interviews with 92 autistic adults described camouflaging as motivated by wanting to fit in and connect, done through masking and compensating techniques, and often followed by exhaustion and threats to self-perception.
doi.org/10.1007/s10803-017-3166-5

Lewicki, R. J., Polin, B., & Lount, R. B., Jr. (2016). *An exploration of the structure of effective apologies.* Negotiation and Conflict Management Research, 9(2), 177–196. Testing six apology components with 755 participants, acknowledging responsibility was rated most important, then an offer of repair; a request for forgiveness mattered least. Apologies with more components were rated better.
doi.org/10.1111/ncmr.12073

Main, M., & Solomon, J. (1990). *Procedures for identifying infants as disorganized/disoriented during the Ainsworth Strange Situation.* In M. T. Greenberg, D. Cicchetti & E. M. Cummings (Eds.), Attachment in the Preschool Years (pp. 121–160). University of Chicago Press. Added a fourth attachment pattern, disorganized/disoriented, for infants who seemed frightened or confused by the caregiver in the Strange Situation, with indices for coding it.
chicagoreference.com/ucp/books/book/chicago/A/bo3774473.html

Rempel, J. K., Holmes, J. G., & Zanna, M. P. (1985). *Trust in close relationships.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 49(1), 95–112. Described trust in close relationships as having three components, predictability, dependability and faith, and developed a self-report Trust Scale to measure them.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.49.1.95

Rutgers, A. H., Bakermans-Kranenburg, M. J., van IJzendoorn, M. H., & van Berckelaer-Onnes, I. A. (2004). *Autism and attachment: A meta-analytic review.* Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry, 45(6), 1123–1134. Across 16 studies, about half of autistic children in Strange Situation studies were securely attached; autistic children were less often secure on average, but the difference disappeared in samples of children with higher mental development.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1469-7610.2004.t01-1-00305.x

Sandstrom, G. M., & Dunn, E. W. (2014). *Is efficiency overrated? Minimal social interactions lead to belonging and positive affect.* Social Psychological and Personality Science, 5(4), 437–442. People who had a brief, friendly social exchange with a coffee-shop barista reported more belonging and positive mood than those who kept the exchange purely efficient.
doi.org/10.1177/1948550613502990

Tajfel, H., & Turner, J. C. (1979). *An integrative theory of intergroup conflict.* In W. G. Austin & S. Worchel (Eds.), The Social Psychology of Intergroup Relations (pp. 33–47). Brooks/Cole. Sets out social identity theory: part of our self-image comes from the groups we belong to, and we are motivated to see our groups positively, often by favouring them over others, even when groups are formed on trivial grounds.
alnap.org

Williams, K. D., Cheung, C. K. T., & Choi, W. (2000). *Cyberostracism: Effects of being ignored over the Internet.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 79(5), 748–762. In an online ball-tossing game (1,486 people from 62 countries in the first study), being left out by computer-controlled "players" made people feel worse and lowered their sense of belonging.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.79.5.748

PART THREE · CHAPTER 6

Habits and change

Baumeister, R. F., Bratslavsky, E., Muraven, M., & Tice, D. M. (1998). *Ego depletion: Is the active self a limited resource?* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 74(5), 1252–1265. In four experiments, an earlier act of self-control (such as resisting chocolate and eating radishes) was followed by giving up sooner on a later task, which the authors took as evidence that self-control draws on a limited resource.
researchconnect.suny.edu

Bem, D. J. (1972). *Self-perception theory.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 6, 1–62. Proposed that people come to know their own attitudes and feelings partly by observing their own behaviour, much as an outside observer would.
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(08)60024-6

Bolger, N., Zuckerman, A., & Kessler, R. C. (2000). *Invisible support and adjustment to stress.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 79(6), 953–961. In couples where one partner faced a stressful exam, support the recipient did not notice (reported by the giver but not the receiver) was linked with better adjustment, while noticed (visible) support was not.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.79.6.953

Breines, J. G., & Chen, S. (2012). *Self-compassion increases self-improvement motivation.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 38(9), 1133–1143. In four experiments, people encouraged to be self-compassionate about a failure or moral mistake were more motivated to improve (for example, studying longer for a retest) than people encouraged to boost their self-esteem.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167212445599

Bryan, C. J., Walton, G. M., Rogers, T., & Dweck, C. S. (2011). *Motivating voter turnout by invoking the self.* PNAS, 108(31), 12653–12656. Asking people about "being a voter" rather than "voting" increased interest in registering and, in two US statewide elections, increased turnout measured in official records.
doi.org/10.1073/pnas.1103343108

Christensen, A., & Heavey, C. L. (1990). *Gender and social structure in the demand/withdraw pattern of marital conflict.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 59(1), 73–81. Wife-demand/husband-withdraw was more common overall, but who demanded depended partly on whose issue was being discussed; the authors linked the pattern to social structure (who wants change) as well as gender.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.59.1.73

Christensen, A., Atkins, D. C., Berns, S., Wheeler, J., Baucom, D. H., & Simpson, L. E. (2004). *Traditional versus integrative behavioral couple therapy for significantly and chronically distressed married couples.* Journal of Consulting and Clinical Psychology, 72(2), 176–191. In a randomised trial with 134 seriously distressed couples, both integrative (acceptance-based) and traditional behavioural couple therapy produced similar rates of clinically significant improvement, with different patterns of change during treatment.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-006X.72.2.176

Drigotas, S. M., Rusbult, C. E., Wieselquist, J., & Whitton, S. W. (1999). *Close partner as sculptor of the ideal self: Behavioral affirmation and the Michelangelo phenomenon.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 77(2), 293–323. Across four studies, people whose partners saw and treated them in line with their ideal self moved closer to that ideal over time, and this affirmation was linked with better couple functioning and more stable relationships.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.77.2.293

Gollwitzer, P. M. (1999). *Implementation intentions: Strong effects of simple plans.* American Psychologist, 54(7), 493–503. Reviewed research showing that if-then plans ("when situation X arises, I will do Y") hand control of action to the planned cue and help people act on their goals.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.54.7.493

Gollwitzer, P. M., & Sheeran, P. (2006). *Implementation intentions and goal achievement: A meta-analysis of effects and processes.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 38, 69–119. A meta-analysis of 94 independent tests found that forming if-then plans had a medium-to-large effect on reaching goals (d = .65).
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(06)38002-1

Hagger, M. S., Chatzisarantis, N. L. D., Alberts, H., et al. (2016). *A multilab preregistered replication of the ego-depletion effect.* Perspectives on Psychological Science, 11(4), 546–573. A preregistered replication across 23 labs (2,141 participants) found an ego-depletion effect close to zero (d = 0.04, confidence interval including zero).
doi.org/10.1177/1745691616652873

Hofmann, W., Baumeister, R. F., Förster, G., & Vohs, K. D. (2012). *Everyday temptations: An experience sampling study of desire, conflict, and self-control.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 102(6), 1318–1335. Tracking people's desires through the day by smartphone, the researchers found that people high in trait self-control reported fewer temptations and conflicts, rather than resisting more often.
doi.org/10.1037/a0026545

Kahneman, D., & Tversky, A. (1979). *Prospect theory: An analysis of decision under risk.* Econometrica, 47(2), 263–291. People weigh choices as gains and losses from where they stand now, and a loss feels bigger than a gain of the same size ("loss aversion"), which helps explain why change can feel risky even when it would help.
jstor.org/stable/1914185

Lally, P., van Jaarsveld, C. H. M., Potts, H. W. W., & Wardle, J. (2010). *How are habits formed: Modelling habit formation in the real world.* European Journal of Social Psychology, 40(6), 998–1009. Following 96 volunteers who repeated a daily behaviour in the same context for 12 weeks, automaticity rose along a curve that levelled off; reaching 95% of each person's plateau took between 18 and 254 days, and missing a single day did not meaningfully set progress back.
doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.674

Marlatt, G. A., & Gordon, J. R. (Eds.) (1985). *Relapse prevention: Maintenance strategies in the treatment of addictive behaviors.* Guilford Press. An edited volume setting out the cognitive-behavioural relapse prevention model, including the "abstinence violation effect": after one slip, guilt and a sense of total failure can make a full relapse more likely.
krimdok.uni-tuebingen.de/Record/27251005X

Miller, W. R., & Rollnick, S. (1991). *Motivational interviewing: Preparing people to change addictive behavior.* Guilford Press. The first full presentation of motivational interviewing: a way of talking about change that treats mixed feelings as normal and draws out the person's own reasons for change.
motivationalinterviewing.org

Murray, D., Lesser, M., & Lawson, W. (2005). *Attention, monotropism and the diagnostic criteria for autism.* Autism, 9(2), 139–156. Proposed "monotropism": autistic attention tends to be pulled strongly into a few interests at a time, and the authors argued this can explain the other diagnostic features of autism.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361305051398

Neal, D. T., Wood, W., Wu, M., & Kurlander, D. (2011). *The pull of the past: When do habits persist despite conflict with motives?* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 37(11), 1428–1437. In field experiments on habitual eating, people with a strong cinema-popcorn habit ate stale popcorn about as much as fresh popcorn in a cinema, but not in a different setting: context cues drove the habit more than taste or intentions.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167211419863

Prochaska, J. O., & DiClemente, C. C. (1983). *Stages and processes of self-change of smoking: Toward an integrative model of change.* Journal of Consulting and Clinical Psychology, 51(3), 390–395. Applied an integrative "stages of change" model to 872 people quitting smoking on their own, describing movement through stages such as contemplation, action and maintenance.
digitalcommons.uri.edu/psy_facpubs/572

Raymaker, D. M., Teo, A. R., Steckler, N. A., et al. (2020). *"Having all of your internal resources exhausted beyond measure and being left with no clean-up crew": Defining autistic burnout.* Autism in Adulthood, 2(2), 132–143. From 19 interviews and 19 public online accounts, analysed with autistic co-researchers, autistic burnout was defined as long-term exhaustion, loss of function and reduced tolerance to stimulus, arising from chronic life stress and a mismatch between expectations and abilities without enough support.
doi.org/10.1089/aut.2019.0079

Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2000). *Self-determination theory and the facilitation of intrinsic motivation, social development, and well-being.* American Psychologist, 55(1), 68–78. Summarised self-determination theory: people are most motivated and well when three basic needs are met: autonomy, competence and relatedness.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.55.1.68

Samuelson, W., & Zeckhauser, R. (1988). *Status quo bias in decision making.* Journal of Risk and Uncertainty, 1, 7–59. In decision experiments and in real choices of health plans and retirement programmes, people disproportionately stuck with the current option (status quo bias).
jstor.org/stable/41760530

Thaler, R. H., & Sunstein, C. R. (2008). *Nudge: Improving decisions about health, wealth, and happiness.* Yale University Press. Argues that small changes in how choices are presented (defaults, order, ease) can steer people towards better decisions without removing their freedom to choose.
identity.wellcomecollection.org/works/usu4u2um

Wood, W., Quinn, J. M., & Kashy, D. A. (2002). *Habits in everyday life: Thought, emotion, and action.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 83(6), 1281–1297. In two diary studies with hourly reports, a large share of everyday behaviour was habitual (repeated in the same place, often while thinking about something else), and habits came with less stress than non-habitual actions.
dornsife.usc.edu

Self-worth, shame and self-compassion

Baumeister, R. F., Campbell, J. D., Krueger, J. I., & Vohs, K. D. (2003). *Does high self-esteem cause better performance, interpersonal success, happiness, or healthier lifestyles?* Psychological Science in the Public Interest, 4(1), 1–44. A major review concluded that high self-esteem does not reliably cause better performance or relationships; for example, good school performance partly produces high self-esteem rather than the reverse.
doi.org/10.1111/1529-1006.01431

Breines, J. G., & Chen, S. (2012). *Self-compassion increases self-improvement motivation.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 38(9), 1133–1143. In four experiments, people encouraged to be self-compassionate about a failure or moral mistake were more motivated to improve (for example, studying longer for a retest) than people encouraged to boost their self-esteem.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167212445599

Curran, T., & Hill, A. P. (2019). *Perfectionism is increasing over time: A meta-analysis of birth cohort differences from 1989 to 2016.* Psychological Bulletin, 145(4), 410–429. A meta-analysis of college students' perfectionism scores found perfectionism rose between 1989 and 2016, with the largest rise in the sense that others expect perfection.
doi.org/10.1037/bul0000138

Festinger, L. (1954). *A theory of social comparison processes.* Human Relations, 7(2), 117–140. Proposed that people judge their own opinions and abilities by comparing themselves with others, especially when there is no objective standard.
doi.org/10.1177/001872675400700202

Hewitt, P. L., & Flett, G. L. (1991). *Perfectionism in the self and social contexts: Conceptualization, assessment, and association with psychopathology.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 60(3), 456–470. Introduced a multidimensional model of perfectionism, distinguishing self-oriented, other-oriented and socially prescribed perfectionism, and linked these to psychological difficulties.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.60.3.456

Lewis, H. B. (1971). *Shame and guilt in neurosis.* International Universities Press, New York. Drawing on therapy sessions, Lewis distinguished shame, which centres on the whole self, from guilt, which centres on a specific act.
find.library.upenn.edu/catalog/99549673503681

Mueller, C. M., & Dweck, C. S. (1998). *Praise for intelligence can undermine children's motivation and performance.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 75(1), 33–52. In six studies, children praised for intelligence cared more about looking good than learning, and after failure persisted less and performed worse than children praised for effort.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.75.1.33

Neff, K. D. (2003). *Self-compassion: An alternative conceptualization of a healthy attitude toward oneself.* Self and Identity, 2(2), 85–101. Defined self-compassion as three parts: self-kindness instead of harsh judgement, common humanity instead of isolation, and mindfulness instead of over-identifying with painful feelings.
doi.org/10.1080/15298860309032

Nolen-Hoeksema, S. (1991). *Responses to depression and their effects on the duration of depressive episodes.* Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 100(4), 569–582. Proposed the response styles theory: people who ruminate on their low mood tend to have longer depressions than people who distract themselves.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-843X.100.4.569

Tangney, J. P., & Dearing, R. L. (2002). *Shame and guilt.* Guilford Press. Summarizes years of research distinguishing shame (about the self) from guilt (about the act): guilt-proneness goes with empathy and repair, shame-proneness with hiding, blame and anger.
guilford.com/books/Shame-and-Guilt/Tangney-Dearing/9781572309876

Loss, grief and big life changes

Bonanno, G. A. (2004). *Loss, trauma, and human resilience: Have we underestimated the human capacity to thrive after extremely aversive events?* American Psychologist, 59(1), 20–28. Argued that resilience after loss or trauma is distinct from recovery, is more common than many theorists assumed, and can come about in several ways.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.59.1.20

Bonanno, G. A. (2009). *The other side of sadness: What the new science of bereavement tells us about life after loss.* Basic Books. A book summarising bereavement research: most people are resilient after a loss, grief tends to come and go rather than follow fixed stages, and only a minority develop long-lasting, severe grief.
hachettebookgroup.com

Boss, P. (1999). *Ambiguous loss: Learning to live with unresolved grief.* Harvard University Press. Named "ambiguous loss": losses without clear closure, such as someone physically absent but psychologically present, or present but psychologically changed (as in dementia), and suggested ways to cope.
bookshare.org/browse/book/2050897

Bowlby, J. (1969). *Attachment and Loss, Vol. 1: Attachment.* Hogarth Press and the Institute of Psycho-Analysis (London) / Basic Books (New York). The first volume of Bowlby's trilogy, setting out attachment theory: children's bond with caregivers is an evolved system for seeking safety and comfort.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/194760

Bridges, W. (1980). *Transitions: Making sense of life's changes.* Addison-Wesley. Distinguished outer change from inner transition and described three phases: endings, a "neutral zone", and new beginnings.
narrativestudies.lib.unb.ca/bibcite/reference/16554

Doka, K. J. (Ed.) (1989). *Disenfranchised grief: Recognizing hidden sorrow.* Lexington Books. Coined "disenfranchised grief": grief that is not openly acknowledged, publicly mourned or socially supported.
openlibrary.org/books/OL354418M

Holmes, T. H., & Rahe, R. H. (1967). *The Social Readjustment Rating Scale.* Journal of Psychosomatic Research, 11(2), 213–218. Created the Social Readjustment Rating Scale, a list of 43 life events (such as divorce, job loss, moving and bereavement) rated by how much readjustment they demand.
doi.org/10.1016/0022-3999(67)90010-4

Klass, D., Silverman, P. R., & Nickman, S. L. (Eds.) (1996). *Continuing bonds: New understandings of grief.* Taylor & Francis. Challenged the idea that healthy mourning means cutting ties with the dead, showing across many groups that ongoing inner bonds with the deceased are common and often healthy.
routledge.com

Kübler-Ross, E. (1969). *On death and dying.* Macmillan. Described five stages (denial, anger, bargaining, depression, acceptance) from work with dying patients.
search.worldcat.org/title/4238

Martin, T. L., & Doka, K. J. (2000). *Men don't cry... women do: Transcending gender stereotypes of grief.* Brunner/Mazel. Described intuitive (feeling-focused) and instrumental (thinking- and doing-focused) grieving patterns, plus blended ones, arguing that they are related to gender but not determined by it.
opac.tangaza.ac.ke/bib/168348

O'Connor, M.-F. (2022). *The grieving brain: The surprising science of how we learn from love and loss.* HarperOne. A neuroscientist's account of grief as partly a learning problem: the brain must slowly update a map of the world in which the lost person is always there.
newbooksnetwork.com/the-grieving-brain

Pennebaker, J. W., & Beall, S. K. (1986). *Confronting a traumatic event: Toward an understanding of inhibition and disease.* Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 95(3), 274–281. An early expressive-writing experiment in which students wrote about traumatic experiences over several days; it launched decades of research on whether writing about difficult experiences helps health and well-being.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-843X.95.3.274

Stroebe, M., & Schut, H. (1999). *The dual process model of coping with bereavement: Rationale and description.* Death Studies, 23(3), 197–224. Proposed the dual process model: healthy grieving moves back and forth (oscillates) between loss-oriented and restoration-oriented coping, including taking breaks from grief.
research-portal.uu.nl

PART THREE · CHAPTER 9

Minds that work differently

American Speech-Language-Hearing Association (ASHA) (2018). *Facilitated communication [Position statement].* ASHA policy PS2018-00352. States that facilitated communication, where a helper supports the person's hand or arm while they type or point, is discredited: research has found the messages come from the facilitator, and it should not be used.
asha.org/policy/ps2018-00352

Aron, E. N., & Aron, A. (1997). *Sensory-processing sensitivity and its relation to introversion and emotionality.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 73(2), 345–368. Across seven studies, the authors identified a single core trait of sensory-processing sensitivity, partly independent of introversion and emotionality, and developed the 27-item Highly Sensitive Person Scale.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.73.2.345

Au-Yeung, S. K., Freeth, M., & Thompson, A. R. (2025). *'Am I gonna regret this?': The experiences of diagnostic disclosure in autistic adults.* Autism, 29(8), 2181–2192. In interviews with 12 adults diagnosed as autistic in adulthood, telling others helped some reach support, be more themselves and help others, but many had not been believed, which made them more cautious about telling.
doi.org/10.1177/13623613251337504

Barkley, R. A. (1997). *Behavioral inhibition, sustained attention, and executive functions: Constructing a unifying theory of ADHD.* Psychological Bulletin, 121(1), 65–94. A theoretical review proposing that ADHD centres on a difficulty with behavioural inhibition, which in turn affects executive functions such as working memory, self-regulation of emotion and motivation, and the sense of time.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.121.1.65

Bird, G., & Cook, R. (2013). *Mixed emotions: The contribution of alexithymia to the emotional symptoms of autism.* Translational Psychiatry, 3(7), e285. Argued that emotional difficulties seen in some autistic people are better explained by co-occurring alexithymia than by autism itself.
doi.org/10.1038/tp.2013.61

Blackwell, A. G. (2017). *The curb-cut effect.* Stanford Social Innovation Review, 15(1), Winter 2017. An essay arguing that laws and programmes designed for disadvantaged groups, like kerb cuts made for wheelchair users, often end up benefiting everyone.
ssir.org/issue/winter-2017

Botha, M., & Frost, D. M. (2020). *Extending the minority stress model to understand mental health problems experienced by the autistic population.* Society and Mental Health, 10(1), 20–34. In 111 autistic adults, everyday discrimination, internalised stigma and concealing being autistic predicted poorer mental health even after accounting for general stress, suggesting minority stress plays a part.
doi.org/10.1177/2156869318804297

Cooper, K., Smith, L. G. E., & Russell, A. (2017). *Social identity, self-esteem, and mental health in autism.* European Journal of Social Psychology, 47(7), 844–854. In 272 autistic and 267 non-autistic participants, autistic people who identified more strongly with other autistic people had higher self-esteem, which was in turn linked to lower anxiety and depression.
doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.2297

Crompton, C. J., Ropar, D., Evans-Williams, C. V. M., Flynn, E. G., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2020). *Autistic peer-to-peer information transfer is highly effective.* Autism, 24(7), 1704–1712. In "diffusion chains" where a story was passed along eight people (72 adults), all-autistic chains passed on as much detail as all-non-autistic chains, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported lower rapport.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361320919286

Demetriou, E. A., Lampit, A., Quintana, D. S., et al. (2018). *Autism spectrum disorders: A meta-analysis of executive function.* Molecular Psychiatry, 23, 1198–1204. Pooling 235 studies with over 14,000 participants, found that autistic people on average scored lower than non-autistic people across executive function tasks, with wide variation and mixed findings across ages.
doi.org/10.1038/mp.2017.75

Donnellan, A. M. (1984). *The criterion of the least dangerous assumption.* Behavioral Disorders, 9(2), 141–150. Proposed that when we lack evidence about what someone can understand or do, we should act on the assumption that would do the least harm if wrong, which usually means presuming competence.
scholar.google.com

Dunn, W. (1997). *The impact of sensory processing abilities on the daily lives of young children and their families: A conceptual model.* Infants & Young Children, 9(4), 23–35. Proposed a model of sensory processing in which people differ in their neurological thresholds (high or low) and in how they respond (going along with them or acting against them), giving four patterns that affect daily life.
doi.org/10.1097/00001163-199704000-00005

Grove, R., Hoekstra, R. A., Wierda, M., & Begeer, S. (2018). *Special interests and subjective wellbeing in autistic adults.* Autism Research, 11(5), 766–775. In a survey of autistic adults in the Netherlands Autism Register, about two-thirds reported a special interest; greater motivation for the interest was linked to higher wellbeing, while very high intensity of engagement was linked to lower wellbeing.
research.vu.nl

Hull, L., Petrides, K. V., Allison, C., Smith, P., Baron-Cohen, S., Lai, M.-C., & Mandy, W. (2017). *"Putting on my best normal": Social camouflaging in adults with autism spectrum conditions.* Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders, 47(8), 2519–2534. Interviews with 92 autistic adults described camouflaging as motivated by wanting to fit in and connect, done through masking and compensating techniques, and often followed by exhaustion and threats to self-perception.
doi.org/10.1007/s10803-017-3166-5

Kapp, S. K., Steward, R., Crane, L., Elliott, D., Elphick, C., Pellicano, E., & Russell, G. (2019). *"People should be allowed to do what they like": Autistic adults' views and experiences of stimming.* Autism, 23(7), 1782–1792. Interviews and focus groups with 32 autistic adults described stimming as a way to regulate overwhelming emotions and sensations, and as something that becomes accepted through understanding; participants objected to efforts to stop harmless stimming.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361319829628

Kenny, L., Hattersley, C., Molins, B., Buckley, C., Povey, C., & Pellicano, E. (2016). *Which terms should be used to describe autism? Perspectives from the UK autism community.* Autism, 20(4), 442–462. A survey of 3,470 people in the UK autism community found no single preferred term: "autism" and "on the autism spectrum" were widely endorsed, and "autistic" was favoured by many autistic adults and families but much less by professionals.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361315588200

Kildahl, A. N., Helverschou, S. B., Rysstad, A. L., Wigaard, E., Hellerud, J. M., Ludvigsen, L. B., & Howlin, P. (2021). *Pathological demand avoidance in children and adolescents: A systematic review.* Autism, 25(8), 2162–2176. Reviewing 13 studies, found they nearly all relied on Newson's original descriptions and mostly on parent reports, seldom considered other explanations such as anxiety, and none asked people with the profile about their own experience.
doi.org/10.1177/13623613211034382

Leedham, A., Thompson, A. R., Smith, R., & Freeth, M. (2020). *'I was exhausted trying to figure it out': The experiences of females receiving an autism diagnosis in middle to late adulthood.* Autism, 24(1), 135–146. Interviews with eleven autistic women diagnosed at 40 or older explored how they made sense of a lifetime of feeling different and how the diagnosis changed their understanding of themselves.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361319853442

Millar, D. C., Light, J. C., & Schlosser, R. W. (2006). *The impact of augmentative and alternative communication intervention on the speech production of individuals with developmental disabilities: A research review.* Journal of Speech, Language, and Hearing Research, 49(2), 248–264. Across 23 studies (67 people aged 2 to 60), AAC did not hold back speech, and in many cases speech increased, though most studies lacked strong experimental control.
doi.org/10.1044/1092-4388(2006/021)

Milton, D. E. M. (2012). *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

Miserandino, C. (2003). *The spoon theory.* ButYouDontLookSick.com (essay). A personal essay in which Christine Miserandino, who has lupus, used a handful of spoons to show a friend that each daily task costs some of a limited supply of energy.
butyoudontlooksick.com/articles/written-by-christine/the-spoon-theory

Murray, D., Lesser, M., & Lawson, W. (2005). *Attention, monotropism and the diagnostic criteria for autism.* Autism, 9(2), 139–156. Proposed "monotropism": autistic attention tends to be pulled strongly into a few interests at a time, and the authors argued this can explain the other diagnostic features of autism.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361305051398

Newson, E., Le Maréchal, K., & David, C. (2003). *Pathological demand avoidance syndrome: A necessary distinction within the pervasive developmental disorders.* Archives of Disease in Childhood, 88(7), 595–600. Proposed recognising "pathological demand avoidance" as a separate profile within the autism spectrum, based on 150 cases with an equal sex ratio, describing strong avoidance of everyday demands.
doi.org/10.1136/adc.88.7.595

NHS (n.d.). *Prosopagnosia (face blindness).* NHS website (nhs.uk), health A to Z. Describes face blindness as difficulty recognising faces, often present from childhood and sometimes running in families; there is no treatment, but strategies such as recognising voices, hair or clothes, and telling people, can help.
nhs.uk/conditions/face-blindness

Phung, J., Penner, M., Pirlot, C., & Welch, C. (2021). *What I wish you knew: Insights on burnout, inertia, meltdown, and shutdown from autistic youth.* Frontiers in Psychology, 12, 741421. Interviews with eight autistic children and young people explored burnout, inertia, meltdown and shutdown as separate experiences, what they feel like, and what others do that helps or makes them worse.
doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2021.741421

Raymaker, D. M., Teo, A. R., Steckler, N. A., et al. (2020). *"Having all of your internal resources exhausted beyond measure and being left with no clean-up crew": Defining autistic burnout.* Autism in Adulthood, 2(2), 132–143. From 19 interviews and 19 public online accounts, analysed with autistic co-researchers, autistic burnout was defined as long-term exhaustion, loss of function and reduced tolerance to stimulus, arising from chronic life stress and a mismatch between expectations and abilities without enough support.
doi.org/10.1089/aut.2019.0079

Sasson, N. J., & Morrison, K. E. (2019). *First impressions of adults with autism improve with diagnostic disclosure and increased autism knowledge of peers.* Autism, 23(1), 50–59. 215 observers formed more favourable first impressions of autistic adults when told they were autistic, and observers who knew more about autism rated them more favourably.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361317729526

Sasson, N. J., Faso, D. J., Nugent, J., Lovell, S., Kennedy, D. P., & Grossman, R. B. (2017). *Neurotypical peers are less willing to interact with those with autism based on thin slice judgments.* Scientific Reports, 7, 40700. Across three studies, non-autistic observers formed less favourable first impressions of autistic children and adults from a few seconds of video, and were less willing to interact with them; the bias disappeared when they judged only transcripts of what was said.
doi.org/10.1038/srep40700

Weigelt, S., Koldewyn, K., & Kanwisher, N. (2012). *Face identity recognition in autism spectrum disorders: A review of behavioral studies.* Neuroscience & Biobehavioral Reviews, 36(3), 1060–1084. Found that autistic people were, on average, less accurate at recognising and remembering face identity, especially when memory was involved, while processing faces in broadly the same way; whether the difficulty is specific to faces was unclear.
doi.org/10.1016/j.neubiorev.2011.12.008

PART THREE · CHAPTER 10

Values, meaning and a good life

Baumeister, R. F., Vohs, K. D., Aaker, J. L., & Garbinsky, E. N. (2013). *Some key differences between a happy life and a meaningful life.* Journal of Positive Psychology, 8(6), 505–516. In surveys of about 400 adults, happiness and meaningfulness overlapped but differed: good health and an easy life went with happiness but not meaning, while thinking more about the past and future went with more meaning but less happiness.
doi.org/10.1080/17439760.2013.830764

Curry, O. S., Rowland, L. A., Van Lissa, C. J., Zlotowitz, S., McAlaney, J., & Whitehouse, H. (2018). *Happy to help? A systematic review and meta-analysis of the effects of performing acts of kindness on the well-being of the actor.* Journal of Experimental Social Psychology, 76, 320–329. A meta-analysis of 27 experiments found that performing acts of kindness had a small-to-medium positive effect on the giver's well-being (δ = 0.28).
doi.org/10.1016/j.jesp.2018.02.014

Gollwitzer, P. M. (1999). *Implementation intentions: Strong effects of simple plans.* American Psychologist, 54(7), 493–503. Reviewed research showing that if-then plans ("when situation X arises, I will do Y") hand control of action to the planned cue and help people act on their goals.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.54.7.493

Hayes, S. C., Strosahl, K. D., & Wilson, K. G. (1999). *Acceptance and commitment therapy: An experiential approach to behavior change.* Guilford Press. The first main book on acceptance and commitment therapy (ACT), which puts chosen values at the centre and teaches making room for difficult feelings while acting on what matters.
contextualscience.org/publications/hayes_strosahl_wilson_1999

Lally, P., van Jaarsveld, C. H. M., Potts, H. W. W., & Wardle, J. (2010). *How are habits formed: Modelling habit formation in the real world.* European Journal of Social Psychology, 40(6), 998–1009. Following 96 volunteers who repeated a daily behaviour in the same context for 12 weeks, automaticity rose along a curve that levelled off; reaching 95% of each person's plateau took between 18 and 254 days, and missing a single day did not meaningfully set progress back.
doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.674

Lazarus, R. S., & Folkman, S. (1984). *Stress, appraisal, and coping.* Springer Publishing, New York. Set out the appraisal model: stress depends on judging whether something threatens you and whether you can cope; it also distinguished problem-focused from emotion-focused coping.
wellcomecollection.org/works/b5zr7tvm

Markus, H. R., & Kitayama, S. (1991). *Culture and the self: Implications for cognition, emotion, and motivation.* Psychological Review, 98(2), 224–253. Argued that cultures differ in how they construe the self, as independent or interdependent with others, and that this shapes cognition, emotion and motivation.
sites.duke.edu

Martela, F., & Steger, M. F. (2016). *The three meanings of meaning in life: Distinguishing coherence, purpose, and significance.* Journal of Positive Psychology, 11(5), 531–545. Proposed that meaning in life has three parts: coherence (life makes sense), purpose (having core goals and direction) and significance (feeling that one's life has value).
research.aalto.fi

Milton, D. E. M. (2012). *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

Murray, D., Lesser, M., & Lawson, W. (2005). *Attention, monotropism and the diagnostic criteria for autism.* Autism, 9(2), 139–156. Proposed "monotropism": autistic attention tends to be pulled strongly into a few interests at a time, and the authors argued this can explain the other diagnostic features of autism.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361305051398

Ross, L., & Ward, A. (1996). *Naive realism in everyday life: Implications for social conflict and misunderstanding.* In E. S. Reed, E. Turiel, & T. Brown (Eds.), Values and Knowledge (pp. 103–135). Lawrence Erlbaum / Psychology Press. Described naive realism: people assume they see the world objectively, so those who disagree must be uninformed, irrational or biased — a dynamic that fuels conflict and misunderstanding.
doi.org/10.4324/9780203773772-6

Rotter, J. B. (1966). *Generalized expectancies for internal versus external control of reinforcement.* Psychological Monographs: General and Applied, 80(1), 1–28. Described individual differences in "locus of control", how far people believe outcomes depend on their own actions rather than outside forces, and introduced a scale to measure it.
doi.org/10.1037/h0092976

Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2000). *Self-determination theory and the facilitation of intrinsic motivation, social development, and well-being.* American Psychologist, 55(1), 68–78. Summarised self-determination theory: people are most motivated and well when three basic needs are met: autonomy, competence and relatedness.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.55.1.68

Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2001). *On happiness and human potentials: A review of research on hedonic and eudaimonic well-being.* Annual Review of Psychology, 52, 141–166. Reviewed two traditions of well-being research: hedonic (pleasure and the absence of pain) and eudaimonic (meaning, self-realisation and full functioning), and how they diverge and complement each other.
doi.org/10.1146/annurev.psych.52.1.141

Ryff, C. D. (1989). *Happiness is everything, or is it? Explorations on the meaning of psychological well-being.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 57(6), 1069–1081. Proposed six dimensions of psychological well-being (self-acceptance, positive relations, autonomy, environmental mastery, purpose in life and personal growth) and tested them with 321 adults, finding that several were not captured by earlier happiness measures.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.57.6.1069

Schwartz, S. H. (1992). *Universals in the content and structure of values: Theoretical advances and empirical tests in 20 countries.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 25, 1–65. Using data from 20 countries, found that the meaning of a set of basic value types was broadly similar across most groups, and that values are organised by two dimensions into a circle of compatible and conflicting motivations.
cris.huji.ac.il

Steger, M. F., Frazier, P., Oishi, S., & Kaler, M. (2006). *The Meaning in Life Questionnaire: Assessing the presence of and search for meaning in life.* Journal of Counseling Psychology, 53(1), 80–93. Developed the 10-item Meaning in Life Questionnaire, which separately measures the presence of meaning and the search for meaning, and tested its reliability and validity across three studies.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-0167.53.1.80

Healing after hurt

Baumeister, R. F., Stillwell, A., & Wotman, S. R. (1990). *Victim and perpetrator accounts of interpersonal conflict: Autobiographical narratives about anger.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 59(5), 994–1005. People wrote stories about a time they angered someone and a time someone angered them; perpetrators and victims described the same kinds of event very differently, for example in how serious, understandable and finished the harm was.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.59.5.994

Bonanno, G. A. (2004). *Loss, trauma, and human resilience: Have we underestimated the human capacity to thrive after extremely aversive events?* American Psychologist, 59(1), 20–28. Argued that resilience after loss or trauma is distinct from recovery, is more common than many theorists assumed, and can come about in several ways.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.59.1.20

Carrère, S., & Gottman, J. M. (1999). *Predicting divorce among newlyweds from the first three minutes of a marital conflict discussion.* Family Process, 38(3), 293–301. In 124 newlywed couples, how the first three minutes of a conflict discussion went (more negative and less positive emotion) predicted which couples divorced over the next six years.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1545-5300.1999.00293.x

Cohen, S., & Wills, T. A. (1985). *Stress, social support, and the buffering hypothesis.* Psychological Bulletin, 98(2), 310–357. A review arguing that social support protects (buffers) people from the harmful effects of stress, especially perceived availability of support, alongside general main effects of being socially integrated.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.98.2.310

Eisenberger, N. I., Lieberman, M. D., & Williams, K. D. (2003). *Does rejection hurt? An fMRI study of social exclusion.* Science, 302(5643), 290–292. Being left out of a virtual ball-tossing game increased activity in the anterior cingulate cortex, a region also involved in physical pain distress, in proportion to how upset people felt.
doi.org/10.1126/science.1089134

Eubanks, C. F., Muran, J. C., & Safran, J. D. (2018). *Alliance rupture repair: A meta-analysis.* Psychotherapy, 55(4), 508–519. Across 11 studies (1,314 patients), repairing ruptures in the therapist-client relationship was moderately associated with better outcomes; training therapists in rupture repair did not show a significant effect on outcomes in 6 studies.
doi.org/10.1037/pst0000185

Frattaroli, J. (2006). *Experimental disclosure and its moderators: A meta-analysis.* Psychological Bulletin, 132(6), 823–865. Pooling 146 randomised studies, experimental disclosure (such as expressive writing) had a small but significant positive average effect.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.132.6.823

Frazier, P., Tennen, H., Gavian, M., Park, C., Tomich, P., & Tashiro, T. (2009). *Does self-reported posttraumatic growth reflect genuine positive change?* Psychological Science, 20(7), 912–919. Measuring 122 students before and after a trauma, the researchers found that self-reported growth was largely unrelated to actual measured change, and perceived growth went with more distress while actual growth went with less.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2009.02381.x

Gordon, K. C., Baucom, D. H., & Snyder, D. K. (2004). *An integrative intervention for promoting recovery from extramarital affairs.* Journal of Marital and Family Therapy, 30(2), 213–231. In a small study of six couples who had a structured couples therapy after an affair, most were less distressed by the end, and the hurt partners reported more forgiveness. The therapy moved in stages: dealing with the shock, understanding how the affair came about, and then deciding how to move on.
pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/15114949

Gottman, J. M. (2011). *The Science of Trust: Emotional Attunement for Couples.* W. W. Norton (New York). A book drawing on Gottman's lab research and game theory to argue that trust is built through emotional attunement in everyday moments, and describing how couples can repair it.
wwnorton.co.uk/books/9780393705959-the-science-of-trust

Kim, P. H., Ferrin, D. L., Cooper, C. D., & Dirks, K. T. (2004). *Removing the shadow of suspicion: The effects of apology versus denial for repairing competence- versus integrity-based trust violations.* Journal of Applied Psychology, 89(1), 104–118. Trust was repaired more successfully when people apologised for competence-based violations but denied culpability for integrity-based violations, depending also on later evidence of guilt or innocence.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.89.1.104

Leary, M. R., Springer, C., Negel, L., Ansell, E., & Evans, K. (1998). *The causes, phenomenology, and consequences of hurt feelings.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 74(5), 1225–1237. Hurt feelings were triggered by events that signalled relational devaluation (feeling less valued by someone), usually by people the person knew well.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.74.5.1225

Leary, M. R., Tate, E. B., Adams, C. E., Allen, A. B., & Hancock, J. (2007). *Self-compassion and reactions to unpleasant self-relevant events: The implications of treating oneself kindly.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 92(5), 887–904. In five studies, self-compassion softened people's reactions to unpleasant events in ways distinct from, and sometimes more helpful than, self-esteem.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.92.5.887

Lewicki, R. J., Polin, B., & Lount, R. B., Jr. (2016). *An exploration of the structure of effective apologies.* Negotiation and Conflict Management Research, 9(2), 177–196. Testing six apology components with 755 participants, acknowledging responsibility was rated most important, then an offer of repair; a request for forgiveness mattered least. Apologies with more components were rated better.
doi.org/10.1111/ncmr.12073

McNulty, J. K. (2008). *Forgiveness in marriage: Putting the benefits into context.* Journal of Family Psychology, 22(1), 171–175. Looked at newly married couples and argued, as the title says, that the benefits of forgiving depend on the context, such as how often a partner behaves badly.
doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.22.1.171

McNulty, J. K. (2011). *The dark side of forgiveness: The tendency to forgive predicts continued psychological and physical aggression in marriage.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 37(6), 770–783. In newlywed couples over four years, partners' aggression stayed stable towards more forgiving spouses but declined towards less forgiving ones, suggesting forgiveness can remove consequences that would discourage repeat offending.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167211407077

Milton, D. E. M. (2012). *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

Neff, K. D. (2003). *Self-compassion: An alternative conceptualization of a healthy attitude toward oneself.* Self and Identity, 2(2), 85–101. Defined self-compassion as three parts: self-kindness instead of harsh judgement, common humanity instead of isolation, and mindfulness instead of over-identifying with painful feelings.
doi.org/10.1080/15298860309032

Nolen-Hoeksema, S. (1991). *Responses to depression and their effects on the duration of depressive episodes.* Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 100(4), 569–582. Proposed the response styles theory: people who ruminate on their low mood tend to have longer depressions than people who distract themselves.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-843X.100.4.569

Pennebaker, J. W., & Beall, S. K. (1986). *Confronting a traumatic event: Toward an understanding of inhibition and disease.* Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 95(3), 274–281. An early expressive-writing experiment in which students wrote about traumatic experiences over several days; it launched decades of research on whether writing about difficult experiences helps health and well-being.
doi.org/10.1037/0021-843X.95.3.274

Pillemer, K. (2020). *Fault Lines: Fractured Families and How to Mend Them.* Avery (Penguin Random House). Draws on the Cornell Reconciliation Project, including a national survey on estrangement and interviews, to show family estrangement is more common than people assume and that some people reconcile.
search.worldcat.org/oclc/1145305518

Raymaker, D. M., Teo, A. R., Steckler, N. A., et al. (2020). *"Having all of your internal resources exhausted beyond measure and being left with no clean-up crew": Defining autistic burnout.* Autism in Adulthood, 2(2), 132–143. From 19 interviews and 19 public online accounts, analysed with autistic co-researchers, autistic burnout was defined as long-term exhaustion, loss of function and reduced tolerance to stimulus, arising from chronic life stress and a mismatch between expectations and abilities without enough support.
doi.org/10.1089/aut.2019.0079

Rempel, J. K., Holmes, J. G., & Zanna, M. P. (1985). *Trust in close relationships.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 49(1), 95–112. Described trust in close relationships as having three components, predictability, dependability and faith, and developed a self-report Trust Scale to measure them.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.49.1.95

Rosenberg, M. B. (1999). *Nonviolent Communication: A Language of Compassion (later editions: A Language of Life).* PuddleDancer Press (Encinitas, CA); 2nd ed. 2003, 3rd ed. 2015. Describes Nonviolent Communication: expressing observations, feelings, needs and requests, and listening for the same in others.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/562413

Tedeschi, R. G., & Calhoun, L. G. (1996). *The Posttraumatic Growth Inventory: Measuring the positive legacy of trauma.* Journal of Traumatic Stress, 9(3), 455–471. Developed the 21-item Posttraumatic Growth Inventory with five areas of reported growth: new possibilities, relating to others, personal strength, spiritual change and appreciation of life.
doi.org/10.1007/BF02103658

Tronick, E., Als, H., Adamson, L., Wise, S., & Brazelton, T. B. (1978). *The infant's response to entrapment between contradictory messages in face-to-face interaction.* Journal of the American Academy of Child Psychiatry, 17(1), 1–13. The first "still face" study: when a mother kept a blank, unresponsive face, infants tried hard to re-engage her, then grew upset and withdrew; they recovered when she responded again.
doi.org/10.1016/S0002-7138(09)62273-1

Wade, N. G., Hoyt, W. T., Kidwell, J. E. M., & Worthington, E. L., Jr. (2014). *Efficacy of psychotherapeutic interventions to promote forgiveness: A meta-analysis.* Journal of Consulting and Clinical Psychology, 82(1), 154–170. Across 54 reports, people in explicit forgiveness interventions reported more forgiveness than untreated controls and than those in other treatments, along with larger improvements in depression, anxiety and hope than no treatment.
doi.org/10.1037/a0035268

PART THREE · CHAPTER 12

Helping others well

Bloom, P. (2016). *Against empathy: The case for rational compassion.* Ecco. A book arguing that empathy, feeling what others feel, is biased towards people like us and can cloud judgment, and that reasoned compassion is a better guide to helping.
wellcomecollection.org/works/c5q8eupq

Bolger, N., Zuckerman, A., & Kessler, R. C. (2000). *Invisible support and adjustment to stress.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 79(6), 953–961. In couples where one partner faced a stressful exam, support the recipient did not notice (reported by the giver but not the receiver) was linked with better adjustment, while noticed (visible) support was not.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.79.6.953

Brown, S. L., Nesse, R. M., Vinokur, A. D., & Smith, D. M. (2003). *Providing social support may be more beneficial than receiving it: Results from a prospective study of mortality.* Psychological Science, 14(4), 320–327. In a five-year study of older married adults, those who reported giving practical help to others or emotional support to their spouse had lower mortality, while receiving support was not linked to mortality once giving was accounted for.
researchconnect.stonybrook.edu

Cutrona, C. E., & Russell, D. W. (1990). *Type of social support and specific stress: Toward a theory of optimal matching.* In B. R. Sarason, I. G. Sarason & G. R. Pierce (Eds.), Social Support: An Interactional View (pp. 319–366). New York: Wiley. Proposed the "optimal matching" idea: support helps most when its type fits the problem, for example practical help for things you can change and comfort for things you can't.
search.worldcat.org

Darley, J. M., & Latané, B. (1968). *Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 8(4), 377–383. Participants who believed others could also hear a person having a seizure were slower and less likely to help; the presence of others reduced each person's sense of responsibility.
doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

Dazzi, T., Gribble, R., Wessely, S., & Fear, N. T. (2014). *Does asking about suicide and related behaviours induce suicidal ideation? What is the evidence?* Psychological Medicine, 44(16), 3361–3363. A review of published studies in adults and adolescents, in the general population and in groups at higher risk. None found a significant rise in suicidal thoughts after people were asked about suicide; talking about it may even lower them.
pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/24998511

Dunn, E. W., Aknin, L. B., & Norton, M. I. (2008). *Spending money on others promotes happiness.* Science, 319(5870), 1687–1688. Spending more of one's income on others predicted greater happiness in a nationally representative survey and in a field study of windfall spending, and people randomly assigned to spend money on others were happier than those assigned to spend it on themselves.
doi.org/10.1126/science.1150952

Figley, C. R. (Ed.) (1995). *Compassion fatigue: Coping with secondary traumatic stress disorder in those who treat the traumatized.* Brunner/Mazel, New York. An edited volume introducing "compassion fatigue" as a cost of helping traumatized people, distinguished from burnout and PTSD, with ideas for prevention.
routledge.com

Fischer, P., Krueger, J. I., Greitemeyer, T., Vogrincic, C., Kastenmüller, A., Frey, D., Heene, M., Wicher, M., & Kainbacher, M. (2011). *The bystander-effect: A meta-analytic review on bystander intervention in dangerous and non-dangerous emergencies.* Psychological Bulletin, 137(4), 517–537. Across 105 effect sizes and over 7,700 participants, the bystander effect was reliable but weaker when situations were clearly dangerous.
doi.org/10.1037/a0023304

Flynn, F. J., & Lake, V. K. B. (Bohns) (2008). *"If you need help, just ask": Underestimating compliance with direct requests for help.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 95(1), 128–143. In five studies, people asking for help underestimated how many others would agree to a direct request, by as much as 50%, partly because they overlooked how awkward it feels to say no.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.95.1.128

Helgeson, V. S., & Fritz, H. L. (1998). *A theory of unmitigated communion.* Personality and Social Psychology Review, 2(3), 173–183. Proposed "unmitigated communion", focusing on others to the exclusion of oneself, and distinguished it from healthy caring; unmitigated communion, not communion, was linked to psychological distress.
doi.org/10.1207/s15327957pspr0203_2

Hobfoll, S. E. (1989). *Conservation of resources: A new attempt at conceptualizing stress.* American Psychologist, 44(3), 513–524. Proposed conservation of resources theory: stress arises when people's valued resources are threatened or lost, or when investing resources does not pay off, and people strive to protect what they have.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.44.3.513

House, J. S. (1981). *Work Stress and Social Support.* Addison-Wesley (Reading, MA). A book on social support at work that distinguished emotional, instrumental, informational and appraisal support.
libcat.library.tamu.edu/Record/in00000649568

Maslach, C., & Jackson, S. E. (1981). *The measurement of experienced burnout.* Journal of Occupational Behaviour (now Journal of Organizational Behavior), 2(2), 99–113. Developed the Maslach Burnout Inventory, with three subscales: emotional exhaustion, depersonalization, and reduced personal accomplishment.
scienceopen.com/document/vid/19d4ed76-9f31-47eb-93e2-81f08d26f4d4

Miller, W. R., & Rollnick, S. (1991). *Motivational interviewing: Preparing people to change addictive behavior.* Guilford Press. The first full presentation of motivational interviewing: a way of talking about change that treats mixed feelings as normal and draws out the person's own reasons for change.
motivationalinterviewing.org

Miserandino, C. (2003). *The spoon theory.* ButYouDontLookSick.com (essay). A personal essay in which Christine Miserandino, who has lupus, used a handful of spoons to show a friend that each daily task costs some of a limited supply of energy.
butyoudontlooksick.com/articles/written-by-christine/the-spoon-theory

Philpot, R., Liebst, L. S., Levine, M., Bernasco, W., & Lindegaard, M. R. (2020). *Would I be helped? Cross-national CCTV footage shows that intervention is the norm in public conflicts.* American Psychologist, 75(1), 66–75. Analysing CCTV footage of real public conflicts in three countries, the researchers found that at least one bystander intervened in most incidents, at similar rates across countries, and that more bystanders made intervention more likely.
doi.org/10.1037/amp0000469

Pinquart, M., & Sörensen, S. (2003). *Differences between caregivers and noncaregivers in psychological health and physical health: A meta-analysis.* Psychology and Aging, 18(2), 250–267. Across 84 studies, caregivers reported more stress and depression and lower wellbeing and self-efficacy than non-caregivers, with smaller differences in physical health; gaps were larger for dementia caregivers.
doi.org/10.1037/0882-7974.18.2.250

Raymaker, D. M., Teo, A. R., Steckler, N. A., et al. (2020). *"Having all of your internal resources exhausted beyond measure and being left with no clean-up crew": Defining autistic burnout.* Autism in Adulthood, 2(2), 132–143. From 19 interviews and 19 public online accounts, analysed with autistic co-researchers, autistic burnout was defined as long-term exhaustion, loss of function and reduced tolerance to stimulus, arising from chronic life stress and a mismatch between expectations and abilities without enough support.
doi.org/10.1089/aut.2019.0079

Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2000). *Self-determination theory and the facilitation of intrinsic motivation, social development, and well-being.* American Psychologist, 55(1), 68–78. Summarised self-determination theory: people are most motivated and well when three basic needs are met: autonomy, competence and relatedness.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.55.1.68

Singer, T., & Klimecki, O. M. (2014). *Empathy and compassion.* Current Biology, 24(18), R875–R878. Distinguished empathic distress (sharing someone's pain, which can overwhelm) from compassion (warm concern), which engage different brain networks; brief compassion training increased positive feelings.
doi.org/10.1016/j.cub.2014.06.054

World Health Organization (2019). *Burn-out an "occupational phenomenon": International Classification of Diseases.* WHO news item, 28 May 2019. ICD-11 includes burn-out as an occupational phenomenon, not a medical condition: a syndrome from chronic workplace stress that has not been successfully managed, with exhaustion, mental distance or cynicism about one's job, and reduced professional efficacy. WHO says the term should not be used for other areas of life.
who.int

Anger

Baumeister, R. F., Stillwell, A., & Wotman, S. R. (1990). *Victim and perpetrator accounts of interpersonal conflict: Autobiographical narratives about anger.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 59(5), 994–1005. People wrote stories about a time they angered someone and a time someone angered them; perpetrators and victims described the same kinds of event very differently, for example in how serious, understandable and finished the harm was.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.59.5.994

Bushman, B. J. (2002). *Does venting anger feed or extinguish the flame? Catharsis, rumination, distraction, anger, and aggressive responding.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 28(6), 724–731. Angered people who hit a punching bag while thinking about the person who provoked them felt angrier afterwards than people who were distracted or did nothing.
doi.org/10.1177/0146167202289002

Bushman, B. J., Bonacci, A. M., Pedersen, W. C., Vasquez, E. A., & Miller, N. (2005). *Chewing on it can chew you up: Effects of rumination on triggered displaced aggression.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 88(6), 969–983. In three experiments, people who ruminated about a provocation, even for eight hours, were later more aggressive towards someone who only mildly annoyed them than people who were distracted.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.88.6.969

Carver, C. S., & Harmon-Jones, E. (2009). *Anger is an approach-related affect: Evidence and implications.* Psychological Bulletin, 135, 183–204. A review of evidence that anger is usually an "approach" emotion: like eagerness, it moves people towards a goal or obstacle rather than away from it.
doi.org/10.1037/a0013965

Chida, Y., & Steptoe, A. (2009). *The association of anger and hostility with future coronary heart disease: A meta-analytic review of prospective evidence.* Journal of the American College of Cardiology, 53(11), 936–946. Anger and hostility were linked with a modestly higher risk of later coronary heart disease events, in both initially healthy people and people with heart disease; the link was no longer significant in studies that controlled for behaviours such as smoking.
doi.org/10.1016/j.jacc.2008.11.044

Crompton, C. J., Ropar, D., Evans-Williams, C. V. M., Flynn, E. G., & Fletcher-Watson, S. (2020). *Autistic peer-to-peer information transfer is highly effective.* Autism, 24(7), 1704–1712. In "diffusion chains" where a story was passed along eight people (72 adults), all-autistic chains passed on as much detail as all-non-autistic chains, while mixed chains lost detail faster and reported lower rapport.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361320919286

Del Vecchio, T., & O'Leary, K. D. (2004). *Effectiveness of anger treatments for specific anger problems: A meta-analytic review.* Clinical Psychology Review, 24(1), 15–34. Across 23 controlled studies of adults with anger problems, anger treatments produced medium to large effects; cognitive approaches did well for long-standing (trait) anger, anger suppression and driving anger, and relaxation for in-the-moment anger.
doi.org/10.1016/j.cpr.2003.09.006

Gordon, A. M., & Chen, S. (2014). *The role of sleep in interpersonal conflict: Do sleepless nights mean worse fights?* Social Psychological and Personality Science, 5(2), 168–175. In a 14-day daily study, people reported more conflict with their partner after poor nights of sleep, and conflicts were resolved best when both partners were well rested.
doi.org/10.1177/1948550613488952

Gordon, T. (1970). *P.E.T.: Parent Effectiveness Training.* New York: P. H. Wyden (book; revised 2000). A parenting book and course that popularised "I-messages": describing your own feelings and the effect of a behaviour rather than blaming the other person.
search.worldcat.org/title/670595

Gross, J. J. (1998). *The emerging field of emotion regulation: An integrative review.* Review of General Psychology, 2(3), 271–299. Set out the process model of emotion regulation, with five points where emotion can be shaped: situation selection, situation modification, attention, cognitive change (reappraisal) and response modulation.
doi.org/10.1037/1089-2680.2.3.271

Gross, J. J., & John, O. P. (2003). *Individual differences in two emotion regulation processes: Implications for affect, relationships, and well-being.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 85(2), 348–362. Across five studies, people who habitually reappraised had better emotional experience, relationships and well-being; habitual suppression was linked to worse outcomes.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.85.2.348

James, W. (1884). *What is an emotion?* Mind, os-IX(34), 188–205. James argued that bodily changes follow directly from perceiving something exciting, and that our feeling of those bodily changes is the emotion.
doi.org/10.1093/mind/os-IX.34.188

Kapp, S. K., Steward, R., Crane, L., Elliott, D., Elphick, C., Pellicano, E., & Russell, G. (2019). *"People should be allowed to do what they like": Autistic adults' views and experiences of stimming.* Autism, 23(7), 1782–1792. Interviews and focus groups with 32 autistic adults described stimming as a way to regulate overwhelming emotions and sensations, and as something that becomes accepted through understanding; participants objected to efforts to stop harmless stimming.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361319829628

Kinnaird, E., Stewart, C., & Tchanturia, K. (2019). *Investigating alexithymia in autism: A systematic review and meta-analysis.* European Psychiatry, 55, 80–89. Across 15 studies, about half of autistic participants (around 50%) had high alexithymia compared with about 5% of comparison participants; alexithymia is common in autism but not universal.
doi.org/10.1016/j.eurpsy.2018.09.004

Kjærvik, S. L., & Bushman, B. J. (2024). *A meta-analytic review of anger management activities that increase or decrease arousal: What fuels or douses rage?* Clinical Psychology Review (April 2024). Across 154 studies, activities that calm the body (such as slow breathing, relaxation and mindfulness) reduced anger and aggression, while arousal-increasing activities showed little or no benefit.
news.osu.edu

Kross, E., Ayduk, O., & Mischel, W. (2005). *When asking "why" does not hurt: Distinguishing rumination from reflective processing of negative emotions.* Psychological Science, 16(9), 709–715. After recalling an anger-provoking experience, people who asked why they felt as they did from a self-distanced perspective showed less emotional reactivity than those who relived it through their own eyes.
rascl.studentorg.berkeley.edu/assets/files/kross_etal_2005_ps.pdf

Mischkowski, D., Kross, E., & Bushman, B. J. (2012). *Flies on the wall are less aggressive: Self-distancing "in the heat of the moment" reduces aggressive thoughts, angry feelings and aggressive behavior.* Journal of Experimental Social Psychology. After being provoked, people who reflected on the moment from a distanced, "fly on the wall" view felt less angry and behaved less aggressively than people who relived it from their own point of view.
doi.org/10.1016/j.jesp.2012.03.012

Mostofsky, E., Penner, E. A., & Mittleman, M. A. (2014). *Outbursts of anger as a trigger of acute cardiovascular events: A systematic review and meta-analysis.* European Heart Journal, 35(21), 1404–1410. Across nine case-crossover studies, the rate of heart attacks, strokes and arrhythmias was higher in the two hours after an outburst of anger than at other times, especially for people already at high risk.
doi.org/10.1093/eurheartj/ehu033

Rosenberg, M. B. (1999). *Nonviolent Communication: A Language of Compassion (later editions: A Language of Life).* PuddleDancer Press (Encinitas, CA); 2nd ed. 2003, 3rd ed. 2015. Describes Nonviolent Communication: expressing observations, feelings, needs and requests, and listening for the same in others.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/562413

Saini, M. (2009). *A meta-analysis of the psychological treatment of anger: Developing guidelines for evidence-based practice.* Journal of the American Academy of Psychiatry and the Law, 37(4), 473–488. Across 96 studies and 139 treatment effects, psychological treatments for anger (such as CBT, skills training and relaxation) were generally effective, with considerable variation between treatments and studies.
pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/20018996

Shaw, P., Stringaris, A., Nigg, J., & Leibenluft, E. (2014). *Emotion dysregulation in attention deficit hyperactivity disorder.* American Journal of Psychiatry, 171(3), 276–293. A literature review found that trouble regulating emotions (quick, strong feelings that are hard to bring back down) is common in ADHD across the lifespan, with clinic studies of young people putting it at roughly a quarter to a half, and that it adds a lot to the day-to-day difficulty ADHD brings.
doi.org/10.1176/appi.ajp.2013.13070966

PART THREE · CHAPTER 14

Personality, temperament and change

Aron, E. N., & Aron, A. (1997). *Sensory-processing sensitivity and its relation to introversion and emotionality.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 73(2), 345–368. Across seven studies, the authors identified a single core trait of sensory-processing sensitivity, partly independent of introversion and emotionality, and developed the 27-item Highly Sensitive Person Scale.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.73.2.345

Bleidorn, W., Schwaba, T., Zheng, A., Hopwood, C. J., Sosa, S. S., Roberts, B. W., & Briley, D. A. (2022). *Personality stability and change: A meta-analysis of longitudinal studies.* Psychological Bulletin, 148(7–8), 588–619. Who is more or less of a trait compared with others becomes steadier through childhood and levels off by about 25, while average levels keep shifting gently across life, with emotional stability rising most.
doi.org/10.1037/bul0000365

Grove, R., Hoekstra, R. A., Wierda, M., & Begeer, S. (2018). *Special interests and subjective wellbeing in autistic adults.* Autism Research, 11(5), 766–775. In a survey of autistic adults in the Netherlands Autism Register, about two-thirds reported a special interest; greater motivation for the interest was linked to higher wellbeing, while very high intensity of engagement was linked to lower wellbeing.
research.vu.nl

Hudson, N. W., & Fraley, R. C. (2015). *Volitional personality trait change: Can people choose to change their personality traits?* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 109(3), 490–507. In two 16-week studies, people who wanted to change a trait tended to shift a little in that direction, especially when they set concrete plans to act differently.
doi.org/10.1037/pspp0000021

Hull, L., Petrides, K. V., Allison, C., Smith, P., Baron-Cohen, S., Lai, M.-C., & Mandy, W. (2017). *"Putting on my best normal": Social camouflaging in adults with autism spectrum conditions.* Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders, 47(8), 2519–2534. Interviews with 92 autistic adults described camouflaging as motivated by wanting to fit in and connect, done through masking and compensating techniques, and often followed by exhaustion and threats to self-perception.
doi.org/10.1007/s10803-017-3166-5

Leedham, A., Thompson, A. R., Smith, R., & Freeth, M. (2020). *'I was exhausted trying to figure it out': The experiences of females receiving an autism diagnosis in middle to late adulthood.* Autism, 24(1), 135–146. Interviews with eleven autistic women diagnosed at 40 or older explored how they made sense of a lifetime of feeling different and how the diagnosis changed their understanding of themselves.
doi.org/10.1177/1362361319853442

Leikas, S., & Ilmarinen, V.-J. (2017). *Happy now, tired later? Extraverted and conscientious behavior are related to immediate mood gains, but to later fatigue.* Journal of Personality, 85(5), 603–615. In a 12-day experience-sampling study, acting extraverted went with better mood at the time but more fatigue about three hours later, for introverts and extraverts alike.
doi.org/10.1111/jopy.12264

McCrae, R. R., & Costa, P. T., Jr. (1987). *Validation of the five-factor model of personality across instruments and observers.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 52(1), 81–90. Ratings of 275 adults by their peers showed the same five broad trait factors found in self-reports, and peers and the people themselves agreed moderately well. This helped establish the "Big Five" as a common map of personality.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.52.1.81

Roberts, B. W., Luo, J., Briley, D. A., Chow, P. I., Su, R., & Hill, P. L. (2017). *A systematic review of personality trait change through intervention.* Psychological Bulletin, 143(2), 117–141. Across 207 studies, personality trait scores changed noticeably during therapy and other interventions over about six months, mostly towards more emotional stability, and the changes lasted in follow-ups.
doi.org/10.1037/bul0000088

Roberts, B. W., Walton, K. E., & Viechtbauer, W. (2006). *Patterns of mean-level change in personality traits across the life course: A meta-analysis of longitudinal studies.* Psychological Bulletin, 132(1), 1–25. Pooling 92 long-term studies, people on average became more confident in social settings, more conscientious and more emotionally stable, especially between about 20 and 40, and traits kept changing in middle and old age.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.132.1.1

Thomas, A., & Chess, S. (1977). *Temperament and Development.* New York: Brunner/Mazel. From the New York Longitudinal Study, which followed children from infancy, the authors described inborn differences in temperament, such as activity, regularity, adaptability and mood, and argued that how well a child's temperament fits their surroundings matters ("goodness of fit").
wellcomecollection.org/works/epddh966

PART THREE · CHAPTER 15

Closeness and love

Acevedo, B. P., & Aron, A. (2009). *Does a long-term relationship kill romantic love?* Review of General Psychology, 13(1), 59–65. Reviewing studies of short- and long-term relationships, the authors concluded that romantic love without obsession can last in long-term relationships and is linked with greater satisfaction and well-being.
doi.org/10.1037/a0014226

Algoe, S. B., Gable, S. L., & Maisel, N. C. (2010). *It's the little things: Everyday gratitude as a booster shot for romantic relationships.* Personal Relationships, 17(2), 217–233. In a daily-diary study of cohabiting couples, feeling gratitude after a partner's thoughtful act predicted greater relationship connection and satisfaction the next day, for both partners.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1475-6811.2010.01273.x

Aron, A., & Aron, E. N. (1986). *Love and the Expansion of Self: Understanding Attraction and Satisfaction.* Hemisphere Publishing (Washington, DC). Introduced the self-expansion model: people are motivated to grow by including a partner's perspectives, resources and identity in their sense of self.
libcat.library.tamu.edu/Record/in00000408876

Aron, A., Melinat, E., Aron, E. N., Vallone, R. D., & Bator, R. J. (1997). *The experimental generation of interpersonal closeness: A procedure and some preliminary findings.* Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 23(4), 363–377. Pairs of strangers who spent about 45 minutes on gradually deepening self-disclosure tasks (the "36 questions") felt closer afterwards than pairs given small-talk tasks; matching on attitudes or expecting to like each other made no significant difference.
ggia.berkeley.edu/practice/36_questions_for_increasing_closeness

Aron, A., Norman, C. C., Aron, E. N., McKenna, C., & Heyman, R. E. (2000). *Couples' shared participation in novel and arousing activities and experienced relationship quality.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 78(2), 273–284. Couples who took part together in a novel, mildly challenging activity reported higher relationship quality afterwards than couples who did a mundane task.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.78.2.273

Baumeister, R. F., & Leary, M. R. (1995). *The need to belong: Desire for interpersonal attachments as a fundamental human motivation.* Psychological Bulletin, 117(3), 497–529. A major review arguing that the need to belong is a fundamental human motivation: people need frequent, pleasant contact within a few stable, caring relationships, and unmet belonging has wide emotional and cognitive costs.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.117.3.497

Carstensen, L. L., Isaacowitz, D. M., & Charles, S. T. (1999). *Taking time seriously: A theory of socioemotional selectivity.* American Psychologist, 54(3), 165–181. Proposes that perceived time left shapes social goals: when time feels open-ended people seek new information and contacts; when it feels limited they focus on fewer, emotionally meaningful relationships.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.54.3.165

Driver, J. L., & Gottman, J. M. (2004). *Daily marital interactions and positive affect during marital conflict among newlywed couples.* Family Process, 43(3), 301–314. Observing 49 newlywed couples over dinner and in a conflict discussion, the authors linked turning towards each other's everyday bids with more positive emotion (such as humour and affection) during later conflict.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1545-5300.2004.00024.x

Fraley, R. C., Hudson, N. W., Heffernan, M. E., & Segal, N. (2015). *Are adult attachment styles categorical or dimensional? A taxometric analysis of general and relationship-specific attachment orientations.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 109(2), 354–368. Taxometric analyses suggested that adult attachment differences are dimensional (degrees of anxiety and avoidance) rather than distinct types.
doi.org/10.1037/pspp0000027

Gable, S. L., Reis, H. T., Impett, E. A., & Asher, E. R. (2004). *What do you do when things go right? The intrapersonal and interpersonal benefits of sharing positive events.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 87(2), 228–245. Across four studies, telling others about good news was linked with higher daily positive mood and well-being beyond the event itself, especially when the listener responded actively and constructively; couples whose partners usually responded enthusiastically reported more intimacy and satisfaction.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.87.2.228

Hazan, C., & Shaver, P. (1987). *Romantic love conceptualized as an attachment process.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 52(3), 511–524. Two questionnaire studies proposed that adult romantic love is an attachment process: the share of adults in each of three attachment styles roughly matched infant figures, and the styles differed in how people experienced love, their views of self and others, and recalled relationships with parents.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.52.3.511

Laurenceau, J.-P., Barrett, L. F., & Pietromonaco, P. R. (1998). *Intimacy as an interpersonal process: The importance of self-disclosure, partner disclosure, and perceived partner responsiveness in interpersonal exchanges.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 74(5), 1238–1251. Diary studies of everyday social interactions supported Reis and Shaver's model: disclosing feelings, and feeling that the other person responded with understanding, both contributed to how intimate an interaction felt.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.74.5.1238

Reis, H. T., & Shaver, P. (1988). *Intimacy as an interpersonal process.* In S. Duck (Ed.), Handbook of Personal Relationships (pp. 367–389). Chichester: Wiley. Described intimacy as a back-and-forth process: one person shares something, the other responds with understanding, validation and care, and the first feels known.
search.worldcat.org

PART THREE · CHAPTER 16

Worry, low mood and trauma

Bonanno, G. A. (2004). *Loss, trauma, and human resilience: Have we underestimated the human capacity to thrive after extremely aversive events?* American Psychologist, 59(1), 20–28. Argued that resilience after loss or trauma is distinct from recovery, is more common than many theorists assumed, and can come about in several ways.
doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.59.1.20

Borkovec, T. D., Wilkinson, L., Folensbee, R., & Lerman, C. (1983). *Stimulus control applications to the treatment of worry.* Behaviour Research and Therapy, 21(3), 247–251. People who described themselves as worriers and were taught to postpone worry to a set time and place each day reported less daily worry after four weeks than people given no treatment.
doi.org/10.1016/0005-7967(83)90206-1

Carleton, R. N. (2016). *Fear of the unknown: One fear to rule them all?* Journal of Anxiety Disorders, 41, 5–21. A review arguing that fear of the unknown, closely related to intolerance of uncertainty, may be a fundamental fear underlying anxiety and neuroticism.
doi.org/10.1016/j.janxdis.2016.03.011

Craske, M. G., Treanor, M., Conway, C. C., Zbozinek, T., & Vervliet, B. (2014). *Maximizing exposure therapy: An inhibitory learning approach.* Behaviour Research and Therapy, 58, 10–23. Describes exposure therapy for anxiety as building new learning that competes with old fear, and sets out ways to strengthen it, such as testing specific expectations, dropping safety behaviours and practising in varied settings.
doi.org/10.1016/j.brat.2014.04.006

Cruwys, T., Dingle, G. A., Haslam, C., Haslam, S. A., Jetten, J., & Morton, T. A. (2013). *Social group memberships protect against future depression, alleviate depression symptoms and prevent depression relapse.* Social Science & Medicine, 98, 179–186. In population data on adults aged 50 and over followed for two to four years, belonging to fewer groups predicted more depression later; among people already depressed, joining one group was linked to a 24% lower risk of relapse and joining three to a 63% lower risk.
doi.org/10.1016/j.socscimed.2013.09.013

Dazzi, T., Gribble, R., Wessely, S., & Fear, N. T. (2014). *Does asking about suicide and related behaviours induce suicidal ideation? What is the evidence?* Psychological Medicine, 44(16), 3361–3363. A review of published studies in adults and adolescents, in the general population and in groups at higher risk. None found a significant rise in suicidal thoughts after people were asked about suicide; talking about it may even lower them.
pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/24998511

Ekers, D., Webster, L., Van Straten, A., Cuijpers, P., Richards, D., & Gilbody, S. (2014). *Behavioural activation for depression; an update of meta-analysis of effectiveness and sub group analysis.* PLoS ONE, 9(6), e100100. Across 26 randomised trials (1,524 people), behavioural activation, planning and doing small valued activities, reduced depression more than control conditions, and at least as much as medication in the four trials that compared them.
doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0100100

Felitti, V. J., Anda, R. F., Nordenberg, D., et al. (1998). *Relationship of childhood abuse and household dysfunction to many of the leading causes of death in adults: The Adverse Childhood Experiences (ACE) Study.* American Journal of Preventive Medicine, 14(4), 245–258. Of 13,494 adults at a large health plan sent a questionnaire, 9,508 responded; the more categories of childhood adversity people reported, the higher their risk of many adult health problems, in a graded relationship.
doi.org/10.1016/S0749-3797(98)00017-8

Freeman, D., Sheaves, B., et al. (2017). *The effects of improving sleep on mental health (OASIS): A randomised controlled trial with mediation analysis.* The Lancet Psychiatry, 4(10), 749–758. In 3,755 university students with insomnia, an online CBT course for sleep greatly reduced insomnia and also reduced paranoid thoughts and hallucinatory experiences compared with usual care, with better sleep explaining much of the change.
doi.org/10.1016/S2215-0366(17)30328-0

Hofmann, S. G., Asnaani, A., Vonk, I. J. J., Sawyer, A. T., & Fang, A. (2012). *The efficacy of cognitive behavioral therapy: A review of meta-analyses.* Cognitive Therapy and Research, 36(5), 427–440. Reviewing 106 meta-analyses of cognitive behavioural therapy, found the strongest support for anxiety problems, bulimia, anger and general stress, with support across many other problems; few studies looked at groups such as ethnic minorities or people on low incomes.
doi.org/10.1007/s10608-012-9476-1

Hollocks, M. J., Lerh, J. W., Magiati, I., Meiser-Stedman, R., & Brugha, T. S. (2019). *Anxiety and depression in adults with autism spectrum disorder: A systematic review and meta-analysis.* Psychological Medicine, 49(4), 559–572. Pooling 35 studies, estimated that about 27% of autistic adults had an anxiety disorder at the time (42% over their lifetime) and about 23% had depression (37% lifetime), with wide variation between studies.
doi.org/10.1017/S0033291718002283

Holt-Lunstad, J., Smith, T. B., & Layton, J. B. (2010). *Social relationships and mortality risk: A meta-analytic review.* PLoS Medicine, 7(7), e1000316. A meta-analysis of 148 studies (308,849 participants) found people with stronger social relationships had about 50% greater odds of survival over the study periods, consistently across age, sex and health status.
doi.org/10.1371/journal.pmed.1000316

Kessler, R. C., et al. (2017). *Trauma and PTSD in the WHO World Mental Health Surveys.* European Journal of Psychotraumatology, 8(sup5), 1353383. In surveys of 68,894 adults in 24 countries, about 70% reported at least one traumatic event in their lives (3.2 on average); events involving interpersonal violence, such as sexual assault, carried the highest risk of PTSD.
doi.org/10.1080/20008198.2017.1353383

Koenen, K. C., et al. (2017). *Posttraumatic stress disorder in the World Mental Health Surveys.* Psychological Medicine, 47(13), 2260–2274. Across 26 surveys with 71,083 adults, lifetime PTSD was found in 3.9% of everyone and 5.6% of people exposed to trauma; about half of those with PTSD had lasting symptoms, and treatment-seeking was much lower in poorer countries.
doi.org/10.1017/S0033291717000708

McEwen, B. S. (1998). *Protective and damaging effects of stress mediators.* New England Journal of Medicine, 338(3), 171–179. Explained how the same stress hormones that protect us in the short term cause wear and tear (allostatic load) when stress systems are chronically over- or under-active.
doi.org/10.1056/NEJM199801153380307

National Institute for Health and Care Excellence (NICE) (2022). *Depression in adults: treatment and management (NG222).* NICE guideline NG222, London. The NHS guideline for England on depression: recommends a choice of treatments made together with the person, including guided self-help, group or individual CBT and behavioural activation, group exercise, other talking therapies and antidepressants.
nice.org.uk/guidance/ng222

Noetel, M., et al. (2024). *Effect of exercise for depression: systematic review and network meta-analysis of randomised controlled trials.* BMJ, 384, e075847. Across 218 trials (about 14,000 people), exercise helped depression. Walking or jogging, yoga and strength training did best, especially at higher intensity, and yoga and strength training were well tolerated.
jyx.jyu.fi/handle/123456789/93572

Rose, S., Bisson, J., Churchill, R., & Wessely, S. (2002). *Psychological debriefing for preventing post traumatic stress disorder (PTSD).* Cochrane Database of Systematic Reviews, CD000560. Found no evidence that a single session of psychological debriefing after trauma prevented PTSD, and some evidence it may increase the risk for some people; the authors advised that compulsory debriefing should stop.
doi.org/10.1002/14651858.CD000560

Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration (SAMHSA) (2014). *SAMHSA's concept of trauma and guidance for a trauma-informed approach.* HHS Publication No. (SMA) 14-4884, Rockville, MD. Sets out a working definition of trauma and six principles for trauma-informed services: safety; trustworthiness and transparency; peer support; collaboration; empowerment, voice and choice; and cultural, historical and gender issues.
ncsacw.acf.hhs.gov/userfiles/files/SAMHSA_Trauma.pdf

PART THREE · CHAPTER 17

Groups, influence and culture

Asch, S. E. (1956). *Studies of independence and conformity: I. A minority of one against a unanimous majority.* Psychological Monographs: General and Applied, 70(9, Whole No. 416), 1–70. When a group of actors all gave the same obviously wrong answer about line lengths, participants went along on about a third of answers; about a quarter never went along, and conformity fell sharply when one other person gave the right answer.
doi.org/10.1037/h0093718

Baumeister, R. F., & Leary, M. R. (1995). *The need to belong: Desire for interpersonal attachments as a fundamental human motivation.* Psychological Bulletin, 117(3), 497–529. A major review arguing that the need to belong is a fundamental human motivation: people need frequent, pleasant contact within a few stable, caring relationships, and unmet belonging has wide emotional and cognitive costs.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.117.3.497

Bond, R., & Smith, P. B. (1996). *Culture and conformity: A meta-analysis of studies using Asch's (1952b, 1956) line judgment task.* Psychological Bulletin, 119(1), 111–137. Across 133 studies in 17 countries using Asch's task, conformity was a reliable effect but varied: it had declined in the United States since the 1950s and was higher in more collectivist cultures.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.119.1.111

Brady, W. J., Wills, J. A., Jost, J. T., Tucker, J. A., & Van Bavel, J. J. (2017). *Emotion shapes the diffusion of moralized content in social networks.* Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences, 114(28), 7313–7318. In 563,312 social media posts about divisive political issues, each additional moral-emotional word was linked to about 20% more spread, mostly within like-minded networks rather than across them.
csmapnyu.org

Burger, J. M. (2009). *Replicating Milgram: Would people still obey today?* American Psychologist, 64(1), 1–11. A safer partial replication with 70 adults, stopping at the learner's first protest, found obedience rates only slightly lower than Milgram's 45 years earlier; seeing another person refuse did not reduce obedience.
doi.org/10.1037/a0010932

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Index

Key ideas and the pages where the book talks about them. Chapter names are in the contents.

acceptance 14, 16, 18, 20, 22, 24, 26, 28, 30, 32, 34, 36, 38, 40, 42, 44, 46, 48, 50, 52, 54, 58, 60, 62, 64, 66, 68, 70, 72, 74, 76, 78, 80, 82, 84, 86, 88, 90, 92, 94, 96, 98, 100, 102, 104, 106, 108, 110, 112, 114, 116, 118, 120, 122, 124, 126, 128, 130, 132, 134, 136, 138, 140, 142, 144, 146, 148, 150, 152, 154, 156, 158, 160, 162, 164, 166, 168, 170, 172, 174, 176, 178, 180, 182, 184, 186, 188, 190, 192, 194, 196, 198, 200, 202, 204, 206, 208, 210, 212, 214, 216, 218, 220, 222, 224, 226, 228, 230, 232, 234, 236, 238, 240, 242, 244, 246, 248, 250, 252, 254, 256, 258, 260, 262, 264, 266, 268, 270, 272, 274, 276, 278, 280, 282, 284, 286, 288, 290, 292, 294, 296, 298, 300, 302

ADHD 38, 42–43, 83, 95, 136, 139, 150, 165–166, 169, 173, 176, 178, 180–182, 219, 221, 234, 274

adult children 39, 98, 161, 208

ageing, later life 66, 70, 125, 141, 152, 160–161, 163, 208, 221, 257, 262, 277

Ainsworth, Mary 116

alexithymia 35, 70, 182

anger 65, 69, 187, 209, 223–227, 229–236, 294

anxiety 69, 109, 111, 117, 177, 179, 181, 256, 264–267, 272, 274–275, 289

apology 15, 38, 106, 121, 124, 151, 197, 200, 202–209, 231, 236

appreciation, thanks 256

arguments 21, 79, 84, 89, 93, 95, 101, 111, 132, 149, 175, 192–193, 225–226, 234, 240, 242, 245, 257, 266, 275, 280, 282

Aristotle 188

Asch, Solomon 280–281, 287

attachment 28, 114–117, 119, 121, 123–125, 164, 253, 256, 262–263, 291–295

attention 91, 95–96, 146, 165, 169, 173, 192, 213

autism, autistic 35, 38–39, 42–43, 109, 136, 165–166, 169, 171–182

avoidance 68, 84, 117, 177, 264–267, 271, 274, 276

babies, new parents 18, 86, 136, 139, 143, 159, 163, 191, 199–200, 216, 238, 242, 271, 277, 285

battery 33, 39, 53, 296, 300

Baumeister, Roy 93, 231

belonging 19–21, 28, 109, 114–115, 117, 119–121, 123, 125–126, 164–165, 175, 262–263, 270, 279, 286–288, 290–295

bias 87, 97, 171, 192, 290–291

bids for connection 258

Big Five 239, 241, 250

blame 26, 38, 80, 92, 108, 123, 136, 141–142, 206

boundaries, limits 210, 221

Bowlby, John 116

breakups 26, 48, 125, 150, 163, 201, 204, 208, 214, 259, 261

burnout 85, 138, 148, 165, 171–172, 179, 181–182, 210, 220–221

bystander effect 216

Calm-Down Kit 37, 48–50, 53, 55, 70–71, 73, 81, 85–86, 224, 226, 228–229, 235, 237, 276, 278, 292, 296, 302

care, caring 34, 62, 67, 76, 83–84, 150, 163, 169, 210, 214–215, 219–222, 236, 255, 274, 277, 300

carers, caregiving 70, 83, 150, 163, 211, 215, 218, 220–221, 236, 277, 300

Carstensen, Laura 257

change 16, 19, 28, 46–48, 116, 127–128, 130, 132–136, 138–139, 144, 152, 155, 158–159, 163, 174, 195, 238, 243–244, 247–248, 251–252, 269, 272, 281, 284, 292–295

check-in 47, 59, 68, 100, 112, 138, 220, 222, 265, 276, 285–286, 292–293

children 98, 163, 176, 208, 257

chores 50, 80, 104–105, 180, 206, 226, 229, 258, 285, 301

closeness 103, 110, 117, 124, 126, 184, 252–257, 259, 261–263, 292–294

co-parenting 33, 48, 62, 76, 98, 112, 157, 201, 208, 294

communication 38, 97–99, 101, 103, 105, 107, 109–113, 169, 178, 181, 183, 209, 220–221, 249, 251, 290, 292–295

compassion 55, 140–145, 147–151, 163, 182, 196, 208–209, 214, 221, 277–278, 293–295

complacency 125, 138–139, 262

conflict 82, 208, 236, 296, 300

Confucius 192

control, circle of 40

couples 32, 79, 82, 111, 135, 182, 191, 195, 199–200, 205–207, 245, 256–258, 260–261, 268

coworkers 116, 137, 169, 171–174, 176–177, 187, 198, 215, 244, 255, 270, 272, 280

criticism 104–105, 143, 261

Crompton, Catherine 169

culture 16, 66, 92, 96, 98, 108, 112, 126, 142, 157, 196, 279–281, 283–287, 289, 291–293, 295

curiosity 45, 94, 239–241

daily check-in (90 seconds) 47, 100, 138, 292

debt, money worries 204, 296, 300

depression, low mood 86, 124, 138, 151, 154, 164, 179, 181, 194, 249, 264–265, 267, 269–271, 273–275, 277, 289, 292–295

desire 260

disagreeing kindly 177, 192, 194, 258, 279, 287, 289, 291, 296

divorce 121, 153, 163, 257, 260, 270

dorms, shared rooms 33, 47, 62, 76, 295

double empathy 38, 181–182

drift 59, 85, 122, 124, 126, 153, 163, 193, 206, 208, 247, 260

Edmondson, Amy 282

emotions, feelings 35–36, 52, 58–61, 63–71, 81, 114, 141, 143, 149–150, 163, 184, 187, 198, 205, 208, 210–211, 213–214, 223, 225, 232, 235–237, 253, 255–257, 294, 301

empathy 38, 180–182, 214, 221

empty nest 163, 195, 262

Epictetus 188

Erikson, Erik 18–19

ex-partners 48, 65, 156–157, 201

exams 68, 158, 170, 244, 268–269, 274

expectations 114

fairness 24, 33, 35, 39, 43, 51, 65–66, 73, 87, 96, 106–108, 110, 113, 129, 159, 179, 184–185, 187, 196, 199, 202, 204, 209, 230, 232, 234, 243, 247, 275, 284, 289, 291

faith 157, 162, 193, 242, 279, 282

family 20–22, 26, 62, 76, 98, 125, 157, 163, 182, 187, 193, 195, 206, 208, 236, 253–254, 260, 279, 282, 285–286, 288, 290

fathers, dads 15, 22, 30, 39, 77, 88, 95, 103–104, 109, 143, 145, 156, 158, 160, 171, 199, 201, 203, 218, 225, 230, 233, 253, 259, 268, 270–271, 286

fear 26, 59, 65, 69, 117, 124, 148, 178, 225, 235, 249, 254, 257, 264–267, 287

feedback 80, 83, 93, 110

Festinger, Leon 146

flooded 72, 77–79, 83–84, 225

flooding 72, 77–79, 83–85, 225, 236

forgiveness 123, 151, 197, 203, 205–206, 208–209

foster care 125, 208

friends 24–25, 31, 39, 48, 59, 94, 103, 112, 115, 120, 122, 124, 126, 144–146, 148, 153, 169, 188, 194, 196, 198, 201, 205, 208, 221, 253, 262, 274

friendship 52, 59, 80, 115, 121–122, 124, 126, 153, 163, 195, 208, 235, 253, 255, 260, 272, 279, 288

Gollwitzer, Peter 48

Gottman, John 79, 200, 258

grandparents 30, 51, 67, 74–75, 94, 182, 221, 228, 250, 272, 285

gratitude 158, 202, 256

grief 70, 125–126, 150, 152–164, 176, 182, 195, 208, 221–222, 262, 274, 277, 294

Gross, James 230

group chats 80, 106, 122, 233, 274, 279, 286, 288

groupthink 280

guilt 64, 70, 134, 140–142, 150–151, 159, 194, 209, 253, 269

habits 52–53, 55, 85, 88, 92, 100, 127–133, 135–139, 159, 190, 244, 250–251, 292, 294–296

helping 149, 211, 213, 217, 219–221, 292–293

hope 47, 158, 178, 202, 269

housemates 21, 26, 41, 64, 81, 101, 131, 157, 170, 192, 201, 205, 214, 226, 245, 285

How much are you carrying? 32–33, 42–43, 80, 211, 213, 292, 296, 300

"How to talk to me" card 30–32, 42, 166, 174–175, 239, 245

How you connect, Wave Code 17, 26, 30, 41, 45, 170, 193, 243, 245–249, 251, 255, 293

identity 18, 179, 282

if-then plans 44, 48, 54–55, 139

illness, long-term 35, 39, 83, 100, 109, 156, 159, 162–163, 187, 191, 221, 248, 259, 300–302

in-laws 290

infidelity, affairs 206

Janis, Irving 280

jealousy 59, 123, 261

kind no 214

kindness 37, 44, 51–52, 110, 133, 136, 145, 149, 151, 169, 187, 192

kinship care 125, 208

ladder, the 33, 72, 74–76, 86, 294

Lally, Phillippa 136–137

Leary, Mark 198, 235

Lieberman, Matthew 63–64

listening 99, 103, 210, 212–213, 219, 259

loneliness 114, 123–124, 146, 161, 261, 274, 277

loss 126, 150, 152–157, 159–164, 171–172, 182, 195, 208, 221–222, 261, 269, 294

love 21–22, 24, 30, 52, 94, 110, 122–124, 126, 135, 150, 152, 158, 161, 193, 214, 220, 232, 236, 244, 252–263, 280, 292–294

Malinowski, Bronisław 109

managers 17, 23, 31, 35, 41, 59, 62, 68, 91, 100, 108, 119, 144–145, 174, 219, 274, 283

marriage 118, 153, 160

masking 150, 165–166, 171, 180, 182

meaning 55, 99–100, 106, 134, 162, 184–185, 187, 189, 191, 193, 195, 198, 242, 255, 257, 291–295

Milgram, Stanley 282

Milton, Damian 38

mistakes 23, 26, 59, 100, 123, 140, 142, 144, 146–147, 149, 224

money 34, 45, 53–54, 62, 74, 76, 82, 88, 141, 195, 205, 214, 219, 248, 252, 260, 297

monotropism 173, 181–182

monthly look-back 51, 55, 115, 139

mothers, mums 37, 80, 141, 156, 233, 242, 284

moving in 244, 246

My weather today 30, 32–34, 59, 62–64, 70–71, 76–77, 276, 294, 297

Neff, Kristin 52

neighbours 121, 177, 189, 216, 228, 255, 273

norms 279, 283–286, 291

obedience 68

One owner per job 115, 128, 133, 166, 211, 217–218, 239, 292

online life 30, 37, 43, 86, 98, 113, 115, 135, 139, 222, 233, 258–259, 263, 283–284, 286, 289, 291

ownership, one owner per job 101, 115, 128, 132–133, 153, 166, 211, 217–218, 239, 284, 292

panic 120, 266, 273, 276

parents 48, 98, 106, 112, 125, 139, 163, 221, 236, 250, 277, 285–286

partners 41, 83, 148, 161, 204, 253, 256, 260–261

pause, taking a 26, 29, 49, 73, 79, 83–85, 108, 118–119, 157, 201, 228–229, 234, 253, 293, 296, 300–302

perception 87

personality 28, 139, 183, 238–239, 241–245, 247–249, 251, 293, 295

perspective 97–98

praise 26

pressure 33, 62, 71, 73, 76, 80, 116, 123–124, 135, 170, 177, 264, 272, 274, 286–290, 296–297, 300, 302

prolonged grief 160

psychological safety 290

PTSD 271–272

pursue-withdraw 83, 119, 124, 236, 293

reassurance 39, 101, 117, 123, 256, 274

regret 15, 67, 142, 235

Reis, Harry 253–254

rejection 91, 260

remote and hybrid work 29, 190, 215

repair 99–100, 106, 110, 112–113, 141, 147, 197, 199–200, 202, 204, 208–209, 223, 227, 231–232, 236–237

resentment 70, 203, 214

respect 66, 136, 225, 261

Rewind the talk 88, 92, 97–98, 106, 112, 146–147, 203, 293

rituals 119, 121, 158, 190–191, 257, 292

Rosenberg, Marshall 38

Ross, Lee 92

rulebook from home 14, 21–23, 27

rumination 208, 236

sadness 59, 64–65, 69, 84, 158, 185, 187, 202, 269, 275

safety 124, 192, 197, 204, 221, 224, 227, 264, 271–272, 275, 290

Say it so it lands 38, 59, 100, 104–105, 112, 287, 292, 301

second arrow 51, 208

self path 28, 43, 53, 55, 136, 138

self-compassion 55, 140–145, 147–151, 163, 182, 196, 208–209, 277–278, 293–295

self-worth 59, 140–141, 146–147, 149, 151, 196, 293–294

sensory overload 86, 165, 170, 175, 180, 182, 242, 250

separation 81, 172, 197, 206, 214, 230, 234, 242, 292

setup score 73, 128

shame 54–55, 65, 134, 140–143, 145, 147–151, 163, 182, 193, 196, 209, 225, 278, 289, 293–295

shift work 32, 82–83, 94, 282

siblings 20, 49–50, 52, 63, 66, 77, 82, 93, 100, 121, 132, 145, 154, 156, 160, 177, 189, 201, 208, 214, 224, 230, 253, 260, 266, 288

single, living alone 41, 68, 123, 148, 150, 161, 195, 260, 274

sleep 30, 34, 62, 76, 82, 84, 269–271, 274, 276–277, 296–297

small steps 25, 44, 46, 48, 52, 55, 127–128, 131, 134–135, 138–139, 264, 273–274

stress 26, 43, 70–74, 77, 79–80, 82–86, 221–222, 241, 271, 277–278, 292, 294, 302

stress tank 26, 32–33, 39, 43, 71–73, 79, 83, 85–86, 90, 98, 132, 213, 237, 265, 296–297, 300, 302

suicide 211, 215–216, 220, 275, 289

support 127, 138, 152, 162, 212–213, 220–221, 272

Tajfel, Henri 282

teenagers 18, 70, 86, 98, 111–112, 114, 122, 150, 163, 182, 196, 223, 233, 236, 250, 252, 257, 259, 264, 274, 277, 279, 288, 290

temperament 16, 28, 30, 139, 183, 238–239, 241–243, 245, 247–249, 251, 293, 295

tone 30, 32, 40, 96, 99–100, 105–106, 110, 113, 183, 198, 246

trauma 86, 151, 164, 207, 264–265, 267, 269, 271–273, 275, 277, 292–295

Tronick, Edward 200

trust 28, 114–115, 119–121, 123, 204, 206, 263, 293

us and them 98, 279, 282

values 55, 138–139, 158, 184–189, 191–196, 286, 290–295

Watzlawick, Paul 101–102

What keeps coming back? 51, 128, 292

Who did what 38, 88

Who does what? (the page) 297

window of tolerance 75, 85, 277

wired differently 29, 38, 42, 70, 97, 150, 176, 181

wiring 16, 29–30, 32, 38–39, 41–43, 70, 97, 112, 150, 175–176, 179, 181–183, 245, 247, 250–251, 290–293

work, the workplace 150, 182, 190–191, 221

worry 39, 65, 86, 101, 117, 161, 264–265, 268–269, 273–275, 294

your lens 14–15, 17, 19, 21, 23, 25, 27–28, 53, 98, 126, 150–151, 164, 251, 285, 293